I Would Bring You the Stars and the Moon

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/62233987.

Rating:	Explicit
Archive Warning:	Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings
Category:	F/F
Fandom:	Arcane: League of Legends (Cartoon 2021)
Relationships:	Caitlyn/Vi (League of Legends), Caitlyn & Vi (League of Legends)
Characters:	Caitlyn (League of Legends), Vi (League of Legends), Vander (League of Legends), Mylo (Arcane: League of Legends), Claggor (Arcane: League of Legends), Ekko (League of Legends), Powder from s02e07 AU (Arcane: League of Legends), Jayce (League of Legends), Cassandra Kiramman, Viktor (League of Legends), Scar (Arcane: League of Legends)
Additional Tags:	Strangers to Lovers, Alternate Universe, Mutual Pining, Fluff, Fluff and Humor, Eventual Smut, Mutual Masturbation, Phone Sex, except its space phone sex, Outer Space, NASA, Astronaut Vi, capcom Caitlyn, POV Caitlyn (League of Legends), Light Angst, Vi is a flirt, but only with Caitlyn, Vi is smart, Genius Vi as it should be, Lesbians in Space, well one lesbian in space, Flirting, Hurt/Comfort, Lesbian Sex, Family Feels, so much fluff they're so cute, Dialogue Heavy, IN SPACE!, Masturbation, Sex Toys, Miscommunication, Useless Lesbians, Yearning
Language:	English
Stats:	Published: 2025-01-14 Completed: 2025-03-09 Words: 94,555 Chapters: 11/11

I Would Bring You the Stars and the Moon

by GutterWitch

Summary

"Houston, do you copy?"

Caitlyn panicked, feeling extraordinarily unprepared having been thrust into her new position without so much as even a handbook to consult. What were the formalities? What was she supposed to respond with? Where was the damn push to talk button…

"Hellooo? I said Houston, do you copy?"

Caitlyn fiddled with her headset, having finally found the green button on the side and hastily letting out a rather breathless reply. "Um, yes. Hello? This is Houston. I copy."

There was a long pause in which Caitlyn sat twiddling her thumbs, anxiety pushing the frantic pulse of her heartbeat through her eardrums. Was that wrong? Did she already fuck up? She took a steady deep breath, finger hovering over the talk button until the familiar voice of the astronaut came through her headset once more.

"Damn, Houston. I didn't expect you to sound so sexy."

OR

Caitlyn has been assigned as the personal capcom to one of the astronauts currently on a year long expedition at the international space station. Cue long months of pining and desperate longing.

Notes

Heya, it's your friendly neighborhood femme. The idea for this fic came to me and I went into an absolute spiral working on it. This fic contains lots of fluff and humor, tons of heart swelling interactions and moments that hopefully make you laugh. That being said I am also a filthy whore so there will be some good smut comin your way.

The more I wrote, the more I fell in love with this concept so I hope you all enjoy it as well.

I did research for this fic but I, in fact, do not work at NASA. I'm just a dumb horny gay on the internet so, I humbly request you suspend your disbelief a bit. I also did change some things intentionally so please keep this in mind.

Also this first chapter contains a spoiler for season 22 of Law and Order: SVU.

See ya. <3

- Translation into Português brasileiro available: I Would Bring You The Stars and The Moon (tradução) by vicaitfavs
- Translation into Русский available: I Would Bring You the Stars and the Moon by pnchrrr
- Translation into Українська available: I Would Bring You the Stars and the Moon by art_maristiel
- Translation into Français available: Je t'apporterais les Etoiles et la Lune by Ribeka_McClain

Jitters

“A transfer?”

“Well it’s more of a promotion.” Greyson offered a proud smile, leaning back casually against her desk. When Caitlyn had been called into her boss’ office, this was the last thing she expected. “The position is that of a personal capsule communicator to the astronauts on board the international space station. You’d be transferred to the Johnson space center in Houston and working in their primary communications room with the team overseeing the current expedition.”

Caitlyn’s eyes began to dry out with just how wide they had gotten. She blinked hard a few times, willing herself to wake up if this was a dream but nope. She had all ten toes and fingers, could feel the ground under her expensive heels and the uncomfortable way her lace underwear rode up her ass. Yep, she was awake alright.

“I- I don’t know what to say.”

“Of course, you don’t have to take the position. I know asking you to relocate would be a hassle and I admit I would be sad to let you go but when the chief of operations there said he had an opening, you were the first person I thought of for the job.” She rounded her desk and plopped down into the rickety swivel chair, grinning. “Typically capcom’s are astronauts themselves but I believe someone with your knowledge and experience is more than capable. I think it’s a wonderful opportunity for you, but the decision is yours.”

It would, quite frankly, be ludicrous to turn down such an opportunity. Working at the Kennedy Space Center had been great and she loved her job but *the* mission control center in Houston was a dream come true. Not to mention she would be actively participating in the current expedition as opposed to calculating statistics and making graphs all day.

“I would be absolutely honored. Yes, of course I’ll take the position.”

“Wonderful! I’ll message the flight director and let him know you’re on board. I know it is very short notice but we have resources to help you relocate. I’ll email them to you in a bit.” Greyson stood and extended her hand out to Caitlyn, which she took enthusiastically with a firm shake. “Congratulations, Miss Kiramman. It has been a pleasure working with you. I wish you luck in your new career and I do hope you stop by from time to time.”

“Yes, yes of course.” Caitlyn’s cheeks ached from smiling. “I cannot thank you enough, boss.”

Everything had happened in a sort of a whirlwind after that. It was just two and a half weeks after leaving Greyson’s office that Caitlyn found herself in a brand new place with a brand new job and a… very old apartment. A long drive, many painkillers for her aching spine and countless hazelnut iced lattes later, and she was packed up and moved. Just like that.

Houston was her new home. Unfamiliar territory but not one she was unwilling to traverse. Things hadn't slowed down for even a moment after she had left her old boss' office and now here she was, staring down the exposed brick wall of her new (to her) rather adorably antique loft.

Setting down the last of her boxes with a huff, Caitlyn slumped down against the stack of cardboard, sweat gathering on her brow. The space was quaint but surprisingly accommodated Caitlyn's furniture quite nicely. Including the large forest green velvet couch she had insisted was coming along. That couch was her baby and it happily fit right in.

The exhaustion was quickly catching up to Caitlyn. She hadn't realized she'd fallen asleep there among the array of scattered boxes until the frantic vibration of her cell phone on the wooden coffee table made her startle.

"Hello?" Her voice was hoarse with sleep as she stretched out her muscles, angling the phone onto her shoulder to proceed in opening a few of the boxes. She was dead tired but she couldn't very well eat off the countertops of her kitchen.

"Hello, dear. Just calling to check in and make sure you've arrived safely."

"Oh, mother, yes. I'm so sorry I meant to text as soon as I finished bringing up the boxes but I fell asleep." She frowned at the contents of the current box she had elected to unpack. Candles. Not a necessity at the moment but at least her new place would smell nice.

"The journey must have been particularly exhausting for you to fall asleep in the middle of the afternoon." Cassandra hummed and Caitlyn could hear the soft clink of what she assumed was a teacup over the other end of the line. It was nearly eleven pm in London so she must be having her evening cup of tea before bed.

"Yes, a sixteen hour drive does tend to have that sort of effect on the body." Caitlyn muttered, electing to light up a candle that smelled of fresh linen for while she worked.

"You could have taken the private jet we offered, dear."

Caitlyn groaned. "I know mother but this was something I wanted to do on my own." Another box, this time with expensive plates her mother had gifted her after she'd landed her first job at NASA. A little more useful.

"I understand, dear. I must say I do admire your determination and… tenacity." Caitlyn rolled her eyes with a smile. Her mother had her own way of showing her love. It often came wrapped in eloquent vocabulary and a closed off expression, but it was most definitely there. "As a mother I simply harbor a desire to assist you where I can, is all."

"Thank you, mother. I do appreciate it."

"Yes, well." Her mother cleared her throat awkwardly. "I will leave you to your unpacking, then. I have also scheduled a delivery for you tonight. Think of it as a congratulatory gift for your new position."

Well that was certainly surprising. “You didn’t have to get me anything.”

“I know but… I’m proud of you, Caity. I simply wanted you to know it.” Caitlyn smiled warmly at her childhood nickname. Her mother and her had a rather rough go of it as she grew up, but they had definitely come a long way in love and understanding of one another. “Good luck tomorrow, dear.”

“Thank you, mum. I’ll talk to you later.”

Caitlyn hung up the phone exhausted, but in high spirits. She put on a playlist of feel good music and danced around her apartment, unpacking as she went and dropping the occasional kiss on her ragdoll cat’s head. As she was on her third suitcase of clothing, a soft knock came from the front door, most likely the delivery from her mother.

She hip checked the door closed after signing for the delivery and inspected the tall garment bag. The label was expensive. Like, triple dollar signs expensive. It was no surprise her mother had gone overboard but Caitlyn couldn’t find it in herself to be upset. A luxurious gift every once in a while was acceptable, regardless of her desire to be self-sufficient and independent. Caitlyn was also finding it difficult to complain as she inspected the deep blue pantsuit her mother had gifted her. No doubt attire she deemed “appropriate” for Caitlyn’s first day.

“What do you think, Chowder?” She held up the two separate hangers against her slender body, grinning at the small gold details etched into the material. Her mother did have fantastic taste. Cassandra would often say that there is no stronger advisory than a woman dressed to impress.

Chowder meowed softly and rolled onto his back, showing complete disinterest in Caitlyn’s impromptu fashion show. The rest of the evening involved frozen pizza, a bath with enough candles to most likely be considered a fire hazard, and an extra step of adding a cucumber face mask to her skin care routine to prepare for her first day. Caitlyn settled into bed feeling a pleasant mix of jitters and excitement. It was a wonder she was able to fall asleep, but she did in record time, allowing her to wake refreshed and invigorated once her alarm blared at five am.

After a quick morning pilates routine in her living room and a once over in the full length mirror that the movers had been none too gentle with, Caitlyn felt ready.

“Well. I’m off.” She dropped a kiss atop Chowder’s head who was far more interested in nudging Caitlyn’s salt shaker off the counter. She snatched it away and gave the cat a playful scowl before heading out the door, adjusting her new suit as she went.

The Houston command center was a short drive from Caitlyn’s apartment. Greyson had really done her a solid in terms of living recommendations. Considering the sporadic and sometimes rather extensive hours she would be required to work, the closer she was, the better. Caitlyn pulled her car into the parking lot of the rather sterile looking building. It was a large structure made up of several different blocks. Very square and rigid without any windows in sight.

The clack of her heels against the sidewalk put an undeniable confidence in her step as she approached her new place of work. Another proverb from her mother rang in the back of her mind. “Nothing gives a woman confidence quite like the sound of her heels against the ground.” Caitlyn tended to agree with this one. She felt smart, successful even. All with the simple click clack of an expensive stiletto.

Having familiarized herself with the structure before arriving, Caitlyn knew the exact route to take toward the control room. She walked along several hallways lined with photos of astronauts and expeditions of the past before stopping in front of a grand wooden door with Chief Wick’s name etched into a gold plaque.

After a steadying breath and two soft knocks, Caitlyn could hear a rather friendly sounding “Come on in.” From the other side of the wooden barrier. She stepped inside and immediately schooled her expression because holy shit. This man, her new boss, was a beast of a man.

“Ah! You must be Caitlyn!” He stood from his desk and good gods above he was even *bigger*- “Name’s Vander. I’m the flight director behind the current expedition.”

The man extended a large hand toward Caitlyn which she had taken enthusiastically with a poor attempt at grace. His grip was surprisingly soft for such a big man, most likely out of consideration for others because Caitlyn was quite sure he could turn her into spaghetti squash if he wanted to.

“It’s a pleasure to meet you, Chief. I’m Caitlyn Kiramman. I look forward to working with you.” She flashed a gap toothed smile as Vander gestured to the brown leather lounge chair across from his own desk, rounding it to take a seat of his own once more.

“Likewise, but let’s not waste too much time on formalities. There will be plenty of time for that later.” He leaned back casually and Caitlyn wasn’t quite sure why, but she felt rather comfortable in this man’s presence despite his size. “As you know, we’re already four months into this expedition. The previous capcom had to leave for personal reasons which put us in quite a tough spot so we’re very glad to have you aboard.”

“Happy to be here, it’s a dream opportunity for me so I’m grateful.”

He waved her off. “Typically we have a previous astronaut fill the position but based on your resume, you’re more than qualified. I’m confident you’ll thrive here.” Caitlyn liked this man. He was rather straightforward, but in such a way that wasn’t brazen or cold. An interesting contrast to her own mother. “Now, let’s go over some details. We used to have one capcom take on communicating with the entire team, but we found it more efficient to have multiple communicators each assigned to their own astronaut. I assume you’ve read over the summaries of the current team on the space station we sent out?”

“Yes, sir. I’ve familiarized myself with them along with the spacecraft.” The summaries weren’t extensive. Just their names and positions aboard the space station. Caitlyn had them memorized rather quickly. It was a small team, only six of them on board.

“Excellent. There will be much more information and files on your computer. You can spend the morning combing through it before you’ll need to do any actual work today.” Vander stood and motioned for Caitlyn to follow along, leading her to another entrance next to a large window at the back of his office. “Now then, let’s show you to your station.”

Vander led her out of his office to a small balcony that overlooked the communications room. The room was dimly lit to accommodate several projectors that lit up three large screens at the front of the room. There were several rows of desks laid out almost like a university lecture hall with a couple of enclosed private cubicles at the back. Each desk had a minimum of five monitors and countless papers with graphs scattered throughout. Lovely framed art pieces of various planets and landscapes of stars decorated the walls. It felt strangely tranquil for an office space.

“You’ll be working with astronaut number five one six.” Chief Vander instructed as he made his way down the rows with Caitlyn in tow. He rounded a private, dimly lit black cubicle at the back corner of the room. “Fair warning, she’s a bit of a handful. She also happens to be my daughter, though. So take good care of her, aye?”

Caitlyn sucked in a nervous breath. She was going to be the personal point of contact for the *chief’s* daughter? A man who looked as though he could promptly turn Caitlyn into a human football and punt her into space? This wasn’t a promotion. This was a death sentence.

The chief offered her a knowing smile. “Don’t look so stiff there, kiddo. Greyson gave you quite the glowing review so I know you’ll do great. Now, this is your cubicle. Feel free to decorate and make it your own little home away from home. There’s a bunk for sleeping on any long nights you may need to be here under the desk there. You have your own computer and filing cabinets and even your own coffee maker.”

Caitlyn inspected the small space. There wasn’t much in lieu of decor but it was strangely cozy. Soft blue neon lighting the edges of the mahogany L-shaped desk and walls tall enough to conceal her completely from the rest of the room if she were to sit in the rather comfortable looking rolling chair. A large sign that read “CAPCOM: CAPSULE COMMUNICATOR” stuck out from the front wall. Her mind had already begun picking out cute objects from her apartment that would look splendid in this space.

“What else is there- ah! Of course, the most important thing is your headset. Better get used to having this on, you’ll be practically living in it for the next eight months.” Vander nodded his head to the bulky pair of headphones with an attached microphone sitting next to the desktop computer with two monitors.

“Well, unless you have any questions for me, I’ll leave you to get settled.”

Wait, that was it? That was all the instruction she was going to get? “Um, well, actually…”

“What is it kiddo?”

Caitlyn sucked her lower lip between her gapped teeth. “What… what do I do, exactly?”

Vander let out a hearty laugh. “It’s pretty straightforward. Just sit here and chat with the astronaut, relay any important updates they provide to the team. Communicate information and instruction between us and them. Monitor the spacecraft data on your computer, write up reports and bob’s your uncle.”

Caitlyn’s lips formed a little ‘o’ shape. She nodded and squared away her shoulders, fully determined to do her job efficiently. “Thank you, Chief. I promise she’s in good hands.”

“That’s the spirit. Let me or any of the team know if you need anything, alright? Take breaks as well. Go around and introduce yourself to everyone. Oh, and welcome aboard.”

With that, the man winked and sauntered away, leaving Caitlyn feeling mildly overwhelmed but excited nonetheless. She set down her satchel on the edge of the desk and sat in her plush chair, giving a little spin with glee while she adjusted the lumbar support. She began unpacking her bag with some work day essentials including snacks, a reusable water bottle decked out in stickers, and a small framed photo of her cat for moral support.

Caitlyn spent a good amount of time glancing over the furniture in her cubicle while waiting for the computer to boot up. She opened the filing cabinets, intent on finding some sort of information booklet or a manual but was only met with files upon files of spacecraft data that she mostly already memorized in preparation for her first day.

She then inspected the headset that would essentially be her lifeline for the next eight months, fixing it to her head and pulling a few wayward cobalt strands of hair out of the front. It was quite bulky, but strangely comfortable. No issues there.

It had only been about ten minutes since Caitlyn sat down. She had just started a cup of coffee and begun to rearrange the files on her computer when a woman’s voice crackled through the plush ear coverings on either side of her head.

“Houston, do you copy?”

Caitlyn panicked, feeling extraordinarily unprepared having been thrust into her new position without so much as even a handbook to consult. What were the formalities? What was she supposed to respond with? Where was the damn push to talk button…

“Hellooo? I said Houston, do you copy?”

Caitlyn fiddled with her headset, having finally found the green button on the side and hastily letting out a rather breathless reply. “Um, yes. Hello? This is Houston. I copy.”

There was a long pause in which Caitlyn sat twiddling her thumbs, anxiety pushing the frantic pulse of her heartbeat through her eardrums. Was that wrong? Did she already fuck up? She took a steady deep breath, finger hovering over the talk button until the familiar voice of the astronaut came through her headset once more.

“Damn, Houston. I didn’t expect you to sound so sexy.”

Caitlyn balked. So *that* was what the chief meant when he said this astronaut was a handful. “I- I beg your pardon?”

“You can beg for whatever you want, sweetheart.”

Caitlyn promptly ripped off her headset, sitting up straight like a deer caught in headlights. She lifted herself off the arms of her chair and glanced frantically around the room over her cubicle. Was anyone else *hearing* this?

No one in the room had any sort of reaction. They were all buried in their own work. Aside from one rather lanky man with spiked hair who had busied himself with the contents of his nostrils.

Caitlyn swallowed down her nerves and lowered herself back into the chair. A slow exhale later and she was sliding back on her headset. She had dealt with her fair share of women like this before. She could do this. Fight fire with fire, so to say.

“Sorry.” She responded into the mic, her voice much steadier than it had been moments prior. “But I’m a sophisticated woman. You would need to wine and dine me before I’d entertain such notions.”

A beat, followed by a hearty laugh that made Caitlyn’s own lips curl up at the corners.

“Oh, I like you.” The astronaut responded, a genuine intrigue lacing her words. “What’s your name?”

“My name is Caitlyn, I’m your new personal capsule communicator.”

“Hm, so I figured.” There was a slight bit of shuffling over the line, what sounded like a wrapper tearing open. When the astronaut’s voice came back it was muffled by whatever food she had put into her mouth. “Name’s Vi, astronaut five one six. Flight engineer.”

“So I figured.” Caitlyn parrotted, she clicked around on her computer monitor, finding several folders worth of information on the current mission, the structure of the space station, and the astronauts on board. “The chief’s daughter, yes?”

“Ah, don’t let that scare you. Dad may not look it, but he’s harmless.”

Caitlyn hummed. “That may be so, but we should probably do our best to maintain a certain level of professionalism, no?”

“Awe don’t worry about that. I don’t know about you but personally, a little harmless flirting never hurt my ability to do my job. Besides-” Vi took another bite of her probably rather atrocious astronaut food. “We’re kinda stuck with each other for the next eight months, so I think it’s best to loosen up a little, y’know? Have a little fun.”

Caitlyn pursed her lips, mulling over Vi’s words. She did have a point, they were stuck with one another. They may as well make the best of it.

“So, tell me about yourself, Caitlyn.”

She tried to pretend the sound of her own name coming from this strangely sultry voice didn't have an effect on her as she replied. "Didn't you phone in for something regarding the expedition?"

"Nah, just heard you were coming in today. Wanted to introduce myself is all."

"I see." Caitlyn drummed her fingers against her new desk, thinking. "What do you want to know?"

"You got a boyfriend?"

What did she expect, really?

"No." Caitlyn decided a bit of honesty couldn't hurt and based on the way Vi had opened their conversation, she figured the woman would be more than accepting of it. "I'm a lesbian."

"A girlfriend then?"

"Regrettably, no."

"Hm, regrettable for you, but not for me."

"Do you flirt like this with all of the capcoms?"

Vi barked another laugh. "Hell no. The last guy you replaced was awful. Made way too many space puns and would recap entire episodes of Law and Order."

"SVU? I like that show." Caitlyn found herself smiling at Vi's agitated groan.

"Of course you do." She sighed. "I didn't ever get to find out what happens, though, so I'm curious. Do Benson and Stabler ever get together?"

"Hm, not exactly. However, he does confess to her after his wife explodes."

"She fucking explodes?!"

It was Caitlyn's turn to laugh. She clapped a hand over her mouth to muffle the wheezes, doubling over onto her desk. It wasn't even that funny, really, but something about Vi's reaction had her gasping for air.

"I like hearing you laugh." Vi's voice was laced with a smile, less flirtatious and more genuine. "So, other than dramatic crime shows, what else do you like?"

"That's a rather broad inquiry." Caitlyn sat back, feeling significantly more comfortable. Vi was definitely a handful, that was for sure, but she was fun and had a miraculous way of relaxing Caitlyn. Not an easy feat.

"Okay, let me narrow it down then." The astronaut hummed in thought for a bit before continuing. "What's another show you like?"

“Hmm, I like Yellowjackets.”

Vi paused. “The one about the cannibalist soccer team?”

“That’s the one.”

“Okay, now you’re scaring me a bit.”

Caitlyn chuckled softly. “Alright well, what about you?”

“Don’t really watch much TV. More into sports, specifically MMA and boxing.”

“I see.” Caitlyn squinted at her computer screen, finally digging out Vi’s file and expanding it to fully fit the monitor. She sucked in a shocked breath upon seeing the astronaut’s image displayed at the top of the document. Vi was… well she was stunning. Feathered pink hair and sharp features contrasted by the soft powder blue of her eyes. Cute freckles adorned her cheeks along with a small roman numeral tattoo, piercings lining the one visible ear and sticking out slightly from the neck of her space suit was unmistakable black ink etched into her skin. “Tattoos…”

“Hm? What’s that?”

“Oh. Um-” Caitlyn hadn’t realized she was musing out loud and quickly cleared her throat awkwardly. “You have tattoos.”

Vi laughed softly. “Found my file, didya?”

For a reason she couldn’t explain, Caitlyn found an unmistakable heat of blush filling out her cheeks. “Perhaps.”

“Like what you see?”

This woman was certainly going to be the death of her. “I don’t dislike what I see.”

“Playing coy huh? That’s alright, I dig it.” Caitlyn did her best to ignore Vi’s teasing as she scrolled down the file. It was mostly a list of Vi’s accomplishments as an engineer, her history at NASA, where she went to college, and her duties aboard the international space station. Nothing Caitlyn could use as ammo, unfortunately. She made a mental note to do more research later.

“Well now this isn’t fair.”

Caitlyn frowned. “What’s not fair?”

“You know what I look like but I’m still in the dark about you. Care to share?”

She pursed her lips in thought and gave a little spin in her chair. Deciding this was the ammunition in her arsenal at the moment. “It’s a secret.”

Vi groaned and Caitlyn smiled with her small victory. “C’mon, that‘s mean. Give me one detail.”

“How about I give you a detail if you behave for the rest of the day?”

“Oof, that’ll be quite a challenge for me.”

“Yes, I’m sure it will be.”

Vi actually giggled and Caitlyn was suddenly overwhelmed with feeling like a teenage schoolgirl on the phone with her crush, kicking her feet in the air with a giddy grin. She shook the thought from her mind. Professionalism. She was an adult, this was her job. She could absolutely maintain professionalism.

“Hate to cut this short but I gotta go get my workout in. I’ll check in later to start on some tasks for the day.” Caitlyn couldn’t help but feel a bit disappointed until Vi muttered. “Don’t miss me too much.”

Her eyes rolled. “Likewise. Enjoy your workout.”

“Oh I will, I’m strangely motivated now.” Caitlyn bit her lip shyly. Was that because of her? Did she do her job right? “See ya later, Caitlyn.”

“Bye, Vi.”

A soft beep sounded indicating Vi had gone offline. Caitlyn let out a very slow, deliberate breath and simply stared at Vi’s picture on the computer screen. It then dawned on her that this, Vi, was her job now. She would spend nearly every day for the next eight months simply communicating with Vi. From that first conversation alone it was clear the two had decent chemistry. Caitlyn couldn’t deny the inevitable flutter of butterflies in her stomach, but for now she could blame it on first day jitters. She would be lying, though, to say it didn’t excite her at the prospect of speaking to Vi again.

She hadn’t even realized that her coffee sat cold and abandoned under the coffee maker.

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About two hours later, Vi’s voice came through Caitlyn’s headset once again. She had spent the allotted absence fully customizing her computer, grabbing lunch from the cafeteria, and familiarizing herself with the comm center and the employees that worked there. The spiky haired boy’s name was Mylo, the visiting vehicle officer. He monitored any traffic or shipments coming and going from the space station. Sharing a desk space with him was Claggor, who monitored the ETHOS system that maintained the astronaut's life support systems. To Caitlyn’s surprise, both of them were also the chief’s adopted children. It made her feel all the more pressure to perform well, but also brought about a rather comfortable familial environment within the workplace.

“Yeah, my brother’s are cool.” Vi said in between grunts as she performed the maintenance tasks Caitlyn was reading off to her. “Mylo is kind of a dumbass. Nearly got fired for projecting a big-ass dick drawing on the comms screen.”

“You’re joking. How did he *not* get fired for that?”

“Well it helps when your dad is the one responsible for said *not* firing.”

Caitlyn shook her head. “I believe that’s called nepotism.”

“Hard to argue with you there. They’re both stupid smart though. Earned their way up fair and square.”

“As did you, I presume.”

“You read my file, you tell me.” There was mirth laced in Vi’s voice. Caitlyn wasn’t about to entertain her ego, though she did read Vi’s file thoroughly. Three times, in fact. It was indeed very impressive. Top of her class at the US Naval Academy, two bachelor's degrees in physical science and systems engineering as well as a master’s in Nuclear Engineering. Several achievements, medals, and scholar athlete awards. All before the age of thirty. A regular protege. “Alright I aligned the replacement gas trap and got it slid into the mounting assembly. What’s next?”

Caitlyn squinted at the instructions pulled up on her monitor, finding where they had left off. “Raise the mounting assembly stirrup over the gas trap. Then tighten the push bolt until the gas trap is fully seated on QD’s.”

“Okay, got it.” Vi grunted softly. “Done.”

“Alright now install the quick release pin through the mounting assembly stirrup and push bolt.”

“Hold on, I gotta rotate the push bolt to align the holes- there. All set.”

“Did you engage the side latch?”

“Do you take me for an amateur or something?”

Caitlyn rolled her eyes fondly. “Of course not, Violet, I would never.”

“Oh no, not the government name. You definitely read my file.”

“What can I say? I like to familiarize myself with every aspect of my job rather thoroughly.” Caitlyn sat back and sipped at her fresh cup of coffee, feeling giddy at the prospect of a job well done. It hadn’t even been a full day yet and she could already confidently say Vi was quite easy to work with and that she was getting the hang of things.

“I would make some comment about you being as thorough as you want with me, but I’m on strict orders to behave.”

“Hm, yes and since I’m in a good mood, I’ll let you even hinting at it slide. Only this once, though.”

The astronaut laughed, a sound Caitlyn was growing quite fond of. “A good mood, huh? That have anything to do with me?”

“Well, yes. In a way.” Caitlyn simply didn’t feel like lying. Her and Vi were going to be spending quite a bit of time together. Honesty was a decent path to trust. “To be frank, I was quite nervous to take on this position and despite your apparent need to push the limits of my tolerance to perversion, I must say I think I quite like you, Vi.”

Vi was quiet for a minute and Caitlyn suddenly felt a bit of a twitch beneath her fingertips. The astronaut was wonderful to communicate with, of course, but Caitlyn couldn’t help but wonder what sort of expression she made whenever she went quiet. Or how her eyes may light up when Caitlyn could hear a smile in her voice. There was a bit of an itch beneath her skin she felt she couldn’t scratch. One that could only be described as longing. She hadn’t known Vi for more than a few hours and there was still plenty they didn’t know about one another, but the desire was there. The gravitational pull of wanting to be closer and yet, being unable to.

“Likewise.” Was all Vi said. There was something somber in her voice, almost as if she too felt the same longing that was plaguing Caitlyn’s heart.

Caitlyn wasn’t given long to dwell on her thoughts as Vi seemed to recover a lot faster than she did. “So, anything else on the schedule today?”

Caitlyn pulled up the schedule on her computer, a furrow to her brow. “Actually, no. Today is rather devoid. It seems that one maintenance task was projected to take a lot longer.”

“Damn, I guess you’re just too good at your job, huh?”

“Oh stop. You did all the work. I simply sat here, read a document and drank some bitter coffee.”

“Awe but you did it so well and didn’t make a single space pun.”

“That could change, you know. There’s still time.”

“Please, no. I’m begging you.”

The sound of their laughter overlapped with one another. Caitlyn’s cheeks were actually beginning to ache with how much she had been smiling today. It was a feeling of euphoria she hadn’t experienced in quite some time.

“Well, I guess you’re off the hook then today.”

Her smile slowly disappeared. This was ridiculous. Who actually frowns at the idea of leaving work and going home for the day?

“One more thing, though.”

“Yes?”

There was a clear smile in Vi’s voice, a teasing lilt to her tone. “I’m still waiting for that detail.”

Caitlyn bit her lip, considering her options carefully. It wasn’t that she was self conscious in her looks, but, considering how undeniably gorgeous the woman on the other end of the line was, she couldn’t help the spark of anxiety that set butterflies loose in her gut.

“I’m tall.” Is what she settled on.

“Oh yeah? How tall are we talking?”

“Six feet even.”

A low whistle on the other end drew heat to Caitlyn’s cheeks. “No shit. You’re taller than me. I’m five-nine.”

“I’ve always been a bit self conscious about it, to be honest.”

“Are you kidding? Tall women are the best. I bet you got legs for days.”

Caitlyn’s face was positively burning now. “You’d be right about that.”

“Damn. Well, good to know.” She paused and Caitlyn heard a soft thump. Almost as if she had braced her forehead against a wall or maybe a window. “Thanks for telling me. Now I can start to imagine what you look like.”

“Based on that alone?”

“Well, sure, but I can deduce a few things as well.”

“Oh posh. Like what?”

Vi was seemingly smug now as she quoted Caitlyn from earlier. “It’s a secret.”

“Touché.”

The astronaut chuckled softly and sighed. Caitlyn wondered if she, too, didn’t want their day to end.

“Talk to you tomorrow then?” Caitlyn suggested.

Vi paused, her voice rather soft and almost sentimental as she replied. “Yeah, talk to you tomorrow. Have a good rest of your night, Caitlyn.”

“You too, Vi.”

It took a moment for the soft beep of Vi going offline to sound in Caitlyn’s headset. Another five minutes of Caitlyn staring once more at the smiling photo of Vi from her profile. She was struggling to put words to this feeling fluttering around in her stomach. Simply the

nerves of talking with a beautiful woman, perhaps. Or maybe the gratefulness of the opportunity. The revelation that her job was actually fun? There had to be a logical explanation.

After documenting a report summary of her and Vi's maintenance tasks of the day and emailing it to the team, Caitlyn collected her suit jacket from the back of her chair along with her satchel and made for the chief's office.

"Hey kiddo! How was your first day?" Vander greeted her warmly as she entered his office after knocking.

"It was… it was lovely, actually. Your daughter is indeed a handful but she's very easy to get along with."

Vander hummed softly with a smile. "Yeah, that's Vi for you. She's fierce but I'm convinced there's no one with a bigger heart in the universe. I should know, I've seen quite a lot of it."

Caitlyn laughed shyly, tucking a strand of loose hair behind her ear. "I'm excited to get to know her more. Please, do let me know if there's anything specific I can say or do to make her journey more bearable. I can't imagine it's easy being up there away from your family."

There was a bit of sadness in the chief's eyes as he nodded, something seemingly gone unsaid for now. "Thanks, kiddo. Will do. Enjoy your night."

Caitlyn practically skipped out of work, electing to try a Thai takeout restaurant she had spotted on her way home. It had been so long since she felt this immense joy and reinvigoration in her work. She was finally there, at the peak of where she spent her career desperately climbing to and she was sure she'd enjoy every moment of it. Every moment of working with Vi.

She lamented over her conversation with the astronaut over and over again that evening, excitement coursing through her with an eagerness for what tomorrow may bring.

And if she sat that night out on her balcony with a warm cup of tea in hand, staring up at the stars and thinking about just how distant Vi was from her, well then that was between her and her cat.

Longing

Chapter Summary

> “What do you miss most about Earth?”

Chapter Notes

> Heya. It's been like, what, 24 hours?
>
> Thank you all for the positive feedback on the first chapter! I'm very excited to bring you what I have planned for this fic.
> This chapter is a lot of filler conversation but there's some important development here.
>
> I made a sweet little Spotify playlist for this fic. You can find that here if you'd like.
>
> See ya. <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

ISS Expedition number 59
Time Elapsed: 165 Days
Time Remaining: 200 Days

Caitlyn should have remained curious. What was the phrase? Curiosity killed the cat? What was the lesbian equivalent of that? Vi could probably come up with some sort of pussy joke if Caitlyn asked. She wasn’t going to.

Still, as Caitlyn was laid out on her stomach in a NASA t-shirt and sleep shorts, feet up in the air and a carrot stick covered in ranch half sticking out of her mouth, she most definitely couldn’t help but sympathize with the phrase. Her curiosity had driven her to Googling the very astronaut she had spent the last six weeks conversing with on the daily. This led to a couple articles, various google images that displayed much more of Vi than her profile picture in her file at NASA did, and a couple of youtube videos. One of which was pulled up on Caitlyn’s laptop screen and practically spiraling her into an absolute gay frenzy.

As it turns out, Vi’s employee photo for NASA did not do her physique a lick of justice by hiding her away in that bulky space suit. Vi was *built.* Astronauts were expected to be quite

fit and passing an extensive physical test was required for the position, but Caitlyn was fairly confident the woman could probably bench press at least two of her.

And Caitlyn would be a filthy liar if she said this new view of her astronaut wasn't devastatingly attractive to her.

The video pulled up was an interview segment on the news that covered how astronauts exercise in space without gravity. Caitlyn was obviously familiar with this information, it wasn't what peaked her interest.

The thumbnail of Vi in a tank top and NASA blue track shorts most definitely did though.

"So, Violet, would you do the honors of leading us through what a typical workout looks like for an astronaut aboard the international space station?"

"Just Vi is fine, and of course. Let's get started." Vi offered the interviewer a polite smile and Caitlyn's heart did a flip. Sure, she had heard Vi speak many times by now, but this was the first time she had *seen* Vi moving and speaking. It was… definitely having an effect on her.

"It's necessary for us to get about two hours of exercise minimum per day on the space station. Without gravity, our bodies don't necessarily feel the need for muscles so they begin to deteriorate if we don't work them. This could cause a lot of problems when we come back down to Earth." Caitlyn was downing her carrot sticks like they were popcorn, completely enraptured by Vi's explanation. "We have three different types of equipment on the space station. There's a stationary bike and a treadmill, similar to what you see here." She led the interviewer over to two machines. "I can demonstrate one for you if you'd like."

"Yes, please! That would be great." Caitlyn squinted at the interviewer who was staring at Vi with a rather rosy glow to her cheeks. Vi unzipped the blue jacket she had been wearing, revealing the fabled outfit from the thumbnail and stealing Caitlyn's breath as she saw peeks of the black ink that extended up the back of Vi's muscular arms. "Oh wow." The interviewer openly ogled. "Look at those biceps! You can definitely tell you work out."

Caitlyn rolled her eyes. How obvious and shameless this woman was.

"Ah, yeah. We gotta do a lot of training and pass a pretty hardcore physical exam before we can even go up in space, but I like staying in shape. So, for the treadmill we have to strap ourselves into this harness that's connected to the base of the machine with bungee cords…"

A strange sense of satisfaction washed over Caitlyn at Vi's blatant ignoring of the interviewer's advances. So Vi really wasn't a voracious flirt with just anyone. Good to know.

She watched through the video in absolute awe as Vi went through the various workouts. Vi made everything look so effortless with a natural charisma that made her absolutely captivating to watch. Once she was done demonstrating the treadmill, a light sheen of sweat making her forehead and biceps glisten, Vi moved on to the next portion of the workout.

"This is our advanced resistive exercise device or ARED as we call it. We can't use dumbbells in space so this machine relies on pistons contained in vacuum cylinders to

provide constant resistance. This is how we maintain our muscle mass."

"Ohh right because dumbbells wouldn't have any mass in space."

This woman was insufferable. She was clearly trying to sound much smarter than she was, probably an attempt at impressing Vi. Caitlyn groaned. "Their mass would stay the same. Weight is the force due to gravity therefore they would still have mass but not weight."

Vi scratched the shaved side of her head with an awkward chuckle. Caitlyn did not stare at the way her bicep moved with the action nope nope. "Well there's a difference between mass and weight. An object in space would have the same mass but the weight, which is the force due to gravity, wouldn't be there so they'd essentially be weightless, yes."

"That's what I said!" Caitlyn nearly shouted at the screen. Chowder, who had been napping at the end of the bed, shot her a glare.

"Oh I see." The woman looked slightly embarrassed. Caitlyn counted it as a small victory for herself, ignoring that small voice in the back of her head that told her she was being territorial and giving mean girl energy. "So what sort of exercises can you do with this machine?"

"All kinds. Squats, deadlifts, bench press, the works."

"Would you show us a few of them?"

"Sure, I'd love to. Let's start with some deadlifts and then I'll demonstrate a bench press and some cable curls."

Caitlyn isn't sure when she froze halfway through eating a carrot stick until Vi was midway through her bench press set and it promptly fell out of her mouth onto the bed, smearing ranch everywhere.

"Shit." She grumbled, wiping away the stain with her napkin and shoving the rest of her snack aside. At this point she had chewed through half the bag and risked turning into a damn rabbit.

If Caitlyn was having a hard time not closely observing Vi's muscles before, now she was no better than the interviewer. Who could blame her though? The woman was simply incredible, lifting weights with ease that Caitlyn wouldn't even be able to nudge. By the time Vi got to her cable curls, there was no denying the heat in Caitlyn's cheeks

"Very impressive!" The interviewer beamed as Vi unstrapped herself from the machine.

"Ah it was nothing."

Several things then happened in immediate succession that ended with a furiously blushing Caitlyn, a stained carpet and a broken flower vase.

First was that Vi lifted her tank top from the bottom to wipe away the sweat on her forehead, exposing her *ridiculously* toned abs.

Second was that, on instinct and without a second thought, Caitlyn panic jammed her finger into the space bar key on her laptop's keyboard. Freezing the screen on said toned abs.

Thirdly, having realized what she had done and what she was looking at, Caitlyn squealed in horror and slammed her laptop shut, scaring the ever loving daylights out of poor Chowder.

Last of all, in his terror, Chowder launched himself off the bed and onto Caitlyn's dresser. Knocking the flower vase onto the ground and spilling her congratulatory bouquet from Jayce along with week old flower water onto her plush carpet.

Caitlyn sat for a moment in shock. That was a lot to take in all at once.

"Oh my god." She eventually groaned into her comforter, coming to terms with the devastation her hopeless gay ass had caused. "I'm so sorry, Chowder. I didn't mean to pause the video there, I just panicked."

She slid out of bed with a huff and made her way into the kitchen for cleaning supplies, Chowder's judgmental and rather irritated blue hues following her movements. Once the mess was cleaned up to the best of her abilities, Caitlyn opened up a can of tuna and spooned some onto a paper plate as a peace offering. Maybe curiosity really did kill cats and she had just gotten lucky this time.

Either way she had no clue how she would face Vi tomorrow.

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"Favorite candy?"

"Hm, what's that?" Caitlyn was really trying her best to pay attention but, much to her chagrin, her incident from the previous night had indeed burned the image of Vi in a sports bra with her abs on display into Caitlyn's mind. Effectively providing quite a distraction for the day. In fact, she was envisioning Vi a lot more clearly than she had the past weeks and it was practically plaguing her as the two conversed.

She equated it to reading a book. Maybe there's an image of the protagonist on the cover and while you read you can do your best to envision them but the image isn't quite so clear. However, once you watch the movie adaptation and you can see the character with your own eyes, it becomes easier to imagine them whilst reading.

This was now how she felt having seen that interview of Vi. She now had a clear picture in her mind of the way Vi moved, the shape of her body, the way she smiled and laughed. It was much easier to imagine the sort of facial expressions Vi would make whilst conversing with Caitlyn. If Vi's tone seemed awkward she could imagine the woman was scratching at the shaved side of her head. If she exerted effort she could imagine Vi's biceps moving, her nose scrunching adorably with the strain. It was all a bit too much all at once.

“You okay? You seem a bit distracted today.”

“Yes.” Caitlyn winced, having answered far too quickly. It didn’t sound very convincing but she wasn’t going to give her astronaut any time to question it. “Sorry. Just had a bit of a long night. Paperwork and all that. What was your question?”

Vi hummed in thought and yeah she definitely wasn’t buying the shit Caitlyn was selling but seemed to let it go for now. “I asked what your favorite candy is.”

“Oh, nerds gummy clusters.”

“Huh. I don’t think I’ve ever had those.”

“We will need to remedy that as soon as you get back down to Earth.”

“That good, huh? Alright. I’ll add it to the list.” Vi paused. “Aren’t you going to ask me?”

“Sorry?”

“What my favorite candy is?”

“Oh, well I sort of just assumed you don’t eat much candy.”

“Yeah? Why’s that?”

Shit.

“Um, well because- you know astronauts need to stay in such good shape and what not…”

There was a long stretch of time that Caitlyn couldn’t help but feel Vi was dragging out on purpose. Confirmed, what felt like countless minutes later, by her smug reply.

“You found the workout interview, didn’t you?”

Caitlyn wanted to bang her forehead on the desk, but settled for her knuckles instead. “I might have found the workout interview.”

Vi’s laughter filtered through the headset and despite Caitlyn’s mortification, she found herself smiling a bit too. Vi was just infectious like that. “So that’s why you’ve been acting so dang weird today. Jeez you had me thinking I did something wrong.”

“Of course not. I’m so sorry. It’s just-“ She sighed and slumped backward into her chair. “It’s a lot easier to picture you now while we’re speaking and it’s been… distracting.”

“In a good way, I hope?”

Caitlyn’s lips pursed, a warm blush filling out her cheeks. “Well, certainly not in a *bad* way.”

“Always playing coy with me.” Vi sounded fond, a hint of a smile in her voice. “So what did you think?”

Caitlyn blinked, tilting her head curiously. “Of?”

“The interview.”

A difficult question to answer. Caitlyn couldn’t very well admit that what she thought is that Vi looked like every lesbian’s wet dream personified. She was also most definitely not going to admit to the incident with the flower vase.

“I think the interviewer had a thing for you.”

Vi snorted. “Oh, you think so?”

“It was blatantly obvious.”

“Well, she did give me her number afterward.”

Caitlyn really gave it her best effort to sound indifferent in her response. “Did she now?”

“Mmmhm.” There was a loud clang on the other end, it startled Caitlyn slightly out of her calm, cool and collected facade. “You jealous?”

“Don’t be daft. She didn’t even know the difference between mass and weight.”

It was amazing how Vi’s laughter could dissolve even the toughest of Caitlyn’s walls. She sucked in her cheeks to keep from smiling as Vi guffawed into the mic. “I know right. I never gave her a call.” Caitlyn could imagine Vi shrugging. “Not my type. I like smart girls with a little bit of attitude… and great titts.”

Caitlyn rolled her eyes. “How revolutionary of you.”

“Oh yeah? Well what about you then?”

“What’s my type?” Caitlyn simply received a grunt in reply. Vi most likely had some sort of tool in her mouth. “I don’t know if I have a type.”

“Sure you do. Everyone’s got a type.”

Caitlyn thought about it. She had never searched out a specific type of woman. Growing up she would attempt to date someone she felt her parents would find agreeable. Mostly out of fear of disappointing them, but that was the only “type” she had specifically sought out. Since then she had only ever dated women she found interesting for one reason or another.

The chief’s words from her first day suddenly egged at the back of her mind. “I guess… just someone with a good heart.”

Vi was quiet for a decent chunk of time and Caitlyn fidgeted in her chair. Sure, it was easier to picture Vi when she was speaking, but that ever present twinge of anxiety still sparked whenever Vi went quiet like this. What sort of facial expression could she be making? What was she thinking? Had Caitlyn said the wrong thing?

“I like that.” She ended up saying softly.

Caitlyn bit her lip shyly. There was something strangely intimate in Vi’s voice, something she hadn’t heard before. Those familiar butterflies began twitching around in her gut, that unusual longing itch beneath her fingers returning at full force.

“We should probably move on to the next thing on the schedule, huh?”

“Oh.” Caitlyn breathed out, giving her head a small shake to snap out of the daze. “Yes, we’re working on several different developmental vaccine experiments today.”

“Right.”

Caitlyn wasn’t sure why this conversation seemed to have left so much unsaid between the two, but she would spend many nights thereafter thinking she would give her entire salary to see what sort of expression her astronaut had made in that moment.

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Time Elapsed: 172 Days
Time Remaining: 193 Days

Caitlyn sat with her flaming cheeks placed into her palms, Vi’s inconsolable laughter continuing on endlessly through the headset.

“One more time, *please.*” The astronaut wheezed.

“I feel as though you are dragging this out.”

“No no I *need* to hear it again.”

Caitlyn sighed. “My cat’s name is Clam Chowder.”

Vi’s voice shook with laughter. “And why is that?”

“Because it’s a lesbian’s favorite soup.”

Vi dissolved into another fit of hysterics, her voice sounding further away as if she had taken off her headset. “Ekko! C’mere, man, you gotta hear this one.”

Caitlyn should have never left Florida.

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Time Elapsed: 178 Days
Time Remaining: 187 Days

“What do you miss most about Earth?”

“Besides gravity you mean?”

“You are so cliche.” Caitlyn smiled, popping a goldfish cracker into her mouth and chewing methodically.

Vi hummed in thought, a smile in her voice once she spoke again. “Good question. There’s so many things I miss. The weather, my favorite diner, going to the movies, taking a cute girl out on a date, pinning her down on my kitchen table-“

“Oh for god’s sake. Why do I even bother with you?”

Muffled laughter, followed by, “Well they kind of pay you for that, don’t they?”

“Not nearly enough to put up with your antics.”

“You wound me.” Caitlyn rolled her eyes, but found herself smiling as she usually did when conversing with Vi. She dug into her snack bag for more crackers, a sound that had apparently picked up over the mic.

“Wacha snacking on?”

“Goldfish crackers. They’re my favorite.”

“Fuck I miss goldfish crackers.” Vi groaned, Caitlyn felt a little guilty. “They the flavor blasted ones?”

“Pizza, actually.”

“Wait what?” Vi chuckled disbelievingly over the line. “Who the fuck eats the pizza flavor?”

“I do, thank you very much. I particularly like to have them with apple slices.”

A beat. “What, like, at the same time?”

“Absolutely.”

“Now that’s just weird.”

“Don’t knock it till you try it.” She brushed her hands off against themselves and tucked away her lunch bag. “Let me rephrase my earlier inquiry to be more specific since you enjoy twisting my words into debauchery so much.” Vi laughed, Caitlyn ignored her and continued on. “What do you miss the most to *eat* on Earth?”

A long pause.

“Caitlyn.”

“Yes?”

Vi didn’t respond. Caitlyn squinted hard at the corner of her cubicle. What could she possibly have-

“I swear to god Violet if you say pussy-“

“All I’m saying is if you’re trying to avoid my perversion then you should know, as a lesbian, that was the wrong question to ask.”

Caitlyn groaned and slumped back into her seat. The astronaut had gotten her there. That was her fuck up. “You’re right. I give up.”

“Awe don’t be like that. Here, I’ll answer seriously. The food I miss the most is cupcakes.”

That peaked Caitlyn’s interest a bit. “Really? Cupcakes?”

“Mmhm.” There was a soft clanging sound on the other end of the line. Vi must be adjusting something on the spacecraft. “They’re the perfect dessert. They’re so soft and sweet, kinda like you.”

A warm blush crept up on Caitlyn’s cheeks. Vi was often rather crass but she had her moments of genuine charm. “What sort of cupcakes do you like?”

“Any kind.” Vi’s voice appeared strained, like she was tightening something or exerting force to move an object. “Though there was this one specific kind my mother used to make. Fuck, they were the best in the world. Some sort of apple, caramel and cinnamon flavor. I’d give anything in the universe to have those again.”

“That does sound wonderful. Perhaps you can have some when you return.”

She chuckled humorlessly. “Nah, mom died when I was a kid. The recipe died with her I’m afraid.”

Caitlyn felt a familiar pang in her chest. She had known Vi and her siblings were adopted by Vander, but this was the first mention of her mother. “I’m so sorry, Violet.”

“Ah, don’t be. Time passes, wounds heal.” There was a crackle over the mic, a glitch that often occurred as Vi moved her way through the space station. “Though, to be honest, I dunno if I’d be up here if it weren’t for her.”

Caitlyn kicked her heels off under the desk and drew her legs up, hugging her knees and getting comfortable. “Did she inspire you to become an astronaut?”

“In a way.” There was a sort of echo to Vi’s voice now. From this Caitlyn could only assume she was in the cupola, a hexagon bubble of windows that gave the best view of Earth from

inside the ISS. “She used to read Powder and I all kinds of books about the universe. From science fiction to books on astronomy and planets. We grew up poor, so she had other ways of showing us our worth. She would remind us just how small our problems were in retrospect. That up here, none of that truly mattered. Said we shone brighter than any star in the universe and that we belonged up here with them, above it all.” A soft thump, most likely Vi’s forehead against the glass window. “Guess she beat me to it.”

There weren’t words to truly express the beauty in Vi’s story. Caitlyn’s eyes stung as she listened and hugged her knees tighter against her chest, not afraid to admit to herself for the first time that she wished it were Vi she was hugging instead.

“She sounds like an incredible woman.” Caitlyn mused softly, resting her chin atop her knees. “And for what it’s worth, she’s right… you do shine.”

Vi was quiet for a moment, but when she spoke once more Caitlyn thought she could hear a soft smile in her voice. “What about you?”

Caitlyn sucked in a breath, eyeing the framed Kiramman family portrait hung on the left wall of her cubicle. “I… had sort of the opposite experience.” Her feet lowered back to the ground, fingers entwining in her lap. “I grew up very wealthy, but what I had in material goods, I lacked in compassion from my parents. My mother wasn’t warm or encouraging. She was cold and calculated. Everything was about status, who I associated with, what I wore, the way I spoke.” Her head fell back against the chair, wishing desperately she could see through the ceiling and up at the stars, toward Vi. “They were so concerned with material wealth and public perception. Stuck in their bubble of privilege. One day, as I sat alone in my family's archives, I discovered my own passion for the universe. I picked up countless novels of worlds and stars beyond our own and I realized just how silly it was to obsess over trivial things like fancy cars and expensive jewelry when there was so much more wealth in knowledge and discovery.”

Caitlyn closed her eyes and breathed out slowly. She envisioned Vi in front of her, the soft hue of her powder blue eyes and an understanding smile to her scarred lips as Caitlyn continued. “I suppose, despite our opposing circumstances, we came to similar realizations. That up there, none of it matters. That there is so much more to experience.”

There was a stretch of silence between them, although not an uncomfortable one. They were both simply absorbing each other’s stories, reveling in the shared emotions and experiences. It was incredible, really, that despite never having seen Caitlyn in person, Vi was beginning to understand her on a level no one else had. Vi was over two hundred and fifty miles away, and yet, Caitlyn hadn’t felt closer to anyone else.

“I wish I could share this view with you.” Vi murmured, her voice laced with that familiar longing that Caitlyn could feel buzzing beneath her skin.

“Maybe someday I will.”

Vi hummed. “I’d like that.”

Caitlyn wasn't sure how long they sat there, listening to each other's breath. It was such a comfortable feeling, a calm that soaked into Caitlyn's bones and soothed her soul.

"Vi?"

"Yeah?"

"Thank you for telling me."

She didn't expect a reply, but after a moment of contemplation on Vi's part, she got one that nearly stole the very breath from her lungs.

"Thanks for listening, cupcake."

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Time Elapsed: 180 Days
Time Remaining: 185 Days

"Ah, Caitlyn, a quick word if you would?"

Caitlyn paused on her usual trek to her cubicle, spotting the chief passing through the aisles of desks with a coffee mug in hand.

"Everything alright, chief?"

He waved her off and took a sip from his mug. "Oh yes everything is good. I just wanted to touch base with you about this week's schedule. You've no doubt noticed you have your first long night with us on Thursday."

"Oh, for the space walk, yes?"

"That's the one. Just wanted to prepare you, it's a hell of an experience. You'll be on comms for about nine hours straight. Think you're up for the task?"

Any sane person may hear this information and want to crawl under a rock, but Caitlyn couldn't help but feel excited about the opportunity to assist in her first space walk. It would also be a lie to say she wasn't excited about the prospect of being online with Vi for nine whole hours.

"I'm definitely up for it. I'm actually rather excited."

"Good to hear." Vander smiled warmly. Caitlyn often struggled to think of this man as her boss. He was more of a teddy bear. "Dress comfortably. You can even wear pajamas if you'd

like. Bring lots of snacks and anything you'd need to feel more comfortable. Oh and in terms of Violet…" He leaned casually against the walls of a nearby cubicle, indicating this was more of a dad talk than one from your superior. "She's been on her fair share of these walks and always handles them flawlessly. I'm sure she'd never admit it, but it is still a pretty scary experience. This trip has been… particularly hard for her in terms of being away from her family and it's giving her a lot more strain than usual. I guess what I'm trying to say is, please do your best for her, yeah?"

Caitlyn didn't need to be asked to do this. At this point, she was fairly certain she would move the Earth itself for Vi. Still, she nodded in agreement. "Of course, chief. I'll be well prepared and do what I can to make her more comfortable."

"I know you will." He smiled warmly. "Truth be told, although she's finding it difficult being away from us, I've never seen her more motivated. I think you're having quite a positive effect on her so whatever it is you're doing, keep doing it."

With that, Vander flashed her his signature wink and left Caitlyn standing there without a clue of how to process what he'd just said. It was fairly obvious at this point that the two of them had grown closer, but to hear someone else put it into words. Well, that made it feel tangible, real even.

As Caitlyn made her way back to her station, a warm glow filling out her cheeks, she couldn't help but wonder just how much space in Vi's heart was left for Caitlyn. It didn't necessarily matter, Caitlyn would take anything Vi could give her. She was simply grateful to be a part of this experience with her.

But it would be a lie to say she didn't secretly hope for just a little more.

Chapter End Notes

Love how the most sentimental part of this chapter started with a pussy joke.

Anygay yell at me on X if you want: @GutterWitchAo3
Next Chapter will be out soon but not as quickly as this one. I do appreciate your patience!

Comments and kudos much obliged <3

A Dance Among the Stars

Chapter Summary

"I'd dance up here with you."

Chapter Notes

Spacewalk time girls, gays and they's. I watched an actual ten hour spacewalk video from NASA for this chapter so there's a lot of fun space shit in here. And shameless flirty lesbians, of course.

Side note: I dunno if anyone was really paying attention but I had to alter the time stamps in the last chapter because I had them messed up but they're correct now. Sorry about that. Let me know if you need timeline verification in the comments.

I think this is my favorite chapter thus far. There's lots of new characters introduced and I simply love character writing so I had fun here. I hope you enjoy it as well.

The song that plays later in this chapter is "Dance with Me" by beabadoobee. It's in the Spotify playlist for this chapter here if you want to listen.

See ya <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Time Elapsed: 183 Days
Time Remaining: 182 Days

"Good afternoon, Miss Kiramman."

Caitlyn straightened up from where she was hunched over in the break room refrigerator, a piece of sourdough toast between her lips.

"Oh." She promptly removed the toast and hip checked the door closed, a bottle of vanilla creamer in her hand. "Good Morning, Viktor."

Viktor was the capsule communicator for the Russian astronauts on board, two in total. Unlike Caitlyn, he had once been an astronaut himself. However, years of exploration had caused some significant muscular atrophy and bone density issues that he had been unable to

recover from. The man now utilized a cane to walk but maintained his fierce passion for space exploration. Caitlyn couldn't help but think he was a bit of a workaholic, but one of the more likeable coworkers nonetheless.

He poured some sugar into his own mug of coffee and offered a polite smile with a questioning quirk to his brow. "Excited for your first space walk?"

Caitlyn nodded enthusiastically around bites of her toast, making her way over to the counter to continue preparing her caffeine buzz. One of many she would most likely need for the day. "Very much so. I know it's just for maintenance, but I'm absolutely buzzing with anticipation."

"Eh, I've always believed any action in the pursuit of scientific discovery is a worthwhile venture, regardless of its magnitude." Caitlyn frowned as the man poured his fifth sugar packet into the mug. Was that even coffee at this point? "It may just be maintenance but it's for a craft that is pursuing *wonders* in various medical advancements and other fields. I was just as excited for my first. Although, I was actually *in* space so I suppose it's not quite the same…"

Caitlyn giggled to herself. Viktor had a tendency to tangent and get lost in his musings, a rather adorable quirk. She agreed with him, of course, but she didn't have the heart to admit to the man that really what she was most excited for was spending nine hours among the stars with her crush.

Oh, yeah, because Caitlyn had a crush. She wasn't denying it anymore.

It was just too obvious, too black and white for her to reject. Vi was brilliant, smart, suave, funny, and too bloody attractive for her own good. So yeah, Caitlyn had a crush. Would she do anything about it? Probably not. What *could* she do about it while Vi was in space anyway? A whole lot of nothing.

For now she would simply settle for re-watches of Vi's fitness interview, quick glances of longing up at the night sky, and the fleeting flaps of butterfly wings in her tummy whenever Vi shamelessly flirted with her. Which begged another inquiry, could Vi feel the same? Again, probably not. Vi hadn't even ever actually seen Caitlyn. Sure, they'd flirt and there were moments of pure sentiment, but how could Vi possibly reciprocate any kind of feelings without having seen Caitlyn or even knowing the basics of what she looked like?

"Miss Kiramman?"

Caitlyn snapped out of her train of thought, offering Victor an apologetic smile. "Sorry, I just got lost in thought there for a moment."

The man hummed and sipped his sugary bean water. "As do I when contemplating the vastness of the universe."

Caitlyn bit her lip. Again, not willing to confess that her only contemplations as of late were more attune to the vastness of her homosexuality. "Yes, it's quite a magnificent opportunity. I wish you luck today, Viktor."

“Yes of course. Good luck to you as well. Let me know if you require any sort of assistance.”

“You too.” She smiled fondly at the man as he left, sighing to herself as she was left to her breakfast. It was around four in the afternoon at that point, however most of the team had only just arrived. Electing instead to spend the morning relaxing and getting some well needed rest before a long night. Caitlyn herself hadn’t slept much. She felt absolutely restless, an eagerness shooting sparks of adrenaline through her every time she attempted to close her eyes.

Stifling a yawn, Caitlyn made her way to the comms room, shuffling along in the worn sneakers she had elected for in accordance with the chief’s request to dress comfortably. The rest of her outfit included a pair of NASA sweatpants with a large space logo on the left thigh and a Cambridge alumni sweatshirt. She left her hair down today, but slipped a black scrunchie onto her wrist should she need to sweep the cobalt locks up from her shoulders.

Caitlyn sipped at her coffee and finished the rest of her toast, rounding the walls of her cubicle with an eagerness to begin work, only to find a rather spritely looking woman with bright blue space buns occupying her seat.

“That’s what I’m saying, but she says it can’t be done.” The woman undid her criss-crossed legs and threw up her arms enthusiastically while she spoke into Caitlyn’s headset. “Like, listen lady, I invented a robot that could braid my hair for me when I was thirteen. If I want to make a fucking machine that can translate bees then that’s what I’m going to do but noo. Miss Sevika knows better than me. Swear that woman doesn’t even know the difference between an axle wrench and a blowtorch-”

“Um, Excuse me.”

The woman tossed her head back over the edge of the chair, the two staring at each other in stunned confusion on Caitlyn’s part.

“Oops. Busted.” The pixie girl sat up straight and adjusted the headset slightly. “Gotta go, sis, your girlfriend’s here.”

Caitlyn sputtered, absolutely dumbfounded.

“Yeah, yeah I’ll tell her. Okay, talk to you later. Love you too.” She clicked the button on the side of the headset and slipped it off, grinning sheepishly over her shoulder at Caitlyn. “Heya toots.”

Caitlyn shook off her panicked excitement at being referred to as Vi’s girlfriend, albeit jokingly, and hugged her coffee close to ground herself. “You must be Powder.” Vi had told Caitlyn about her baby sister many times, insisting that Powder was the true brains of the family and that her and Vander combined didn’t hold a candle to her sister’s intellectual prowise. Powder was a true protege in advanced robotics development. She was half a decade younger than Vi and yet she had already developed advancements in technology for NASA that most wouldn't accomplish in their lifetime.

“That’s me.” She kicked away from Caitlyn’s desk and shot up, standing a whole head shorter than Caitlyn. “Sorry I commandeered your station. Just wanted to chat with Vi for a sec. I hope that’s okay? The old guy used to get so up his ass about it.”

“Oh, no that’s quite alright.” She gave Powder a once over, a bit surprised at the woman’s appearance. Powder looked like she belonged in a studio making sculptures or painting abstract art. Caitlyn never would have guessed she was one of NASA’s top genius inventors. Although, genius minds do often come wrapped in unexpected packages. “I know how much Vi misses you so, please, feel free to stop by any time.”

Powder beamed, her blue eyes lighting up. “Wow, Vi was right. You are super sweet.”

If Caitlyn were to become any more surprised then her eyebrows would probably melt into her hairline.

“Welp, in any case, I’m your relief today if you need to take a break so I’ll be around tinkering with shit. Oh! I brought you a peace offering as well.” Powder tilted her head toward a small wrapped rectangle with a bow leaning against Caitlyn’s monitor. “You can thank me later. Enjoy your space date!”

She skipped away before Caitlyn had so much as a second to process all of which was said. Girlfriend. Vi thinks she’s sweet. A present? Space date.

“I haven’t had nearly enough coffee for all of this.” Caitlyn muttered, plopping down into her warmed up rolling chair and sipping her beverage while eyeing Powder’s gift. She gingerly inspected the messy collage of a wrap job before peeling the paper back.

Caitlyn let out an overwhelmed breath, staring wide eyed at the graffiti decorated framed photograph of Vi in her hands. Vi was leaning against a brick wall, a bottle of beer in her hand and a wide smile on her rose painted lips. She was wearing a leather jacket and a short cropped NASA t-shirt underneath, her abs exposed by the low cut of some rather egregiously tight jeans. Caitlyn silently made a vow to repay Powder worth her weight in gold. The photo was stunning beyond words, a true captured moment of pure joy. Caitlyn had received many luxurious gifts in her life, and she would set them all ablaze in exchange for this one.

Stroking the edges of the frame with her fingertips, Caitlyn placed it upright at the edge of her monitor, smiling softly to herself as she reached for her headset.

“ISS, do you copy?”

“Hey beautiful, I copy.”

Was absolutely everyone out to completely fluster Caitlyn today? “Wha- you don’t even know what I look like.” She mumbled shyly, pulling out strands of dark hair to frame her face.

“Hm, that may have once been true, however I was just given some pretty solid information.”

Nevermind, Caitlyn was going to smother Powder in her sleep.

Caitlyn covered the microphone with her palm for a moment to let out a shaky breath, willing the nerves to settle down post haste. “Oh? What exactly did you hear?”

Vi paused before speaking in a rather wistful tone. “Heard you got eyes like the ocean. Dark blue hair that looks like a raven’s wings. Cute little gap in your front teeth…” She trailed off for a moment, Caitlyn held her breath, blatantly ignoring the burning heat radiating from her face. “Stunning and elegant… just like I imagined you’d be.”

Caitlyn was beginning to wonder which of them was truly in zero gravity. She felt weightless, and yet a crushing ache in her heart all at the same time. There was no chance that Powder had given descriptions such as these, which means Vi seems to have taken whatever information she did receive and was interpreting it in such a way that made Caitlyn’s heart pound.

“I- I don’t know about all that. You make me sound so… ethereal. I’m afraid you may have to temper your expectations a bit.”

“Nah. I don’t.” Vi said softly. “You’re beautiful regardless of what you look like, Caitlyn.”

Vi must have inhaled some sort of noxious space fumes to make her say something so brazen. Caitlyn opened and closed her mouth like a goddamn fish but simply couldn’t form any tangible words.

A man’s voice called Vi somewhere in the background.

“Coming!” She called out to him, addressing Caitlyn once more. “Gotta go get suited up. Talk to you in a bit. See ya cupcake.”

“Mmhm.” Caitlyn hummed, still flustered beyond words. “Yes, talk to you soon.”

A beep signalled Vi going offline, leaving Caitlyn in a post whirlwind tizzy. She hadn’t even been an hour into their long work day and already felt as though a second dose of caffeine was more than necessary.

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“Knock knock.”

Caitlyn glanced up from her computer to see Vander leaning over the edge of the cubicle, some sort of handheld monitor in his hand. “Ready to roll kiddo?”

“Yes sir. I’ve just gone over the maintenance task list once again and pulled up any additional instructions that Vi may need.”

“Outstanding.” He smiled warmly. “I’ve brought you a little something.”

Had Caitlyn forgotten her own birthday or was the entire family just in a gift giving mood? "Sir?"

Vander extended his hand to offer Caitlyn the small screen. She took it with a confused downturn of her lips. The device seemed home made but definitely sturdy. It was no bigger than a piece of paper and surprisingly lightweight. Turning over the screen, Caitlyn found several buttons with a large sticker of what looked like a crayon drawing of Mylo's head, the words "press here to turn me on" written with an arrow above one of the buttons. Caitlyn pushed it and flipped the screen back over.

It took a moment to boot up, but then, clear as day, Caitlyn could see a messy white room filled with various tubes and wires. A young male astronaut in a spacesuit sat locked in place directly across from Caitlyn's POV, discussing something with a woman floating above him. It then dawned on Caitlyn exactly what she was seeing.

"Is this… is this the view from Vi's helmet?" She breathed out, stunned and overwhelmed with excitement.

"It is indeed. It's linked to a small camera placed at the top left corner of the dome, courtesy of Powder. The tech's not perfect yet, you'll be beta testing it today, but you should be able to see everything Vi sees out there."

Caitlyn felt a prickle of tears at her waterline. What had she done to deserve the two greatest gifts of her lifetime in one day? "Thank you so much." She beamed a genuine smile up toward Vander. "This is *wonderful*."

"Well, we owe ya one for taking such good care of our girl." Caitlyn wanted to hug him. Truly an amazing father figure. "Anyway we're about to get started. Make sure you're locked in but also, have some fun, aye?"

"Yes, of course. Thank you again, chief."

Vander straightened up, his eyes catching the framed photo on Caitlyn's desk. He nodded to it with a smirk. "That was taken after her graduation from the Naval Academy and landing her first job at NASA. Never been more proud."

With that, the man tapped the top edge of the cubicle wall and walked off, leaving Caitlyn buzzing with warmth.

"Cupcake, you copy?" Vi's voice came alive in her headset once more. It sounded slightly different from inside the space suit, a tiny bit farther away with a little more static, but not unpleasant to hear.

"Yes! Yes I'm here. I copy."

"Woah there, someone's eager. I assume you got FALAC working?"

Caitlyn frowned. "FALAC?"

“That’s what Powder calls it. I think it stands for ‘fuckass little astronaut camera’ or something. That’s not its actual NASA approved name, but it's definitely funnier.”

“Oh.” Caitlyn let out a burst of giggles at the name. She couldn’t help it, she was on cloud nine. “How clever.”

“She’s a brat, but she has her moments.”

Caitlyn hummed, eyeing Powder’s gift. “Yes, she certainly does.”

“Oh yeah? She say something to you? I told her to apologize for using your station without asking.”

Caitlyn shook her head, holding her monitor close. “She was absolutely lovely.”

A pregnant pause. “You sure that was my sister?” Vi snickered, disbelieving.

Caitlyn hummed, electing to keep Powder’s little gift a secret for now. Instead she squinted at the monitor. “Is that Ekko across from you?”

“Sure is. Little man’s first walk today. He’s a bit nervous.”

From the screen Caitlyn could see a disapproving pout to Ekko’s features behind his helmet. Caitlyn couldn’t hear him, but she could make out the words ‘no I’m not’ mouthed from his lips.

“Are *you* nervous?” Caitlyn asked, pulling up her legs to sit criss-cross and balancing the screen on one knee.

“Nah. There’s like… that buzz of anticipation, y’know? And there’s no feeling in the world that compares to when the air lock opens and you’re just- staring into the void, but I’ve done this shit before. I got this.”

Caitlyn thought maybe Vi was showboating a bit, maybe even overcompensating. Despite her astronaut’s words, Caitlyn could sense the slight angst in her tone. She wouldn’t call Vi out for it, but knowing it was there simply encouraged her to ensure Vi was as comfortable as she could be.

“You’re amazing.” Is what she settled on. Flattery was often a decent method of distraction. Besides, she meant it.

It seemed to work a bit. “Careful there, cupcake, or my head’s gonna get too big for my helmet.”

Caitlyn giggled. “Well, we wouldn’t want that now would we?”

“Mm.” Vi hummed in reply, the woman hovering above her and Ekko began tampering with a small monitor of her own. Vi said something to her in Russian and Caitlyn had to suppress the urge to swoon. She had heard Vi speak Russian a few times but god, there was something so strangely satisfying about the way the foreign words sounded in her sultry voice. “We’re

gonna finish up here in a bit. Viktor should have Sky on the broadcast channel but our line will remain closed so it's just gonna be you and me out there."

So, like a space date.

Caitlyn bit her lip, far too pleased at the idea of being alone with Vi amongst the stars. Still, she had to put in some sort of effort to play it cool lest she reveal her silly school girl crush. "I suppose that sounds nice."

"Yeah, I kinda like the idea too." Caitlyn could hear a soft smile in Vi's voice. She almost wished Ekko was the one wearing a camera so that she could see Vi.

"Air lock on one Houston, we are clear to copy." The voice of a woman called out over the broadcast intercom at the front of the comms room. Caitlyn could see from her screen that it was Sky, speaking into a very odd looking mic attached to a long chord on the wall above Ekko's head. Caitlyn thought the mic sort of looked like an electric toothbrush.

"We copy." Viktor spoke into his own headset. He had moved from his cubicle to sit at one of the long arched desks toward the front of the room so that everyone could see and hear. They spoke English rather than Russian, probably out of consideration for all of the American employees in the comms room.

"Hi Viktor!" Sky sounded absolutely giddy. "I'm prepping Ekko and Vi's for depressurization. They're completing the pre-breathing steps." Pre-breathing was a two step process they had to undergo before entering space. The astronauts start out breathing one hundred percent oxygen from a mask to purge any nitrogen from their bodies. Then once they're in their spacesuits, they begin the in-suit light exercise. This involves them raising their arms and legs, bringing up their metabolic rate slightly and expunging any excess nitrogen. Caitlyn could see Vi lifting her arms up from the camera's POV.

"Very good, Sky. Standby."

"Copy!"

Ekko wiggled his eyebrows at Sky and Caitlyn thought she could see a bit of blush on the astronaut's cheeks. So Caitlyn wasn't the only one with a space crush, it seemed.

"How are we looking folks?" Vander returned to the comms room, strolling down the steps from his office with a fresh cup of coffee in his large hand. "Caitlyn, are you clear on comms?"

Caitlyn nodded enthusiastically over the wall of her cubicle. "Yes, sir. Astronaut five one six comms clear and stable."

"Scar? How's our little man sounding?"

"He's clear." Caitlyn glanced at Scar, the other American capsule communicator giving a thumbs up over his cubicle. She hadn't spoken to him much in her time on the team. He was a very tall and stoic man, but seemed relatively friendly.

“Alright, we’ll wait for the pre-breathing to finish up and begin depressurization.” Vander sat himself at the edge of Viktor’s desk, squinting at the projector screen and its multiple graphs. “Everyone get your bets in?”

Caitlyn’s brow furrowed. “Bets?”

“They’re betting on whether or not Ekko will puke in his helmet.” Vi snickered. Ekko rolled his eyes and said something with an annoyed expression. Vi barked a laugh and Caitlyn could hear Scar sigh and say “No, I’m not telling them that. Language, please” from his cubicle.

Sky’s voice echoed through the room once more. “Okay, Houston, we are finished with step eighteen. Purge complete.”

“Copy, purge complete.” Viktor responded, nodding toward Vander.

Sky began fiddling with Ekko’s suit, starting to remove him from his equipment-locked portion of the quest airlock. She then moved over to Vi and the camera shifted as Vi was pushed forward, Sky dipping behind her to complete the maintenance. “Oxygen tanks have been replaced. We’ve got tank number five situated on Ekko and tank number six on Vi.”

“Copy.” Viktor replied. It was fascinating to see the other capcom's in action. They were so focused, so locked in to their tasks. Of course Caitlyn took her job very seriously, but it can be quite difficult when you have a beautiful astronaut in your ear flustering you with crude remarks and flirtatious compliments every chance they get.

As if on cue with Caitlyn’s thoughts, Vi chuckled darkly. “Been a while since I’ve been this strapped up.”

Both Caitlyn and Ekko rolled their eyes, ignoring the remark.

Sky seemed relatively unbothered. “Vi’s going to be our EV1, we’re going to attach the SAFER now.”

Caitlyn’s breath caught. EV’s, or extra vehicular crew members, were situated with a sort of jetpack-like device that utilized compressed nitrogen for movement. They would be responsible for rescue should one of the crew members become detached from the space station. The astronauts would be tethered at all times and it was more of a precaution, but it stirred a bit of anxiety within Caitlyn nonetheless.

“Have you ever needed to use that before?” Caitlyn couldn’t help but ask.

“Nah.” Vi sounded very nonchalant about it. Perhaps Caitlyn was anxious for no reason. “Really it’s just in case of an emergency. There’s no reason the tethers should malfunction and we always stick close to the handrails. Don’t worry about it too much, kay?”

It was incredible how attuned Vi seemed to be to the concerns and fears of those around her. She always made such an effort to ensure everyone else felt reassured and comforted. Caitlyn felt irritated with herself. It was supposed to be her job to calm Vi’s nerves today, not the other way around.

“Vi’s all set. She’s moving into the crewlock portion of the quest airlock now.” Sky called out. Viktor responded in affirmative and Caitlyn watched eagerly as Vi’s camera POV moved through the small doorway opening. “Getting ready to move Ekko in now.”

Once Ekko and Vi were situated, Sky popped in and out of the camera’s view to do some final tweaks and checks. Caitlyn couldn’t see much at this point, just the hatch at the base of the airlock. The anticipation was killing her. Her nerves settled slightly as soon as she could see the tether in Sky’s hands while she clipped it to the front of Vi’s suit. She’d be connected the entire time, nothing to worry about.

Sky disappeared from sight but her voice still came through. “Closing the crew lock portion of the airlock hatch now. We’ll begin depressurization in a moment.”

“Ready to go Cupcake?”

“Yes.” Caitlyn sucked in an eager breath, her knees bouncing with excitement. “I’m here, I’m with you.”

“Yeah…” There was a wistfulness to Vi’s tone. Caitlyn wondered if Vi wished she were actually there.

“Depressurization is just about done, Viktor!” Sky said.

“Alright, Caitlyn.” She looked up to where Viktor addressed her. “It looks like we see a delta P of less than zero point five PSI so you can instruct Vi to open the EV hatch.”

Caitlyn nodded and turned her attention back to Vi’s POV. “Vi, you can open the hatch now.”

“Bout damn time. It’s crowded as hell in here and I’m sick of Ekko’s flat ass in my face.”

Caitlyn let out a soft giggle while Scar sighed. Most likely in response to whatever Ekko’s retort had been.

“Bringing up the outside camera feed now.” Viktor said, typing away at his computer. Caitlyn looked to the projector screen to see a rather blurry image of the outer edge of the space station. Everything was lit in an eerie yellow glow. The camera was most likely set to some sort of night mode, indicating this was the darker side of the station that wasn’t in the sun at the moment. The hatch was still visible as it opened up, Ekko being the first to exit at a careful snail's pace.

“Whoo, oh boy.” Vi let out an anxious laugh and Caitlyn looked back to her screen just in time to see Vi full on *launch* herself out of the airlock.

“My god did you just jump?!”

“Of course I did.” Vi sounded breathless, exhilarated. The screen went blurry while Vi moved, Caitlyn chewing at her bottom lip until her astronaut had landed on the edge of the space station and gripped onto a handrail. She then pushed off and began to maneuver from place to place along the surface. “What, you’ve never wanted to just jump into space?”

“Well, sure, when I was six and didn’t know any better. You nearly gave me a heart attack!”

“Aw, am I making your heart pound, baby?”

Baby.

“You know what? I think I might like to be Ekko’s capcom instead.”

“I’ll take you up on that offer.” Scar grumbled.

“C’mon, don’t be like that.” Vi snickered, climbing her way around the station. “Look, check out the view.”

Caitlyn did just that, focusing intently on the screen as Vi rounded the edge of the space station and the Earth came into view. Caitlyn gasped. It was unlike anything she had ever seen. Far beyond what a photograph could capture. Sure, she was looking at a small monitor, but the movement and the sound of Vi’s breath echoing through her headset made her feel as though she was really *there.*

“I can’t believe you’re seeing this right now. This is incredible.” Caitlyn murmured in awe. Vi hooked her foot into a handrail and pushed herself upright, allowing herself and Caitlyn a more extensive view.

“I love being up here.” Vi said softly, panning slowly to get a full view. “Wish my mother could see me.”

Caitlyn’s heart ached. “She’d be beaming with pride. I know it.”

“Yeah.” There was a smile in Vi’s voice. Caitlyn wished more than anything to see it. “Thanks for being here with me, cupcake.”

Caitlyn wanted to tell Vi she would go further. She’d go beyond the stars and back, to any unknown galaxy if it meant being with Vi. “There’s nowhere else I’d rather be.” Is what she settled on instead.

The two stayed for a moment and simply gazed out at the view. It was difficult for Caitlyn to wrap her mind around the fact that she was down there, hundreds of feet below where Vi was looking down. So close, yet so far.

“We should probably help Ekko with some of those tasks, huh?”

“Yes, I suppose.” Caitlyn pouted. She couldn’t help but feel a bit bummed as Vi moved away from the spectacular view back toward the hatch.

“Don’t worry we’ll have plenty of time to look at it later. What’s up first?”

Caitlyn felt a bit like a child who had their toy taken away, but she had a job to do after all. “First task is to vent the early ammonia system jumper cable. We will be rerouting one to just outside the quest airlock.”

“Copy that, I’m on it.”

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“You’re fucking joking.”

Caitlyn shook her head, sipping at her cherry coke can from the break room vending machine through a straw. “I can assure you I am very much not joking.”

“They think it’s *flat?* What complete bull shit. I can’t even wrap my head around the possibility of that.”

Vi was currently on her third task of replacing a cable for the HAM radio system. The tasks weren’t exactly thrilling, but then again Caitlyn could watch Vi knit a sweater and she’s convinced she’d have the time of her life.

Caitlyn hummed around her straw. “They also believe the moon landing and any space exploration is fake.”

“I’ll punch them in the teeth.”

Caitlyn couldn’t help but laugh. Something about Vi’s, for lack of a better word, *bitchy* tone was quite amusing.

“I haven’t been pissing in a goddamn hose for six months for some fucker to tell me it’s fake.”

“Oh my god *stop.*”

“Haven’t felt the touch of a woman in six months. Eating gross ass astronaut food and having to smell Ekko’s rancid farts-”

Caitlyn laughed so hard cherry coke spilled out of her nose.

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Despite the coke incident, most of the day had gone on without a hitch. The tasks were most definitely tedious. Caitlyn had made the mistake of wondering aloud how Vi’s hands weren’t dead tired. Vi, of course, made a crude comment about the capability of said hands. Caitlyn decided that was a good moment to have Powder take over for a bit so she could stretch out her limbs and splash some cold water on her face to get rid of the raging blush.

The overall excitement from earlier in the day had died down significantly. Everyone was mostly quiet and relaxed as they sat at their monitors observing and recording data. Caitlyn herself was on her third cup of coffee and she began to wonder just how much of the industry was supported entirely by NASA's consumption.

"Is it two and a half turns or ten and a half?" Vi was holding a tool that Caitlyn could only define as a space drill, various wires and other scrapped debris floating around her as she worked. The view of the Earth was behind her at this point in time, but Caitlyn was still mesmerized by the vast array of stars that stretched to infinity.

"It's actually four and a half turns." Caitlyn corrected. She didn't need to check her information sheet for that one.

"You sure about that?" Vi teased.

"Do you think I'm an amateur or something?"

Vi laughed and Caitlyn could practically hear the eye roll. "Throwing my own words back at me, huh? I guess I deserve that."

"Hm yes that's what you said the day we met, I believe."

"Good memory, cupcake."

"I have an eidetic memory, actually." Vi whistled low in response and Caitlyn felt a bit smug. "Helped me through college and probably helped land this job."

"Where did you go to college? I don't think I've ever asked that."

"Oh." Caitlyn fidgeted a bit, she didn't discuss her college days often. "I got my double bachelor's in engineering and mathematics at Stanford, and then my master's at Cambridge."

"Ooo a Cambridge scholar. How fancy."

Caitlyn shrugged. "Well, if you experience college the way I did it's decidedly less fancy than you think."

"What do you mean?"

A bit of anxiety stirred within Caitlyn. She had only ever really opened up to one person about her university experiences before. Vi was trustworthy, and Caitlyn was sure the woman wouldn't judge her, but it made her squirm uncomfortably regardless. "Well when you live a rather… sheltered life. You tend to lash out a bit once you get a taste of freedom."

"Bit of a rebel, were you?" There was no judgement in Vi's voice, mostly just teasing curiosity.

"If you consider partying every other night and an arrest for arson and vandalization being a rebel then, yes. I suppose."

Vi was quiet for a moment. Then, much to Caitlyn's shock, she sounded almost awed. "No shit. Arson? I can't imagine you doing something like that. I gotta hear the details."

Caitlyn glanced over her cubicle to ensure no one was listening. "There was this politician that was channeling non profit funds into his personal vices. Many of which were unethical and illegal. He was also predominantly involved with activities and funding resources that were detrimental to the environment. I found out while digging through my mother's computer and, well, he really didn't need three Mercedes so a couple of friends and I… took care of them."

On her handheld monitor, Caitlyn could see Vi's movements halt. She twiddled her thumbs anxiously while she waited for her astronaut to process her confession.

"Caitlyn. That's the most badass thing I think I've ever heard."

Caitlyn's brows shot up in surprise. "Really? You think so?"

"Fuck yes are you kidding?" Vi resumed her work, seemingly with a new sense of vigor. "I remember you told me about your upbringing and you've always sounded so posh. I never got the impression you were one of those stuck up rich people but damn. I feel like I have a whole new level of respect for you."

"Oh." The admiration was unexpected, but not unwelcome. For the first time when discussing the event, Caitlyn actually felt a strange sense of pride and validation. "Well, um- thank you. I suppose."

"Wait, don't take this the wrong way but how the hell did you get hired at NASA with something like that in your arsenal?"

"Ah." The high was quickly squashed. Replaced by a deep sense of shame. "Well, turns out the reason that information was on my mother's computer is because she was assisting in getting that man uprooted from his position and put away. I could have jeopardized the operation but… my parents have ludicrous amounts of wealth and power. Once he was locked up, they made the charges disappear."

"I see. Kinda lucky then, huh?"

Caitlyn scoffed. "Luck. No I wouldn't call it that. I would call it cowardice on my part."

"Caitlyn-"

"I committed a crime and my privilege and parent's money lended to me getting off without so much as a mark on my record." She squeezed at her upper arms, glaring at the family portrait. "It was irresponsible and reckless. I'm deeply ashamed of it."

The two sat quietly for a minute, Caitlyn stewing in distaste and Vi quietly looking out at the stars as she mulled over Caitlyn's story.

"Listen, Caitlyn. I understand why you feel that way, but I think there is something to be said about the fact that it bothers you so much. You have a deep sense of pride and independence

and that speaks for itself, regardless of your past circumstances." Caitlyn held her breath as Vi spoke, a feeling like that of a rubber band constricting her heart. "You did the wrong thing, sure, but you did it for the right reason. Sometimes your intentions outweigh the magnitude of your actions. I think that applies here."

Caitlyn let out a long exhale. She had gone to therapy, been pulled out of her partying phase kicking and screaming by her best friend, patched things up with her parents, the whole nine yards. Yet only now, years later, had she finally felt that weight lift from her shoulders. She felt light, breathless and overwhelmed with peace in the best way just from a few words from her astronaut.

Vi patiently waited for Caitlyn to come around. Her voice was timid, laced with insecurity once she finally mustered the courage to speak again. "You really think so?"

"Of course I do." God, Vi sounded so considerate, so gentle and encouraging. Caitlyn was convinced the sound of her voice could cause world peace. "You're a good person, Caitlyn."

Caitlyn quickly wiped at her eyes to prevent any tears from forming, breathing in and out slowly to quell the anxiety and heartthrob. "Thank you, Violet. You have no idea how much that means to me."

Vi hummed softly and not for the first time, Caitlyn ached to feel the warmth in Vi's toned arms wrapped around her. "You don't have to thank me, cupcake. Just speaking the truth."

"We should-" She sniffed softly and rubbed her palms on the back of her neck, laughing softly at how absurd she felt wallowing in her emotions. "We should probably get back to work."

"Yeah. Let's get this shit done so I can go home."

It was a joke, and Caitlyn laughed, but she knew they both secretly felt that ache. Both wishing desperately that it were possible.

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"Heya toots."

Caitlyn looked up from where she had been very intently watching Vi install clamps along platform cables. She offered Powder a warm smile and shifted her headphones to the side. "Hi Powder. Did you need to speak with Vi?"

"Nah, just wanted to ask if you'd try something out for me." She held out a small rectangle, about the size of a flash drive but with a headphone jack sticking out of the end.

"What's this?" Caitlyn asked, taking the object and flipping it over in her palm to inspect it.

“Just something I whipped up in the last hour or so.” Powder tapped the side of her head over her ear. “Plug it into the audio jack on your headset. You’ll see.” She practically danced away before Caitlyn could ask any clarifying questions.

“Was that Powder? What did she want?” Vi asked, her voice strained slightly with the effort she was exerting. They were about seven hours into the space walk so it made sense she was getting a little tired by this point. Even if Vi would never admit it.

“She wants me to try out this device she made.”

“Careful, it may explode.”

“What?!”

Vi laughed as she finished up her clamp, grabbing the hand rails to move along to a new position. “Powder used to dabble in explosives a bit. She claimed it was one of the necessary fields of robotics to explore. Nearly took off my damn eyebrows a couple of times.”

“Should I be worried?”

“Nah, I was just messing with you. She hasn’t made anything that volatile in years.” Vi had reached the top edge of the station, hooking her carabiner into one of the rails and pushing off to float in mid air. “What is it, though?”

“I’m not sure. She told me to plug it into my headset.”

“Well, give it a go.”

Caitlyn felt around her headset to find the audio jack, awkwardly maneuvering the device around a bit before managing to plug it in. Nothing happened for a couple seconds. There was a tiny bit of static until a soft voice crackled through with an airy tune in the background.

“Oh.” Caitlyn breathed out, suddenly overwhelmed. “It’s music.”

“Yeah I- I can hear it too.”

“You can? How the heck did Powder manage that?”

Vi laughed softly. “Told you she’s a genius.”

The two quieted down to just revel in the rather romantic song choice. Caitlyn’s heart was in her throat, nerves curling her toes while she sat locked into the sound and the view of the Earth from Vi’s helmet on her screen. The comms room had been quiet and dim with most of the employees having gone off to nap somewhere, leaving this moment between them one of pure intimacy.

Caitlyn watched as Vi swayed slightly among the stars, the horizon of the Earth adding a gentle glow that she could simply lose herself in the ambiance of.

“It’s like we’re dancing.” Caitlyn said softly.

Vi was quiet, thoughtful for a moment as the song continued on.

“I’d dance up here with you.” She murmured softly.

The butterflies were violent inside of Caitlyn, flapping in a frantic beat to the tune of her heart.

“I’d like that.”

Vi stayed there until the song ended, and then a bit thereafter. Her gaze eventually turned to face fully toward the Earth, her breath soft with a gloved hand outstretched towards it.

Caitlyn wondered if her astronaut felt it too. That mutual ache of longing in her heart.

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“Well done folks. Good work today.” Vander sounded entirely too cheerful for just how long everyone had been there.

“You owe me fifty, Mylo!” Powder shouted at her brother as she wheeled past him in a rolling office chair.

“This is so not fair, he always pukes!”

“That’s what you get for doubting my man.”

Caitlyn laughed at the scene in front of her. She wasn’t sure how they had so much energy at nearly two in the morning but it was a bit refreshing to see.

“Settle down there kids.” Vander scolded, turning then to Viktor. “They secured back in the airlock?”

“Yes, sir. EV hatch is closed and locked. I’ve passed duties over to Sky and she’s finishing up the final steps to get them back into the station and out of their suits.”

“Outstanding. You’re off the hook then today, Viktor. Thank you as always for your dedication.” Vander offered Viktor a fist bump to which the man frowned at before tentatively pressing his own knuckles against.

Many of the employees began to file out, including Powder and her brothers. She offered Caitlyn a pleasant wave and a wink as she skipped out, eliciting a bit of shy heat to fill Caitlyn’s cheeks.

“Caitlyn?”

“Yes?” Caitlyn responded into her headset. Vi hadn’t gone offline yet but she would be any second.

“Can you hang around for a bit longer? I want to show you something.”

Caitlyn was dead tired but didn’t hesitate for a moment. “Yes, of course. I’ll wait.”

“Awesome, just give me a bit and I’ll pop back on, okay?”

“Okay.” Vi’s mic cut out with a beep and Caitlyn sighed, slumping back in her chair and taking the time to process everything that had happened that day.

Vi really was incredible. She carried herself with such confidence and fearlessness, truly admirable traits to have. Heck, Caitlyn was worried her astronaut would be a nervous wreck only to see her full on jump into outer space. The two had spoken nearly every day for over two months and yet Caitlyn felt she was seeing even more to Vi every day.

Then there was her impromptu confession, Vi’s reassurance, their dance…

As she sat there waiting for her astronaut to return, she couldn’t shake that familiar feeling of wanting, *yearning* for something more.

“Caitlyn?”

Caitlyn shot up like a bolt, feeling a bit silly toward her own eagerness. She just spent all day with Vi and yet after thirty minutes apart the butterflies had returned at full force. “Yes, I’m here.”

“Look at the monitor.”

She frowned. “Which one?”

“Your handheld one.”

Caitlyn retrieved the small screen from her desk and flipped it back on. Waiting until the familiar space of the airlock came into view. “Okay? I don’t really see anything outside of the airlock.”

“Ah, hold on.” The camera moved, the screen blurring for a moment with the motion before settling into a clear picture. Caitlyn sucked in a shocked breath.

Vi was there, floating in the middle of the frame and squinting into the lens as she adjusted something on the camera. “Can you see me?”

Caitlyn was rendered utterly speechless. Vi had just spent nearly ten hours crammed into a spacesuit and yet she looked breathtaking. Her magenta colored hair had gotten longer over the months, fanning out a bit with the absence of gravity around her. She had stripped out of her thermal gear that astronauts typically wear under their suits and remained in a simple white tank top, arm muscles and a thin sheen of sweat on display. Caitlyn couldn’t think, her

mind and heart running circles around each other in a constant battle of what she should say and feel.

Vi frowned at the camera. “Caitlyn? Is it not working?”

“No! No it’s… it’s working.” She breathed out slowly, wondering how it was possible she could even hear Vi at all over the pounding of her heart. “I can see you.”

A bright smile lit up Vi’s face. Caitlyn had spent the entirety of the day looking at countless stars and the vast view of the Earth, yet they paled in comparison to this sight. “Yeah?”

“Yeah.”

Vi’s smile softened, a more fond sort of gentleness overtaking her sharp features. “Hey, cupcake.”

Caitlyn felt her eyes burn. “Hi.”

“I can’t keep the camera on all the time since it’s attached to the suit, but, I dunno-” She rubbed at the back of her neck awkwardly. “Just wanted you to see me at least once y’know?”

“Yes.” Caitlyn needed to get her shit together and come up with non one word answers but the remainder of her brain cells were already working over time to process the beauty that was Vi. “You- um, you look good.”

“Thanks.” Vi actually fucking smirked but as quickly as it was there, it was gone. Replaced with a genuine look of frustration and something somber. “I’d give anything to see you.”

“Well you will.” Caitlyn wrapped her arms around herself, squeezing tightly. “You know, when you get back… I’ll be here.”

Her astronaut glanced away for a moment, a thoughtful purse to her lips. She seemed to be debating something internally. Caitlyn didn’t want to push but god did she desperately wish to know what Vi was thinking at that moment.

“You promise?” Is what she ended up asking.

“Yes, of course.” Caitlyn wished Vi could see the genuine care in her smile as they spoke. “I’ll wait for you.”

Something in Vi’s expression shifted at that. She looked almost… pained.

“What’s wrong?”

“It’s nothing.” The astronaut took a breath and looked to the camera once more. “I can’t stay, cupcake. I’ll talk to you tomorrow, yeah?”

Caitlyn wasn’t ready to say goodbye. Practically ten hours of work and yet she had no desire to leave, to look away from her astronaut, from Vi.

“Do you really have to go?” The question was quiet, timid. Caitlyn wasn’t even sure Vi would be able to hear it. Hell, it probably would have been better if she didn’t but based on the way Vi’s nose scrunched adorably with frustration, she most definitely had.

“You know I wish I didn’t.”

Caitlyn sighed, dragging her fingertip down the edge of Vi’s features depicted on the screen. “Yes.” She whispered. “I know.”

Vi breathed out, her head tilting slightly. It was almost as if she was leaning into Caitlyn’s touch, but no. That wasn’t possible.

“Goodnight, Caitlyn.”

“Bye, Vi.”

She sat there for a moment after the screen went black, simply staring at the blank monitor. Every other employee had long since cleared out. It was just Caitlyn. Alone in the dark with only the dim light from soft blue fluorescence filling her cubicle. There was something devastating about the dark quiet after Vi had just lit up her entire world. It cleared her mind like a bucket of ice water, making two things abundantly clear to Caitlyn.

The first was the reality of just how far away Vi was from her. The inevitability of the fact that she still had six months up there, so close in Caitlyn’s heart and yet so far out of reach.

The second was that Caitlyn’s feelings extended far beyond just that of a simple crush.

Chapter End Notes

Powder beating the homophobic allegations.

Tune in next time and you better grab a mop because it's gonna get sticky in this bitch.

Comments and kudos much obliged. <3

Buzzkill

Chapter Summary

> "… do you even know if she likes you back?"

Chapter Notes

> I've decided this fic is entirely too wholesome and cute.
>
> Let's change that.
>
> Mind the new tags.
>
> Playlist for this fic here
>
> See ya. <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Time Elapsed: 213 Days
Time Remaining: 152 Days

In the month following the spacewalk, Caitlyn had developed a bit of a routine. She would wake up, feeling excited at the prospect of heading to work, grab a semi-healthy breakfast due to Vi's request that she eat something other than instant meals and junk food, do her pilates, go to work, spend the day speaking with Vi, and spend the rest of the night thinking about Vi.

So yeah, she had a bit of a problem.

Having fully recognized the gravity (pun intended although she would never say it aloud), of her feelings, Caitlyn had felt almost refreshed and invigorated. She had never felt the joys of high school love. That fluttery feeling you get when you pass your crush in the hallway, the thrill of hanging around together after school and just hoping, praying that things may go a little further. She assumed that this feeling was a lot like that. She couldn't see Vi, obviously, but that fine line between them seemed to shrivel more and more each day. She had even begun to really believe that it wasn't just harmless flirting on Vi's part anymore, that she may actually feel the same.

Because Vi's flirtatious antics, well, they had gotten worse. Bolder. She seemed to almost enjoy torturing Caitlyn, in fact. And Caitlyn, ever more hopeful of igniting something more between them, had begun to fire back.

"Houston, do you copy?"

"Yes, I'm here."

"I have a very important question."

"Alright, shoot."

"Caitlyn, how you answer this could jeopardize the success of this expedition."

That caught Caitlyn's attention. She aptly put down her coffee mug and pulled the rolling chair toward her desk, ready to do her best at the given task.

"Okay, I'm ready. What's the question?"

"What are you wearing?"

Yeah, scrap all of that. Caitlyn was going to quit this fucking job.

Vi cackled maniacally at Caitlyn's dignified groan. She slumped back into her seat and kicked away from the desk. "You are absolutely insufferable."

"I do what I can."

"Is your mind ever *not* in the gutter?"

"Hey, you trying being stuck in a metal tube in space for a year without sex or a vibrator."

"You have perfectly functioning fingers don't you?"

Vi paused. Caitlyn sucked in a breath. Shit, that was too much. She knew she shouldn't give in to Vi's goading but the banter came so naturally that she hadn't even thought about it. Months of flirtatious remarks and blasphemous innuendos tend to break down even the toughest of walls. Especially when you're operating on lesbian time and have already fallen deeply. Caitlyn figured she would snap eventually.

What she hadn't anticipated and certainly was not prepared for, was Vi upping her game.

"You'd like to find out, wouldn't you?" Vi's voice was absolutely sinful. It was different from her normally light, teasing tone. She sounded hungry, dangerous, serious.

It's not like Caitlyn hadn't thought about it. Vi made that increasingly difficult with her perversions, but their flirting had mostly been light, humorous. It was never backed by any legitimate sexual tension. But in that instant, Caitlyn could feel it. Like popping the cork off a champagne bottle that's been shaken up after sitting on a shelf untouched.

Caitlyn swallowed past the lump in her throat, trying very hard not to picture the astronaut or her fingers or where she might put them.

“A blazer.”

“Huh?”

“I’m wearing a cream-colored blazer.”

A long, dead silence. Followed by a snort from Vi and a burst of color to Caitlyn’s cheeks. No one was quite as good at ruining a mood as she was.

“Professionalism is sexy I guess.”

Caitlyn scooted her chair back toward the desk and placed her elbows atop the wooden surface, burying her burning face into her palms. She really should shut down this line of thinking. What was it she had said all those months ago? Maintain an air of professionalism? Yeah, that was it. “I am not trying to be sexy. I am at work.” She grumbled.

Vi chuckled darkly. “You don’t ever dress up sexy to work?”

“God, no!”

“Why not?”

“Why would I?”

“To feel good for yourself.” Vi’s words sounded absolutely tantalizing. It was having the intended effect in riling Caitlyn up at a rapid pace.

Her eyes scanned over the cubicle for a moment before she bowed her head and gripped the edges of her headset, attempting to hide away a bit. Her voice was quiet, laced with genuine intrigue and something hot as she spoke. “What do you mean?”

Vi hesitated for a moment. Caitlyn wasn’t sure if she was already working on some tasks for the day but there were no loud clanging sounds in the back like usual, adding to the intensity of Vi’s words. “Sometimes dressing up for yourself can make you feel good. Give you some confidence… even turn you on a little. Knowing everyone is staring at you but can’t have you.”

“I don’t-“ Caitlyn squeezed her thighs together. “I don’t think I’d be comfortable with that.”

“What about something underneath your clothes?”

She was practically chewing at her lower lip at this point, her cheeks flaming and voice a low whisper. “Underneath?”

“Mm.” Vi hummed in affirmative and if Caitlyn really stretched her imagination it could sound like a soft moan. She wouldn’t, though. Not at all. “You know, some sexy underwear or lingerie. Something only you know about, just a fun little secret for yourself.”

“I do…” She hesitated, unsure just how far this conversation would go. Unsure of how far she could push it. “I do have a couple of pairs that are quite sexy.”

“Oh yeah?” Was this what Vi’s voice sounded like when she was turned on? It was so low, deeply laced with something almost predatory. “What do they look like?”

Good god was she really doing this?

“Um, well my favorite is a dark blue thong.” She could hear Vi breathe in and out slowly. “They- um, have thin strings that sit high on my waist and down the back. The front is lace in the shape of a butterfly but there’s a cutout below to leave… that part open.”

“Which part?” Vi breathed out. Caitlyn couldn’t help but let out a little squeak at how sultry and wanton her astronaut sounded. “Say it.”

“Um… my-“

“Yo Caitlyn!”

Caitlyn shot up from her desk like she had been struck by lightning, standing all the way up with her arms firmly at her sides and knocking over her cat figurine that looked like Chowder. “Yes! Sorry! Yes?”

Mylo gave her a quizzical look from over at his desk where he had called out to Caitlyn from. “Uh, you okay?”

“Yes. I’m good. What um-“ She cleared her throat and schooled her expression as best she could, though unable to fix the inevitable reddening of her cheeks. “What did you need, Mylo?”

“Can you and Vi come up with a list of what supplies they need on the next transport and send it over to me by tomorrow? They got a shipment coming in a few days so I want to make sure I have everything.”

“Of course, yes. We will have that to you by the end of the day.”

“Thanks Caitlyn! You rock.”

Caitlyn forced a smile and gave a half hearted thumbs up before slowly sinking back down into her chair. She stared blankly at her computer monitor for a moment, heartbeat roaring in her ears from the sudden adrenaline. Vi wasn’t saying anything either. They were both quiet, the reality of what they had been doing crashing down like a tidal wave.

“Um… so-“

“I’m gonna go workout.”

“Oh.” Caitlyn was a bit taken aback. Vi sounded rushed, eager and maybe even a little anxious. It was definitely unusual for the normally quite composed astronaut. Caitlyn’s brows furrowed in confused concern. “Didn’t you already do your workout this morning?”

“Yeah, well.” There was a shuffling, a clang and a curse under Vi’s breath on the other line. “I didn’t really get to finish so- I just have a bit more. I’ll be back on later. See ya.”

“Okay I’ll talk to you-” The beep of Vi going offline interrupted Caitlyn’s goodbye. She frowned at her monitor. It wasn’t like Vi to just… leave like that. Their goodbyes were always long, drawn out. Neither wanting to let go of the other. Yet she just signed off like that. Gone in a blink.

“Okay then.” Caitlyn murmured, sliding her headset off in favor of a trip to the washroom. She moved in a sort of trance, completely lost in the sudden drop of adrenaline and confusion toward Vi’s rapid departure. It was only after a faceful of cold water and good long stare at her flushed expression in the bathroom mirror that it dawned on her what exactly had just happened.

“Oh my god.” She whispered with pure mortification to her reflection. What would have happened if Mylo hadn’t interrupted? Where would that conversation have gone? In the middle of a workday nonetheless. But the bigger question was, why did Vi practically run away when she was the one instigating most of their charged encounters all this time?

Caitlyn was flustered beyond repair. Whatever happened was most likely just a spur of the moment thing after months of build up. They both just got- what was it Jayce liked to say? “Lost in the sauce.” Caught up in the moment, so to speak.

She was definitely embarrassed and mildly horrified, but also maybe a little hopeful. Vi had egged her on just as much, they were both guilty. So Vi had to reciprocate Caitlyn’s feelings even a little bit, didn’t she? That was the logical conclusion to make.

Never in her life had Caitlyn spoken so scandalously in a place of work. She knew it was irresponsible, but those schoolgirl jitters buzzed around under her skin and with them came a giddiness she couldn’t force down despite her efforts. It was possible Vi was just simply flustered by their encounter. There were a myriad of reasons she could have reacted the way she did. Caitlyn could dwell on them but the reality was, she just didn’t care at the moment.

Because that precarious line between the two of them was nearly invisible at this point. One move away from snapping altogether.

And yeah, Caitlyn wanted that. Craved it, even. Not just in her heart, but now between her legs as well.

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Time Elapsed: 217 Days
Time Remaining: 148 Days

“A date?” Caitlyn frowned at the inside of her fridge, lamenting the lack of ingredients. She would need to go grocery shopping again. Caitlyn hated grocery shopping.

“Yeah, a date.” Jayce said from the other end of the phone pressed up to Caitlyn’s ear. “One of my employee’s just transferred to the Houston branch. She’s cute, I think you’d have fun together.”

Caitlyn grabbed the nearly empty carton of milk, now bracing the phone between her shoulder and ear to unscrew the cap for a sniff test. A few days past expiration, but seemed fine. Boxed mac and cheese for dinner it was. “I don’t know, Jayce. I’m not… really interested in dating at the moment.”

There was a beat of silence. Jayce rarely had nothing to say which could only mean he wasn’t fully convinced of Caitlyn’s reluctance. “Didn’t you just get done telling me how horny you’ve been lately?”

Caitlyn made a distasteful expression as she fished out a small pot and retrieved the box of noodles from her cupboard. She hadn’t used those exact words, but that was essentially the previous path of their conversation. “Well, sure. But I’ll have you know there is a big difference between feeling… riled up and wanting to go out on a date.”

“But if the date goes well, you may have your problem solved at the end of the night, yes?”

“Are you actually suggesting I have a one-night stand?”

“Heck, why not? You’ve been locked up in that comm center for what, three months? You deserve to have some fun.”

Caitlyn groaned as she filled the pot with water, setting it on the crappy stove and letting it spark endlessly until the flame finally lit. “I suddenly don’t want to have this conversation anymore.”

“Mhm. Right. And this has absolutely nothing to do with that astronaut of yours?”

She paused, having poured only half the box of macaroni into the pot. “What are you on about?”

“Seriously, Caitlyn? You’ve been talking about her non-stop for weeks.”

“That is not true.” Caitlyn grumpily tossed the rest of the pasta in, making an annoyed face as the cheese powder packet also fell into the pot. She had forgotten to take that part out of the box first. Oops. “I talked to you about pilates earlier.”

“Yeah, and you followed it up with ‘you should see Vi’s physique, though. She’s so strong and toned. I want to lick her muscles.’”

“I did *not* say that!”

“You may as well have!”

Caitlyn rolled her eyes whilst fishing out a ladle from the utensil holder to retrieve her drowned cheese packet. “I swear you are just as insufferable as-”

“Hm? As who, Caitlyn? Go on.”

Shit.

“I hope you crash your Porsche. But not like, aggressively. Just an annoying fender bender. That you have to pay for. No insurance.”

“Wow. How dastardly of you. How would I ever recover from something so devastating?”

Caitlyn sighed in defeat, leaning back against the counter and staring blankly at her stained tea towels decorated with architecture from England hanging over the handle of her dishwasher. “Okay, so maybe she has something to do with it. Would that be so wrong?”

“Well, no but… do you even know if she likes you back?” There was nothing but consideration and concern in Jayce’s voice. The two may bicker like siblings but the man was also extraordinarily compassionate when it came to Caitlyn as well. She knew Jayce would always be encouraging of her endeavors while also grounding her in reality. Something Caitlyn didn’t care to admit she often needed.

She sighed and closed her eyes, going over everything in her mind that her and Vi had experienced up until this point. There were the flirtatious remarks, yes, but Vi did say herself on day one it was meant to be harmless. Then there was the space walk, an undeniable step forward for them that still set Caitlyn alight with emotion. She was so sure something had shifted after that, and their impromptu sexy dialogue from the other day had almost confirmed that. She had felt so hopeful that day, but the more she thought about it, the more she just couldn’t put all of the pieces together.

“I… I think so. I don’t know. There have been moments where I thought she could but then…” Caitlyn recalled Vi’s expression after she said she’d wait, the pain and reluctance in her gaze. She remembered the other day when Vi had practically run for the hills once things got too heated. She had brushed it off at the time but now it instilled that sense of doubt in her, a hesitancy in confirming Vi’s mutual feelings.

Jayce waited for a moment, allowing Caitlyn time to finish her thought. When she didn’t and the two had been in contemplative silence for far too long, he finally broke the tension. “Caitlyn, if you’re this unsure then you can’t just sit around and wait, y’know? You need to either confirm what the two of you have, or move on. You know, shit or get off the pot.”

Caitlyn made a face. “What a distasteful expression.”

“Still applies. What do you think?”

Chowder sauntered into the kitchen and began to rub at Caitlyn’s silk pajama clad shins. She smiled down at him, happy to have some comfort for this difficult conversation.

“Let me… let me think about it a bit, okay?”

“Sure, sprout. Whatever you need.”

Despite the subject matter, Caitlyn did feel a little better having talked to someone. She was happy to be able to rely on Jayce. He was definitely right about one thing, she had been locked in that comm center without many outside work experiences. It was nice to still have a friend to bring you back down to Earth.

“Oh, I’ll be doing some business around different parts of the country over the next few weeks. Maybe I could drop by Houston?” It’s like he read Caitlyn’s mind. Truly an intuitive older brother.

“Yes, please. I miss you desperately.”

He laughed and Caitlyn ached to give him a hug. Jayce became Caitlyn’s best friend during their college years and since then their visits had been sporadic, but they never grew apart in the ways that mattered. “I miss you too. I’ll let you know when I’m near your neck of the woods but don’t hesitate to call if you need anything, okay?”

Caitlyn smiled to herself, feeling worlds better already. “Yes, alright. Thank you, Jayce.”

“See ya sprout.”

Caitlyn stood there staring down at where Chowder had laid out against the tops of her feet once the call dropped. She felt better, sure, but there was still a pang of nerves and anxiety fluttering around in her gut. Jayce was right, she had drawn out this game with Vi long enough. It was beginning to weigh her down, affect how she moved and operated throughout the day. Infatuation was one thing, obsession and uncertainty another.

Only when a sizzle of water splashing against the stove sounded was Caitlyn pulled from her musing. She turned with a frown to where her forgotten dinner had boiled over and cursed as she flipped off the gas. The pasta was most definitely over cooked by now. It was almost like some sort of fucked up metaphor.

So yeah, Caitlyn would need to turn off the gas and figure things out with Vi. Before everything overflowed and left her in ruin.

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Time Elapsed: 218 Days
Time Remaining: 147 Days

“Fuck, I hate this shit.”

Caitlyn couldn't help but giggle at the mental image of Vi elbow deep in a mixture of cement made with rock fragments from the surface of the moon. It sounded cool in principle, but in practice it was really just thick space goo that Vi was rather vocal about disliking. "Yes it sounds particularly messy."

"Are we almost done? I want to get my damn hands out of here."

Caitlyn hummed and squinted at the steps of the experiment pulled up on her computer screen. "It seems you have a few more minutes of molding, then we'll place the mixture into a few different thermos' to see how it solidifies without the effects of gravity."

"Great." Vi groaned. Caitlyn could practically hear the eye roll. "Looks like I'm stuck for a bit then."

"What ever will you do?"

"Well I'm sure you can find some way to entertain me."

The comment was relatively innocent, but given what the two had nearly "entertained" a few days prior, it brought an inevitable heat to Caitlyn's cheeks. "How do you propose I do that?"

"Hm, I dunno. What did you do after work yesterday?"

Oh. Caitlyn fidgeted, mulling over the conversation with Jayce in her mind. "Well I burnt some instant mac n' cheese."

Vi paused for a moment before bursting into a fit of laughter. "My god you are hopeless in the kitchen. How the hell did you burn instant mac n' cheese?"

"Well in my defense." Caitlyn crossed her arms, pouting like a child. "I was on the phone with Jayce at the time so I was a bit distracted."

"Oh c'mon. You would have found a way to burn it regardless and you know it." Vi snickered. Caitlyn rolled her eyes, though she knew deep down Vi was right. She had been rather open about her distinct lack of skills in the kitchen and tendency to snack on more unfavorable treats in terms of nutritional value. Another product of her sheltered upbringing. Forcing a child to eat cucumber sandwiches and crudites will inevitably lead to binging on cookies and nacho cheese flavored chips once they're old enough to choose for themselves. Having every meal prepared by a world renowned chef was a path to, well, burnt instant mac n' cheese.

"So how is pretty boy doing?" To Caitlyn's surprise, Vi was actually familiar with Jayce and his industry. Turns out Mylo is a bit of a fan boy. Caitlyn made a mental note to grab an autograph at some point.

"He's… good." This could be the opportunity Caitlyn was waiting for, a chance to bring up what her and Jayce had discussed. She bit her lip and breathed in deep, planning her mode of execution. Perhaps a less direct route, something that may push Vi to reveal her own feelings.

Caitlyn forced a laugh, a poor attempt at nonchalance. “Although, he tried to set me up on a date for this weekend so there’s that.”

“Yeah? That sounds fun.”

Oh.

Caitlyn’s heart leapt into her throat, stealing the very breath from her lungs and the words from her mouth.

That was not what she expected to hear. Not what she wanted to hear.

“You… you think I should go?” Caitlyn fidgeted, staring down at her lap and attempting to keep her voice steady. “I wasn’t sure if I should agree to it...”

“Why not? You’ve pretty much done nothing but work the last three months. You deserve to go out and have some fun.”

Caitlyn’s heart then sank like a stone. She found herself frozen to the spot. A deep cut of rejection slicing through her like a knife.

She had gotten this all wrong. Vi wasn’t ever interested in her. She was just work to Vi. A fun distraction. Harmless flirting. That’s all this was.

The reality was painful. Caitlyn wasn’t sure what she was expecting, but it certainly wasn’t this. How could she have been so foolish? She had only ever actually seen Vi’s face while they spoke once and now that she thought about it, that pained expression her astronaut had made that night must have been some level of uncomfortability.

Because she didn’t want Caitlyn. That was clear now.

“I guess…” Caitlyn’s voice was timid, still even a little hopeful that Vi would change her mind. Tell her not to go. Anything. “Maybe I will go then.”

“That’s the spirit.” No. That was worse. So much worse. Vi sounded chipper, encouraging, even. Caitlyn wanted to crawl under her desk and wither away. “So, we done here?”

Caitlyn blinked. “What?”

“The cement. Are we done with it?”

“Oh.” The cement. Right. That’s what she meant. “Yes, you can stop mixing it now. Break off a few pieces and put it into the thermos’. Then you can pull your hands out of the stationary gloves.”

“Thank god. I never want to touch this shit again.” Caitlyn was overthinking now. Looking for double meanings in everything Vi said. She knew Vi wasn’t talking about her, she really did, but that didn’t mean it didn’t hurt. “What else we got today?”

“Um. Nothing. That was it.”

“Oh, well alright then.” Caitlyn could hear the rustling of Vi finishing up the experiment, the static of her mic crackling slightly as she moved out of the lab to somewhere else on the station. “I guess we can call it a day then.”

“Yes.” Caitlyn breathed out. She wanted to say more, she just couldn’t. Lest her emotions come spilling out of her.

Vi was quiet for a moment. Caitlyn cursed internally. She was being too obvious. Vi wasn’t stupid. In fact, she was incredibly intuitive and perceptive. If Caitlyn kept this up then she would most definitely be found out.

“I’ll talk to you on Monday, then?” Caitlyn forced out, her fingers gripping the edge of her desk to ground herself.

“Yeah.” Vi’s voice was soft, like she knew something was bothering Caitlyn but didn’t want to push. Caitlyn was grateful for it. She didn’t want to talk. She wanted to run. “Talk to you Monday. Goodnight, cupcake.”

“Bye, Vi.”

Caitlyn never liked the sound of that beep whenever Vi ended communication but today it was particularly painful. Grating in her ears like nails on a chalkboard. She ripped her headset off and pulled her knees up, hugging them tightly and burying her watery eyes there.

She felt so miserable. So stupid and hopeless.

It was her own fault, really. For falling so incredibly hard. For misreading the tone of Vi’s voice, the timbre of her laugh. Misreading probably everything. Maybe it wasn’t fair for her to simply expect Vi to reciprocate those feelings, but, fuck did she really not want Caitlyn at all? Even a little?

No, their talk the other day definitely meant something. Caitlyn was naive when it came to dating, but she wasn’t totally incompetent. Maybe Vi didn’t feel entirely the same, but there was still a spark there. She refused to believe that there wasn’t.

She glanced at the framed photo of Vi sitting on her desk, wondering if she had ever made Vi make that face. If she had ever brought her astronaut that level of joy. It was eating her up inside, a devastating wave of confusion and heartbreak swirling around. Her butterflies felt dead. Heavy in her gut now.

It was unclear how long she sat there, mulling over the perplexities of her relationship with the astronaut while staring at her photo. At one point, Caitlyn simply couldn’t take it any longer, her feet dragging like lead as she made her way out of the comm center.

Once outside, she found herself as she did many times staring up at the sky. There were no stars out tonight. It felt painfully poetic and apt for her current situation.

With a bitter taste in her mouth, Caitlyn sighed and pulled out her phone. Feeling defeated and torn as she punched in Jayce’s number.

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Time Elapsed: 219 Days
Time Remaining: 147 Days

Caitlyn swung her door open with a disapproving scowl, kicking off her heels dramatically and leaning against the wood as it shut. She stood there for a moment, posture “unbecoming of a lady” as her mother would put it, with the taste of Chardonnay still on her tongue. Caitlyn hated Chardonnay.

The date was… fine.

Caitlyn didn’t like it.

The woman was pleasant. She was pretty and friendly enough and had a nice smile, but she was all wrong. Caitlyn felt so guilty, her mind would travel elsewhere whenever her date would talk about herself, her job, her interests. She hadn’t meant to disassociate but she just couldn’t focus. Things got even worse when she was asked about her work at NASA. Caitlyn had attempted, and failed, all evening not to think of her astronaut but with talk of work came the inevitable truth that Caitlyn had to admit to herself, thus souring the rest of her evening.

The woman was all wrong because she wasn’t what Caitlyn wanted. She wasn’t Vi.

Vi had rejected her and even in her pathetic attempt at moving on, she just couldn’t shake those feelings away.

The date had ended on a decent note. Caitlyn must have done something right because she was invited over to continue the rest of their evening at the woman’s flat, but she just couldn’t. Everything felt off, like when you accidentally wear clothing inside out and it bothers you until you fix it. So Caitlyn had politely declined and now here she was, with aching feet and a growing migraine.

With an agitated groan, Caitlyn pushed herself off the door and padded into the kitchen. She may as well pour herself a glass of wine she actually likes to make up for her shit evening. Chowder followed her into the kitchen and she gave him a scoop of dry cat food before fixing her own drink.

“Jayce, you owe me a bottle of wine.” She grumbled, swirling her much preferred glass of merlot before taking a swig. Jayce hadn’t done anything wrong, he was only trying to help. Yet Caitlyn felt a stubborn sort of irritation toward the entire situation. Maybe because he called her on her bullshit, able to recognize from a mile away that Caitlyn had feelings for Vi. That it was preventing her from getting out there. She hated that he was right.

But she did try. It failed, but now she knew for sure it would take a lot more than a simple date to move on from her feelings.

The wine began to warm Caitlyn a bit from within, creating a comforting fog over her rampant emotions. Instead Caitlyn felt a new kind of burn, one she was supposed to be quelling at a beautiful woman's apartment tonight but had passed on because of that gorgeous damn astronaut that held her heart captive two hundred and fifty miles above the Earth.

"Fuck it." Caitlyn grumbled. She could take care of this issue by herself. She owed it to herself even. Self care by means of a well deserved orgasm. Fuck her stupid feels. She wanted to see stars.

She refilled her wine and clumsily made her way to the bedroom, slipping off the silk black dress and stockings she had chosen for her night out. She stood for a minute and considered the mood she wanted to set for herself. Maybe a nice pair of panties would be good?

"Sometimes dressing up for yourself can make you feel good."

She pulled open the top drawer of her dresser and pursed her lips in contemplation. Caitlyn's fingers skimmed over the lacey blue butterfly g-string she had told Vi about. It would be a lie to say she wasn't tempted but-

"No. Absolutely not." She wouldn't be thinking about Vi tonight. That wasn't the point. This was for her to relieve her pent up energy, not to get off thinking about Vi.

Electing that any sort of lingerie was off the table, Caitlyn simply settled for a cropped grey sleep tank top and the underwear she had been wearing on her date. A simple pair of light pink cotton. Who was she fooling with those, really? If she had any intention of getting laid that night then she would have elected for a much sexier pair. The choice was obviously a reflection of her reluctance.

Caitlyn lit up a couple of candles to set the mood for herself, taking a deep swig of her wine before setting the glass down and flopping unceremoniously onto the silk bed sheets. She laid there for a moment taking in the ambiance of the room, breathing deeply in and out a few times in an effort to clear her head.

Finally feeling relaxed, Caitlyn reached over to the nightstand to retrieve her vibrator. Nothing too fancy, just one of those soft purple clit stimulators in a teardrop shape. It had gotten her through many a rather lonely evening and would do the job just fine. She didn't necessarily want to use her fingers, unwilling to risk the fleeting thoughts of where, or who, her mind may go to while feeling a human touch.

The soft hum once she clicked the device on did wonders for a distraction. Caitlyn didn't necessarily need to fantasize or picture anything, just the stimulation and relaxation alone could get her there. She started on the lowest setting, spreading her legs slightly and dragging the curved end of the vibrator over the front of her underwear. This was something Caitlyn always started with, it created the illusion of foreplay in her mind, making it easy to feel as though someone could be teasing her, feeling her up before eventually slipping beneath the material.

Eyes closed and head tilted back against the soft plush of her pillows, Caitlyn allowed herself to become lost in the feeling. Her hips slowly ground up to create friction against the device. The sound of her own breathy moans only served to heighten her arousal. She loved making sounds, loved how absolutely wrecked she could make herself feel. It was euphoric.

After a short while of teasing over the fabric, the cotton now absolutely soaked, Caitlyn slipped out of her underwear and tossed them elsewhere. She bit her lip, feeling shy for some reason at the prospect of opening herself up bare and wide in this empty room. It wasn't an unwelcome feeling. Caitlyn almost liked feeling embarrassed, being teased, observed as she was spread open.

A soft moan slipped past her lips once she forced her thighs to part. She couldn't help but look down, noticing a few strings of slick on the inside of her thighs from where they rubbed together. It looked absolutely sinful. If only someone were there to taste-

Caitlyn quickly shook the thought from her mind and brought the vibrator back toward her now unclothed clit, rubbing up and down slowly at first before dragging the soft buzzing silicone in circles.

"Oh my god." She whispered, head falling back once more as she began to lose herself in the blinding pleasure. It was such a pleasant and calming experience and just felt so damn good. Practically melting into the sheets, Caitlyn was now steadily grinding her hips up. That familiar spark of her climax began to build. It climbed higher and higher, her thighs and abdomen clenching while she got so close to her finish and then-

her vibrator died.

"What? No!" She sat up on her elbows and held up the toy, frantically clicking at the buttons to no avail. "Piece of shit." She groaned, tossing the device aside and falling back with a huff.

This wasn't fucking fair. She was so damn close. Of course it was her luck that her toy had given up on her. If anything it was her fault for never charging the damn thing, but that just added to the frustration.

Caitlyn was still absolutely soaked, her breath still ragged and the embers of arousal flickering around in her gut, begging to be lit anew. This was ridiculous. She was a goddamn lesbian. If anyone knew how to use their fingers to orgasm, it was her.

Her words to Vi from the previous week rang in her mind. *"You have perfectly functioning fingers, don't you?"*

Yeah, she could use her fingers. It wasn't the plan but when she was this close and had already successfully built herself up on a clear mind, it should be easy to finish herself off. She could resist thinking about someone else. Easily.

Caitlyn breathed out slowly with a newfound determination and slid her right hand down and down, finding the soaked folds between her legs and dipping her fingertips in experimentally. She groaned at the feeling, sliding the two fingers between her heat without pressing inside or

clamping down on her clit. She would work up to that. For now she just wanted to feel. Feel how wet and spread open she was. How *ruined* she was.

A single finger slowly slipped inside and Caitlyn's breath caught. It had been so long since she used her own fingers on herself. She had forgotten just how delectable the feeling could be. She twisted the single digit in and out, building up a rhythm and finding her way back to that precious bliss. Yeah, she could come on her fingers. She didn't need a vibrator. Vi would probably like that better anyway. She'd probably say something about how no toy could make Caitlyn feel as good as her fingers could-

Caitlyn froze, her eyes snapping open. Shit, this was exactly what she wanted to avoid. Vi had rejected her, made it clear that she wanted Caitlyn to go out with someone else. Caitlyn shouldn't be imagining her in this way. She promised herself she wouldn't.

But now that the seed had been implanted, the intrusive thoughts flowed like a river having broken through a dam.

Caitlyn moaned out loud at the thought of Vi between her legs, her core clenching involuntarily. Vi was probably just so damn good with her fingers. She would probably start just as Caitlyn had, with just one. She'd twist and pull all while watching Caitlyn from down there, reveling in the sound of Caitlyn's sounds and the way her back arched off the sheets. Vi would be so teasing, such a hungry look in her eyes but unwavering until Caitlyn begged her for more.

"Please…please Vi-" She whispered into the empty air of her bedroom, adding a second finger along the first and increasing their pace as a sort of reward to herself for being good. Being so good for Vi.

"Yes…" She whined high and needy, not even registering that her other hand seemingly moved on its own to dip under her tank top and grasp her left breast. She squeezed around the entirety of it before twisting the peak of her nipple between her fingers, teeth now sinking into her bottom lip hard in an effort to quiet her mewling sounds of pleasure. Her hand wasn't rough enough, too smooth without calluses to graze against the hardening nubs on her chest. Vi's hands would be perfect. So rough but also so gentle…

The sparks had returned, shooting up her spine at a borderline frightening pace. Caitlyn's fingers picked up the pace, her palm now rubbing against her clit and hips grinding down in frantic and uncoordinated thrusts. She was so close, so so close.

She could practically see Vi's smirk in her mind, that knowing look in her eyes that she had done this to Caitlyn. That she had absolutely ruined her. Caitlyn could see it all so clearly. The way Vi's arm muscles would flex as she fucked her fingers in and out of Caitlyn's drenched pussy, that tantalizing smolder in her powder blue eyes as she watched Caitlyn fall apart. The shape of her lips as she would finally close that distance to Caitlyn's clit and flick at it slowly with the tip of her tongue before covering her completely and sucking-

Caitlyn came with a desperate cry of Violet's name on her lips. Her orgasm shot through her like a storm, all consuming and static and wet. Her muscles clenched and body shook with it, leaving her absolutely limp and breathless.

She remained there for a good minute, gently stroking against her clit while she slowly came down from the high. It was only then after slipping her fingers out and staring at the candle glow flickering on her ceiling that reality came smacking into her like a freight train.

“Shit… shit. No no no-“ She covered her eyes with her forearms, shame building hot tears behind her eyes. She had done exactly the thing she intended to avoid. Vi absolutely consumed her thoughts at the worst possible time, and now she had finally crossed that boundary she’d laid out for herself.

It wasn’t right. She knew it wasn’t. Not after Vi had drawn a clear line in the sand.

Caitlyn couldn’t help but cry softly as she lay there half naked. The drop in dopamine and the feeling of rejection was simply too much. Too all consuming in the way Vi had been to her very existence. This evening was supposed to be for her. To help her cope, move on and find that ecstasy she craved.

Instead she was left with a wine hangover, a dead vibrator, some mild heartbreak and a bad case of carpal tunnel.

Chapter End Notes

Alright, lemme have it.

I'm sorry gays. This chapter was probably not enjoyable but I need you to trust me that the build up of angst is necessary and will pay off.

Comments and kudos much obliged <3

Alarm Bells

Chapter Summary

> “Who said I wasn’t interested in you?”

Chapter Notes

> Heya (ᵔ ¬ᴗ¬ᵔ)
>
> I've had the last scene of this chapter written basically since I started this fic (although it has been tweaked as the story progressed) so I'm very excited to finally share it with you. Hope you enjoy!
>
> Playlist for this fic here.
>
> See ya. <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Time Elapsed: 221 Days
Time Remaining: 144 Days

“Okay, what’s next?”

“Hm? Oh.” There was a big pink splotch forming on Caitlyn’s cheek from where she had it propped up on the palm of her hand, nearly falling asleep against her desk. “Turn the gasket bolt clockwise three times.”

There was a pause. Then a soft chuckle. “Caitlyn I did that like three steps ago.”

Shoot. “Right, I’m so sorry hold on. Let me check again…” She scanned through the maintenance document, reading it over three times and still not finding which goddamn step they were on. “Let’s see, um, right…”

“Hey, are you okay?”

Caitlyn bit her lip hard. The genuine concern in Vi’s voice should have been reassuring, but it was just frustrating. All she wanted was Vi’s comfort, yet it didn’t feel earned.

“Yes, I’m fine. I just didn’t get much sleep over the weekend.”

“Oh…”

Vi was really quiet for a moment, no longer emitting noise from her task or tinkering with anything in the background. Caitlyn frowned, unsure of why this information could warrant such an empty response.

Then it hit her. Vi knew about the date. She probably thought Caitlyn’s lack of sleep was because of-

“Oh my god, no! Not because of that!”

Vi chuckled humorlessly. The sound was awkward, maybe even a bit relieved if Caitlyn was hearing correctly. She probably wasn’t. There was a soft scratching noise, which Caitlyn knew meant that Vi was running her fingers through the shaved side of her head. “Well I know you had a date so, y’know that was the only logical conclusion.”

Caitlyn’s eyes rolled. “Maybe if sex is the *only* thing on your mind.”

There was a stretch of silence, which was very unlike Vi. This was the normal routine for them. Caitlyn would say something relatively innocent, Vi would spin it into debauchery, Caitlyn would retort with a level of calculated sass, they’d laugh, rinse and repeat.

Only Vi wasn’t laughing this time.

“So, it went okay then?”

Caitlyn blinked, unable to follow their wayward conversation today. It was all over the place, almost like neither of them had their heads on straight. “What?”

“The date.” Vi breathed in deeply, she still hadn’t resumed her work. “It went okay?”

Caitlyn’s brow furrowed. This was most definitely a different tone from the rather enthusiastic encouragement Vi had offered a few days prior. “It was… fine. I don’t think I’ll be going on a second one.”

“Oh. Well, I’m sorry to hear that.” Vi sounded genuine. But there was something about this conversation that just didn’t sit right. It sparked a newfound sense of irrational irritation in Caitlyn.

“Yes. I’m sure you are.”

There was a pause. Caitlyn sucked in a breath. She hadn’t meant to lash out, that wasn’t what she wanted but, fuck, she couldn’t help it. Vi was running her in circles and never before had she been so frustrated to not be able to see her astronaut's expression. To dissect what she could be thinking.

“What’s that supposed to mean?” Vi didn’t sound angry, more so cautious. Like she was treading dangerous ground.

“It’s nothing.” Caitlyn squeezed at her upper arms, caging herself in and curling up slightly. “I’m sorry. I didn’t mean to snap at you, it's just… it’s nothing.”

“It doesn’t sound like nothing.” Vi sounded tentative, considerate even. God, why was that riling Caitlyn up even more. “You can talk to me about it, you know.”

“Well I don’t want to. So can we just drop it? Please.” Shit, she’ll regret this later. She knew she would but what else could Caitlyn say?

I never wanted to go on that date. I thought we had something. I came thinking about you after you rejected me and the guilt is eating me alive.

Why don’t you want me? Why are you acting so strange? Please stop confusing me…

“Yeah… whatever you want, cupcake.” There was an intrinsic sadness in Vi’s voice, but also a deep amount of understanding and consideration.

Forget later. Caitlyn felt bad about it now.

“Vi-”

“We really gotta get this finished. We’re on step seventeen decimal three.”

Caitlyn squeezed her eyes shut, guilt and shame churning uncomfortably in her gut. It wasn’t fair for her to unleash her pent up exasperation on Vi when the astronaut hadn’t really done anything wrong. Vi wouldn’t ever call her on it, Caitlyn knew she wouldn’t but that simply made her feel worse.

It wasn’t necessarily the rejection itself that was tearing Caitlyn apart, though it would be a lie to say that wasn’t one of the contributing factors. There were many emotions at play but at the very forefront of it all was just… confusion. The not knowing of just what it was she did mean to Vi. There was care and attraction, that was certain but despite Vi’s enthusiasm a few days prior she now seemed distant and withdrawn.

Why?

Caitlyn couldn’t dwell on it now. She steadied herself with a deep inhale through her nostrils and resigned herself to the only thing she could do for now.

“Right, seventeen decimal three.”

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Time Elapsed: 225 Days
Time Remaining: 140 Days

After what Caitlyn could only call their first “argument,” things had been relatively normal with Vi. Not completely, but relatively.

Their banter continued as usual, their conversations just as heartfelt as they had once been, but Caitlyn could feel an unpleasant itch beneath her skin. An anxiety swimming beneath the surface. It’s as if there was a wall built up where that fine line had once been. Not big enough to cut them off from one another, but she feared one wrong brick placement could build it back up tenfold.

She had been looking for the right opportunity to apologize, an opening in their conversation in which such sentiment would be appropriate but none had arisen. Caitlyn was becoming antsy the longer things went on. She could feel something was coming, an inevitable build up like the shaking of a soda can. The question now was, which one of them would pop first?

Caitlyn had been reading Vi a list of tasks to maintain the environmental control systems aboard when Powder stopped by. She offered Caitlyn a mint chocolate chip shake with a cheeky smile and Caitlyn had gratefully accepted before giving the sisters some time to themselves. She took her shake to the breakroom, not wanting to eavesdrop but a little hopeful that maybe Powder could help Vi to open up.

After about an hour, having fully devoured her shake and making a mental note to ask Powder where it was from so she could grab another some time, Caitlyn made her way back to her cubicle. Her fingers were twitching with nerves. Powder had definitely made moves to push Caitlyn and Vi closer before, she could only hope Vi’s sister had something else up her sleeve that could help the two absolutely useless lesbians.

“Mhm, yeah. Tell Ekko I’ll be on with him later for our game night. Love ya sis!” Powder turned off the headset and pulled it off, smiling up at Caitlyn before blowing a bubble with her gum. “Thanks, Caitlyn. I appreciate you letting me chat with her.”

“Oh it’s no problem. Did you have a nice talk?”

“Yeah! It was good…” Powder bit her lip, eyes drifting to the top of Caitlyn’s desk for a moment.

Caitlyn tilted her head. “Something wrong?”

“No no just…” Powder pulled up her knees and crossed her arms over them, offering Caitlyn an apologetic smile. “Listen, my sister is smart. Like, crazy intelligent. She doesn’t showboat it but she was reading Shakespear when she was like, ten.” Caitlyn frowned, unsure where this was going. Powder blew another bubble and offered Caitlyn a rather knowing look. “But she’s also really fucking stupid.”

That took Caitlyn by surprise. It made absolutely no sense at all. Her lips parted to ask Powder what she could possibly mean but before so much as a word could be uttered, Powder shot up out of her desk chair, smacked Caitlyn lightly on the shoulder with a “Later

toots" and sauntered away. Leaving Caitlyn with far more questions than answers. As per usual.

"What did Powder bring you this time?" Vi asked as Caitlyn pulled her headset back over her ears.

Powder always brought Caitlyn some sort of snack or a trinket for her desk when she came to chat with Vi. First it was the photo of Vi, then a bag of goldfish crackers, then a metal sculpture that looked similar to the figurine of Chowder that Caitlyn kept on her desk. Caitlyn wasn't sure why she did it. She asked once and Powder said something about the alchemist's law of equivalent exchange. Caitlyn didn't bother asking again. "A milkshake. It was quite delicious."

"Awe damn, from Jericho's? He makes the best milkshakes. What flavor did she bring?"

"Mint chocolate chip."

Vi made a gagging noise over the line. "C'mon, not you too."

Caitlyn frowned, crossing her arms and feigning offence. "And just what do you mean by that?"

"Mint chocolate chip? That's Powder's favorite and I just don't get it, man. That shit tastes like toothpaste."

"It certainly does not. I'll have you know it is also *my* favorite."

"Of course it is." Caitlyn could practically hear the eye roll.

"Well alright if you're such a milkshake connoisseur, what's your favorite flavor?"

"Peanut butter and banana of course."

It was Caitlyn's turn to make a disgusted face. "You are joking, right?"

"Not even a little. Packed with protein and delicious. You should know I have excellent taste when it comes to sweet things."

"Oh do you? Like what?"

"Like you."

There it was again. Caitlyn uncrossed her arms and glowered down at her hands now resting in her lap. She didn't understand Vi's logic in the slightest. Here Caitlyn was being practically tormented by her desires and confusion and Vi was just shamelessly flirting like it was nothing.

Caitlyn simply couldn't let it slide this time. It was eating her up too fucking much. She sighed and wrapped her arms around herself, unable to prevent the fleeting thoughts of wishing it were Vi's strong arms instead. "Why do you do that?"

There was a beat and then genuine confusion in Vi's response. "Do what?"

"Flirt with me."

"Oh, uh." Vi hesitated, the soft scratch of her rustling her hair crackling through Caitlyn's headset as she contemplated her reply. "I guess because it's fun and I like the way you react. It- I don't know, why wouldn't I want to flirt with a woman as beautiful and fun as you?" Vi chuckled awkwardly. Caitlyn stubbornly ignored the heat in her cheeks and the little known fact that Vi still has not seen what she looks like. "Why do you ask?"

"I don't know, I suppose I just want to understand." Caitlyn wouldn't have questioned it a few weeks ago, but the things Vi says and does seem to be all over the place lately and it was becoming increasingly difficult to ignore. She shrugged "You're not interested in me so I guess I just don't see the point."

"Who said I wasn't interested in you?"

Caitlyn swore she could feel the ground shake below her feet. Vi had said it so casually, like one may speak about the weather. It seemed she had no inkling of just how torn up Caitlyn has been wondering if her astronaut felt anything toward her over these last weeks. She was beginning to understand what Powder had meant earlier. "But… I thought that…"

Vi offered another shaky laugh. It was shy sounding, Caitlyn might even think it cute if she weren't seconds away from offering Vi a verbal grenade of frustration. "Caitlyn I think I've made it pretty obvious."

Caitlyn thought back on everything once more. Admittedly she did think it was obvious at first, but then Vi had left abruptly after they crossed a proverbial sexual boundary and encouraged Caitlyn to seek companionship elsewhere. Why would she have done either of those things if she claimed to be interested?

"But you know I… I'm up here so…"

Oh. That was why.

"Right. Yes, you are." Not for the first time, Caitlyn felt like an absolute moron. She hadn't even considered the possibility of their distance being a problem for Vi. It was so inconsequential to her in regards to the magnitude of her feelings that she had assumed the same for her astronaut, but it seemed that wasn't the case.

Caitlyn buried her face in her palms, willing the ground to swallow her whole. This information was most definitely eye opening, but it didn't completely solve her gay dilemma.

So Vi wasn't uninterested, but that still didn't mean she necessarily had the same feelings for Caitlyn.

Caitlyn sucked a deep breath in and out, somehow managing to keep the shaking from her voice as she found it once more. "What would you do if you weren't?"

Vi paused. "If I weren't… in space?"

Caitlyn simply hummed in affirmation.

There was a long stretch of silence. Caitlyn was on the edge of her seat, hoping that she could finally get some damned answers out of Vi.

Her astronaut spoke softly, indecisive as always. “I don’t know, Caitlyn.” Yeah, Caitlyn wasn’t sure what she had expected. She wasn’t necessarily disappointed in Vi’s response, but it didn’t help much. “What would you want me to do?”

Caitlyn didn’t really need to think about it. She knew what she wanted. Vi’s touch, the softness of their lips moving against one another, to be able to look into the bluish grey of her eyes and get lost as one would among the stars. It was too much to put into words. “A lot of things.” Is what she settled on saying. It may have come out a little seductively. Oops.

Vi groaned and Caitlyn could hear a soft thunk followed by a curse under the astronaut’s breath. Caitlyn didn’t know what any of it meant, but she felt as though she may have pushed a little too hard. She didn’t have the answers that she had desperately sought, but she didn’t want to torment her astronaut either.

“Vi?”

“Yeah?”

“I just… I wanted to say I’m sorry. About the other day.”

Caitlyn held her breath as she waited for Vi to respond. The nerves were eating at her, the usual butterflies feeling more like a school of fish flopping around unpleasantly, making her feel sick, but she just couldn’t hold it in any longer.

Of course Vi would respond with the utmost gentle tone, soothing Caitlyn in a near instant. “You don’t have to apologize for that, Caitlyn.”

“No, I do. I shouldn’t have lashed out at you.” She rubbed at her upper arms and glanced longingly at the framed photo on her desk. “I’ve just… I've been overwhelmed with emotions lately and in that moment all I could manifest was frustration. But all you’ve been is supportive, kind, and selfless. You didn’t deserve that.”

There had never been so many drawn out beats in their conversation before. It’s like the two were walking on glass, tiptoeing around what it was they really wanted to say or how to brooch what they felt.

Vi scoffed. “I’m not as selfless as you’d think.” The words were spoken so quietly that Caitlyn wasn’t even sure she heard right. She couldn’t have.

Caitlyn frowned. “What do you mean?”

“Nevermind. I shouldn’t have said that.”

This wasn’t right. Vi was nothing but selfless and forgiving. Caitlyn’s own desires and emotions be damned, this was no longer about her and her potentially unreciprocated

feelings. This was about Vi. This new air of self deprecation simply did not sit right with Caitlyn. There was very clearly something bothering her astronaut. So, yeah, Caitlyn would shelve her own desires for the time being. She would do anything for Vi.

She found herself offering the very thing she had thrown in Vi's face a few days ago, pushing past the pang of guilt that came along with it. "Vi… you know you can talk to me, too. I'll understand."

Vi sighed. "I know, Caitlyn. Believe me I want to but… I'm sorry just, not yet. I will. I promise, but I just don't have the words right now."

Caitlyn pulled her knees up and hugged them, her gaze still fixated on the portrait of Vi on her desk. She wanted nothing more than to bring that smile back, to take all of Vi's insecurities and wipe them away.

"Then I'll wait." She said with the utmost care she could muster.

Vi groaned. "You need to stop saying that."

"Why?"

Caitlyn focused on the steady rhythm of Vi's breathing, using it to ground herself as she waited.

"I can't." Vi whispered.

It hurt Caitlyn to hear her astronaut this way. It hurt to know she couldn't do anything else at that moment, but she understood. Just as she promised Vi she would.

"Okay." Caitlyn offered a small smile, knowing Vi couldn't see it, but hoping her astronaut would hear it in her voice.

This was a difficult path for them to tread, Caitlyn could feel it in her heart and soul. Still, she felt hopeful that Vi would find what it is she needed to say and until then, Caitlyn would wait.

She'd always wait for Vi.

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Time Elapsed: 228 Days
Time Remaining: 137 Days

"You wanted to see me, chief?"

“Yes, come on in, Caitlyn.” Vander smiled politely, gesturing to the chair across from where he sat at his desk as Caitlyn entered the office. She took a seat and shyly brushed off the tops of her dark brown slacks, folding her fingers together elegantly atop her legs thereafter. She couldn’t help the formality. Caitlyn loved having Vander as a boss and he’d never made her uncomfortable, but she had felt so discombobulated lately over a certain pink haired astronaut she had fallen for and, well, he happened to be said astronaut’s father.

“So, I imagine you’ve noticed quite a change to your schedule this week.”

Caitlyn nodded. “Yes, I have an overnight shift on Wednesday evening and the rest of Thursday off.”

“Always on top of things. I admire that about you.” The compliment broke a bit of the tension in Caitlyn’s posture. She found herself relaxing a bit into the worn leather seat beneath her. “Overnight shifts aren’t so bad around here. We require them every once in a while depending on what maintenance tasks are being performed that evening. We’ll be rebooting a few systems on Wednesday night and Vi will need to remain online in case any errors occur.”

“I see, so I need to stay online with her?”

Vander waved her off with a shake to his head. “You won’t be expected to stay on comms the entire night. That’s why we added those bunks below the desk, so you can get some shuteye if you need to. There’s a roll down metal privacy screen attached to the underside of your desk as well. We had Powder make them soundproof at Mylo’s request so that the entire city doesn’t get woken up by Claggor’s snoring. So you’ll have as much privacy as you need.”

Caitlyn giggled at the notion. “I assure you I’m quite a silent sleeper myself, although I appreciate the thoroughness.”

“Well we want you to be as comfortable as possible so feel free to bring anything you need from home.”

Caitlyn pursed her lips. “Now that you mention it, I do have a cat…”

Vander laughed. “Hey, it’s fine by me but I can’t guarantee Powder won’t kidnap the creature should she be around.”

“Hm, perhaps not then.” Caitlyn found herself smiling along with Vander’s bark of laughter. She’d really won the world’s greatest boss lottery.

“Now then, how’s Vi doing?”

Caitlyn’s smile abruptly fell from her lips. “Oh, um. She’s good.”

Vander’s brow furrowed. Caitlyn really was a terrible liar. “Something the matter?”

“Well…” Caitlyn fidgeted a bit. She wasn’t about to out her and Vi’s situation and she certainly wasn’t going to confess her feelings to the woman’s dad. However, a bit of fatherly advice and some insight couldn’t hurt. “I’m just- I’m struggling a bit with her lately.

Sometimes she acts so nonchalant about things but other times I just can't read her. It's like she's keeping something bottled up and forcing a smile and I just don't understand why."

Vander listened intently, nodding his head as Caitlyn finished and drumming his large fingers against the desk, staring off in thought. Caitlyn hoped she hadn't said anything to offend him.

"I care very deeply about her." She added, staring down at her hands and steadying her breath to avoid the blush crawling up her neck. "I don't want to push her. I just… I wish I knew how to help."

Vander sighed, but he didn't seem perturbed. There was a deep look of understanding in his warm gaze as it found Caitlyn's.

"Vi has an inherently selfless and protective nature." The man leaned forward on his desk, smiling fondly as he spoke of his daughter. "She'll do anything to facilitate the happiness of those she loves but in doing so often neglects her own feelings. Then when it inevitably all comes to a head, she's left unsure of how to deal with her emotions. She doesn't know what the right path is so she becomes lost in her attempt to navigate it. Sometimes it results in the wrong decision being made and she really beats herself up over it. She stumbles but she does get there eventually. I know it can be frustrating, but have some faith in her to find her way, yeah?"

Caitlyn could tell where Vi gets her intuitive nature from. She hadn't told Vander any details of the issues they were having and yet he seemed to hit the nail directly on its proverbial head.

"Yes." She nodded mostly to herself and rubbed at her forearms, feeling worlds better having gotten this perspective.

"Told you she was a handful." Vander grinned, raising his eyebrows at Caitlyn. She let a nervous laugh bubble out in response. "The trick with her is knowing when she needs you to back off, and when she needs a swift kick out the door."

Caitlyn frowned. "How will I know which she needs?"

"Intuition." He shrugged, leaning back into his chair. "I'm afraid it depends on the context of the issue you're having but you're smart, Caitlyn. You've done wonders with Vi so far, I know you'll figure it out."

Caitlyn wasn't sure why, but she felt her eyes sting with unshed tears. Perhaps it was because she was grateful. Not just for Vander's empathy toward her, but for his presence in Vi's life. It brought her great comfort to know the person she cared for the most had such a tremendous support system of a family.

"Thank you, chief." She smiled, pushing past the tears threatening her waterline.

"Call me Vander, kiddo."

It was a wonder she managed not to cry at that moment. She simply nodded, let out an shaky breath and offered the man a wider smile.

“Thank you, Vander.”

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Time Elapsed: 230 Days
Time Remaining: 135 Days

“Houston, you up?”

Caitlyn was settled down into her sleeping cot for her overnight shift with a book in her hands and the privacy screen closed. A pleasant soft light filling the space from the fairy lights she had hung along the wall. She closed her book and slid on the headset that was laying next to her, tapping the button on the side to speak. “Yes, I’m here.”

“Hey, cupcake.”

Vi’s voice was soft, almost somber even. Given how enthusiastic the astronaut usually was, Caitlyn could immediately tell something was off. “Everything alright?”

Vi hesitated and then sighed softly. “You alone?”

“Yes, I’m in my bunk with the screen shut.”

“Hm. Can I ask you something?”

Caitlyn frowned, slightly concerned. “Of course, always.”

There was another long beat of silence. Whatever Vi had on her mind, it didn’t seem easy to get out.

“What do you do when you’re pent up?”

Caitlyn stopped breathing. Ordinarily she would respond with a sarcastic quip that went along with their banter but this was different. This wasn’t Vi’s usual flirtatious antics. She seemed genuinely curious and… frustrated.

Caitlyn made sure the privacy screen was well secured before she responded quietly. “You mean sexually?”

Vi inhaled deeply. “Yeah.”

“Well… I don’t know. I suppose-“ She closed her eyes, willing down the frantic pace of her heartbeat. “I suppose exercise? That usually helps me loosen up. Gets rid of that… feeling.”

“And when that doesn’t work?”

Caitlyn bit her lip, carefully considering her answer. She could shut this down, put up a boundary. She could let Vi deal with this on her own and not get involved, knowing full well her astronaut wouldn’t fault her for it.

And yet, she didn’t want to.

She began to feel it too. That itch, that spark of excitement below that pushed her to speak. “Then I give into it.”

Vi’s voice was thick with want and desperation all in one word. “How?”

“You… you want the details?”

A pause. “Yeah. I do.”

Caitlyn hesitated, her voice timid. “And you won’t run away this time?”

“No.” Vi’s answer was immediate, firm. “I’m not going anywhere.”

She breathed out slowly, her bunk suddenly feeling far too hot.

“I like to take my time with myself.” She closed her eyes, imagining the scene in her mind to describe it the best she could for Vi. “I start slow, dragging my fingertips up my bare stomach and to my chest.” There was a shaky exhale over the line, a soft rustling as Caitlyn continued. “I like to tease myself softly at first, gentle rubs against my nipples until I can’t take it anymore. Then I’ll pinch and pull at them, imagining it’s a woman’s lips and teeth instead.”

“Fuck, Cait.”

Caitlyn exhaled shakily. The nickname sending a shiver straight down her spine. “I’m sorry, is that- was that too much? I can stop-”

“No. *Please*… please tell me more.” Vi sounded wrecked already, so much desperation and pleading laced within her words.

Caitlyn threw her head back against the pillow, thighs rubbing together for any sort of friction. “I like to lightly trace my fingers down and brush them against the front of my undergarments. I leave them on for a bit, there’s just… just something so sexy about touching yourself over the silk, making it as wet as you can before finally moving them aside to slip your fingers in.”

The sound of Vi’s heavy breath over the line was encouraging, pushing Caitlyn to utter things she’d never said aloud before. Driving her to be the perfect fantasy for her astronaut.

“I’ll do that for a bit, just languidly slide one finger in and out before I remove the silk altogether. Then I spread myself wide open. Sometimes… sometimes I do it in front of a mirror.”

“Yeah?” Vi finally broke her silence, what was once neediness in her voice replaced with a carnal desire that sent shivers all throughout Caitlyn’s body. “You like to watch yourself?”

Caitlyn’s mouth felt bone dry, she swallowed and nearly damn whimpered in reply. “Yes.”

“I’d like to see you spread in front of a mirror.” Caitlyn did let out a small whimper this time, her fingers absentmindedly finding their way to the warmth between her legs, gently stroking over her sweats. “I’d sit behind you, gently stroking up the insides of your thighs, sucking at your neck and dragging my tongue along any inch of you I could.”

“Vi…”

“I’d- fuck- I’d spend so long making you watch me trace my fingers over every part of your body, except for where you need it.”

“Why not?” It was Caitlyn who now sounded wrecked, her voice broken and needy.

“Because I’d make you beg for it.”

“Shit.” Caitlyn hissed, her fingers slipping underneath the waistband of her sweats and underwear. The shuffling was picked up over the mic, because of course it was.

“What are you doing, Caitlyn?”

She froze, the frantic pace of her heartbeat driving her breath out in short puffs. “I… I need to…”

“What did I just say?”

Caitlyn groaned, her fingers so close to where she needed them to be.

“Caitlyn.”

“Yes?”

“Beg for it.”

“Please-“ Caitlyn breathed out, her hips twitching desperately for some friction, some relief. “Please Violet. I’m so- so wet for you. I need to touch myself *please.*“

Vi moaned hungrily and Caitlyn could hear a soft wet sound, like Vi was licking her lips. “Good girl. Slowly, yeah? Just… rub some circles on your clit.”

“Yes-“ Caitlyn whispered, finally closing the distance to what she needed. Doing as she was told and very slowly rubbing her fingertips in circles.

“Does it feel good baby?”

“Yes- god yes.” Caitlyn’s teeth sunk into her bottom lip, her back arching slightly against the sleeping pad.

“Wish I could see it, how wet you are for me.” Vi murmured softly, Caitlyn had never heard her voice so low before, so unbelievably temping and laced with pure lust. “Wish I could taste it. Have you dripping down my chin, only coming up to lick into your mouth and have you taste yourself on my tongue.“

Caitlyn let a low whine escape her throat, her fingers inadvertently moving faster. “Yes I- I want that. I want your head between my thighs. Wanna ride your tongue, it’s all I’ve thought about when…” She paused, knowing full well she’d admitted too much, but Vi wasn’t going to let it go.

“When what, Cait? Say it.”

“When I touched myself at home.” She whispered, her hips now grinding up into her palm. “When I came on my fingers with your name on my lips.”

“Fuck, when was this?”

“A- about two weeks ago. After that date…”

Vi sucked in a breath. “You went on a date with another girl and then went home and came thinking about me?”

“Yes.” It was too much. Tears of overstimulation prickling at the outer corners of Caitlyn’s eyes. “I didn’t want her. I don’t want anyone else I- I just want you.”

There was a pause, filled only with the increase of Vi’s breath over the line.

“Violet please-“ Caitlyn whimpered.

“Fuck yourself on your fingers for me.”

“Yes- *yes*…” Caitlyn reached down further and sunk two fingers deep into herself, twisting and curling them in the way that she liked. She was absolutely soaked and if it weren’t for the fact that she was still wearing her sweats, she was sure the sound would be obscene. She let out soft continuous whimpers into the mic and ended up clapping a hand down over her mouth out of fear of being discovered.

“No.” Vi breathed out, her own voice wobbling slightly, like she too was shaking while getting herself off. “Don’t do that, I want to hear you. Wanna know what sound you make when you cum.”

“I- I can’t be too loud.” Caitlyn whispered, climbing higher and higher to the edge.

“I know. God if I was there though, I’d make you be loud. Would- would fuck you so good you’d be screaming my name.”

Caitlyn was so close. She could feel her core tightening, that familiar tingling sensation building. She just needed one more thing to reach the edge…

“Vi?”

“Yeah?”

“Are you- are you also…”

“Yeah, baby. I am.”

She moaned softly at the thought of Vi touching herself, her muscular arm moving in quick strokes, abs flexing as she slid her fingers in and out.

“I wish it were my tongue inside you instead.” Caitlyn whispered. “God I- I’d be on my knees for you for hours. Letting you pull at my hair and using my tongue for your own pleasure…”

“Shit, oh my god Caitlyn.”

“I- I’m so close Vi.” Her fingers picked up a frantic pace, pushing and pulling rapidly, hips twitching and thighs shaking. “Want to cum for you. Please *please* let me…”

“Fuck you’re so *good.* Cum for me, baby.”

Vi was the one in space, but Caitlyn swore she could finally see stars. She let out a desperate gasp as she came, Violet’s name a whimper on her lips as her body trembled with the force of her climax.

“Sound so beautiful, Cait. Just like I knew you would.” Vi murmured.

“Your turn.” Caitlyn breathed out. “Gonna- gonna lick my fingers clean, taste myself and imagine it’s you instead. God I wish I could have your cum on my lips, Violet. I’d be so good- such a good little slut for you…”

Vi cried out Caitlyn’s name as she came, a delicious cacophony of moans and whimpers following as she came down from her high. The sound of their breath mingled over the line, adrenaline pulsing hotly through Caitlyn’s veins and the loud thrum of her heartbeat filling the now chilling silence of her bunk.

“Oh my god.” Caitlyn whispered.

“Yeah.” Vi seemed just as shell shocked.

“I- I can’t believe I just did that at *work.*”

“I can’t believe I just did that in space.”

“What, you’ve never cum in space before?”

“Well sure, but not like *that.*”

Despite herself, Caitlyn laughed. Vi chimed in as well and the two took a moment to bask in the post orgasm euphoria. As the endorphins wore off though, Caitlyn was left with an empty feeling. The inevitable reality of her solitude weighing heavily on her heart.

“I wish I could feel you…” She whispered, turning to lay on her side and closing her eyes to imagine Vi there in front of her. “I wish I could feel the warmth in your touch, the soft strands of your hair, the firmness of your muscles beneath my fingertips. I just- I want to feel that you’re real.”

Vi was very quiet. If it weren’t for the soft puffs of her breath then Caitlyn would have assumed she had gone offline.

“Say something.” Caitlyn pleaded. “Please.”

Her astronaut took a few steadying breaths. Caitlyn waited. She’d always wait.

“I’m sorry.” Vi ended up saying, a desperate yearning to her words. “I’m so sorry, Cait. I’d trade all of this to be there right now… you know I would.”

“Yes.” Caitlyn breathed out. “I know.”

More silence passed between the two, although no longer an uncomfortable one. The tension was thick with a mutual longing, an understanding of the joys having finally let themselves go, releasing the tension they had tiptoed around for weeks and yet it simply not being enough. So many things still left unsaid between them.

Caitlyn could feel herself drifting off, a soft yawn spreading her lips apart where she lay basking in the warmth of her pleasure.

“You should get some sleep.”

Caitlyn frowned. “Don’t wanna. Wanna stay with you.”

Vi chuckled fondly. Caitlyn wished she could feel her astronaut’s touch against her cheek. “I’ll be here when you wake up.”

“Promise?”

“Yeah.” Vi whispered, so much care laced into her words. “I promise.”

Caitlyn hummed, thinking back on her own promise she had made to Vi after the space walk. That she’d be here when Vi returned. She would keep it. She knew Vi would do the same.

She hadn’t even realized she’d fallen asleep, her mental depiction of Vi blending seamlessly into the one of her subconscious mind. Vi was in front of her, smiling, looking over Caitlyn with an awed sense of devotion. Caitlyn returned the sentiment, the two locked together in a bubble of bliss. Vi slowly lifted her hand, reaching out to Caitlyn, intent on stroking her

fingertips down Caitlyn’s cheek like she’d wanted earlier. She was so close to feeling Vi’s warmth, to finally giving in to what she had craved, longed for all these months.

But then a black hole opened under Vi’s feet, dragging her down and down into a murky abyss beyond Caitlyn’s reach. Caitlyn tried to scream, to reach out and meet Vi’s extended grasp and pull her back in, but she couldn’t. Their fingertips just barely missed one another.

And Vi was gone.

A sharp, shrill screech let out into the air.

Caitlyn’s eyes flew open to find the underside of her desk. Her heart began to pound in a frantic rhythm, matching the piercing sound echoing around her.

Because that part wasn’t a dream. The blaring tune washed over Caitlyn and turned her blood cold. She had really thought it was a part of her subconscious at first, but no.

That sound could only be the very real siren of the emergency alarm.

Chapter End Notes

Cliffhangers suck amirite?

But I gave you some smut so don't be too mad at me

Comments and kudos much obliged <3

Breathless

Chapter Summary

> “Vi… come back. Please…”

Chapter Notes

> Heya, remember at the beginning of this fic where I said there would be a lot of fun and accurate space shit in here but also to suspend your disbelief a little bit? I’m gonna need you all to lock into that for this chapter. If you can enjoy pretty much any space media today you can look past some of my inaccuracies for the sake of L.O.L space lesbians. Just turn your brain off and enjoy the drama.
>
> Playlist for this fic here
>
> See ya. <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Time Elapsed: 231 Days
Time Remaining: 134 Days

Caitlyn sprang into action immediately. She slid open the screen of her bunk and practically rolled out of it, shooting straight up and frantically glancing around the room in her panic. Mylo and Claggor were already up, Mylo standing frozen with his chest heaving while Claggor was speedily typing away bent over his desk.

Neither made any attempt for an exit, because this wasn’t the alarm for a fire in the comms building. It was an alarm for the space station.

Vander’s office door banged open, startling Caitlyn as he made his way down the steps and toward the center of the comms room. The man looked- shit, he looked terrified.

Caitlyn didn’t waste any time in retrieving the headset from her bunk and sliding it over her ears, hardly a second in between her finger pressing against the green talk button and the sound of her hurried voice.

“ISS do you copy?”

“Heya cupcake.” Vi sounded irrationally calm for someone in an emergency situation.

“I’m broadcasting our conversation. What’s going on?” Caitlyn was significantly less calm, her fingers shaking against the keyboard as she pressed the necessary buttons.

Vi’s voice began to filter through the speakers at the front of the room. “A nearby Russian satellite broke, we’re not quite sure how but there’s a fair amount of debris coming at us. We sustained some hull damage.”

“Instruct them to shelter immediately.” Vander said, hunched over a computer to pull up the spacecraft's live diagnostics on the projector screen. Caitlyn nodded once and relayed the message.

“No can do, chief. Hull damage is significant enough that our O2 levels are dropping. We gotta go out and patch it before the hole gets bigger.”

Caitlyn’s heart dropped into her stomach. “While the debris is hurtling toward you?”

“Yep. Ekko and I are suiting up now. Already completed pre-breathing. Loris and Sky are helping us out and then Sky is going to shelter. Loris will stay on standby to get us back in.”

Caitlyn clicked off her microphone and turned to the chief. “This can’t be the proper protocol.”

“It is.” Vander had the most intense expression Caitlyn had seen on him yet. The man was clearly torn between his duty as the flight commander of this expedition and his role as a father. It was heartbreaking for Caitlyn to see the genuine fear in his eyes. “If they lose their O2, everyone on board could perish. This is… the best path for minimal casualties.“

Minimal. Not *no* casualties. Minimal.

“Mylo, go call Powder. She should know what’s going on.”

Caitlyn looked to the two boys, her heart sinking further at their forlorn expressions. Mylo nodded and made his way out of the room, tears threatening his waterline.

“Claggor, you better monitor the hell out of ETHOS. Constantly relay their O2 levels to us.”

“Okay.” Claggor inhaled deeply and turned back to his monitor, making quick work of clicking around his desktop.

“Caitlyn.”

The two locked eyes, panic and bile rising in Caitlyn’s throat.

“Stay calm. They’ll be alright. We have to believe that.” He offered a smile that didn’t touch his eyes in the slightest. “Talk to her. Keep her calm. I’m not asking as your boss… but as her father. Please.”

“Beginning depressurization.” Vi called out.

The alarm had long stopped, but there was still a roar of adrenaline in Caitlyn's ears. It went against her every instinct to remain standing when all she wanted to do was crumple into a ball and hide away. Still, as she stood there locked in to eye contact with Vander, she found herself motivated by his own resolve. There was real, palpable fear in his eyes and yet he stood firm. Caitlyn needed to find the same strength, the same determination.

For Vi.

Caitlyn focused on the push and pull of her own breath as she yanked open the top drawer of her desk and retrieved the small monitor Powder had given her. She flipped it on and propped it up against her desk, waiting until it was fully booted up and she could see Vi's point of view before proceeding.

She clicked the button on the side of her headset once more. "Vi."

"Yeah?"

Caitlyn swallowed past the lump in her throat, bracing her knuckles at the edge of her desk and screwing her eyes shut. She knew the rest of the room was listening but frankly did not care in the slightest. "Do you remember what I promised you?"

Vi breathed in deeply, the sound picking up static from inside her space suit. "That you'd be there when I got back."

"Yes." Caitlyn's heart was thundering. It was a wonder she was still standing, but she had to. She needed to stand strong, keep her feet firmly planted. "So you better make it back, Violet. I swear to god-"

"I'm coming back, Cait." Despite the situation, Caitlyn could hear a bit of fondness, a soft smile in Vi's voice. "I still gotta see what you look like, after all."

A hysteric bubble of laughter slipped out of Caitlyn. She clapped her hand over her lips, only then noticing the moisture spilling down her cheeks and hurriedly wiping at it with the back of her hand. "Well now I- now I really have a lot to live up to. Don't I?"

"Well, yeah. If I'm gonna survive a near death experience you better have one rocking bod."

"Oh my god shut *up*."

The two laughed albeit anxiously. Caitlyn could feel a tiny bit of tension leave the room. She noticed Claggor's tiny smile and Vander's shoulders losing some of their stiffness. Caitlyn too felt she could actually breathe for a moment.

Then Vander's office door flew open once more and Powder entered the room in her pink bunny pajama set at a swift pace with Mylo in tow. She glanced up at the projector screen with a panicked look in her eyes and the static tense climate returned in full force like a gust of wind.

"Bringing up the outside camera feed." Claggor said. The feed then popped up in a window on the projector screen and Caitlyn gasped. There were tons of varying pieces of debris

floating around the station. Most of it was stagnant, drifting around slowly. Some larger pieces banged against one another, spinning out of control and away from the station. It was worse than Caitlyn imagined. A hornet's nest of large metal pieces and insulation.

"Depressurization complete. Waiting on your word to open the hatch, chief." Vi said through the speakers.

"What the *hell* are they doing?!" Powder called out, glancing around the room as if they were all out of their minds. "Why aren't they sheltering?"

Claggor pushed his glasses up his nose. "O2 level is at two hundred eighty nine decimal two and dropping."

Caitlyn closed her eyes, envisioning the mathematical formulas to calculate flow rate in her mind. "The alarm began about fifteen minutes ago. If their O2 is at two hundred eighty nine point two kilograms, that would mean they are leaking approximately twelve grams of oxygen per second. Given this and taking depressurization into account, they have a little under two hours to find the hole and it should be no bigger than the size of a quarter."

She opened her eyes to find everyone in the room was staring at her incredulously. Claggor blinked and looked back to his computer, typing in some quick calculations before nodding toward Vander. "She's right."

"That was so hot." Vi murmured.

Caitlyn was convinced Vi could be thrown into an active volcano and still find time to flirt. "Focus, please."

"Right." Vi relayed the information Caitlyn had provided to Ekko before addressing her once more. "We good to open the hatch?"

Caitlyn turned to Vander, failing to keep the pain and anxiety from her features. The man ran his large fingers through his slicked back hair and sighed. After a quick glance at the monitor indicating the air lock had been properly depressurized, he nodded toward Caitlyn.

"Dad, you *can't* let them go out there." Powder's voice sounded absolutely broken, a vulnerability laced into its normal raspiness. "At their current orbit the velocity of any space debris coming at them could *kill* them."

"We don't have a choice, Powder." There was so much kindness and understanding to Vander's tone. Caitlyn couldn't believe she ever thought this man to be scary when in reality he was so kind, harboring the most comforting presence she'd ever known in a person. "The likelihood of debris hitting them is slim, you know that."

"I know but it could still happen!" Powder wrapped her arms around herself, her voice and breath becoming increasingly panicked. "I can't lose either of them, I can't lose *both* of them-"

"Houston? What's going on?" Vi asked.

Powder's tearful gaze whipped around and landed on Caitlyn. There was a deep, pleading look in her watery eyes. It broke something in Caitlyn, but also awakened something. A newfound determination and strength rooted in the desire to protect this family.

Caitlyn offered Powder a kind smile before schooling her expression into one of fierce focus and speaking into the mic. "Listen to me, Violet. There's a practical minefield of debris floating around the station. The turn radius of your suits are shit, so I'm going to be monitoring the outside camera and directing you as best I can. You and Ekko need to watch each other's six'. Stick back to back and close to the handrails. Do not touch any of the debris if you can avoid it, there's no way to calculate the trajectory of those larger pieces if they were to bump into one another and spin out of control. Standby for my command to open the hatch, copy?"

It was eerily quiet for a moment while they awaited Vi's response. Caitlyn's gaze found Powder's once more. There was no longer an overwhelming panic in her eyes, moreso shock and a bit of acceptance. She swallowed and wiped at her wet cheeks, mouthing a small "thank you" at Caitlyn with a soft nod. It was a small gesture, but one of trust and gratitude nonetheless.

"Copy." Vi said. She relayed to Ekko once more. Caitlyn sucked in a nervous breath through her teeth, turning her full attention to the outside camera feed.

After about a minute or so, she deemed the area around the hatch clear enough, ignored her instincts screaming at her not to let them go out there, and gave the command. "Engage the EV hatch."

"On it." Vi grunted with the effort of slowly opening the hatch. Every eye in the room was glued intently to the surveillance feed as the metal door opened. Vi was the first out of the station, sticking closely to the hull of the ship as she extended her gloved hand to Ekko to pull him out.

Powder turned on her heel and made her way over to Scar's comm station. She swiftly booted up his computer and pressed various keys at an alarming speed. "I'm opening up comms so we can hear and communicate with Ekko, too."

"How the hell are we going to find a hole the size of a quarter in two hours?" Ekko's voice came through the speakers. Caitlyn hadn't ever heard him speak before. He sounded so young…

"Look for where the damage to the hull is the most significant and start there." Caitlyn replied, forcing down her anxieties. "You'll just have to patch as you go until the O2 stops dropping. Then we can assume you'll have fixed the leak."

"Oh, you must be Caitlyn."

Caitlyn smiled for a second, wishing her and Ekko could have met under far better circumstances. "I'm afraid pleasantries will have to wait, but yes. Do you guys see any damage?"

“Not much on the starboard side.” Vi replied. “We’ll have to make our way around.”

“Can barely see shit out here.” Ekko mumbled.

“I’ll be your eyes as much as I can.” Caitlyn reassured them, watching intently as the two slid along the hand rails. A large metal sheet caught her eye in the bottom right corner of the screen. She squinted at it, watching the angle and speed at which it was moving toward them.

“Stop.”

The two astronauts froze. Seconds later, the sheet collided right into the handrail mere feet away from Vi before rotating slightly and floating downward away from them.

“Shit.” Ekko breathed out. Caitlyn could hear Powder let out a worried squeak from somewhere to her left. It was painful to hear but as much as she wished to comfort Vi’s sister, she needed to maintain her focus.

“Proceed, you’re clear for now.”

Vi breathed out slowly before continuing her path toward the port side of the station, Ekko closely in tow but turned at an angle to watch her back. You could cut the tension in the comms room with a knife, however Caitlyn had completely dissociated herself from it. Her eyes darted around the screen, assessing all nearby pieces of debris and their likelihood of affecting Vi and Ekko’s venture as they went.

It continued on like that for a while. The rigid atmosphere and air of anxiety never dulled for a moment and Caitlyn remained locked-in. She barely registered Vander asking Powder if she wanted to hop onto Ekko’s comms, Powder shaking her head and declaring she didn’t want to distract them and she trusted Caitlyn to handle it.

After about half an hour of continuous monitoring, occasionally checking in on Vi’s POV on her handheld monitor, and calling out varying instructions to the astronauts, Caitlyn spotted something.

“Vi, look at your two o’clock, what is that?”

They were on the port side of the station moving up toward the bow at this point. Vi turned toward the direction Caitlyn had indicated and there sticking off the ship was a piece of the metal exterior nearly ripped off from the hull.

“That’s gotta be it.” Ekko said, sounding slightly winded.

“Good eye, cupcake.”

Some tension that Caitlyn hadn’t realized she was grasping onto released from her shoulders. They found the damage. Now they just needed to patch it and get back inside. Halfway there. Sort of.

Vi hooked her carabiner into the handrail, Ekko following suit so the two could make their way up toward the damage. As if sensing Caitlyn’s momentary relief, two metal clusters of

debris smacked into one another directly to their left, sending one hurtling toward them.

Caitlyn gasped. “Hit the deck, now!”

“Shit.” Vi hissed out, gripping the front of Ekko’s suit and hauling him in front of her. A gust of compressed nitrogen shot out from the back of her SAFER pack, pressing the two firmly against the hull of the ship just in time for the debris to miss where their heads had been moments prior.

“Holy shit.” Mylo whispered, fisting at his spiky hair. Powder began quietly sobbing in the corner.

“We’re good.” Vi breathed out, releasing Ekko so the two could continue their crawl up toward the damaged section of the station.

Caitlyn hadn’t realized she had been holding her breath until it burst out of her. A shiver wracked through her body which she rubbed at her upper arms in response to but otherwise disregarded.

“Okay, we’ve reached the damage. Gonna start patching it up now.” Vi unclipped the patch kit from her belt, Ekko flipped in the opposite direction to keep an eye out for any danger.

“Claggor, how’s O2 looking?” Vander asked.

“It’s currently at around two twenty.” There was a slight tremor in Claggors voice. Shit, why did this entire room have to be made up of Vi’s family? It was cruel for them to have to endure this sort of situation. Especially when there was practically nothing for them to do but watch.

Vander hummed in acknowledgment. “Keep an eye on it and relay to us if it goes steady. Caitlyn-” For the first time since Vi and Ekko left the hatch, Caitlyn turned her attention away from the screen toward Vander. She blinked hard a few times, her eyes having dried out staring at the monitors for so long. “Take a deep breath. You’re doing great.”

Caitlyn did just that. She took a moment to steady herself while Vi worked to seal the metal hull together. Patch kits usually worked with a combination of epoxy soaked gauze or high tech tape. Vi was currently using the former to seal up the tear, working as focused and as swiftly as she could in zero gravity. The debris around them was stagnant for now, but Caitlyn was still on edge knowing full well that could change in a second’s time.

“How are you doing, Vi?” She couldn’t help but ask, the nerves clawing at her from the inside out.

Vi chuckled nervously. “I’d make a comment about you doubting my ability to handle wet things, but my father is listening, so.”

Vander sighed and pinched at the bridge of his nose. Caitlyn sucked her bottom lip under her gapped teeth, trying to hold back an inappropriate smile in this ridiculous situation.

“You really wanna die a pervert, Vi?” Ekko shot at her.

“You know me, little man. I wouldn’t have it any other way.”

The two laughed softly over the line and Caitlyn could hear Powder snort disbelievingly from where she was curled up in a rolling chair now in the middle of the comms room with a blanket over her shoulders. “Idiots.” She grumbled. Caitlyn couldn’t help but agree.

“I’m almost done here. Just gotta lay down one or two more strips and that should do it.”

“Okay.” Caitlyn exhaled, shifting her gaze from the handheld monitor to the outside cam. Things remained steady at the moment and yet that same fear and pulse of adrenaline coursed its way through Caitlyn in a steady beat. She wouldn’t relax until Vi and Ekko were safely sheltered.

“Done. How’s O2?”

“Claggor?” Vander pressed. Claggor squinted at his screen for a moment and held up a finger indicating for them to wait. After a solid minute or two of monitoring, he sighed with relief and grinned toward Vander.

“It’s stable. They got it.”

“Oh thank fuck.” Mylo let out, collapsing into his own chair.

Caitlyn smiled wide, her heart rate spiking in a momentary lapse of joy. “You got it, Vi. O2 is stable. Get back to the EV hatch post haste.”

“Copy, heading back.”

“Man, I never want to do this shit again.” Ekko grumbled as the two began to pull themselves back toward the hand rails via their tethers.

“It’s kind of part of the job there little man.” Vi teased.

“Screw that. You think Jericho is hiring?”

The two laughed and for just a fleeting moment, Caitlyn was feeling as though they were almost out of the woods. That they had successfully accomplished what they set out to do and could make it back without a hitch. She really believed so.

That moment was shattered as the largest cluster of debris Caitlyn had seen yet came seemingly out of nowhere and smacked into one of the solar arrays jutting out from the station, knocking several of the panels loose and launching them along with pieces of the metal framework toward Vi and Ekko.

“Lookout!” Caitlyn shouted, frenetically looking from piece to piece as they fell. There were too many of them. She couldn’t calculate where each would land as they smacked into one another, their trajectory all over the place.

One of the panels smacked into Ekko *hard*, knocking him off the hull of the space station and out toward the darkness. Caitlyn gasped. Powder screamed.

“Shit, Ekko!” Vi called out, her voice crackling slightly over the line.

Ekko wasn’t responding. Had he lost consciousness? No, Caitlyn could see him moving still on the monitor. It could be a communications error, or simply that the man was too panicked to speak. The suit diagnostics on the screen showed no signs of breach, so physically he was most likely fine.

Caitlyn could feel her own panic rising higher and higher within her. Like water about to burst from a dam. She shook her head and pleaded with reason in her mind. Ekko would be fine so long as his suit wasn’t punctured nor his helmet cracked. He would be fine so long as his tether remained intact.

More debris ricocheted off the edge of the space station, hurling itself in multiple directions. A sharp broken piece of the metal framework spiralled toward the handrail.

It severed Ekko’s tether, releasing him freely toward the vast emptiness around them.

“EKKO!” Vi unhooked her carabiner without a second’s hesitation, planting her feet firmly against the surface of the space station.

“No-” Caitlyn gasped.

Caitlyn’s heart felt as though it was going to burst from her chest, breath caught in her throat while she watched the woman she had fallen for over the last four months relinquish her line of safety to push herself off into a field of debris filled space in the direction Ekko had gone.

There was a ringing in Caitlyn’s ears, an empty white noise that was all consuming and debilitating. She could hear nothing but the sound of Vi’s breathing, do nothing but stand and watch Vi drift further and further away until her breath crackled away and she was completely out of the camera’s view. Caitlyn looked down to her handheld monitor, but it was simply nothing but grey static.

“Vi…” Caitlyn couldn’t even hear her own voice, but she could feel how broken it was. “Vi… come back. Please…”

“Cai-” There was nothing but crackling on Vi’s end. Caitlyn couldn’t see Vi. Couldn’t hear her. Couldn’t feel the Earth under her own feet. There was nothing but an emptiness consuming every fiber of her being.

Suddenly, Caitlyn’s dream came flooding back to her. The feeling of Vi sinking into darkness, completely out of Caitlyn’s reach. Watching her disappear, leaving Caitlyn helpless with a hollowness in her gut unparalleled by any black hole in the universe. That’s what this was. Only this time, it was no dream.

Caitlyn wasn’t sure how long she stood in shock, unblinking at the projector screen. Nothing felt real, not the skin on her bones nor the very breath caught in her lungs. Time had slowed to a staggering halt and nothing else mattered except for the pleading voice on loop within her heart.

Please come back.

Please.

I haven't even told you yet.

I haven't told you how much I-

Vi came back into frame, Ekko firmly in her grasp and spurts of nitrogen fizzling out around her. Her voice crackled back to life over the speaker, popping in and out sporadically with syllables they couldn't make out.

"The SAFER is failing." Vander said, his voice shaking with fear. It shocked Caitlyn out of her stupor like an ice bath. She shook her head and let a gasped breath slip from her trembling lips, unable to tear her gaze away from where Vi was emitting small inconsistent puffs from her rescue aid. There was definitely something wrong with it. They most likely hadn't time to check it was properly rigged before heading out. Whatever the problem was, it wasn't allowing Vi to make a steady retreat.

Vi was maneuvering around large pieces of debris in space without a safety tether while carrying another astronaut all with a broken jetpack. It was simultaneously the most terrifying and most astounding thing Caitlyn had ever seen.

"Fuck-" Vi's voice crackled through the speakers as she approached a metal sheet the size of a door. She let out a burst of nitrogen and turned her body to go feet first into the metal, rotating on it like a surfboard before pushing off back toward the station.

Caitlyn could only barely register Mylo saying "holy shit" once more from somewhere in front of her. She'd be lying to say she wasn't in complete awe, but the only real emotion at the forefront of her being was pure terror.

"She's going straight for the hatch." Claggor threaded both sets of fingers into the hair at the base of his neck, pulling at the strands with his jaw clenched in tense anticipation.

"She can make it." Powder was standing once more, glaring fiercely at the screen. Caitlyn had never seen such a look in the girl's eyes before. It was almost terrifying, as if she would set the world ablaze should Vi and Ekko not make it back safely.

"Come on Vi." Vander said, fear but also an astounding faith laced into his words.

A broken solar panel approached Vi's path. This time, Vi kicked her legs forward to position herself upside- down before engaging the SAFER and blasting downward out of its way. She was so damn close to the hatch now, just a little bit further-

"Vi-" Caitlyn pleaded, unsure if her astronaut could hear her but feeling the need to call out anyway.

Vi didn't respond, but she reached back and banged her fist hard into her rescue aid pack, it then emitted a large burst of nitrogen that propelled her and Ekko forward, straight into the EV hatch.

“I got him. We’re secured.” Vi breathed out, her voice crackling from remaining static.

All three of her siblings erupted into cheers. Claggor grabbing both of them into a bear hug before lifting them off the ground as if they weighed nothing. Caitlyn simply collapsed back into her chair, staring blankly ahead of her. The emotions she had been suppressing under her roaring adrenaline all came pouring to the surface at once and she broke down. She had just enough foresite to mute her microphone before the uncontrollable sobs ripped from her throat, tears streaming in thick streaks down her face.

She had almost lost her. She’d almost lost Vi. The most precious thing she had ever known. Someone who lit up her world brighter than any star could dream of.

It was in that moment of sheer overwhelming panic and relief that it became so clear to her what exactly it was she felt for her astronaut. She had danced around admitting it to herself for so long but in the face of losing it for good, she finally understood. It flowed through her like a river, sparks lighting in her gut and warmth filling her chest. Drowning out her fears, all of her panic and mixing with the remaining adrenaline to create something devastatingly painful, but also beautiful.

“Caitlyn.”

Caitlyn hadn’t realized she stopped sobbing and was now just quietly emitting tears. She glanced up to find Vander standing at the entrance of her cubicle, his brow furrowed in concern but gazing at Caitlyn with an irrevocable look of gratitude.

“Yes?” Caitlyn breathed out, unable to say much else or move from where she was slumped into her chair.

Vander let out a shaky exhale, his right hand coming to rub against his chest directly over his heart. There was so much meaning in the gesture, more than words could convey. “*Thank you.*”

Caitlyn wanted to say that Vander had nothing to thank her for. That she would go to hell in a handbasket a million times over for Vi, but she just couldn’t find the words. Instead she offered a weak nod, which seemed to be good enough for Vander at that moment.

He smiled fondly in understanding and walked away to join the others. Caitlyn let them have their family moment. She was still in a world of her own. Lost in coming down from the most terrifying situation she’d experienced in her lifetime and yet wrapped in a newfound understanding of herself and what she wanted.

It was all too much.

“Whoo, close one, aye?” Vi’s voice came back to Caitlyn’s headset. She seemed to be out of her suit now, back onto the closed communication line that the two usually shared. Caitlyn’s breath caught, her mouth suddenly dry and a new sort of anxiety pulsing through her veins.

“Caitlyn?”

Caitlyn took a deep, ineffectively steadying breath, unable to keep the tremor from her voice as she unmuted her mic to speak. “That was- that was quite the show of heroism.”

Her voice was so quiet and timid that she wasn’t even sure if Vi heard her. The adrenaline and anxiety roared in her ears as she sat, knuckles white where she gripped against the wooden edge of her desk.

Vi was quiet for a moment before she sighed, an understanding and compassion in her voice once she spoke once more.“Is that really what you want to say?”

“No.” Caitlyn said, her voice shaken but firm. “No it’s not.”

“Well then, let me have it.”

Caitlyn did just that, unable to stop the pouring of emotions that spewed out of her like a broken faucet. “That was- that was so stupid and reckless and-and dangerous and if you ever do something like that again I swear to god I will go up there myself and drag your ass back down to Earth.”

Vi paused. “Well, that doesn’t sound too bad...”

“Violet.”

“I know, I know. I’m sorry, cupcake. It won’t happen again.” Caitlyn closed her eyes, envisioning Vi in front of her, a sympathetic and remorseful furrow to her brow. “Hey, I’m alright, yeah?”

Caitlyn shook her head, frustrated tears brimming in her waterline. “I’m so- I’m so angry. I wish you were here.” She gasped out a small sob, furiously wiping at her cheeks. She knew what Vi did was necessary. She saved Ekko. It didn’t mean Caitlyn wasn’t irate with concern and frustration. “I wish you were here so I could hold you and feel that you’re safe and punch you in your stupid toned abs and tell you how- how *frightened* I was.”

Vi sighed, simply listening to Caitlyn sob softly, allowing her to get everything she needed out. It was so unbelievably aggravating not being able to physically be with Vi at that moment. To touch her and ground herself and find that relief in Violet really being all right.

“I’m sorry, Cait.” Vi said quietly. “I’m sorry I- fuck if I was there I’d hold you so tight and wipe those tears away. It’s killing me that I can’t but please just try to take a few deep breaths for me, okay?”

Caitlyn did as she was told, closing her eyes and focusing in on Vi’s voice while forcing some shaky in and exhales. After a minute or two, the shaking in her limbs had calmed to a dull tremor and she couldn’t help but let a hysterical laugh bubble past her lips.

“What’s funny?”

“I just- you were the one in danger and yet you’re comforting me.” Caitlyn wiped at her cheeks, pouting cutely at the frustration she felt toward herself. “I just feel sort of ridiculous.”

Vi laughed softly. “Don’t worry about me, cupcake. I’m tough as nails.”

“Quite stubborn as them too, I’d say.” Caitlyn smiled fondly, folding her arms atop her desk and laying her head against them to stare at her photo of Vi. It was a bit uncomfortable and awkward with the headset on, but she couldn’t care less at that moment. “You’re really alright?”

“Yeah, I’m good. That was- shit, I won’t lie it was fucking scary, but it’s gonna take a lot more than that to get rid of me.”

Caitlyn hummed. “I’ll keep that in mind.”

“Oh yeah? Gonna put a hit out on me, cupcake?”

“If you scare me like that again then I just might.”

“Damn. It’s kind of sexy when you threaten me.”

“Shut up.” Caitlyn found herself smiling. She felt a lot calmer now just hearing Vi’s voice, hearing the steadiness in it and knowing that Vi was safe. “How’s- how is Ekko?”

“Well, he could be better.”

Caitlyn’s smile dropped. “What? Why? Is he okay?”

There was a pause. Then, “He puked in his helmet.”

Caitlyn couldn’t help but laugh a little too hard into her forearms. She didn’t care anymore. Everything was so absurd. “Well that explains why he went quiet.” Caitlyn sniffled and wiped at her cheeks. “Looks like Powder owes Mylo his money back.”

Vi groaned. “Don’t even get me started, man. I had so much bet on him, now I owe Loris like fifty drinks when we get back.”

“Hm, a moment of silence for your wallet.”

Vi chuckled and Caitlyn took a moment to bask in the sound of her laughter. Vi was okay. She was there. Caitlyn couldn’t feel her touch, but she knew it in her heart.

“You should go home and get some rest, Cait.” Her voice was so soft, filled with so much concern. How incredible this woman was to do nothing but show empathy and care for others after what she had just been through.

Caitlyn tensed. Her voice quiet as she responded. “I don’t want to leave you.”

“I know, but I need to regroup with the crew and assess the damage, make sure everyone is alright. There’s a lot of stuff we’re going to need to catch up on over the next few days.” Vi breathed out slowly. There was a gentle smile in her voice now as she spoke. “We’ll talk tomorrow. I’m not going anywhere. Everything is fine now, yeah?”

Caitlyn lifted her head off her desk, wrapping her arms around herself in a hug. “Are we…” She felt a warmth creep up on her cheeks, her voice shy and hesitant. “Are we going to talk… about last night?”

Vi hesitated. Caitlyn’s heart thumped steadily while she waited. “Yeah.” Vi said gently, relaxing Caitlyn’s posture immediately. “We’ll talk about it.”

“Okay.” Caitlyn smiled to herself, the butterflies practically singing in her gut.

“Get some rest, cupcake. You earned it.”

“You too.”

Neither one of them made to end the transmission. It seemed neither of them wanted to. Not after the day they had. It was almost painful to Caitlyn knowing she would need to leave. To walk out of this building and go home to her empty flat. She almost lost Vi today, she wasn’t ready to say goodbye again.

After a moment of listening to one another’s breath over the line. Vi finally sighed in defeat.

“Talk to you tomorrow, Cait.”

Caitlyn closed her eyes, trying and failing to push down the well of emotions overflowing in that moment, but resigning herself nonetheless.

“Bye… Vi.”

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Caitlyn didn’t remember leaving the comms building. She didn’t remember the drive home, or pushing open the door to her apartment. She didn’t remember changing out of her sweats into a pair of silk pajama pants and a tank top, or feeding Chowder a scoop of food before collapsing onto her velvet green couch. She had done it all in a trance, a state of shock that had her moving through the motions of what she needed to do without really feeling the impact of any of it.

After staring at the ceiling of her apartment for god knows how long, the emotions of that evening had once again caught up with her, spilling down her cheeks in quiet streaks of hot tears.

It was all too much to bear and suddenly she was smacked with the heavy feeling of solitude. She was so alone. Too alone.

She needed Vi there. That was the only thing that could bring down the swelling ache in her heart, but it wasn’t possible. Still, that desperate need for companionship was weighing on her heavily, a desperate cry for help within her heart that she couldn’t bear to leave unheard.

She whipped out her phone without a second's thought and typed in the number of the only one who she knew could help at this moment.

"Hey Sprout! What's up?" The sound of Jayce's voice over the phone alone gave Caitlyn a spark of comfort. Still, it wasn't enough.

"How soon can you get to Houston?"

Jayce must have heard the desperation in Caitlyn's voice. Within seconds she could hear the expensive clack of his shoes against the ground moving in a swift pace from wherever he currently was. "I'll be there in two hours."

Caitlyn sighed, feeling a bit of relief. Jayce truly was an amazing friend, someone she could always count on. "Thank you."

"Did something happen?"

"Yes." Caitlyn tilted her head against the back of the couch, her jaw clenched as she glared at the ceiling to avoid any more tears threatening to fall. "It's- everything's fine now I just… I need you here. Physically. I can't take the distance any longer." There was a bit of a double meaning to her words. She wasn't specifically talking about Jayce, but it did apply to him. She needed to feel someone's presence. To ground herself in reality.

"I'm coming. Let me hang up and make a few calls and I'll be there. Okay?"

"Yes… okay."

"See you soon. It'll be alright."

Despite the ache in her chest, Caitlyn smiled to herself. Jayce was on his way.

"See you soon."

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A little over two hours later, Caitlyn was pulled out of her sleepy lull by two soft knocks at her door. She was exhausted and yet she nearly lept off the couch, almost slipping due to her fuzzy socks as she ran to the front door and yanked it open.

Jayce was standing there in a brown leather jacket with a comforting smile, a bouquet of flowers, and an overnight duffle bag. "Hey sprout."

Caitlyn held herself together for all of two seconds before she grabbed the man by his lapels and hauled him into her apartment. She ripped the flowers from his hands and tossed them to her counter before nearly tackling him into a hug and proceeding to sob into his probably very expensive cotton v-neck shirt.

Jayce was seemingly stunned for a moment before he dropped his bag to the ground and wrapped his strong arms around Caitlyn's shoulders. She couldn't begin to explain the immense relief it gave her to feel someone, to ground herself in companionship and love. It wasn't exactly what she had craved over these past few months, she didn't have that sort of relationship with Jayce, but it was comfort in a loved one nonetheless.

"I'm so glad you're here." She sobbed into him, unable to hold back the feelings she'd bottled up over the last several hours.

Jayce didn't seem to mind. He had seen Caitlyn at her absolute worst plenty of times. This was no sweat off his back. He gently stroked Caitlyn's hair and let her cry and squeeze the life out of him until she was ready to let go.

Once she finally pulled back, offering the man an apologetic smile, he sighed and reached over to the tissue box on Caitlyn's kitchen counter, offering her a few to which she mumbled out a small thank you.

"Come on, let's sit down and talk." He retrieved his duffle bag and ushered Caitlyn into her own living room. She was being a bad host, but it was Jayce and she had been through a rather traumatic experience just a few hours prior. So she didn't give a shit.

They plopped down on the couch, Caitlyn pulling up her legs and wrapping her arms around them. Jayce's eyes were filled with so much warmth and sympathy as he spoke. "Wanna tell me what happened?"

Caitlyn really didn't, but she needed to. She couldn't hold any of it back anymore. Starting from the end of their last conversation where Jayce had set her up on that ludicrous date, Caitlyn explained everything. Her torn confusion on Vi's feelings, the odd way Vi had acted after the date, their impromptu sexual encounter over the comm system, and nearly losing Vi whilst being unable to do anything. She expressed her feelings of helplessness, the overwhelming rush of emotions, the relief and distress. It all flowed out of her like a waterfall.

"I don't know, I just…" Caitlyn sighed, her head falling back to stare at the ceiling. "When I thought I would lose her today… I felt a sense of fear and panic I had never known before. I couldn't bear the thought of a world where I wouldn't get to hear her voice every day. I was terrified and in that moment when I saw her return safely… nothing else mattered. My world simply stopped and at the center of it all was her. I've never felt something so powerful before."

Jayce listened along patiently, his posture relaxing into the couch cushions and a newfound understanding overtaking his chiseled features.

"So… if I'm hearing this correctly then-" He sighed, forcing Caitlyn to meet his knowing gaze. "You're in love with her."

Caitlyn squeezed her legs in tighter, staring blankly at the edge of her coffee table. She simply didn't have the energy to fight her feels any longer. "Yes. I'm in love with her."

The man nodded slowly. Chowder jumped onto the couch and curled up in his lap, purring softly as the man began to scratch behind his ears. He never laid in Caitlyn's lap like that, the traitorous whore.

"And how do you feel about that?" Jayce asked hesitantly.

"I don't know. Conflicted? Irrational, maybe?" She lowered her legs to the ground and gripped the edge of the couch. "I mean, I've never met her in person. Is it possible to fall in love with someone you've never even touched? Never seen in the flesh? Never been in the same room with?"

"Of course it is, Cait." He said it so casually, like it was the most obvious thing in the world. "In this day and age of technology people fall in love on the other side of the world from one another. Sometimes they go years before they actually meet in person. You've spent nearly every day for the last four months talking to her for hours on end. You told her about Cambridge and opened up about things that it took you years to do with others. You clearly trust her and have formed a connection on a deep level."

Caitlyn chewed on her bottom lip. "You don't think it's too fast? That I'm being far too hasty and mistaking that fear in the moment as being feelings deeper than they are?"

The man shook his head. "If it feels right to you Caitlyn then it doesn't matter how fast it is. Tell me something, do you still feel that adrenaline? That horrible fear that you'll lose her?"

"No." She didn't really need to think about it. Was she still on edge? Absolutely. Terrified as she was earlier though? Not at all.

"And you still feel the same about her?"

Caitlyn swallowed nervously, her voice a soft whisper. "Yes."

"Well then, there you have it."

She couldn't help but roll her eyes. "Sometimes you are so painfully pragmatic. Not everything is so easily solved as a simple equation. There are other factors to consider."

"Like what?"

"Like… I don't know." Caitlyn fidgeted with her hands. If only she had some sort of emotional support cat that wasn't licking himself shamelessly on her millionair friend's lap at the moment.

"Like, how Vi feels?"

Caitlyn nodded. "Yes. That."

Jayce hummed in thought for a moment. "Well, you won't know unless you ask her."

Caitlyn fell sideways onto the couch, grabbing one of her decorative strawberry pillows and pressing it over her face. "It's not that easy." She grumbled into the fabric.

Jayce sighed. “Lesbians are so fucking useless.”

Caitlyn kicked him in the arm, earning her an annoyed glare from Chowder. The man laughed and rubbed at his arm, feigning like it hurt when Caitlyn knew she couldn’t put a dent in him even if she tried.

“Seriously, talk to her about it. What’s the worst that could happen?”

“I could get my heart broken and lose my job.”

“You’re so dramatic. That’s not gonna happen, Caitlyn. Based on what you’ve told me, I would frankly be shocked if she didn’t feel the same.”

Caitlyn removed the pillow from her face to frown at her best friend. “You think so?”

Jayce’s eyes rolled. “Well she’s been flirting for months, you had whatever that romantic dancing shit was, clearly she regretted encouraging that date, then you had phone sex-”

“It wasn’t phone sex.” Caitlyn grumbled.

“Space comm sex, whatever. I’m just saying the signs are there. So stop being a gay mess and just communicate. That’s all you’ve been doing with her all this time.” The man chuckled incredulously. “You’d think you’d be good at it by now.”

Caitlyn crossed her arms, a stubborn pout to her lips. “You’re so annoying.”

He flashed a cheeky grin. “But you know I’m right.”

Yeah, he was. Jayce was far more familiar with the intricacies of romantic relationships than Caitlyn was, but she wasn’t a completely lost cause. She knew he was right, that the only path forward with Vi was to put all of her cards on the table. Consequences be damned, she had almost lost Vi today, it couldn’t get any worse than that.

After deciding she had been enough of a shitty host, Caitlyn made her and Jayce each a cup of tea. They sat for a while reminiscing and catching up on each other’s life and Caitlyn finally felt as though she could relax. Enough for a soft yawn to part her lips.

The alarm had sounded at about five in the morning, leaving Caitlyn with only about four hours of sleep behind her from the previous night. After much insistence from Jayce, she shuffled off to take a nap while leaving the man to do some work on his laptop. Caitlyn wasn’t sure she could sleep, not after everything that’s happened, but she was surprised to find an unavoidable heaviness to her eyelids as her cobalt hair settled across the silk pillows.

Her last thoughts before she completely lost consciousness were of Jayce, how grateful she was to have such an incredible and supportive friend. Of Vi’s family, how much she admired their strength and will as they watched their beloved daughter and sister put her life at risk for the sake of another.

And her very last thought was of Vi, how she ached to finally breathe life into those feelings she’d danced around for months. How she yearned to feel Vi’s touch and revel in the softness

of her lips, the warmth in her fingertips.

And how hopelessly and desperately in love she was with her astronaut.

Chapter End Notes

:)

Comments and Kudos much obliged <3

Stuck

Chapter Summary

> “I’ll wait for you.”

Chapter Notes

> Let’s go lesbians.
>
> First off I want to say thank you all so much for your love on the last chapter. I wasn’t expecting such positive feedback and I’m so touched this fic has become so special for a lot of you.
>
> Now, I think I’ve edged you all long enough.
>
> Playlist for this fic here.
>
> See ya <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Time Elapsed: 232 Days
Time Remaining: 133 Days

Caitlyn had slept for far longer than she had anticipated. It seemed the exhaustion from the prior evening's events had finally caught up on her. She napped for about four hours that day, awaking to a rather cheerful Jayce at her kitchen table with his laptop and work papers scattered throughout. After a long shower and a light scolding from her friend about the distinct lack of healthy foods in her fridge, the two went grocery shopping together, stopping by a quaint french cafe on the way home for some iced lattes and desserts.

Caitlyn knew it was all a distraction, an effort to encourage some normalcy after a traumatic event. Still, it had its intended effect of clearing her mind so she was grateful regardless.

That evening the two sat on her balcony each with a beer in hand, Caitlyn unable to keep her gaze away from the stars above. If Jayce noticed her quite literally staring off into space, he didn’t acknowledge it. Caitlyn was immensely grateful for him. Jayce knew her far too well, harboring a deep understanding after all these years for when Caitlyn needed a good distraction and when she needed to be left to her daydreams.

After providing her dear friend with a more suitable pillow that was not in the shape of a fruit and a warm blanket, he settled down on her green sofa and Caitlyn collapsed into bed once more. She was feeling both desperately eager but also devastatingly anxious to return to work tomorrow. Having the day to sit with her feelings toward Vi did nothing to quell the ache in her heart. Instead it remained like a flickering candle, fluttering around with a warmth and fragility that could either be cultivated, or smothered.

Caitlyn was grateful for a dreamless sleep that night, unsure if she'd be able to handle another subconscious vision like she had the previous night. She woke feeling sluggish and more nervous than she had been on her first day at the comm center, readying herself for the day with butterflies in her gut as she elected for her most comfortable khaki pantsuit with a simple white tank top underneath. She was surprised to find Jayce was gone when she emerged from her bedroom, a small note on the coffee table indicating he had elected to go to a nearby gym for a morning workout and would see her later.

The conversation with Jayce played on loop in Caitlyn's mind as she drove to work. He was right, she needed to come clean and simply communicate to Vi, but how? Dropping such a large bombshell of feeling such as love onto someone who you're stuck working with could be quite catastrophic if they don't feel the same. It could potentially be detrimental to their relationship and even make Vi uncomfortable for the remainder of their time on the expedition. Was Caitlyn prepared to risk that? Her own fear of rejection was one thing, but could she really put Vi in such a tough position?

Her hesitancy continued to plague her mind as she walked into the building, electing to grab a coffee from the break room before heading to her desk. She had her own coffee maker, yes, but there was something ritualistic and comforting about preparing her drink in the communal space. Besides, the break room had better creamer flavors in the fridge.

As Caitlyn finished up stirring her caffeine fix, she suddenly heard a soft sniffle come from somewhere to her left. She grabbed her coffee off the counter and tentatively stepped around the two vending machines, surprised to find Powder tucked into the small space between the far machine and the wall.

Powder was crying. Her colorful makeup smeared around her large eyes as she stared down at her black graffitied boots. Her legs were pulled tightly to her chest, an oversized sweater nearly swallowing her into a little ball of sadness.

She looked- well- she looked like someone who needed a big sister.

"Powder?"

Powder's tired eyes shifted up to meet Caitlyn's, thin fingers peeking out from her sweater sleeve to wipe some of the moisture from her face. She looked like she hadn't slept a wink since the incident, a broken softness to her voice making it rasp somehow more so than usual. "Oh, hey Caitlyn."

Caitlyn schooled a pained expression. Powder seemed so small at that moment. "Are you alright?"

Powder shrugged weakly.

Caitlyn didn't have any siblings aside from the forged bond she had with Jayce, but in that moment she knew she wanted to attempt to be that for Powder, regardless of her competence in such areas of expertise. "Can I join you?"

Powder sized her up for a moment, pulling her knees in tighter and simply offering Caitlyn a small nod.

Caitlyn dropped her brown leather satchel to the ground and pressed her back to the adjacent wall before sliding to the floor. She tucked her heels back beneath her and held the warm mug close to her chest, unsure of how to brooch this situation.

After a minute of comfortable quiet, Powder broke the silence. "You know, when Vi was approached by NASA for the ISS expeditions, she was going to turn them down."

To say Caitlyn was surprised would be an understatement. "What? Why? Wasn't it always her dream to be an astronaut?"

"Yeah, it was." Powder's posture relaxed slightly, her chin coming to rest atop her knees. "But I was… going through some real tough shit at the time and she didn't want to leave me behind. It took me weeks to convince her to go. I couldn't live with myself if she had stayed because of me, but she would have done it." She smiled fondly with an unmistakable sadness in her eyes. "That's just how Vi is, how she's always been. She'll give up her dream to take care of her family, just like she'll launch herself into space to save someone she cares about."

Caitlyn felt that all too familiar pang in her heart. She was suddenly reminded of what Vander had said on her first day, that there was no one in the universe with a bigger heart than Vi. She hadn't doubted it then, but to see it for yourself was truly something precious to behold.

"I suppose she's quite fearless when it comes to protecting her loved ones."

"Nah. She just likes to pretend she's not afraid." Powder stretched out her legs, some of the tension releasing from her limbs. "She knows we rely on her so she always puts up a strong front. The truth is that she's terrified but…nothing scares her more than the idea of losing us."

Caitlyn could recall a few moments where Vi had done just that. Vi always had an air of nonchalance, was always cracking jokes and comforting others where any sane person would have been scared or nervous. Caitlyn had to admit she always thought her astronaut fearless, but this new perspective was quite eye opening. "I never realized but… now that you mention it, a lot of things make sense. She's always comforting others before taking any time for herself. It's simultaneously admirable and… frustrating."

Powder chuckled softly. "Yeah, that's Vi for you. She's so… painfully self sacrificing. She'd live her entire life continuously giving up what she wants if she thinks it will make us happier."

Caitlyn found herself smiling, her head falling back with a soft thunk against the wall. “She truly is insufferable, but also quite incredible.”

The two sat in comfortable silence for a moment. Caitlyn wasn’t sure if she had helped much, but Powder wasn’t crying anymore so she counted that as a small victory.

“I… I never got to say thank you to you.”

Caitlyn blinked at her. “What ever for?”

Powder scoffed incredulously. “Caitlyn, they wouldn’t have made it without you. My family and I… we just kind of froze. We all felt helpless and terrified but you were so strong and determined. You completely locked in and took charge. You have no idea how grateful we are.”

“Oh.” Caitlyn was quite surprised to hear this. She hadn’t even considered the impact of her own actions that day, too focused on Vi and the fear of nearly losing her. “To be honest, I was terrified. I felt as though I couldn’t breathe, like someone had dropped the weight of the world on my chest, but…” She looked down the steam rising out of her coffee mug, lost in recovering the memories of how she felt that day. “It just didn’t matter. All I could think of was her. The comm center itself could have exploded and I don’t think anything would have uprooted me from that spot.”

They were quiet for a minute. Then Powder let out an amused laugh. “Sounds like the start to a bad joke. Two self-sacrificing lesbians walk into a bar. No wonder you two are so hopeless.”

Caitlyn frowned. Powder often spoke in riddles and references she just couldn’t comprehend. “What do you mean?”

“You're smart, you’ll figure it out.” Powder flashed a smug grin. “But listen, one of you has to be selfish first and I know my sister so I’m telling you right now, it ain’t gonna be her.”

Powder leapt up from her spot on the floor, tossing Caitlyn a wink and leaving Caitlyn completely bewildered once again as she headed toward the break room door.

“Oh, by the way.” She called over her shoulder. “Your friend is real nice. Nearly thought my brother was gonna faint when he walked in. Tell him thanks for the donuts.”

Caitlyn’s breath caught, her head whipping in the direction of the egregiously large pink box on the break room counter she had somehow missed when she came in. A new sense of panic flooded her system, resulting in her nearly spilling her coffee as she shot up from the ground and walked as fast as her heels would allow toward the door that led to the comms room.

She passed Mylo and Claggors desk, the two of them excitedly munching on their own sugary breakfast and furthering the impending feeling of doom Caitlyn felt. Claggor offered her a soft smile and a kind wave with his donut-free hand. If Caitlyn wasn’t so stressed she would have returned the gesture with much more enthusiasm but she couldn’t stop for even a moment.

Sure enough, a familiar laugh sounded from her cubicle as she approached and Caitlyn's heart felt as though it would fall right out of her chest.

"No it wasn't that bad. The worst was our junior year halloween party. You haven't seen anything until you've seen Caitlyn do a keg stand in a Hello Kitty costume- Oh, hey sprout."

Caitlyn sputtered, her cheeks flaming. "What on Earth do you think you're doing?" She hissed.

Jayce flashed a pleasant smile, feigning innocence. "I'm just getting acquainted with Vi here. Telling her all about our college days, nothing crazy." He paused for a moment as Vi said something into the headset. "No no, the keg stand thing was before she streaked the quad, that was senior year-"

Caitlyn was seconds away from committing a murder in a government sanctioned building. Instead, she smacked Jayce hard on the shoulder and motioned for him to get the hell out of her chair.

"Ow, easy there." He chuckled. "Well, it looks like I'm being kicked out. It was nice meeting you, Vi." Jayce slid off the headset and stood from the desk, grabbing his own cup of coffee and bringing it to his smug lips. "She seems nice."

"I cannot believe you." Caitlyn whispered, glancing around the room. "You know this is a huge security risk, right? You could get in so much trouble-"

"Relax, Cait. I got the chief's permission. Besides, if I wanted any of the information on these computers it wouldn't exactly be difficult to obtain it. Talis Industries did invent half of the tech in this room, after all."

Caitlyn rolled her eyes "Well your commitment to being a nuisance is admirable, I must say."

Jayce placed his hand over his heart. "You wound me, and after I nursed you back to health and brought everyone donuts out of the goodness of my heart. How could you?"

"Nursed me back to- my god do you ever tire of being absolutely intolerable?"

"Of course not, that's what brothers are for." He winked in Mylo's direction, who Caitlyn had only then realized was staring at Jayce with stars in his eyes before awkwardly busying himself with a stack of papers on his desk.

"You didn't-" Caitlyn glanced around, swallowing anxiously before turning back to her friend. "You didn't tell her anything about our conversation yesterday, did you?'

"No! No, of course not. I wouldn't do that." Caitlyn exhaled, the tension leaving her shoulders. "But I still think you should tell her."

Caitlyn folded her elbows and gripped at her forearms, fidgeting slightly. "I- I thought about it a lot."

"And?"

She sighed. “I don’t know, Jayce. There’s no telling if she feels the same and we still have four months left of working together on this expedition. I would be putting her in a very uncomfortable spot and… and she already misses her family so much. I can’t add myself to that stress.” She paused, crestfallen gaze falling to the walls of her cubicle. “I care about her too much to do that to her.”

A deep look of understanding overtook Jayce’s features. He sighed, eyeing the photo of Vi on Caitlyn’s desk. “Well, it’s your decision, Caitlyn. But you can’t hold it in forever.”

“I know.” Caitlyn leaned against the wall of her cubicle, pouting stubbornly at her conundrum.

Jayce offered her a smile and a comforting pat on the shoulder. He truly was a nuisance, but at least he was a supportive one.

“By the way, who’s the twink with the cane?”

Caitlyn couldn’t help but snort at Jayce’s bluntness. “That’s Viktor, he’s the capcom for the Russian astronauts.”

“He single?”

She thought for a moment. “No. I'm afraid he’s in a deeply committed entanglement with his work.”

“We’ll see about that.” Jayce straightened out his leather jacket and smoothed his hair back dramatically, making his way past Caitlyn in the direction of Viktor’s cubicle.

Caitlyn rolled her eyes. “You’re wasting your precious, arrogant breath.” She called after him.

“Oh but you know I can be so persuasive.” He called back to her with a wink.

She watched with kindhearted amusement as Jayce crossed his arms over the wall of Viktor’s space. Caitlyn couldn’t hear their conversation, but she could see the seemingly confused and almost annoyed quirk to Viktor’s brow as the two conversed. Poor Viktor, he had no idea what he was getting himself into.

Caitlyn steadied herself with a deep breath before sliding out her rolling chair and taking the spot Jayce had commandeered prior. She picked up her headset and made for the green talk button-

Only to see that it was already lit.

Caitlyn’s breath caught, her heart doing somersaults in her chest. Jayce didn’t correctly turn off the headset before his conversation with Caitlyn. If there’s anything she had learned over the months of working here, it was that this microphone picked up quite a bit. Which means Vi most likely heard their conversation.

She felt a drastic spike of anxiety that sent her heart into a frenzy. She needed to check, needed to make sure Vi hadn't heard anything but, fuck, she was so goddamn scared.

"Vi?" She let out softly once she mustered the courage to don the headset once more.

"Hey, Cupcake." Vi's voice was casual, seemingly unaffected. Maybe she hadn't…

"Did you hear something?" She had to ask. She had to. The uncomfortable thrum of her heart against her ribcage was simply too powerful to ignore. Consequences be damned. She didn't say anything specific, she could write it off as something else if she had to.

"Oh, I heard something alright."

Caitlyn sucked in a breath. A myriad of curses swirling around in her mind. She desperately sputtered to come up with an excuse. Something to explain away her conversation with Jayce. Anything at all.

Her brain fizzled out. She came up with nothing. "What-" Caitlyn cleared her throat awkwardly, her heart pounding and thighs squeezed together in tense anticipation. "What did you hear?"

There was an unmistakable smirk in Vi's voice. "I heard you shotgunned a beer on top of a canoe in the middle of the Cam river."

Caitlyn's heart was far too fragile for the day she was having.

"Oh." She collapsed back into her chair, completely overwhelmed with the relief to the point she sounded absolutely winded. "Yes, well. I suppose that did happen."

Vi paused and Caitlyn bit her lip nervously. She probably should have played that off better, sounded less obvious in her relief. Vi's voice was hesitant as she spoke "Should I have heard something else?"

It was an opening, a good opportunity to come clean, but Caitlyn just couldn't do it. Not directly anyway. "Is there something you *want* to hear?"

The two were always in a practical dance with their words, swerving around one another in an effort not to be the first to break. It was exhausting and Caitlyn thought it cowardly on her part, but she simply did not have the proverbial balls to admit to anything just yet.

"No." Vi said eventually, her tone sounding distant, avoidant. "There isn't."

Caitlyn could feel something was deeply off. She could lie to herself and say it was most likely the result of the rather eventful last few days they had together, but no. Vi was holding something back, just as Caitlyn was. The two were at a draw, neither wanting to be the first to whip their pistol out.

If there was one thing Vi was better at than Caitlyn though, it was schooling her voice into one of nonchalance and changing the subject.

“So, Hello Kitty, huh?”

Jayce Talis was a dead man.

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The day passed relatively uneventfully and even somewhat relaxed. As much as it pained her to admit it, Caitlyn felt as though Jayce’s presence had a somewhat refreshing effect on the atmosphere. He stayed until lunch, casually conversing with a few of Caitlyn’s coworkers, entertaining some of Powder’s silly ideas for useless inventions, and giving a euphoric Mylo an autograph on the polaroid photo Powder had taken of the two that morning.

Caitlyn was settled down in her cubicle with an open lunch box she had packed from home, watching in utter shock as Jayce returned to Viktor’s cubicle and the two exited the comms room together. Jayce winked at Caitlyn as he went, earning him an eye roll in response. Okay, so the two were going on a lunch date. Not entirely unexpected. Jayce was smooth and incredibly handsome after all.

What was completely unexpected was Viktor returning about an hour later, his clothing and hair mused with unmistakable bruises littering his neck.

Unbelievable.

There were a plethora of maintenance tasks to complete since the satellite incident, keeping Caitlyn and Vi plenty busy as the day went on. The ISS crew needed to check through every single system, make tons of necessary repairs, and each perform psych evals to ensure they were in their right minds after such an experience.

A psychiatrist had been brought in and ushered to each of the capcom’s stations at varying time intervals throughout the day. Caitlyn had just returned to her cubicle after Vi’s evaluation was complete. She obviously wouldn’t pry, they were deeply personal and confidential sessions after all, but Caitlyn couldn’t help but be curious how Vi handled therapy given her usual reluctance to prioritize her own feelings.

“How did it go?” She asked Vi, sipping at a fresh cup of coffee.

There was a beat with some soft shuffling, probably Vi offering a shrug. “Fine, I guess. I don’t really do well with shrinks. They pry too much, always looking for a deeper rooted issue in everything. I don’t like opening up to strangers. If I need to talk I usually just go to Powder or my dad.”

Caitlyn hummed in thought. She guessed this would be the case. “You, um… you can always talk to me too, if you need.” Vi didn’t say anything for a moment and Caitlyn rushed to clarify. “You obviously don’t have to if you don’t want to but… I just want you to know I’m here for you.”

Vi sighed, Caitlyn could hear a soft smile in her voice. “Yeah, I know. Thanks, cupcake.”

Caitlyn smiled momentarily. This was a good chance, a good opening to bring up what had been nagging at her heart the past two days. “Um, speaking of talking.” Caitlyn could hear Vi suck in a breath. “Can we? About… what happened between us?”

“Yeah, um.” There was suddenly a lot of movement and static, some frantic tinkering over the line. “Later, yeah? We got a shit ton of tasks to take care of so it’s just not a really good time…”

“Oh.” Caitlyn’s heart fell in disappointment, but she understood. Or at least, she pretended to. “Yes, of course. Later, then.”

“Can you bring up the instructions for fixing the water orbital replacement unit?”

“Yes… one moment.” She tried desperately to keep her disheartened tone at bay. It wasn’t personal. Vi was right, they had a plethora of tasks to complete. This was the priority. It made sense.

They would talk later.

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Time Elapsed: 237 Days
Time Remaining: 128 Days

Okay, maybe it was personal. Later came, and later went, and the two still had not talked about that night. Vi said they would talk about it and yet every time Caitlyn would attempt to broach the subject, her astronaut would run through an obstacle course of excuses to get out of it.

“Shoot, sorry, I completely forgot I’m on housekeeping duty today so I got a lot of cleaning to do. Rain check?”

Or-

“We have a meeting with the crew actually so it’ll have to wait until later.” That time Caitlyn could actually hear Ekko in the back say “We have a meeting?”

Or, her personal favorite-

The one time she swore Vi intentionally moved to an area of the ship where reception was shit. Her voice crackling in and out with another excuse. “Sor- bad -ception. Ta- later.” It was unbearably cliche.

It was becoming glaringly obvious that Vi was avoiding her. To say Caitlyn was frustrated would be an understatement. In fact, she was becoming increasingly more annoyed as the days went on. Eventually she just gave up on asking, tired of Vi's constant avoidant tactics and just missing their old conversations. Still, Caitlyn couldn't lie to herself and say she wasn't deeply hurt by this turn of events.

It reminded Caitlyn a bit of herself during her college days. The stubbornness, the avoidance. It was infuriating. How had anyone dealt with her back then?

Jayce had left a few days prior and she didn't want to burden him with more of her lesbian woes. Instead she elected for someone who had a fair amount of experience with this sort of stubborn evasion.

"Ah, Caitlyn." Cassandra greeted over the phone, Caitlyn could hear a smile in her voice. "To what do I owe the pleasure darling?"

Caitlyn stood from her couch, weaving around her coffee table with a hand on her hip and a quite focused posture. "I need your advice, mother."

"Well, this is quite an unexpected development." She wasn't wrong, Caitlyn rarely went to her mother for any sort of advice. Yet she was becoming absolutely desperate as the days dragged on. "You're usually so headstrong and independent."

"Yes, well. I find myself in a bit of an… enigma."

Her mother hummed thoughtfully. "I see. I'll advise you to the best of my abilities, dear. Go on."

Caitlyn didn't want to delve into the intricacies of her relationship with Vi. Instead she chose a more broad approach to her inquiry. "How do you get someone to stop avoiding you? To get them to finally sit down and just *talk* to you?"

There was surprise in Cassandra's response. "Well, I suppose it depends but typically I've found the best solution is to use your wits."

Caitlyn frowned. "How do you mean?"

"Fabricate a scenario in which they have no choice but to hear you out. Lay out a trap, if you will."

Caitlyn began to pace her living room, gnawing on her lower lip in thought. It honestly wasn't a bad suggestion although slightly more malicious sounding than Caitlyn would have liked. She didn't necessarily want to trap Vi or back her into a corner, but at this point it may be her only option. This wasn't just about Vi's feelings, she had her own to consider as well and she truly believed she deserved answers.

But how the hell was she going to set a trap for someone orbiting two hundred and fifty miles above her? She had to figure something out. It had to be possible.

“That’s not a bad idea. Thank you, mother.” Caitlyn smiled, feeling an unexpected hopefulness and gratitude. Perhaps she should consult her mother more often. The woman was a politician, after all. If there was one thing she knew, it was how to navigate people.

“You're quite welcome, darling.” Cassandra paused. “Do I get to know what this is in regards to?”

Ah. Caitlyn sighed. “I don’t particularly want to go into too much detail at the moment but… let’s just say there’s someone very special to me who is, to put it bluntly, driving me up a goddamn wall at the present juncture.”

Her mother actually laughed at that. “So that’s why you came to me, because of my experience in corralling stubborn girls into opening up?” There was a knowing hint to Cassandra’s tone. She was obviously referring to Caitlyn and her own past tactics of elusion.

Caitlyn pursed her lips to hold back a smile. “I’m sure I don’t know what you’re talking about, mother.”

“Very well, darling. I won’t pry. But I will say this-” Caitlyn stopped pacing, her curiosity peaked. “Stubbornness and evasion from a loved one can often come from a place of harboring a desire to not be burdensome, more so than a place of malice. My advice still stands, if you feel you are deserving of the truth then that’s your right to seek it out, but do so with pure intentions. Try to understand their reasoning and not hold it against them, yes?”

Yeah, Caitlyn would definitely need to come to her mother for advice more often. Mother’s intuition was truly something else. This conversation reminded her a bit of the one she had with Vander. They seemed to understand the heart of the issue going purely off of what they knew about their daughters. It was a bit heart warming to say the least.

“Thank you.” Caitlyn smiled to herself, feeling seen and understood in her frustrations with a new sense of determination. “This has been wonderfully helpful. I appreciate it, mum.”

Cassandra hummed light heartedly, a pleasant smile laced into her words. “Anytime, Caity.”

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Time Elapsed: 238 Days
Time Remaining: 127 Days

Caitlyn had spent nearly the entirety of her workday desperately trying to come up with a plan, an idea, something to get Vi in her clutches. She came up with absolutely nothing, becoming increasingly uneasy as the day progressed.

“See ya Caitlyn!” Mylo called out to her. She glanced up and waved at the two brothers as they made their way out. The entire family was leaving early for the day to attend a showcase at Powder’s lab. Leaving just Caitlyn and Viktor to finish up their tasks for the day.

Viktor finished around three o’clock, ever the efficient worker, and nodded to Caitlyn in acknowledgement before making his way out of the comm center. Most likely headed to the library for some additional research. Either way, Caitlyn was left alone with Vi.

It was the perfect opportunity to take action, to do something, and yet she still had no plan.

“Alright, I swapped out all the batteries and finished recalibrating the scales. Anything else on the schedule today?”

“Let me check.” Caitlyn pulled up the schedule on her monitor. They had pretty much finished everything. She could probably find something for Vi to do, but there wasn’t anything necessarily urgent-

Caitlyn's fingers froze against her keyboard, her heart suddenly pounding with the resurgence of an idea that had popped into her head. She wasn’t sure how she didn’t think of it sooner. It was the perfect situation she could manifest, exactly what she needed to finally break through Vi’s walls.

“Caitlyn?”

“Yes. There is one thing.” Caitlyn wasn’t a good liar, but she would be damned if she fucked this up now.

“Oh, really? Alright, what is it?”

Caitlyn sucked in a breath. “The moon rock cement experiment.”

Vi groaned from the other end. “Again? Can’t we skip that one?”

“I’m afraid not. There’s an abundance of maintenance tasks scheduled for this week so today is the only day we will have to do it.” Caitlyn was probably speaking too fast. Shit, she needed to keep it together.

“Great.” Vi grumbled, her voice picking up static as she moved along the space station. Caitlyn chewed on her lower lip to avoid giving herself away. Her heart began to beat faster and faster, her leg twitching up and down anxiously below the desk. The stoic facade was fading fast, but she had waited far too long to cave to her anxieties now.

“Give me just a second and I’ll get everything set up.” Vi said, Caitlyn could hear rustling in the background. It seemed Vi didn’t even bother to question whether or not Caitlyn was telling the truth about their schedule. A pang of guilt hit Caitlyn in the gut, she didn’t want to break Vi’s trust and she’d apologize for it later, but frankly her astronaut hadn’t given her much choice at this point.

“We trying a different ratio?”

“Um.” Shit. “Yes, we will do a five to three ratio this time instead.”

“Awesome, so it’s going to be even messier.” Caitlyn bit back a guilty smile. She knew Vi hated this experiment, she would *absolutely* apologize for this betrayal later.

Vi finished concocting her mixture of cement and began the messy process of mixing it. Caitlyn had intentionally chosen a ratio in which it would take Vi much longer to get the muddy substance to its desired texture and viscosity. Vi wouldn’t be able to stop mixing once she began or she’d risk compromising the test, giving Caitlyn plenty of time for their discussion.

“Back in the goop.” Vi laughed nervously, the sound of her gloves shuffling as she mixed.

Caitlyn closed her eyes and breathed in deep. This was it. No more dancing around one another, no more dodging the topic or skating around her feelings.

A swift kick out the door.

“Caitlyn?”

“Why do you keep avoiding talking about that night?”

Vi paused, quiet for a good long moment until Caitlyn could hear a soft curse under her breath. It must have dawned on the astronaut that she was stuck. Caitlyn waited patiently despite the erratic flutter of her heartbeat. There was nowhere for Vi to run off to. No excuse she could make. Heck, she couldn’t even turn off her headset. She was well and truly backed into a corner.

The astronaut took a deep breath before finally uttering her chosen words. “I’m not… I’m not avoiding it.”

“You are.” Caitlyn was firm, steadfast in her need to finally figure out what this was. What they were. “Every time I try to bring it up, you either change the subject or go offline.”

Vi sighed. “Caitlyn-”

“I just want to know why. It’s- shit- it’s driving me insane, Violet. I’m so tired of it.” Caitlyn could feel the familiar sting of tears behind her eyes. Her well controlled mask had been completely shed, unable to keep the well of emotions in any longer. It all spilled out of her completely unabashed. “You- you flirted with me for months and we had that moment during the space walk and I thought we were *going* somewhere. But then you encouraged me to go on that date and you acted so damn strange afterwards. Then you continued to flirt with me and we had that night together but now you won’t even speak to me about it and I can’t do it anymore. You are sending me so many mixed signals and I am so *tired.*”

Things were eerily quiet for a moment as they both absorbed everything that Caitlyn had said. She truly didn’t mean to explode, but she just couldn’t take it anymore. So there it was, her heart laid completely bare for Vi.

She focused in on the unsteady pull of her breath while she waited. It was probably too much, had come out too fast all at once. The longer the silence stretched, the more Caitlyn began to panic in anticipation for Vi's response.

Suddenly, there was a soft thud over the microphone, most likely Vi pressing her forehead against the plastic dome that held the stationary gloves she was stuck in. Her voice sounded strained, pleading as she finally spoke. "Fuck… I- I'm so sorry, Caitlyn. When you lay it all out like that… shit, that's so bad. I didn't mean to send you mixed signals. You have to believe me."

Caitlyn did. Her feelings for Vi were more than just infatuation, there was a deep rooted trust there. She didn't doubt the genuineness behind Vi's words for even a second, and yet there were still so many unanswered questions.

"Then why?" Caitlyn hated how broken she sounded. Based on the sharp intake of Vi's breath, she could only assume her astronaut felt the same. "Why did you tell me to go on that date? Why did you contact me that night? Was it just a one off? Do you…"

Vi's voice was so gentle, heartbreakingly so. "Do I what?"

Caitlyn wrapped her arms around herself, suddenly drenched in a feeling of scared vulnerability. "Do you not want me?"

To Caitlyn's utter shock, Violet actually let out a breathless laugh. The sound was almost hysterical, incredulous with disbelief. The astronaut steadied herself with a shaky sigh as her laughter died down, her tone becoming one of complete surrender.

"Caitlyn… I've wanted you since the first second I heard your voice."

Caitlyn's heart dropped into her gut. That was not what she had expected to hear. "What…?"

"Fuck, you're kidding, right? You really couldn't tell?" Caitlyn had never heard such raw honesty in Vi's voice before. She'd give anything to see Vi's face right now, to piece together the desperation in her astronaut's tone with whatever expression she was making. "You think I did all of that just to mess with you? I know I've been stupid but god- how could I *not* want you, Caitlyn?"

"Then explain it to me." Vi made a pained noise but Caitlyn was finally getting the honesty she craved and was not about to let it slip away. "Talk to me. Tell me why-"

"Because I was trying not to be *selfish,* Cait. Fuck-" Vi's voice was taut with frustration, Caitlyn was on the edge of her seat, eyes blown wide in shock. "I've wanted you so badly all this time. It's all I could ever think about, it *consumed* me, but I'm over two hundred miles away from you and I just couldn't *ask* that of you."

Caitlyn couldn't breathe, couldn't think. Her mind was running a million miles an hour to try and catch up with what Vi was saying. Vi didn't wait for her to recover before she continued, her voice just as strained but a bit softer.

“That night after the space walk, when you said you’d wait for me- I just panicked. I panicked because that’s exactly what I wanted to hear. You have no idea what that did to me. I was so happy but I felt so goddamn guilty because I knew it was wrong of me to want that. I’ve never wanted something so selfish in all my life.

“Then you mentioned that date and… I don’t know I just couldn’t forgive myself if you didn’t find happiness because of me. I regretted so much telling you to go, it tore me apart. When I heard it didn’t go well I- I felt so damn relieved and *that* made me feel like shit because that’s just not fair to you.”

Caitlyn sat in complete bewilderment as Vi unloaded months of feelings onto her. Her butterflies danced around fiercely in her gut, unable to process anything, unable to think past the sound of Vi’s pleading confession.

“That night…” Vi continued. Caitlyn sucked in a breath. “I was so frustrated and so pent up and you were all I could think about. God, I was going out of my mind with how badly I wanted you and so I…I gave in. Then I heard your conversation with Jayce-“

Caitlyn finally found her voice, albeit small. “You did hear that…”

“Yeah.” Vi swallowed, her voice sounding hoarse from her practical monologue of pent up emotions. “I did, and it made me realize how damn selfless you are. It killed me, knowing that you would sacrifice what you wanted for my wellbeing but here I was in my self absorbed fantasy of wanting you to wait for me.”

She took a moment to breathe, her voice so fragile and almost broken, soliciting a deep ache in Caitlyn’s heart. “How could I possibly ask that of you when you have been so good to me?”

It took Caitlyn a good long minute to take it all in. Every piece fit together so perfectly, every mind-boggling statement Powder had made suddenly crystal clear. Vi had reciprocated Caitlyn’s feelings all this time, maybe even moreso, but she felt she couldn’t pursue them out of a self righteous determination to be selfless. It made logical sense, Vi’s hesitation and self-preservation stemming from a desire to not selfishly hold Caitlyn back, but it seemed she hadn’t even considered the fact that Caitlyn never felt that way. Caitlyn had never once considered her feelings or the prospect of waiting for Vi to be a burden. Not even for a second.

There was so much she wanted to say, so many desperate pleas swimming around in her heart, and yet all she could think to utter was, “You are so… unbelievably stupid.”

Vi sighed, not an ounce of fight in her. “Yeah, I know.”

“God, for someone so smart you are so *stupid,* Violet.” She finally well and truly understood what Powder had told her weeks back. How could Vi have possibly not realized- “I’ve *been* waiting for you. All this time. You didn’t have to ask because I already was. I still am.”

“You shouldn’t be.” There was a wobbliness to Vi’s voice, like she was shaking her head. “You should be getting out there and living your life and finding real happiness, Caitlyn.”

“My real happiness is with you! Have you ever considered that? You think yourself such a burden to me but you’re *wrong.* Do you honestly think a few measly months is such a big deal?”

“Well what about the two months of recovery when I get back?” A new sort of strength returned to Vi’s voice, a forlorn sort of frustration. “What about when I need to come back up here for another year? Then another six months. Then eight. You still gonna wait for me then?”

“Yes!” There wasn’t a second of hesitation in Caitlyn’s reply. “I would!”

“Cait, that’s insane.”

“I don’t care. I would wait years for you if I had to. You’re worth every second.”

“You’re so damn stubborn.” Vi groaned, but she was losing steam. Caitlyn could tell she was getting through the tough exterior, peeling back Vi’s layers to a point of submission. “Why couldn’t you just make space puns and recap TV shows? Why did you have to be so fucking perfect and make me fall so completely hard for you?”

Caitlyn’s heart nearly doubled in speed. There it was, the last piece she needed to solidify her resolve. “You- you’ve fallen for me?”

A long beat of silence. Then, “How could I not have?” There was a sudden fondness in Vi’s voice, maybe even a soft smile. “You’re everything, Caitlyn. Shit, I’m in fucking outer space with the greatest view ever known to man and I would give it up in a heartbeat just to see you instead.”

As romantic as that was and as much as Caitlyn wanted to dwell on it, she needed Vi to know- “I would never ask you to do that.”

“I know and that’s the problem. God, you’re just like Powder. I’ll come home and fall even harder for you and then when it’s time for me to leave again, you’ll just let me go even if it tears you apart.” The tension was building again, Vi’s words cutting deeper than a knife. “Do you really want to live that way? What will you have left if you waste your life away just sitting around waiting?”

“I’ll have *you,* Violet.” The tears finally welled up and overflowed steadily down Caitlyn’s cheeks. She didn’t have the energy to keep them in any longer. She’d pour all of it out for Vi, every ounce of her soul and beat of her heart. “I-I never knew what I wanted out of life before you. When I was a child and I discovered just how vast the universe was and just how small we are in comparison, I thought that nothing mattered. That there couldn’t possibly be anything consequential enough to happen in my life for me to care. Then I met you and I realized that the only thing that can transcend the magnitude of our universe for me is how I feel about you.”

A long bout of stretched silence lingered between them while Caitlyn’s words soaked in. That was it. Her entire bleeding heart now in Vi’s grasp. She had no more cards left to play, it was all on the table left for Vi to decide what to do with. Caitlyn felt an overwhelming amount of

relief having finally gotten it all out. She had finally freed herself from the prison of her desires and she'd be damned if she'd let something as silly as Vi's self sacrificing nature force her back into it.

Vi's voice was so quiet, disbelieving almost once she found her words once more. "I mean that much to you?"

It was Caitlyn's turn to laugh, a soft breathy sound of genuine elation and bewilderment. "You mean everything to me." It wasn't enough. There just simply weren't words to fully encapsulate just how much Vi really meant to her, but it was something.

There was a shaky exhale over the line, a tentativeness in her astronaut's tone. "We've never even met in person."

Caitlyn smiled, finally glancing toward the picture of Vi on her desk and wrapping her arms around herself tightly. "Does that really matter to you?"

"No." Vi didn't miss a beat, firm in her stance. "It doesn't."

The two sat still for a moment, listening to one another's breath while a deep sense of acceptance draped over them like a warm blanket. There was an unspoken mutual understanding between them, the flickering candle within Caitlyn's heart glowing brighter and brighter with the cultivation of their feelings having finally been acknowledged.

"So what now?" Vi asked tentatively.

Caitlyn smiled to herself. "Well, now that I know you feel the same, I'm afraid you're stuck with me."

"I guess that doesn't sound too bad." Vi chuckled softly. Caitlyn felt a new sense of calm wash over her, sensing that there was truly no more fight left in Vi. "You're sure this is what you want?"

"I've never been more sure of anything in my life."

Vi let out a sigh of surrender. "Okay."

"Okay?"

"Yeah." There was a smile in Vi's voice, but still a hint of remorse. "I'm so sorry, cupcake. For everything. I was so shitty to you and you didn't deserve that. I'll make it up to you, I promise."

Caitlyn shook her head, knowing Vi couldn't see it but pouring every ounce of genuine care into her words as possible. "You already have."

Vi scoffed. "You gonna let me off that easy?"

"Well… I sort of owe it to you for trapping you into confessing."

“Huh? What do you-” Vi paused, then let out a deep groan. “This experiment wasn’t on the schedule at all, was it?”

Caitlyn bit her lip, fighting back a sly smile. “I’m afraid not.”

“You sneaky little-” There was a shuffling sound, most likely Vi pulling her gloved hands out of the cement mixture and shedding them.

Caitlyn’s palms gripped the back of her neck anxiously. “I’m sorry, I couldn’t think of any other way to get you to stop avoiding me.”

Vi laughed and Caitlyn could almost hear the eye roll from down on Earth. “Yeah, well. Can’t even be mad about that. It was a good play. I probably deserved it.”

Caitlyn frowned. “Don’t say that.”

“Sorry. I’m just… I’m a bit angry with myself for being so stupid.” Caitlyn ached to hold Vi at that moment, to kiss away her insecurity. “You’re not angry with me?”

“No.” She really wasn’t. How could she be when Vi had finally reciprocated the feelings she’d cultivated all these months? “You’re absolutely insufferable as always, but I’m not angry with you. I just feel… relieved. And so very happy.”

“Yeah?” Vi seemed to be moving elsewhere in the station. Caitlyn wondered if she was heading somewhere to gaze down at the Earth as she often did toward the stars. “Me too.”

“Really?”

“Yeah I’m- shit, I’m so happy.” Vi laughed softly to herself, Caitlyn couldn’t help but smile, new tears of joy brimming in her cerulean hues. “It feels like this crushing weight that’s been on me for months is finally lifted. I like you so fucking much Caitlyn.”

“Likewise.” The butterflies kicked around voraciously in Caitlyn’s gut. She couldn’t believe this was finally her reality, that her months of hopeless pining had paid off. Her cheeks ached from smiling, a pleasant warmth blooming in her chest that had wiped away nearly all of the stress from the last week. “Promise me something?”

“Anything.”

“No more of this self-sacrificing nobility. I won’t stand for it anymore. Your wants are important too. If you want something, tell me.”

Vi hummed in thought for a moment. “You’ll regret asking that. I may get greedy. There’s a lot that I want.”

Caitlyn blinked curiously. “Like what?”

“I want to kiss you breathless.” Caitlyn felt that familiar blush creep up on her skin. She pulled her legs up onto her chair, hugging her knees and hiding her flaming cheeks in them as Vi continued. “Want to stroke my fingers through your hair, spend hours running my hands

up your sides. Want to take you to my favorite diner, stargaze with you, make love to you on every damn surface available."

"Oh my god." Caitlyn pressed her forehead into her knees with a shy giggle. She was so unbelievably giddy. Never before have words had this profound of an effect on her. Vi was the astronaut but Caitlyn was absolutely over the moon.

There was a teasing smile in Vi's voice. "I told you there was a lot. That doesn't even begin to cover it."

"Well… I look forward to all of it." A thought suddenly occurred to her, an insecurity nagging at the back of her mind. "Vi?"

"Yeah baby?"

Caitlyn was going to die of heart palpitations.

"Does it bother you… that you don't know what I look like?"

Vi hesitated for a second. "No. Not really. I mean, obviously it's killing me to know, but it wouldn't change how I feel."

"Hm. What if I'm actually three ducks in a trench coat?"

Vi burst into hysterics. Caitlyn giggled to herself. It was a bad joke, but if Vi was going to laugh like this at all of her bad jokes then she certainly wouldn't complain.

"Well then lucky for me because then I'd have three of you." Caitlyn rolled her eyes. How ridiculous this line of thinking was. "But, seriously, Cait. It doesn't matter to me what you look like. I'll feel the same regardless."

Caitlyn was practically wiggling in her seat with elation. Vi wanted her. Vi had fallen for her. They were- well technically not together but they were something.

And they would be more when Vi got back.

"So you'll really do it then?"

Caitlyn blinked, having been lost in her love struck daydreams for a moment. "Do what?"

Vi hesitated and Caitlyn knew. She knew what it was Vi wanted to ask, what she had been holding back asking all this time. So she waited with baited breath.

There was so much tenderness in Vi's voice. It was as if Caitlyn could feel the warmth of Vi's fingertips caressing her cheek. "You'll wait for me?"

And suddenly Caitlyn was crying softly, overflowing with just how desperately she longed to hold Vi in her arms, to kiss her lips and revel in what they had, what they finally made real after all this time.

“Yes, Violet.” She whispered, smiling and hugging her clasped hands to her chest, knowing one day she would be able to hold Vi there instead. To utter her words of love and feel the warmth of her astronaut’s touch. Now cherishing the longing that had once plagued her heart.

“I’ll wait for you.”

Chapter End Notes

Who's ready for them to meet?

Comments and Kudos much obliged <3

Brace for Impact

Chapter Summary

> “I’m on my way, baby.”

Chapter Notes

> Heya. Keen-eyed readers may have noticed that this fic sort of exploded in the last few days thanks to twitter. I’ve honestly been in a perpetual state of shock for the last two days. I can’t even begin to express my gratitude for the love and support this work is getting, it means more to me than I can put into words.
>
> I can’t reply to every comment but I want you all to know that I see every one of them and they each make my heart soar. Truly thank you so much.
>
> I’ve seen a couple people say that this fic is one of their favorites even though it isn’t completed. This sentiment is absolutely insane to me. Thank you so much for trusting me to stick the landing with this work, I truly appreciate it.
>
> Speaking of landing…
>
> Playlist for this fic here.
>
> See ya. <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Time Elapsed: 348 Days
Time Remaining: 17 Days

Powder had gone overboard, as per usual.

The entire break room was covered in frilly graffitied hearts, strung together with lace and ribbons across every possible surface. There was a pink gingham table cloth spread over the round table in the corner with a wide variety of sweet pink treats on display. The floor was littered with heart shaped confetti and if Caitlyn were to squint hard enough, she thought she could make out some dick shaped ones mixed among the shiny scraps of paper. Caitlyn loved Holiday decor as much as the next lesbian, but even she had to admit this was a bit much.

“No but hear me out.” Powder gesticulated enthusiastically while munching on a pink frosted sugar cookie as she walked alongside Caitlyn from the break room to her cubicle. “A remote controlled vibrator-”

“I believe those already exist, Powder.”

Powder smirked. “That can be controlled from *space.*”

Caitlyn nearly choked on her coffee. She had long since gotten used to Powder’s astounding lack of a filter. The two sisters were a lot alike in that regard. Although Vi was slightly less vulgar, if you could believe it. Caitlyn had grown quite close to Powder since the satellite incident, the two bonding in their shared heartache of having their romantic partner drifting among the stars. Yet sometimes, she truly did surprise Caitlyn with her… creativity.

“How on Earth would you manage something like that?”

“Oh, I could do it. Some signal boosters, big ass antenna-”

“That would probably make insertion rather uncomfortable.”

Powder practically collapsed into a fit of laughter, her lithe body falling dramatically overtop of Mylo as they passed the brother’s shared desk, knocking him out of his swivel chair and scattering papers everywhere. Caitlyn bit her lower lip to suppress a smile, sipping at her coffee innocently while pretending not to notice the chaos erupting in her wake.

As she settled into her cubicle, Caitlyn began the day like she always did, by picking up her red gel pen and crossing out the previous day on her desk calendar. She took a moment to stare at the page half marked with red X’s, failing to douse the excited flame flickering around in her gut.

Vi would be home in seventeen days.

Well, not entirely home, but back on Earth nonetheless. Caitlyn tried not to be disappointed at the prospect of Vi needing to remain in Florida for a few weeks to go through physical recovery. She was well aware of the imperative necessity of such a task. Being in zero gravity for a year tends to have a rather harsh impact on the body. Vi most likely wouldn’t even be able to walk properly for a week or two. Caitlyn knew, but it felt almost like a tease, knowing how much closer Vi would be and yet still out of her grasp.

Well, she had waited this long already. What’s a few weeks more?

Caitlyn sat in her rolling chair and pulled it toward the desk. She took a moment to admire the various photos that had accumulated there. Powder had lovingly gifted her two more of Vi. One was an action still of Vi in boxing gear as she trained with a hanging sandbag. The other an adorable image of Vi’s annoyed face having been assaulted with flour and frosting while her and Powder had been baking a cake for Vander’s birthday years prior. The last two photos were ones Caitlyn had added herself including a picture of her and Jayce from university, and a polaroid of her and Powder holding up bunny ears to one another’s heads.

Her cubicle had truly become her home away from home, and Caitlyn found she didn't mind one bit.

"ISS do you copy?" She said cheerfully after slipping on her headset.

Vi's voice was laced with mirth as she responded. "That depends on how you answer my question."

Caitlyn's brow quirked, intrigued but feeling an astounding sense of deja vu. "Sorry to disappoint you, but to no one's surprise I'm wearing the appropriate work attire of slacks and a button-up blouse."

Over the months Caitlyn had gotten very good at discerning Vi's actions even when she wasn't speaking. She could tell by the soft scoff over the line that Vi was rolling her eyes fondly. "That's not what I was going to ask. Plus, it doesn't matter much to me anymore."

Caitlyn blinked. "Oh?"

"Yeah, why would it matter what you're wearing when it's just going to end up on my bedroom floor anyway?"

Well, that was one thing that hadn't changed. Even after all this time together, Vi's shameless flirting left Caitlyn completely bewildered and blushing like a love sick fool.

"Just ask your damn question, Violet." Caitlyn grumbled over the rim of her coffee mug, ignoring the smug laughter over the other end of the line.

Vi cleared her throat dramatically. Caitlyn had to admit she was becoming more intrigued as their conversation progressed.

"Caitlyn Kiramman, will you be my valentine?"

Caitlyn's jaw ached from her desperate attempt to hold in a smile. She carefully put down the caffeine buzz and buried her burning face in her palms. "You are so corny."

"Is that a no? Because I can stay in space for a few more months-"

Caitlyn's head snapped up. "No! I mean, yes." Vi chuckled softly. Caitlyn shook the bewilderment from her head and straightened out her posture, attempting to play it cool. "Yes, of course I will be your valentine."

"Good girl."

Caitlyn had to hold back a panicked wheeze. God, if this is what Vi was like over comms she couldn't even begin to imagine in person-

"I've um-" She cleared her throat, tampering down the very much not workplace appropriate feeling stirring in her gut. "I've never been asked that before."

Vi paused. "Now that's just a damn crime. Anyone should be begging to be your valentine."

“It’s alright.” Caitlyn shrugged. “I’ve never wanted to be anyone’s until now.”

“Lucky me, then. I get you all to myself.” There was something possessive and suggestive in Vi’s tone. Caitlyn nibbled at her lower lip, feeling as though the room was suddenly getting hotter.

“I think I might like that.” She mumbled shyly.

There was a soft thump over the line. Vi had a habit of lightly punching her fist into a nearby surface when she was frustrated. “Fuck. You have no idea the things I want to do to you right now.”

Yes the room was definitely getting hotter. “Tell me, then.”

Vi scoffed. “You may not like it.”

“Try me.”

“Wanna bring you up here and pin you against this window.” Caitlyn sucked in a breath. “Tear open your shirt and press you up against the glass. Slip my fingers inside you and make you cum like that, staring down at the Earth. Show everyone what they can’t have…”

Caitlyn whined and squeezed her legs together, rubbing her thighs against one another to get any sort of friction where she was growing wetter by the second. “My god, Violet.”

“You’d like that?”

Caitlyn glanced around to make sure no one was within ear shot. “Yes… I’d love it. I’d love for you to touch me like that. To show the world who I belong to.”

Vi groaned. “Shit this is driving me crazy.”

Caitlyn closed her eyes and breathed out slow, trying and failing to temper the growing ache between her legs. “Yes, the feeling is mutual.”

The two took a moment to let the heat die down. This wasn’t exactly a new thing for them. There had only been two overnight shifts in which they had the opportunity to quell their urges with one another. Since then they could only settle for a few brief moments such as this one, but it was borderline torturous. Plenty helpful to give Caitlyn content to relieve herself once back in the sanctity of her own bed, but it also left her desperate for more and stuck in a position unable to achieve it. Caitlyn hadn’t even finished her morning coffee and now she’d have to sit with an irritating dampness in her pants for the rest of the day.

“Guess we should get to work, huh?”

Caitlyn pouted, but relented. “I suppose so.”

“Don’t worry, cupcake. We’ll have plenty of time for that once I’m home.”

And suddenly Caitlyn's dour mood was washed away, replaced with a giddy twinge of excitement.

"Yes." She sighed, the familiar strings of longing tugging at her heart. "Once you're home."

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"Special delivery."

Caitlyn glanced up from her documents, surprised to find Vander giving her a cheeky grin over the wall of her cubicle. "Sorry?"

Vander lifted one of his arms over the wall to extend Caitlyn a stunning wrapped bouquet of deep blue roses laced with white baby's breath. "These just came for you."

Caitlyn gasped, blinking at the flowers with absolute befuddlement for far too long before realizing she should probably take them out of the man's hands. She held the bouquet delicately, the brown parchment paper crinkling in her grasp as she inspected the arrangement.

Vander walked away before Caitlyn could question him, leaving her absolutely stunned and confused.

"What is it?" Vi asked over the line, a knowing air of smugness to her voice.

"It's- um, roses." A bright smile spread across Caitlyn's face. She pressed her nose into the soft petals and inhaled deeply. "They're *blue.* I've never seen blue roses before."

Vi laughed softly. "Well, I know it's your favorite color, so."

Caitlyn blinked, her brain finally catching up in time with the blood rushing to her face. "You- did you do this?"

"Of course I did. You thought I was going to ask you to be my valentine and not get you flowers?"

Still so full of surprises. Always making Caitlyn's heart flutter.

"How?" Caitlyn was completely overwhelmed, unsure what to do with herself outside of stroking the soft petals betwixt her fingers.

"Gave Powder my credit card info, told her what to get." There was such an air of casual nonchalance in Vi's voice, as if she didn't realize how monumental of an impact her actions had. Or just how much space she occupied within Caitlyn's heart. "Do you like them?"

“They’re beautiful. I love them so much.” She needed to put the bouquet aside or she’d risk crushing the poor flowers to her chest. “I’ll have to make sure they’re put somewhere where Chowder can’t knock them over again.”

Vi offered a confused laugh. “Wait, what? Again? Does Chowder have a vendetta against bouquets or something?”

Caitlyn froze with the sudden realization of what she had just confessed. “Um, well… no not particularly…”

Vi waited for a moment, clearly hoping for Caitlyn to elaborate. When she didn’t, Vi pressed. “Well out with it, cupcake. You gotta tell me now.”

Caitlyn groaned, but relented. It was just impossible for her to lie to Vi. She recounted the story of her momentary panic upon seeing Vi’s abs during the fitness interview, the absolute devastation her poor cat had left in his wake after she startled him halfway to death. Vi was quiet for all of ten seconds once Caitlyn finished her story before exploding into a fit of laughter.

“Oh my god, Cait. You are so damn clumsy.” Caitlyn slumped back into her chair, the buzz of her humiliation drowning out her astronaut’s laughter. “All that just for some abs?”

“Well it was more so the person the abs were attached to.” Caitlyn grumbled stubbornly. She eyed her bouquet and sighed, a sudden feeling of inadequacy washing over her.

“What’s wrong?” It was incredible that Vi learned how to pick up on Caitlyn’s mood just from her breath alone.

Caitlyn pouted. “I didn’t get you anything.”

Vi let out a genuine laugh. “You’re so fucking cute and silly. You know that’s not possible, baby.”

Yeah, it was silly for Caitlyn to be upset. Didn’t change anything. Logic be damned when you’re hopeless and gay. “I still want to get you something.”

Vi took a moment to think before letting out a heavy, wistful sigh. “Caitlyn, you’ve given me everything.”

A familiar warmth bloomed in Caitlyn’s chest. She smiled and wrapped her arms tightly around herself, a habit that it took her far too long to realize was out of a desperation to be held by her astronaut. “You deserve everything.”

There was a comfortable stretch of silence, thick with unspoken words between them.

“Caitlyn I…” Caitlyn’s breath caught. She could somehow feel it, what Vi wanted to say. What Caitlyn had known since that day she almost lost Vi to the stars.

Vi hesitated for a good long while. Caitlyn wouldn’t push her. She had long decided that she’d wait for Vi to say it first. Caitlyn was pretty confident she had made her feelings

glaringly obvious, so she would leave the ball in Vi's court. Wait for her to pick it up and pass it back.

Another sigh, although one that now stemmed from exasperated frustration. "I can't wait to see you."

Caitlyn's shoulders slumped, the tension releasing from them. She wasn't upset or disappointed. After all, she promised she'd wait for Vi.

"Well then hurry up and get down here."

A smile had returned to Vi's voice. "I'm on my way, baby."

Caitlyn laughed, glancing once more at her desk calendar and reveling in that buzz of anticipation.

Just seventeen days.

✩₊˚.⋆☾ ⋆⁺₊✧

Time Elapsed: 355 Days
Time Remaining: 10 Days

"You excited for me to come home?"

What a ridiculous question. "Of course I'm excited." Caitlyn paused, an idea forming in her mind. One she knew would get her in trouble but she couldn't resist. She had gone eight months without a single one being spoken aloud, it only felt appropriate at the end. "One might say… I'm over the moon."

There was a long beat of awkward silence. Caitlyn held her breath, desperate to keep the laugh threatening to bubble out of her mouth from escaping.

"That's it, I'm not coming back."

Caitlyn fell back into her seat with laughter, unable to contain it any longer. "No! No please, please Vi-"

"Nope. I live here now."

Caitlyn's lungs hurt as she wheezed into the microphone. "But I thought we- we had a cosmic connection."

The beep of Vi abruptly going offline sent Caitlyn into a frenzy of giggles. She clutched at her gut, basking in the pure silly euphoric feeling that had been stockpiling over the last few weeks.

Vi would be home in just ten days.

✩₊˚.⋆☾ ⋆⁺₊✧

Time Elapsed: 362 Days
Time Remaining: 3 Days

“Oh shoot, I forgot to get you a souvenir.”

Caitlyn laughed. “Do they have gift shops on the international space station?”

Vi feigned thoughtfulness with a hum for a moment. “As a matter of fact, they do not. But I could probably whip something up.”

Caitlyn rolled her eyes fondly. “What could you possibly bring me from up there?”

There was a poignant pause. Caitlyn’s smile slowly dropped. She had gotten rather good at reading Vi’s silences. This one was thick with consideration, an air of genuine heartfelt yearning.

“I’d bring you the stars and the moon if I could, Caitlyn.”

Not for the first time, Caitlyn found herself breathless, completely swept away in the warm tide of Vi’s devotion. The ache in her heart grew more and more with each passing day, accumulating a burning desire beneath her fingertips that she’d finally soothe within Vi’s touch soon.

Vi would be home in just three days.

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Time Elapsed: 365 Days
Time Remaining: 0 Days

The entire control center was buzzing with anticipation. It was all hands on deck for the astronaut's return voyage to Earth. The excitement was palpable in the room, building a tense environment that did nothing to quell Caitlyn's nerves. She was currently pacing back and forth within her cubicle, unable to sit still and practically gnawing off her fingernails. Whatever, she needed to trim them anyway.

"Cait, you need to calm down."

Caitlyn froze, blinking down at her desk chair in surprise. "What do you mean?"

Vi laughed softly. "I can hear you pacing. I don't know why you're so freaked out. Everything's gonna be fine."

Caitlyn huffed out an agitated breath and pulled back her rolling chair, finally sitting her anxious ass down. Her leg began to shake under the desk after she had pulled herself toward it. "I know that."

"Okay so what's up? Talk to me."

"I think it's a mixture of things." She clasped her hands together, pressing the joined palms between her thighs and crossing her ankles to stop the frantic shaking. "There's something just so… scary about the idea of you free falling in a flaming capsule toward Earth and crashing into the ocean."

"Well when you phrase it like that, yeah." There was a casual air of nonchalance in Vi's tone, which was to be expected. That's how she always was, or at least how she pretended to be for the sake of others. Caitlyn couldn't actually tell at the moment if Vi was holding in any anxieties, she was too busy drowning in her own. "The spacecraft is pretty much indestructible though. You have nothing to worry about."

Caitlyn sighed, releasing her trapped hands to instead pull at the dark locks draped against the back of her neck. "I suppose."

"Besides-" Vi began shuffling around in the background, most likely finishing up in packing the remainder of her things. "It's gonna take a lot more than a flaming metal death trap to keep me from you."

She couldn't help but crack a smile. Vi always managed to melt down her walls with such ease. "How are *you* feeling?"

Vi paused her shuffling. "Nervous, actually."

The honesty genuinely surprised Caitlyn. "You're nervous? I didn't think you knew the meaning of the word."

"Well I got a beautiful woman waiting for me back home, so."

Oh. So not nervous for the trip itself, then. Vi was nervous about seeing Caitlyn.

"Ready to go, Caitlyn?"

She blinked up at Vander, who had suddenly appeared over the front wall of her cubicle. “Sorry? Oh, um.” She shook her head, no time to dwell on Vi’s confession. “Vi, are you all set?”

“Mmhm. Tell dad I’m heading to the Crew Dragon now.”

“Copy.” Caitlyn relayed the message to Vander, who offered a proud smile in return.

“Quite a nerve wracking day. I remember my first time watching her return.” He crossed his arms casually over the wall, a typical dad-talk position. “Just breathe deeply, you’ll be able to talk to her for most of the trip and we’ll be monitoring closely. She’ll be okay.”

Vander’s presence was usually quite calming, and his words did help, but there was still an unpleasant tremor to Caitlyn’s heart where she sat. She nodded and swallowed the nerves. “Thank you, Vander. I’ll try my best.”

“You got it.” He smiled and winked before making his way to the front of the comms room. Caitlyn’s legs started jittering under the desk once more.

The truth of the matter is that it wasn’t just the voyage itself that had Caitlyn panicked. Vi wasn’t the only one nervous at the prospect of them finally meeting. Caitlyn wasn’t sure which was scarier, the danger of Vi’s journey, or finally meeting her face to face.

“Claggor, what’s the weather looking like?” Vander asked, casually picking up his mug to take a sip. Caitlyn admired how calm he was. Couldn’t be her.

Claggor glanced at his computer, pulling up the forecast diagnostics sent in from Florida. The shuttle would be landing in the Gulf of Mexico, where a recovery boat would be waiting to pull the cap out of the sea to retrieve the astronauts. “We’ve got a forecast of scattered clouds at twenty eight thousand feet, gusty winds and a temperature of about seventy three degrees. Winds are at about two knots.”

“Not bad.” Vander bent over his computer, using it to pull up a black and white outside feed of the shuttle docked at the edge of the space station. “How’s the Dragon?”

“Maintenance checks have been completed and it’s ready for departure.” Mylo said with an eager smile. The two brothers seemed to be in quite high spirits.

“Excellent, once they’re suited up and strapped in, we’ll do final checks and they’ll be on their way.”

Caitlyn stood and began pacing again as she waited for Vi to check back in. Powder arrived after about twenty minutes, offering Caitlyn an iced latte and a confused quirk to her brow.

“You good?”

Caitlyn paused. “What’s that phrase that you used about being anxious?”

“Shittin’ bricks?”

“Yes. That.”

Powder chuckled and rolled her eyes. “You lesbians and your drama.”

Caitlyn pouted. “How are you *not* freaking out?”

Powder shrugged and sipped at her frappuccino. “Well considering I worked on the craft that’s carrying them myself, I know they’re gonna be perfectly fine.”

That gave Caitlyn pause. “You worked on it?” Powder nodded. “Well… I suppose that makes me feel a little better.”

“Awe, shucks toots.” She gave Caitlyn a delicate punch to the shoulder. “Seriously, they’ll be fine. Just relax and enjoy the show.”

Caitlyn would be doing no such thing, but she appreciated the sentiment.

“Alright Cait, we got our launch and entry suits on.” Vi’s voice said in Caitlyn’s ears. “Tell the team we’re strapped in and ready to go.”

“Copy.” Caitlyn managed to get out. She ignored Vi’s chuckle at her strained tone and let the team know.

“Excellent. Let’s get this ball rolling then.” Vander slipped on his own headset. “KSC, do you copy?”

“Hello, Chief Wick, we copy.” Caitlyn smiled at the sound of her old boss’ voice echoing throughout the comms room. She missed the rough timbre of Greyson’s voice, it was nice to hear something familiar today. “We will be closely monitoring the Dragon’s voyage. Our team will be ready and waiting in the water to retrieve the astronaut’s once they land.”

“Excellent, standby for deorbit.”

“Copy.”

“Dragon is currently isolating the thermal control system fluid loops from the radiator.” Viktor called out from his cubicle. This system was located in the trunk or the lower half of the Dragon spacecraft, responsible for keeping the internal temperature comfortable and cool for the astronauts during re-entry. Caitlyn eyed the live diagnostics. The spacecraft was preparing to initiate separation of the claw mechanism. This would terminate data, power, and fluid connection from the trunk, preparing it for the bottom half to break off from the cap once it had cleared the atmosphere. “Deorbit sequence will start in two minutes.”

“Caitlyn…” There was something somber and heartbreaking in Vi’s tone.

Caitlyn blinked nervously. “Yes?”

“Listen…” She paused dramatically. “If I don’t make it back-”

“Oh my god *shut up.*”

Vi cracked up over the line, Caitlyn was going to strangle her once she did make it back. In a murderous way. Not in a kinky way. Though she wouldn't be opposed to that either.

"Just trying to loosen you up a bit, cupcake."

She had to admit it worked a little. No one else seemed worried so there really was no reason for Caitlyn to be. She shook out her hands a bit and breathed out. Everything was fine.

"Beginning deorbit sequence." Viktor spoke once more. Powder let out a whoop from somewhere in the room. "Telemetry is looking good, nitrox system is primed for cabin and suit cooling. Releasing the claw now."

"Bringing up the satellite feed." Claggor noted, typing away at his keyboard. Caitlyn eyed the black and white imagery that popped up on the center projector screen, gnawing at her lip in anticipation as they watched the claw release the spacecraft.

Viktor adjusted his headset. "Trunk separation initiating."

The imagery of the spacecraft showed the front and back halves separating, effectively releasing the capsule in its path toward Earth. In just a few minutes, the ship would begin deorbit burn, activating the four draco thrusters at the front of the capsule to lock in the path the ship would take to arrive on Earth.

"Beginning deorbit burn." Viktor stated.

Caitlyn watched intently on the screen as the capsule picked up speed, ever so slowly building a cocoon of flames around the hull. She let out a frightened squeal that she simply couldn't hold in, clapping her hands over her mouth in shock. It looked like a goddamn meteor hurtling toward the Earth.

"I'm still alive here, Cait." Vi chuckled over the line, her voice shaky from the movement of the capsule.

"Yes but you're on *fire.*" Caitlyn said incredulously.

"I guess that's one way of telling me I'm hot."

Oh for fuck's sake.

"Heat shield is stable." Viktor said. The heat shield was at the base of the pressurized section of the craft, protecting them from, well, burning to a crisp.

"Hold tight, Cupcake. We got an hour 'till splashdown."

Caitlyn slumped back in her chair. That was it. Vi was no longer at the International Space Station. She was freefalling toward Earth, toward the moment Caitlyn had been eagerly counting down for months.

Vi would be home in one hour.

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“Comms check. Do you copy?”

“Read you loud and clear, cupcake.”

Caitlyn smiled, feeling a lot more relieved than she had over the last forty five minutes. There was a blackout point where the comms had cut out briefly, reducing Vi’s voice to a jumbled mess of static. It had unsettled Caitlyn at the time, but the enthusiasm now present in her astronaut’s voice doused any fear she may have held.

“Dragon capsule has entered GPS, drogue parachutes releasing at nominal altitude of eighteen thousand feet.” Vander said.

Greyson’s voice came through the speakers once more. “Copy.”

“Home stretch.” Mylo relaxed back in his chair, casually crossing his arms behind his head.

“Bringing up the ground feed.” Claggor switched the camera viewpoint from the blurry satellite imagery to a clearer camera. The craft was just a small glowing dot on the screen, but it was better than the previous feed at least.

Vander stood from his chair, bracing his knuckles against the wooden desk and leaning forward in anticipation. “Drogue’s deploying.”

“Brace for parachute deployment.” Caitlyn instructed Vi, Viktor and Scar doing the same for Loris and Ekko.

“Copy.” Vi replied. From the screen there was a view of two large parachutes fluttering out and opening up at the back of the capsule, beginning the process of slowing down the craft.

“Speed is about one twenty, good pitch and yaw stability.” Viktor said, sipping at a mug of most likely overly sweet coffee. “Four main parachutes now deploying.”

The screen showed the first two parachutes releasing from the back of the vessel, four new ones fanning out and taking their place.

“I wish I could be there to greet you.” Caitlyn said, pouting into her mic.

Vi chuckled. “No you don’t. It’s not exactly graceful getting out of this thing. I won’t even be able to walk.”

“I know.” Caitlyn said stubbornly. “But still.”

Vi hummed softly, a smile in her voice. “You’ll see me soon, Cait. I promise.”

The craft slowed down on the screen as the chutes grew bigger and bigger, spreading out further atop the vessel.

“One thousand meters.” Vander called out.

Caitlyn’s breath caught.

“Eight hundred meters.”

“You guys ready?” Powder asked her brothers, the three of them standing and linking their arms together as they watched the screen.

“Six hundred meters.”

“Vi?” Caitlyn breathed out.

“Yeah?”

“Four hundred meters.”

“I can’t wait to see you.”

Vi laughed softly. “Yeah, me either.”

“Two hundred meters.”

“Brace for impact.” Caitlyn said, breathless.

The room was quiet enough to hear a pin drop, every eye glued to the monitor until the moment finally arrived, the dragon crashing into the water as the parachutes fell down around it.

“Splashdown!” The siblings all yelled in unison, everyone in the room cheered and applauded, the excitement and relief expelling the breath Caitlyn had been holding from her lungs in a sharp gust. She slumped back in her seat, allowing the high to settle into a sudden state of realization.

Vi was home.

“Still kicking there babe?”

Caitlyn closed her eyes and smiled, all the fears of the day replaced with a gentle warmth and buzz of anticipation. “Yes, still kicking.”

“Good.” Vi was smiling, too. Caitlyn wanted to kiss that smile from her lips. Her heart did a flip at the thought, knowing that soon she would be able to.

“Retrieval vessel inbound.” Mylo called out. Caitlyn nodded and relayed the info to Vi.

“Well, I guess this is it then.” Vi said, something somber in her voice.

It then hit Caitlyn that Vi was right, that was it. They would no longer be communicating over comms every day. She hadn't even taken a second to think about it, too lost in the excitement of Vi's arrival. "Oh… I suppose it is."

There was a beat of silence between them, a realization of crossing that boundary into something new, unfamiliar and nerve-wracking. Caitlyn was elated at the prospect of seeing Vi, but she had to admit she would miss this. Their heartfelt conversations, the deep longing and filling her days with nothing but the sound of Vi's voice. Everything would be different now, a new start. A turn of the page.

"See you soon, then?" Vi sounded anxious, like she was waiting for Caitlyn to change her mind at any second. A silly notion, Caitlyn had waited eight months for this, she certainly wasn't going back on her word now.

"Yes." Caitlyn breathed out, her heart fluttering. She could hear Vi breathe out a shaky sigh of relief. "See you soon."

There was a beat before the final beep of Vi going offline. Caitlyn sat for a moment in shock, the sudden silence overwhelming her senses. That was it. No turning back now.

She slowly slipped off her headset, feeling dizzy at the lack of weight atop her head and rooted to her chair with the new weight settling within her heart. It was too much to process, the change, the anticipation, the eagerness. Caitlyn wasn't sure what to do with herself, so instead she shifted her gaze to the smiling photo of Vi.

She'd be able to see that smile soon. She'd be able to kiss those lips and finally hold Vi in her arms. She could trace the ink on Vi's skin and run her fingers through the deep magenta of her hair. Finally feel that she's *real.*

She would see Vi soon.

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The first week after Vi had returned to Earth, Caitlyn had anticipated the quiet. She knew that Vi was in a medical facility, being monitored closely and taking various tests to ensure she was healthy to begin her recovery. She knew, and of course she understood, but the silence was deafening. It was the first week in eight months that Caitlyn had gone without speaking to Vi. The longest she had gone in so long without hearing her astronaut's voice. Caitlyn understood, but it didn't make the silence any less unbearable.

The second week, Caitlyn began to get antsy. She found herself constantly checking her phone, mistaking every soft buzz around her for a ring, but it never was. She'd wake up suddenly in the middle of the night worried she had missed a call from Vi, but she never did.

As week three rolled around, Caitlyn was beginning to lose her mind. She found herself blasting music through a pair of headphones at work to make up for the eerie quiet, constantly fidgeting and getting up from her desk for a record amount of coffee runs every day. She just couldn't focus, the anxiety was eating her alive from the inside out.

On week four, Caitlyn had nearly burned her hand by knocking over a pot of boiling water in the kitchen as she jumped to get to her phone when it finally rang. She breathlessly answered, heart thrumming steadily in her chest, only for the feeling to be squashed by the robotic voice of a courtesy call reminding her to pay her credit card bill.

So yeah, Caitlyn was going a bit off the rails.

"I don't know, she won't talk to me either." Powder shrugged from where she was sat atop the kitchenette counter. "I've talked to Ekko. He says she's like, training constantly. But every time he tells her to call you, she just says 'I can't.'"

Caitlyn groaned, collapsing into her arms where she sat at the breakroom table. "Not this again."

"Sorry, toots. My sister is kind of a drama queen."

"I don't get why she won't just call me." Caitlyn lifted her head to rest her chin atop her crossed forearms, pouting. "It's driving me crazy, Powder. I know she's busy, but not even a short five minute call? What if… what if she had some sort of epiphany that she was crazy to fall for someone while in space and now that she's here, she doesn't want me anymore?"

Powder sized her up with a very unimpressed look. "If that's the case then I'll set my lab on fire and quit my job to become a potato farmer."

Caitlyn blinked. "What-"

"I'm saying there's no possible way that's gonna happen, Caitlyn. She's just being dramatic. I'm sure that's all it is."

Powder was probably right. If there's one thing Caitlyn had learned, it was that Vi had a tendency for theatrics when it came to dealing with her emotions. She wanted to have trust in Vi. She promised Vi she would wait even through the two months of recovery, so she would.

But why wouldn't Vi call her? What possible reason could she have? Caitlyn would even settle for a voice memo at this point. She had considered being the one to call first, but with Vi's recovery schedule she had no inkling of when an appropriate time would be. So there she was, stuck once more in a mind boggling conundrum of miscommunication with her astronaut.

By week five, Caitlyn had calmed to a state of acceptance. Whatever Vi's reason be, it wouldn't last forever. Even if Vi did lose interest, she wouldn't just leave Caitlyn hanging. The anticipation was killing her, but there was no use in dwelling on what was out of your control.

Caitlyn found herself laying in bed staring at her bedroom ceiling that morning before her alarm even went off, feeling a pang in her chest at the prospect of another quiet day at work. It had all been silent paperwork and calculations once more. It was incredible really, the intense realization of just how much Vi lit up her world and just how dim it had become in comparison without her.

Caitlyn readied herself for work in a robotic state. The weather was quite beautiful in Houston in April. Humid as a bitch as per usual but the temperature was around the low seventies. Caitlyn elected that morning for a black quarter sleeve blouse with a deep v-neck, tucked into a short pleated brown skirt and finished off with a pair of black sheer stockings and her usual heels. She tied her hair up into a loose ponytail, wondering if she should perhaps get a trim considering how long it had gotten.

With a quick kiss to Chowder's sleeping head and a wistful sigh at her reflection in the full length mirror, Caitlyn was off to another uneventful day. She drove in silence to work, parked in her usual spot, nodded to the security guard on duty, and sighed at the sound of the loud clack of her heels filling the empty hallway once she went inside.

"Caitlyn, a quick word." Caitlyn ceased in her trek toward the break room as Vander approached holding a manilla folder. "I've got some documents I'll need you to fill out by the end of the day if you wouldn't mind."

"Oh, of course." She reached out and took the folder, offering the chief a half-hearted smile. Vander seemed to be able to tell she wasn't in the highest of spirits.

"Chin up there, kiddo. It's going to be a good day."

Caitlyn wanted to believe him, she really did.

Upon arriving to the breakroom, Caitlyn opened the refrigerator and groaned. They were out of liquid creamer. She'd have to settle for the powdered version she kept at her desk instead. Caitlyn hated powdered creamer, it made every coffee taste like cardboard. So much for a good day.

Leaving the lounge disappointed and coffeeless, Caitlyn opened up her manilla folder to inspect the documents Vander had handed off to her that morning. Her brow furrowed in confusion as she inspected each of the pages while she walked. Each one of them was a diagnostic inquiry on the function of the space station over the last year as well as the return shuttle. These were documents for the astronauts to fill out, not Caitlyn. Vander must have given her the wrong file by mistake.

Caitlyn sighed and shut the folder, she was about half way through the comms room and had rounded the last row of desks to get to her cubicle-

But she stopped short.

And suddenly her world was turned completely on its axis.

Breath stolen from her lungs, heart stuck in her throat.

She could no longer feel the Earth beneath her, everything had faded away into a dull blur, leaving only one shining beacon at the center of it all.

There, leaning up against the wall casually next to her cubicle, gaze averted to the far wall of the comms room, fists shoved into her pockets, looking more like a Greek goddess than anyone had the right to while wearing a bright blue NASA jumpsuit, was Vi.

Caitlyn couldn't feel her limbs, her arms suddenly falling limp to her sides. The folder of documents fell to her feet, paper scattering all around her and yet Caitlyn still didn't notice.

But Vi did.

Vi's sharp gaze snapped to her.

Their meeting was obviously going to be quite charged, but nothing could have prepared Caitlyn for the agonizing tension that buzzed through the air in that moment. Vi's lips parted on an shocked breath, an intense realization and awe forming in her gaze.

It hit Caitlyn with the force of a freight train that this was the first time Vi had ever seen her.

It seemed to affect Vi just the same, worse even. Her powder blue hues blew wide as they took in all that Caitlyn was, ever so slowly dragging up and down Caitlyn's body. Caitlyn fidgeted a bit, but allowed Vi the time to take her in. There was that nagging sense of doubt at the back of her mind that perhaps she didn't live up to what Vi had envisioned, that maybe she wasn't good enough.

No, Vi left absolutely no room for that in the way she openly stared at Caitlyn. Her astronaut's expression was one of pure overwhelming awe. She looked at Caitlyn as if she couldn't believe what she had laid her eyes upon. Like Vi was a woman starved, having traversed a vast desert before finally coming across a blooming oasis. It bewildered Caitlyn where she stood, rooting her to the ground and flushing a stunning shade of red in her cheeks that Vi's gaze narrowed in on. No one had looked at her in such a way in all her life, with such a raw sense of devotion, longing, and *want.*

Caitlyn had always wondered how each of them would react upon seeing one another for the first time. She'd fantasized about it countless times, what she thought she'd say and how Vi would react. Would she run into Vi's arms? Would Vi sweep her off her feet? Would they kiss? She'd imagined it all, but nothing came close to this overwhelming electricity that lit a fire in her veins and a thunderous applause in her heart.

They just stood there. Staring at one another with bated breath. Both seemingly afraid to make the first move, to make what they had been exploring with one another all this time real, tangible, and physical.

Caitlyn's reality came crashing down on her like a tidal wave. She finally registered the quickening of her breath, the unmistakable heat in her cheeks, the heaviness of her limbs… and the papers scattered all over the floor.

“Shit.” She whispered, awkwardly failing to tuck a loose strand of dark hair behind her ear as she squatted down to collect the scattered papers. Her fingers were trembling, heartbeat pulsing so loudly within her own ears that she didn’t register Vi’s footsteps as she approached until the blue of Vi’s jumpsuit came directly into her field of vision.

Caitlyn sucked in a sharp breath, freezing momentarily before pushing past the frenzied anxiety and focusing on her task. Vi knealed in front of her and began assisting in collecting the scattered documents. The astronaut's muscular forearms and fingers flexed as she smoothly swiped a few of the papers. Caitlyn zeroed in on it, just the small amount of exposed skin and peak of black ink on Vi’s forearms sending a spark of static up her spine. It took all of Caitlyn’s self preservation and will power not to look at Vi’s face lest she fall backwards completely on her ass in shock.

Caitlyn stood with all of the grace of a baby deer, but Vi remained on her knee for a moment. Caitlyn could feel Vi gazing up at her irreverently while she shuffled the papers in her arms together, but she just couldn’t bring herself to look. She was too nervous for what she might see swimming in Vi’s gaze, too scared it would make her crumble into a heaping mess.

Vi finally stood, extending the papers she had collected toward Caitlyn. She gingerly accepted them and stuffed them into her arms, clutching the folder to her chest and swallowing a thick clump of nerves in her throat before finally establishing eye contact.

Vi was less than a foot away from Caitlyn, and Caitlyn was simply not prepared for how devastatingly beautiful Vi looked up close. Months of photographs and a few short videos didn’t do the woman justice in the slightest. Her presence was all consuming, breathtaking, and overwhelming in the best way. Her hair had gotten a lot longer but the shaved side maintained its choppiness and Caitlyn wanted to run her fingers through it. To squeeze Vi tighter than the documents she was crumpling in her arms. To run her lips up Vi’s jaw and whisper heartfelt words of love in her ear…

Caitlyn licked her lips, not missing the way Vi watched the movement with the intensity of a hawk. Fuck, the tension was killing her. She desperately wracked her brain to find something to say, a course of action to take, and yet she came up empty. Completely lost in the depth of Vi’s wonderstruck expression.

It sort of reminded her of her very first day here, unsure of what to say, what to do.

And just as that first day, it didn’t matter. Because Vi was here, and she would be the one to make the first move.

Slowly, ever so slowly and with the utmost care, Vi raised her palm and gently used her fingertips to brush that wayward lock of hair behind Caitlyn’s ear. Goosebumps broke out on Caitlyn’s skin at the warm contact. Vi let her palm linger there, stroking against Caitlyn’s cheekbone using her thumb with the most featherlight touch.

“Hey, Cupcake.” Caitlyn gasped. Her voice was soft, like someone trying to coax a flower to open up its petals and take in the sun. No longer muffled by the static of the comms line. “You copy?”

Caitlyn hadn't realized she was holding in a choked burst of emotion until it broke free. The sting of tears burned at her waterline and yet she had never felt so much relief in their warmth. Her lips stretched into an elated smile, one which Vi mirrored in return, effectively sending the delicate wings of Caitlyn's butterflies into an absolute whirlwind of reverent love.

"Yes." She breathed out, overwhelmed and overjoyed more than she thought ever possible as she *finally* stared into the awestruck eyes of her astronaut. "I copy."

Chapter End Notes

Finally

Yell at me on twitter here.

Comments and kudos much obliged. <3

Touched

Chapter Summary

> “Do you have any idea how long I waited for this?”

Chapter Notes

> I ain’t got nothing to say. You know what’s coming.
>
> Enjoy your filth.
>
> Playlist for this fic here.
>
> See ya. <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Caitlyn watched as Vi made her way around the cubicle, her fingertips dragging against the wood surface and over the various knick-knacks on display. There was something almost tantalizing about the way her astronaut’s fingers moved, languidly and fluidly grazing over each object in a way that should not have had such a profound effect on Caitlyn and yet the heat brewing in her gut was undeniable. Caitlyn was hopelessly gay, but even she had to admit she’d never been so attracted to a woman’s hands before.

God, was this really all it took to rile her up? Or was she simply that touch starved?

Vi stopped suddenly to pick up the framed photo that Caitlyn had spent countless days pining over. Caitlyn fidgeted a bit. She had never told Vi about the photos. She wasn’t embarrassed per se, but it almost felt like a confession, an acknowledgement of the magnitude of Caitlyn’s pining.

Vi’s face was unreadable for a moment before she smirked at the photo, proceeding to gingerly place it back on the desk. It was unbelievably surreal and strangely intimate seeing Vi in this space. The place where Caitlyn had spent all those months hopelessly falling for her.

Now there she was, right in front of Caitlyn’s eyes and yet no matter how many times Caitlyn had stared longingly at that photo, nothing could have prepared her for this intense aura radiating from her astronaut. She wasn’t surprised that Vi was somehow more beautiful in person, but there was something else about her that practically consumed all of Caitlyn’s

senses. She was overwhelming in the best way, her presence somehow dominating and yet soothing all at once.

“So, this is where the magic happened, huh?”

Caitlyn rolled her eyes fondly. For someone who didn’t like puns, Vi certainly regurgitated a lot of cliché one-liners. Caitlyn herself, well, she hadn’t said anything in the last five minutes. She was simply in a state of shock, left practically trembling by the frantic beat of her heart.

Caitlyn shifted against the edge of the cubicle wall she had been leaning against with her palms braced along her forearms. “If by ‘magic’ you mean this is where I sat for eight months while you tormented me with your innuendos then yes, I suppose.” The retort was supposed to be witty, tinged with sass as their usual encounters went but instead Caitlyn’s voice came out timid, fragile.

Fuck, she was so nervous.

Despite the lack of bite in Caitlyn’s tone, Vi grinned, stealing Caitlyn’s breath away not for the first time that day.

“Well I must have done something right.” She rounded Caitlyn’s swivel chair, casually draping her arm across the back and leaning on it, glancing around the space. “This is where we met. Where we spent nine hours together on that first spacewalk.” Caitlyn’s brow furrowed. She wasn’t sure where Vi was going with this, but her tone held implications, softening into something fond as she continued. “Where I told you about my mother, and you told me about Cambridge.” Her gaze suddenly narrowed, zeroing in on Caitlyn. “Where we talked each other through that one night.”

A shiver made its way up Caitlyn’s body. The intensity in her astronaut’s eyes was truly something to behold. Caitlyn felt put under a microscope, like Vi was dissecting every miniscule movement she made, every rise of her chest and flutter of her eyelashes.

Vi’s voice was suddenly so soft, laced with a gentle timbre of devotion. “Where you said you’d wait for me.”

Caitlyn swallowed her nerves as best she could, somehow managing to keep the tremor in her voice at bay this time. “Yes.” She whispered shyly.

Vi was staring at her hungrily, like she was on the verge of leaving no holds barred and devouring Caitlyn in the middle of the comm center. She straightened up and took a step toward Caitlyn, crowding her space. Vi was slightly shorter than Caitlyn, but in that moment she felt so small in contrast to this woman’s dominating presence. “Eight months of nothing but talking and now you’re tight-lipped?“

Caitlyn’s eyes darted all over Vi’s face, unsure of what to focus on. She found it nearly impossible to raise her voice over that of a timid whisper. “What- what do you want me to say?”

“Say you’ll have dinner with me tonight.”

Caitlyn hesitated. “I- um…” God, she wanted to say yes. Desperately wanted to throw herself into her astronaut’s arms, but there was one thing nagging at the back of her mind. Something that, in the rush of seeing Vi for the first time, was momentarily left on the back burner.

Vi blinked, surprised at Caitlyn’s reluctance. “What is it? What’s wrong?” There was a slight quickening of Vi’s breath, an insecurity swimming in her gaze. It was as if she was terrified that Caitlyn had changed her mind about what they had. Caitlyn hadn’t, of course not, but she wasn’t about to just let Vi’s radio silence over the last five weeks go unaddressed.

She rubbed at her upper arms, eyes averting to the far wall of her cubicle. “You… you didn’t call.”

Memories of the intense quiet over the last few weeks came flooding back to her, along with the heartache and confusion she felt among the silence. Vi was finally here, and Caitlyn was elated, but she simply couldn’t ignore that nagging doubt plaguing her heart any longer.

Vi’s expression suddenly broke. She reached forward and cradled Caitlyn’s cheek in her rough palm once more, turning Caitlyn’s hurt-filled eyes back toward her own.

“I’m so sorry, Cait.” There was such heartfelt care in Vi’s tone, a desperate pleading that nearly instantly washed away Caitlyn’s insecurities. “I wanted to, you have to believe me. I just- my only priority was getting through recovery as quickly as I could so I could get to you. I pushed myself harder than I ever have to get it done quickly and if I had heard your voice I just know I would have dropped everything and come here to find you.”

Caitlyn let out a small, exasperated breath. So Powder was right, Vi really was just being dramatic. She found herself smiling softly, amazed at just how fond she could feel toward her astronaut even when she was being a downright fool. “That’s such a terrible excuse.”

“I know, but it’s true. I mean… I also just- I couldn’t.” She stroked Caitlyn’s cheek with the utmost care, grazing the soft skin there as if brushing the petals of a flower. “Hearing your voice up there for eight months and then coming back down to Earth, it felt like a bucket of cold water. Suddenly it wasn’t just dreams and stargazing, it was real. I couldn’t settle for just your voice anymore, I needed to see you, to feel you…” Her palm slid down to caress the side of Caitlyn’s neck, directly under her ear. Caitlyn had to resist the urge to crane her head to the side and give Vi more. “I know it doesn't make any sense. I’m just so sorry, cupcake. You deserved better than that.”

Caitlyn sighed, finally feeling as though the embers of her anxieties had been smothered. “It’s okay. I understand. I just… I was frightened. That you would return and realize this… me, wasn’t what you wanted.”

There was so much intensity in Vi’s gaze. A steadfastness in her clear determination to prove her devotion. “There hasn’t been a second back here on Earth or among the stars that I didn’t want you, Caitlyn.”

Caitlyn could feel the sting of tears behind her eyes. She quickly blinked them away, not wanting to give Vi the wrong impression. Those weeks without hearing Vi’s voice were hard, yes, but Vi had washed away any residual doubt that Caitlyn had once felt with just a few

words. Leaving behind nothing but a soothing sort of elation. “I believe you.” She whispered, the corners of her lips quirking into a gentle smile.

“Do you forgive me?”

Caitlyn shrugged. “Well it wouldn’t be the first time I had to deal with your drama.” Vi chuckled sheepishly. “Besides, I did say I’d always wait for you. Didn’t I?”

Vi stepped even closer into Caitlyn’s space, their bodies mere inches apart as her thumb continued to stroke along Caitlyn’s jawline. “You won’t have to anymore. I promise.”

“I know…” Caitlyn let out a shuddering breath, the proximity starting to get to her. “I forgive you.”

“So you’ll have dinner with me, then?”

She bit her lip, not missing the way Vi’s eyes flickered to it for a moment. “On one condition.”

“Anything.”

“We’ll do it at my place. I’ll cook for us.”

Vi stiffened. “Uh, I dunno. I already had one near death experience. Two may be pushing it…”

“Excuse me?” Caitlyn mock gasped, ignoring Vi’s cackling and thumping the side of her fist on the exposed skin of Vi’s collarbones. “I will have you know that I have worked very hard to improve my cooking skills and I will not have you put my efforts to shame.”

Vi’s soft laughter died down, her free hand coming to snake around Caitlyn’s waist and pressing lightly at her lower back. Caitlyn had to suppress a genuine gasp this time. “I would never, baby.”

The steady thrum of Caitlyn’s heart began to quicken.

They were so close like this. Caitlyn could count the freckles on Vi’s cheeks, see the strokes of the small ink along her cheekbone, feel Vi’s breath puff against her lips. Her fist was still placed against the upper part of Vi’s chest, flattening out to instead rest against the warm patch of skin there. It was the first time Caitlyn had touched Vi. She couldn’t help but stare, marveling at how soft and warm her astronaut was as her fingertips gently brushed against Vi’s collarbone.

She met Vi’s eye level once again, the intensity and heat she found there sparking into something overwhelming and thick with tension. Their surroundings faded away into a quiet murmur that left Caitlyn nearly breathless, the thrum of her heart picking up speed in tempo with the shudder of her breath.

Vi seemed to share this sudden desperation that Caitlyn felt. Her eyes flickered to Caitlyn’s lips and back up. She looked at Caitlyn with a question in her eyes, a hesitancy that Caitlyn

could only confirm by glancing at Vi's own lips.

The astronaut's breath caught, her eyelids drooping slightly and head tilting as she leaned in slowly.

Caitlyn's own gaze hooded, a small desperate whimper suppressed within her throat.

She was finally going to feel it, what she had craved all these months. She'd finally feel how soft Vi's lips would be against her own-

The door to Vander's office banged open, startling Caitlyn backwards out of Vi's grasp and shattering the tense moment between them.

Frantically blinking herself out of her lust filled haze, Caitlyn awkwardly adjusted the few loose strands of hair framing her flaming cheeks. Vi didn't seem nearly as bewildered although she was just as flushed. Her brow furrowed for a split second of frustration and annoyance before turning toward where Powder was running down the steps from Vander's office.

"Vi!" Powder called out enthusiastically as she practically jumped over the stair railing.

A huge smile broke out on Vi's face, stealing Caitlyn's breath from her lungs. The astronaut made to move past Caitlyn, giving her forearm a gentle squeeze of reassurance, a promise to return as she made her way over to meet her sister.

Powder full on launched herself into Vi's arms with a startling force that should knock any normal person flat on their ass but Vi caught her with ease in her muscular arms. Powder's legs wrapped around Vi's waist in a koala-like hug and Vi laughed into her sister's shoulder as they embraced. A warmth settled over Caitlyn's heart as she watched the scene before her. Vi deserved this, she deserved a loving family and all the happiness in the world.

"Jesus, Pow. I'm still recovering, you know."

"Please, I know you're hopped up on Viktor's bone juice."

Vi groaned and made a disgusted face. "Do you have to call it that?"

Caitlyn also made a face. NASA's top scientists had run countless tests and experiments on Viktor at his own request to prevent future cosmonauts from experiencing the same deterioration he had suffered from his years of space travel. The results were magnanimous, bringing forth several vaccines and treatments that allowed the current astronauts to maintain their bone density while in space. Viktor himself could not be cured as the new technology was a preventative measure as opposed to a cure, but the man claimed he never minded so long as he was able to assist future space explorers in their recovery.

"I calls it like I sees it, sis." Powder jumped out of Vi's arms, leaving the astronaut staggering slightly until she gripped the edge of a nearby desk. Caitlyn frowned, watching closely as Vi took a steadying breath and straightened out. Her bones and muscles had been maintained via

treatment and exercise on the ISS, but it seemed her sense of balance was still slightly off kilter.

Claggor and Mylo emerged from Vander's office, blinding smiles on their faces as they rushed toward their sister and crushed her into a joint hug. Caitlyn felt a resurgence of tears welling in her eyes. She couldn't help but recall how terrified Vi's family had been during the satellite incident, the palpable fear in their eyes at the prospect of losing her. To see them all together embracing in a tender moment of reunion was unfathomably heartwarming. Vi's family was truly beautiful and finally whole.

"Sure, let's crush the astronaut to death." Vi grumbled between her brothers. "Not like she was stuck in a confined metal tube for a year."

The boys laughed as they released her, Claggor clapping her on the shoulder. "You look great, Vi. How'd you make it out of recovery so quickly?"

Vi's eyes flickered over to Caitlyn for a second before she shrugged. "What can I say? I was determined."

Caitlyn wasn't sure why the comment made her heart flutter, but it did.

"Well, c'mon. Dad ordered a bunch of shit from Jericho's for breakfast. Ekko's waiting in the break room." Mylo said, waving Vi on as he headed in the direction of the break room. Powder grabbed Vi's forearm and began tugging her along enthusiastically.

Caitlyn hesitated, unsure if she should follow them, wondering if she should give the family their space despite her desperate ache to remain close to Vi.

Vi glanced over her shoulder as she was tugged along by Powder, offering Caitlyn a soft smile and tilting her head in an invitation to follow.

Caitlyn mirrored the smile, giving a shy nod toward Vi, a silent communication that she would be there in a moment. Vi kept her eyes on Caitlyn until she disappeared out the door, leaving Caitlyn a moment to collapse back against the back wall of the comms room and catch her breath.

There was so much for her to process. When she awoke that morning she hadn't mentally prepared herself to even entertain the notion that she might see Vi. She would have put on a different perfume, maybe a little more makeup, some nicer panties…

She shook the thought from her mind. There wasn't time to dwell on it. Not when she was significantly more panicked at the fact that her and Vi had almost kissed. Caitlyn thought she would be ready for it, that she would crush her lips to Vi's the second she was united with her astronaut.

The reality was that she was woefully unprepared. Discussing and creating hypotheticals of intimacy over the communication line was one thing, *doing* another. It's not like Caitlyn hadn't kissed anyone before, but this was *Vi.*

Caitlyn took a moment to shake out the nerves from her arms, steadying herself with a determination to push past the jitters. She had waited far too long to compromise their reunion because of something as silly as gay panic. She could handle Vi.

But with each shaky step of her heels against the carpeted floor as she headed back toward the breakroom, Caitlyn began to doubt herself more and more.

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Now seeing her in person, Caitlyn was learning all sorts of new things about Vi.

The first was that Vi was a bit of a messy eater. Everyone was gathered in the break room, each with varying paper plates of pancakes, eggs and breakfast meats courtesy of Jericho's paid for by Vander to celebrate Vi and Ekko's return. Vi's own plate had a stack of pancakes coated in strawberry syrup, which had subsequently been smudged all over the astronaut's lips as she ate. Surprisingly, Caitlyn found it rather adorable.

She may have also been fighting thoughts of her desperate desire to lick the syrup from Vi's lips.

Caitlyn quickly shook the thought from her mind, trying her best to pay attention to the conversation the group was having. They were all squeezed around the round table, Powder sat on Ekko's lap next to Vi, Claggor and Mylo across from them and Caitlyn-

She was leaning against the wall a few feet away, shyly observing as the group interacted with a cup of coffee in hand. She didn't have much of an appetite, the butterflies filling her gut far too preoccupied with aggressively flapping their wings every time she and Vi made eye contact.

Which was happening quite a lot because, well, Vi simply would not take her eyes off Caitlyn.

Ekko leaned over to Vi, glancing down at her wrist with a frown. Vi was too busy ogling Caitlyn to notice. "You good bro?"

Vi's head snapped in his direction, her brow furrowing in confusion. "What?"

"Your heart rate is nuts. Your monitor should be going crazy. Did you mute it?" He reached over and clicked the button on the side of the watch-sized monitor on Vi's wrist before she seemingly had time to process his actions. Sure enough, the beeping that rang out was absolutely frantic, shockingly so.

Vi hurriedly scrambled to mute her monitor once more and glared daggers at Ekko, who was sharing a rather knowing smirk with Powder.

"Gee, wonder what that's all about." Powder teased.

Caitlyn felt every eye in the room shift to her and suddenly she was *very* interested in the steam coming off the mug of her coffee. She sipped at the warm liquid shyly, ignoring the absolute flaming state of her cheeks and the sudden twitch in her fingers.

Vi picked up a piece of bacon and flung it at Ekko's face. "You're such a shit."

Powder gasped, wrapping her arms around Ekko's head and crushing it against her chest. "How dare you fling highly saturated pork products at my man."

"Get him to mind his own damn business then." Vi grumbled, turning her attention back to her pancakes.

The second thing Caitlyn noticed about Vi, is that her ears turned red when she was embarrassed or shy. Caitlyn wanted to nibble on them.

"There's my hearty crew." Vander said enthusiastically as he sauntered in. "Enjoying breakfast?"

"Some more than others." Mylo teased, wiggling his eyebrows at Vi.

"You know what? I'm going back into space."

"Like hell you are." Ekko chuckled. "You guys should have heard all the whining. 'I can't wait to see her. This is killing me. I'm so damn pent up and horn-'"

This time Vi picked up an entire pancake and smothered it over Ekko's face. Powder squealed, nearly toppling off Ekko's lap in the chaos.

More teasing and wasting of breakfast food occurred, leaving Caitlyn giggling shyly where she stood. Vander sighed and gave her a fond smile. "Not joining in on the fun?"

Caitlyn shook her head. "I quite like this blouse, I would prefer not to get syrup all over it." Vander chuckled and Caitlyn hugged her mug to her chest. "Besides, I thought I'd give them some family time."

Vander hummed. "Well, you're part of the family now. So don't feel the need to hold back, aye?"

A warmth bloomed in Caitlyn's chest. She blinked, completely bewildered up at Vander. All of her anxieties and worries of alienation doused completely by the man's words. She looked back to the messy scene at the table, suddenly overwhelmed with fondness and a sense of belonging.

"Alright that's enough." Vander stepped in, grabbing the bottle of syrup from Mylo's hands that he had been about to dump onto Ekko's head. "Back to work with you all. I'm not paying you to make a mess out of the break room."

Everyone grumbled in submission, each getting up from the table and clearing away any residual mess from the food war. Vi walked over to Caitlyn, stopping wordlessly next to where she was draped against the wall.

The two stared at each other for a tense moment. Caitlyn thought back to Vi's quip from earlier. She was right, after talking nearly every day for eight months straight, Caitlyn was suddenly left without a clue what to say. All she could do was marvel at this stunning woman, completely lost in the haze of her overwhelming desire to just melt into Vi.

Caitlyn cleared her throat, blinking rapidly as she pushed off the wall and made her way out of the break room, knowing Vi would follow close behind.

Caitlyn could feel Vi's hungry gaze firm on the back of her neck as they walked. She couldn't help but swallow anxiously, rubbing at her neck and willing the heat creeping up her flesh there to subside.

They rounded the corner of her cubicle once more and Caitlyn immediately busied herself with retrieving the documentation Vander had given her earlier. She may have spent a second longer than necessary digging through the file, using it to take a deep, calming breath to steady out the erratic beating of her heart. She hadn't anticipated being this nervous, this on edge around Vi, but she also hadn't anticipated Vi being so utterly breathtaking and dominating in her presence alone.

Caitlyn turned from her desk and Vi was right there. Standing far too close for Caitlyn's sanity. She jumped slightly with a surprised squeak, quickly clearing her throat and ignoring the smug look on Vi's face.

"You can- um, grab that chair there and we'll fill these out. Yes?"

Vi didn't say anything. She stared Caitlyn down for a second before turning on her heel to retrieve the folding chair leaning against the wall outside of Caitlyn's cubicle. Caitlyn quickly took her own seat and shook her head, attempting to get a damn hold on herself. It was a bit frustrating, really. She had been able to smoothly match Vi's banter all these months and yet now her spine was practically made of jelly.

Vi pulled the chair up and slouched back into it, her hands in her jumpsuit pockets and legs spread in a casual yet tantalizing manner. Caitlyn refused to let her gaze linger there, electing to focus on her documents instead.

They were all out of order due to Caitlyn's earlier panic. Her brow furrowed as she focused on rearranging them, trying desperately not to notice the way Vi was watching her from her peripheral.

After a minute or two of tense shuffling and getting practically nowhere with her task, Caitlyn breathed out a shaky exhale. "You're staring."

Vi nodded slowly. "I'm staring."

God this atmosphere was intense.

Caitlyn steeled herself with an awkward chuckle and tried her best to throw a flirtatious smirk at Vi, quoting her astronaut from their very first day together. "Like what you see?"

Caitlyn could swear she saw Vi's pupils dilate slightly. She expected a witty retort, something fun and light hearted that went along with their usual banter but no. Instead there was an intensity to Vi's gaze that made Caitlyn's mouth go dry.

"Yes." Vi murmured, her eyes scanning down and back up Caitlyn's body slowly. "I do." Caitlyn's breath caught, a familiar warmth creeping up her skin and forcing her knees together. Vi caught the movement, her eyes narrowing on Caitlyn's stocking-clad legs. "I like it so much, in fact, that it's taking every ounce of my self control not to pull you out of that chair and pin you against this desk."

Caitlyn sputtered, glancing around anxiously and shifting uncomfortably in her chair. "We're at *work.*"

"That's never stopped you before." Her eyes flickered to the sleep bunk under Caitlyn's desk.

This woman was not good for Caitlyn's sanity.

"Shouldn't we- I don't know, start with holding hands or something?" Realistically, if Caitlyn had what she truly desired then Vi *would* be two fingers deep in her right there in the middle of the cubicle. However, considering how Caitlyn had almost collapsed earlier from just a small amount of proximity, she figured it best to cover the basics first lest her heart explode within her chest.

Wordlessly and without hesitation, Vi extended her arm, palm upright in a gesture of offering toward Caitlyn.

Oh. Caitlyn wasn't really expecting Vi to just offer it up like that. She hesitated for a moment, staring blankly at Vi's extended hand. If Vi felt any sort of impatience toward Caitlyn's anxious reluctance, she didn't show it in her stoic facade.

Caitlyn tentatively placed her own hand within Vi's. The contrast and size difference between them was doing things to her. Where Caitlyn's hands were delicate with long slender fingers, Vi's were strong, slightly rough from all her exercise and yet still so gentle.

Unthinkingly, Caitlyn pulled Vi's hand toward herself, the astronaut sitting up to brace the elbow of her free arm atop her knee to lean in closer. Caitlyn became lost for a moment, cradling the underside of Vi's upturned hand while the fingers of her free one traced the lines on her astronaut's palm. She slowly dragged her fingertips up, mapping out the veins on Vi's wrist and turning her arm over to follow the dark lines of ink etched into her skin.

Caitlyn knew she could spend hours there, completely enraptured by the softness and the warmth of Vi's skin, what she had desperately desired to feel over those long months. She chanced a look up at Vi's expression, and nearly gasped at what she saw there.

Vi was looking at her as if Caitlyn had hung the moon in the sky herself, like she was some sort of ethereal being that belonged amongst the stars.

"Do you know what the overview effect is?"

Caitlyn shook her head, bewildered. “No.”

“It’s something astronauts experience when viewing the Earth from space.” There was a soft sense of awe in Vi’s voice as she spoke, taking in every detail of Caitlyn’s expression. “It’s a psychological effect, a cognitive shift in our minds that leaves us so awestruck by the view that we can’t help but develop a new sense of connection to the planet and its beauty. I’ve experienced it many times… but it pales miserably in comparison to how it feels to look at you.”

Caitlyn’s sucked in a shaky gasp, completely at a loss to come up with any sort of words that could match such a heartfelt confession. There was nothing but a buzzing static in her head and an inevitable heat in her cheeks. Vi was just too all consuming, too overwhelming in her fidelity-

“Too much…”

“What’s too much?”

“You.” Caitlyn whispered, lost in the soft blue of Vi’s gaze. “You’re too much.”

Vi let out a soft, breathy laugh, turning her palm over to properly hold Caitlyn’s hand. “I’ll be whatever you want me to be.”

Caitlyn shook her head again, her eyes averted down to their joined hands. “You already are.”

It was unclear to Caitlyn how long they remained there, lost in this small amount of touch they shared. Caitlyn was glad she suggested this. It was the best place they could have started, a pleasant easing into what she knew was to come. As eager as she was to be absolutely devoured by Vi, they had all the time in the world for that later. For now, this was enough. Enough to quell the ache in her heart and the flicker of nerves in her gut.

“We should probably get those filled out so we can get out of here for that date, yeah?” Vi grinned, nodding toward the scattered documents on Caitlyn’s desk.

“Yes.” Caitlyn breathed out. She slowly slipped her hands away from Vi’s arm, already missing the warmth there. She’d had it for only a few minutes and yet Caitlyn could easily say she was addicted, drawn into everything that Vi was.

With her nerves settled slightly, Caitlyn began to shuffle through the papers with a newfound vigor, eagerly motivated to get them done so that she could have her time with Vi later. A warmth of realization draped over her, an understanding that Vi was truly there, with Caitlyn, *home.*

And now they would have all the time in the world together.

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Caitlyn took several, deep steadying breaths as she stared down her reflection in the full length mirror. How many times had she looked in this mirror after readying herself for work, for speaking to Vi? Far too many.

Now Vi would be arriving any minute to Caitlyn's apartment. It all felt surreal, dreamlike, even.

The two had finished their work and left the control center around four PM with the promise of later. Caitlyn had insisted she needed at least three hours to prepare their meal and ready herself and her apartment. Dinner had been ready and left to simmer, Caitlyn's apartment without a speck of dust, and her outfit chosen. Yet she still did not feel ready. She wasn't sure she ever truly would.

Her outfit of choice was relatively simple. A short, silk black dress with thin straps along with additional ruffled sleeves that fluttered down past her shoulders. It had a dipped sweetheart neckline and gathered slightly at the waist before fanning out and stopping about mid thigh. She elected for a simple pair of pearl earrings tucked away behind her cobalt locks, left down in wavy brushed out ringlets after a good thirty minutes with her curling iron.

Dinner was a simple pasta recipe. Nothing fancy. In all honesty, Caitlyn didn't care about the food itself or felt any particular desire to make something extraordinary. She had an alternative reason for wanting Vi to come over.

And no, it wasn't sex. Although she wouldn't be opposed to that either.

She began to pace back and forth as she awaited Vi's arrival, adjusting any small knick knacks and throw pillows as she went. Chowder gave her an unimpressed look from where he was laying on the couch. She ignored him, in no mood to receive judgement from her cat when the woman of her dreams was moments away from arriving.

The three soft knocks on the door had Caitlyn freeze in her step, a cold feeling of nerves filling out her chest. She took several deep breaths before padding over to her door, palm shaking slightly against the doorknob as she turned it to finally face her doom on the other side.

Caitlyn had already seen Vi in person that day, yet she still wasn't prepared for this. Vi was dressed in the infamous leather jacket from the photo on Caitlyn's desk, a simple heather grey ribbed tank top underneath with some low cut black washed jeans. Truth be told, it didn't matter what Vi wore, Caitlyn was sure she'd look divine in anything.

Vi seemed stunned as she stood in Caitlyn's doorway, her wide eyes flickering up and down Caitlyn's body. She let out a long breath and Caitlyn was beginning to feel a heat creeping up on her from how her astronaut was staring. It felt extraordinarily similar to this morning, from the first moment Vi had seen her. Only this time, Vi seemed significantly more flustered.

"Hi." Caitlyn was the one to break the silence this time, snapping Vi out of her daze.

“Hey.” Vi’s voice sounded a bit raw, like she was parched. She quickly cleared it away, that same red from earlier tinging the edges of her pierced ears.

Caitlyn bit her lip to hold back a smile, stepping aside to offer Vi space to enter. “Do you want to come in or would you prefer to have dinner in the hallway?”

Vi scoffed with an eye roll before stepping inside. “She puts on a sexy dress and suddenly finds her voice.”

Caitlyn giggled as she shut the door behind her. “My mother always did say dressing for success builds confidence.”

“Mm. Your mother sounds wise.” Vi continued to openly stare down the expanse of Caitlyn’s body until she glanced suddenly at where Chowder had begun to rub against her own leg . “Oh, hey. If it isn’t the infamous Clam Chowder.”

“Yes, my ever so loving furry gargoyle.” Caitlyn rolled her eyes watching as Vi reached down to scratch at the base of Chowder’s neck. “I wouldn’t bother, I’m afraid he only likes… men…”

Caitlyn’s words died in her mouth as she watched Vi scoop Chowder up in her arm as if he weighed nothing, cradling him like a baby and proceeding to scratch underneath his furry chin. Chowder stretched pleasantly in her arms, soft purrs resounding from his throat.

“Unbelievable.” Caitlyn was completely dumbfounded and slightly betrayed. “He never lets me hold him like that.”

Vi smirked, offering a sly shrug. “What can I say? I’m good with-”

“Please, spare me.”

Vi cackled maniacally, releasing the cat to then shrug off her jacket. Caitlyn sucked in a breath at the sight of Vi’s exposed arms. It took her all the way back to that night she had watched the fitness video, sputtering like a fool and fidgeting with her own fingers as she ogled.

Vi tossed her jacket onto the back of a chair at Caitlyn’s kitchen table, smirking to herself but otherwise leaving Caitlyn’s obvious panic unacknowledged. She began to look curiously around Caitlyn’s apartment, taking slow steps as she went about. She suddenly stopped short at the kitchen counter, a curious brow raised as she inspected the metal cloche set upon it. “This looks fancy. What’s under here?”

Caitlyn shuffled up to the counter, shyly biting her lip. “It’s a surprise for you.”

“A surprise, huh?” Vi eyed the dome suspiciously. “You didn’t have to do anything special for me.”

“I wanted to. You’ve worked so hard, you deserve something special and, well, to be honest I’ve had this planned for a long time.”

“Well now I’m curious.” She flashed a charming smirk, her fingertips brushing the metal dome. “You gonna keep me waiting in suspense?”

Caitlyn hummed, the butterflies in her stomach wildly flapping their wings. “Well it’s supposed to be for later but… I see no harm in showing you now.” Quite the contrary, actually. Caitlyn didn’t think she *could* wait until later.

“Well don’t keep edging me, let’s see it.” Her astronaut leaned casually against the counter, grinning widely at Caitlyn. She looked so effortless and natural in Caitlyn’s apartment that it seemed like she belonged there. It made Caitlyn feel strangely fuzzy and comfortable.

Caitlyn steadied her breath and pinched the small knob atop the cloche, pulling it up and out of the way dramatically for the reveal. She watched with bated breath as Vi’s smile slowly fell from her lips, replaced with a stunned look of shocked awe.

“Cait… are these-”

“They’re probably not *exactly* the same.” Caitlyn said shyly. She placed the lid aside, watching as Vi picked up one of the white frosted cupcakes decorated with a caramel swirl and brown sugar crystals.

It took Vi a moment to speak, leaving Caitlyn in a frenzied state of anxiety. She twisted her thumbs awkwardly, but allowed Vi to take her time absorbing what she saw before her.

“You made my mother’s cupcakes.” Her voice was so soft and awed, an unspoken depth of gratitude and something else Caitlyn couldn’t place present in her eyes.

“Well, I tried my best.” She tucked a long wave of hair behind her ear and shrugged. “It took a lot of trial and error. Vander said he was going to bill me for his gym membership because of all the test ones I had him try.”

Vi seemed absolutely stunned as she inspected the treat. Her eyes found Caitlyn’s once more and Caitlyn could swear she saw moisture gathering in Vi’s waterline.

“Can I try one?”

Caitlyn nodded. “Of course. They’re for you, silly.”

Vi chuckled softly, Caitlyn watching eagerly as she peeled back the paper along the base and took a bite. Her eyes blew wide, staring disbelievingly at the cupcake as she chewed.

Caitlyn fidgeted. “Not too bad?”

Vi placed the cupcake back on the platter, shaking her head disbelievingly. “I don’t know how you did it but… they taste exactly like I remember.”

“Oh posh, you’re just saying that.”

“No. No, I promise I’m not.” Caitlyn was inclined to believe her. There was such raw honesty and gratitude in Vi’s expression, it was hard not to trust her words. “I can’t believe you did

this for me…"

Caitlyn shrugged with nonchalance. "Like I said, you deserve it."

There was an unreadable expression on Vi's face, a deep furrow to her brow in focus as she looked at Caitlyn.

Caitlyn let out a small giggle, unable to take Vi seriously with icing stuck to her face. "You have frosting-" She reached over and swiped the white smudge from the tip of Vi's nose, unthinkingly bringing it to her mouth and wrapping her lips around her sugar coated finger.

Vi sucked in a sharp breath.

Caitlyn froze, immediately able to feel the palpable static of arousal that sparked to life in the short distance between them. Caitlyn's cerulean gaze bore into Vi's hungry eyes, and it was then that she made a decision.

Fuck her nerves. Fuck starting slow. Fuck the dinner.

She'd waited long enough.

Caitlyn very deliberately, slowly pulled the finger from her mouth, pursing her lips around it as she went and leveling Vi with the most seductive look she could muster.

And then, something in Vi seemed to snap.

A strong palm found Caitlyn's hip, the other sliding around to the back of her neck as she was spun to press her lower back up against the countertop. A shocked expression crossed Caitlyn's features before it was quickly doused away by Vi leaning into her and pressing their lips together *hard.*

Caitlyn's brain short circuited for all of half a second before she gasped into the kiss, her own palms immediately reaching for either side of Vi's face to pull her in further.

Caitlyn always thought her first kiss with Vi would be soft, delicate and shy. A slow build up similar to what it had almost been earlier that day at the comm center. But this-

This was frantic. Desperate, hungry, and consuming.

Caitlyn couldn't help but whimper as Vi fucking devoured her lips like a woman starved. Vi's lips felt and tasted like Caitlyn had always dreamed, better even. Like the sweetness of the cupcake. She found herself completely lost in the way they molded against one another, a shudder snaking up her spine from how Vi gripped at Caitlyn's hip like she was afraid someone would steal her away.

More. Caitlyn needed *more.*

She tilted her head to the side, her fingers tangling into the long magenta strands at the back of Vi's neck, grunting softly as she pushed back against Vi's aggression. A sinful moan was pulled from her astronaut's throat, a curse whispered on her breath in between the chaotic

smacking of their lips. Caitlyn gasped in a shaky breath of her own and Vi used the opportunity to lick into her mouth.

And suddenly a boundary had been crossed between hungry and frantic, to downright filthy and sinful.

The wet sound of their tongues tangling had mixed together with a myriad of trembling huffs of breath and soft whimpers, creating a borderline unholy cacophony of lust. Caitlyn felt herself getting damn near drunk off of it, completely lost in the dance of their lips and the push and pull of their flush bodies against one another. She felt a burst of heat below that had her clenching around nothing but the dampness quickly spreading there. All just from the glide of their lips and press of their bodies.

Caitlyn could feel all the curves of Vi's muscles pressing against her, the warmth of her body that Caitlyn had craved for all those months *finally* enveloping her own. She felt greedy in the ways she wanted more, desperate pleas echoing in her head for Vi to touch her more, devour her more.

Vi suddenly broke the kiss and dragged her lips down Caitlyn's jawline, pressing hard pecks against the skin there as she went. Caitlyn angled her head to the side with an nervous exhale to give her astronaut full access, her arms tightening around Vi's neck with an unspoken desperation to be closer.

Soft lips began to pull and suck at Caitlyn's pulse point, soliciting a high pitched and downright needy whine that she didn't even think possible from her own lips. She could feel Vi shudder in her grasp before moving back up to Caitlyn's lips, pressing one last hard kiss there but then suddenly breaking it off.

"Shit-" Vi breathed out against Caitlyn's lips, exasperated. "I'm so sorry."

Caitlyn blinked, still very much drunk on her arousal but slightly taken aback as her laboured breath came out in heavy puffs. "Sorry? For- for what?"

The grip on Caitlyn's waist tightened, she gasped and arched further into it, pulling a frustrated groan from Vi's throat. "I was going to wine and dine you first, really I was but- fuck, how can I possibly hold back when you look at me like that?"

Caitlyn swallowed, her arms sliding down to hold either side of Vi's neck, her thumb brushing against the ink embedded there. "I don't want you to hold back."

Vi stared deeply into Caitlyn's eyes. There was a tantalizing intensity swimming in her greyish hues as her nose scrunched cutely with frustration. "Don't tell me that." She reconnected their lips again, this time slow, as if she were trying to restrain herself. Caitlyn was beginning to get antsy, impatient as Vi pulled back once more to press their foreheads together instead.

"Do you have any idea how long I waited for this?"

Despite her growing neediness, Caitlyn smiled softly, now twirling her fingers around the longer strands of Vi's hair. "Around eight months or so, I'd wager."

"No." Vi shook her head, her eyes closing and brow furrowing with a newfound sense of focus. "No, it was longer than that. I think… I think I've spent my whole life waiting for you."

Caitlyn's heart ached, that flame of arousal now tinged with a fondness that had her itching to pour her own heart out for Vi. She placed a delicate kiss to the corner of Vi's lips, her voice laced with a genuine vow of devotion. "You have me now."

Vi swallowed, her resolve seemingly crumbling before Caitlyn's eyes. "Can I?" She whispered, her eyes searching Caitlyn's face. "Can I have you now?"

Caitlyn licked her lips, her breath a pleading whisper. "Yes."

"And you're sure it's not too fast? I know we talked a big game but I don't want to rush you. Are you sure you want-"

"Violet."

Vi blinked. "Yeah?"

"I have done nothing but listen to you speak for the last eight months." Caitlyn's grip tightened in Vi's hair, practically clawing at the back of her neck. Vi sucked in a shocked breath. "So now I need you to shut up and *fuck* me."

"Shit-" Vi practically fucking growled in response, surging forward to capture Caitlyn's lips eagerly once more. Caitlyn whimpered, her legs parting and back arching into Vi as an invitation that her astronaut took instantaneously. She slid her rough palms down and behind Caitlyn's thighs, lifting her effortlessly onto the countertop and slotting herself in between Caitlyn's legs where she was growing hotter and wetter by the second.

Vi's hands and lips were everywhere, bunching up Caitlyn's dress on her hips, devouring her lips and down her neck. Caitlyn's breath fanned out in labored huffs as she tilted her head back, eyes closing and allowing herself to become completely lost in the way her astronaut grabbed at her hungrily like she was downright starved.

Vi's fingers slid beneath the thin straps on Caitlyn's shoulders, letting the silk fall down as she kissed and sucked down the column of Caitlyn's throat, no doubt leaving angry dark spots in her wake. Caitlyn slipped her arms from the sleeves, her dress falling easily due to the slippery fabric and gathering around her waist.

"Fuck, you're so beautiful." Vi murmured. Her strong arm looped behind Caitlyn's lower back, her palm spreading there in support as she pushed Caitlyn into arching backward. One of Caitlyn's arms fell back to brace against the countertop so that she wouldn't fall over while the other held on tight to her astronaut's shoulder.

Vi groaned softly as she began to suck hard at the base of Caitlyn's neck, slowly dragging her lips down toward Caitlyn's chest. God, the anticipation was insane. Caitlyn lifted her hips off the counter, a desperate whine emanating from her throat. She needed Vi between her legs, needed to clench around her fingers, her tongue, fucking anything.

Vi's free hand met Caitlyn's hipbone, pushing her back down against the counter. "Behave, Caitlyn."

Caitlyn groaned in frustration. "Please, this is- this is cruel."

"So fucking needy." Vi breathed out against Caitlyn's chest, her palm sliding up from Caitlyn's hip to cup the lace covered plush of her bra. "And here I was gonna take my time with you."

Caitlyn shuddered, relishing in the feeling of Vi's thumb teasingly grazing along the top edge of her bra, dipping under slightly. Vi smirked. "What was it that you said all those months ago, huh?" She made her way back up to the hollow below Caitlyn's ear, a sinful whisper on her lips. "That you'd be a good little slut for me?"

There was a third thing that Caitlyn then discovered about Vi at that moment. Something she probably should have picked up from their intimacy over the comm line, but had chalked it up to the necessities of phone sex at the time.

Vi liked to talk dirty.

"I-um…" A spark shot down Caitlyn's spine and gathered in her groin, her thighs squeezing together around Vi but unable to get the friction she needed below.

"Well?" Vi's breath was hot against Caitlyn's neck. "You gonna be good for me, cupcake?"

"Yes." Caitlyn breathed out, biting her lip and making a show of just how desperately she ached for Vi's touch.

"Wanna hear you say it."

"I'll- I'll be good for you."

"Yeah I know you will."

She deftly reached around and unhooked Caitlyn strapless bra with a flick of her wrist, pulling the fabric from Caitlyn's body and tossing it aside elsewhere.

Vi then leaned back to just look.

Caitlyn felt so exposed, so spread open and bare for Vi. Her nipples perked up in the cool air they were now exposed to, chest heaving with the frantic breaths she was pulling into her lungs. It would be a lie to say this didn't heighten Caitlyn's arousal. She loved feeling exposed but being this way for Vi? Becoming lost once more in the intensity of her astronaut's gaze? It had her practically dripping below.

Vi's arm flexed behind Caitlyn's back, the other finding its way to the back of her head before lacing into the cobalt strands there. She combed her fingers backward through Caitlyn's hair, stopping as she got to the base to then twist the locks around her palm and *pull.*

"Ah!" Caitlyn gasped out a cry at the sudden force, her head falling backward at the strength of Vi's tug, making her back arch sinfully and pushing her chest out further.

Vi dove in and closed her lips around Caitlyn's left nipple, sucking softly for a moment before popping off and flicking her tongue lightly against the reddening peak. A broken cry slipped from Caitlyn's throat as she stared up at the ceiling with wide eyes. Her fingers dug into Vi's shoulders for dear life, unable to move or do much else as she was locked in her astronaut's grasp.

Vi's lips dragged along Caitlyn's chest to tease and suck at the other peak of her breast with a hungry moan. Caitlyn's body felt so tight, pulled taut like the strings of a violin for Vi to play. She trembled at the notion, the idea that she was to be toyed with, *used* by her astronaut.

The tension in Caitlyn's neck snapped once Vi released her hair in favor of gripping Caitlyn's hip. She bit down gently against Caitlyn's nipple, ever so slowly gliding her palm along the top of her thigh and slipping under the bunched fabric of Caitlyn's dress.

Caitlyn sucked in a breath once she felt Vi's fingertips graze the inside of her thigh, moving further up toward where Caitlyn was already fucking soaked and ready.

Caitlyn could feel the dampness that clung to her inner thighs. Once Vi sucked in a sharp gasp from where she was still bent over Caitlyn's chest, it was obvious she had discovered this as well. "God, you're so fucking wet."

"Yes-" Caitlyn spread her legs further apart, resisting the urge to push down against Vi's fingers. She gave Vi's shoulder a little tug, pulling her back up to eye level so she could lean in and whisper against her lips. "I'm so wet for you, Violet."

"Fuck." Violet groaned, gripping at Caitlyn's inner thigh. "I'm gonna taste you now, yeah?"

"Yes." Caitlyn whined. "Yes *please.*"

"Let go and lay back, baby. I got you."

Caitlyn trusted the strength in Vi's arm enough to release her shoulder, falling back slowly until her back hit the cool countertop and arching against it.

"Good girl." Vi breathed out, placing a soft kiss between Caitlyn's breasts and slowly trailing downward. Caitlyn's body began to tremble the closer and closer Vi got to between her legs. She dropped another soft kiss just below Caitlyn's belly button, wrapping her fingers around the crumpled fabric of Caitlyn's dress to pull it down over her legs before spreading them once more.

Vi then promptly froze, eyes widening at the sight before her. “Oh my god.” Vi breathed out. “Are these-?”

“The ones I told you about, yes.”

“Shit.” Vi traced her fingers over the blue butterfly shaped lace of Caitlyn’s panties, dragging her thumb down to where the fabric spread to completely expose Caitlyn’s cunt.

Vi’s breath became laboured as she experimentally dipped her thumb between the wet folds. Caitlyn gasped, her fingers clawing against the marble beneath her. Vi was taking this at a torturously slow pace but despite Caitlyn’s desperation, she couldn’t fault her for it. This was a lot for them, a culmination of months worth of desperation and desire. It only made sense that her astronaut was a bit wonderstruck.

“Vi?”

Vi glanced up, her eyes darting all over Caitlyn’s flushed features.

“*Please.*” Caitlyn whispered.

And that’s all it took.

Vi dragged her middle finger up the center of Caitlyn’s pussy, gathering some of the slick there before slipping inside. Caitlyn’s eyes rolled back into her head, unable to hold back the sinful moan she let out or resist the urge to grind her hips down any longer.

“That’s it, baby. Taking it so well.” Vi bent down to drop a kiss to the center of the lace butterfly. She slid her free hand underneath Caitlyn’s knee, hiking it up to place her foot on the edge of the countertop. “Stay spread like this for me, yeah?”

“Yes.” Caitlyn whimpered, her gut clenching in anticipation for what was to come next.

Vi twisted and pulled her finger in and out slowly, her intense gaze locked onto Caitlyn’s as she bent down to press a soft kiss against the hood of Caitlyn’s clit before wrapping her lips around the small bud and pulling it gently into her mouth.

“Oh my *god*-” Caitlyn’s body shook, her hips twitching wantonly as Vi sucked at her clit and curled her rough finger in deep. She pulled the single digit out for a moment in favor of flattening her tongue and dragging up the entire expanse of Caitlyn’s wet core. She repeated this motion a few times, slowly building Caitlyn up to becoming a whimpering mess right in the middle of her kitchen.

Vi moaned hungrily, the vibrations of it buzzing softly into Caitlyn’s warmth. She stared Caitlyn down and suddenly flexed her tongue, pressing it inside of Caitlyn to straight up fuck her with it.

Caitlyn cried out Vi’s name, an echo of it on her lips as if it were something holy. Her shaky palm reached down to lace into Vi’s hair, needing to hold on as she began to move her hips in tempo with her astronaut's ministrations.

Vi pulled her tongue out to return her attention to Caitlyn's clit. She brought her fingers back to Caitlyn's entrance, two this time, and twisted them inside while she sucked, steadily dragging them in a curling motion directly into Caitlyn's g-spot.

"Vi-Violet I can't-" Her voice broke on a whine, a warmth building below and sending her body into a shaking frenzy as she inched closer to her climax.

"Come on." Vi breathed out in between licking and sucking at where Caitlyn was most sensitive. "Cum on my tongue, baby."

Caitlyn did just that. Her walls clenching down hard around Vi's fingers as she shook with the magnitude of her orgasm. She lay there trembling, back bowed against the countertop as the sparks lit up her abdomen, clenching and pulling her so tight while she trembled with her high. Vi gently stroked her through it with a soothing palm running up the underside of Caitlyn's bent thigh, humming appreciatively between her legs.

There were white spots in Caitlyn's vision that she blinked rapidly to clear, an astounding wave of relief washing over her like a warm tide. She felt weightless, euphoric with embers of arousal still flickering below.

Vi gently slipped her fingers out to straighten up, wiping her mouth off on the back of her hand and bending down over Caitlyn with a soft care and concern in her gaze. She laid her palm against Caitlyn's cheek, careful to keep the wet fingers from touching Caitlyn's skin.

"Hey, you good?"

Caitlyn hummed happily with a soft nod. "Mm, read you loud and clear."

Vi snorted. "Oh my god, stop."

"Comms good and stable. Beginning post orgasm phase."

Vi burst in a breathy fit of hysterics, leaning in to capture Caitlyn's lips in a soft kiss as she shook with her laughter. "You're so silly after you cum."

"And whose fault is that?" Caitlyn teased. She reached up to grasp Vi's hand from her cheek, bringing the two fingers Vi had just used to pull blinding pleasure out of her to Caitlyn's lips.

Vi sucked in a gasp as Caitlyn wrapped her lips around the damp fingers, tasting the tanginess of her own juices on them and sucking them off with an appreciative moan.

"Holy shit." Vi breathed out, completely mesmerized. She pushed her fingers in further, her hungry gaze narrowing whilst Caitlyn swirled her tongue around the two appendages.

Vi swallowed, her brow furrowed in concentration. She pulled her fingers from Caitlyn's mouth to kiss her instead, immediately pressing her tongue past Caitlyn's lips. Caitlyn could taste herself on Vi's lips, surprised to find it was having quite an astounding affect on her. The heat began to build back up slowly, Caitlyn lacing her arms around Vi's neck and grinding up into her with the greedy desire for more.

Vi cursed against Caitlyn's lips. "How many times can you cum?"

"Oh." Caitlyn fidgeted. "I- I dunno. I've never tried more than once before."

"Well we're gonna fix that." She suddenly yanked Caitlyn forward by her hips, scooping her up off the counter as if she weighed nothing. Caitlyn squealed, wrapping her legs around Vi's waist and holding on tightly as her astronaut gripped below her thighs to walk them further into the apartment.

"Violet! You shouldn't be doing this, you're still recovering."

Vi ignored her, adjusting Caitlyn slightly in her arms. "Bedroom?"

Caitlyn gripped Vi's shoulders tightly, tilting her head in the direction of the doorway to their right.

Vi strolled into Caitlyn's room like it was a walk in the park and gingerly laid her down across the silk sheets. Caitlyn let herself fall backwards, arms spread above her head and a warm glow to her cheeks. Vi positioned herself on the bed on all fours over Caitlyn, gazing down at the expanse of her body with stunned wonder.

"I can't believe you've been this gorgeous the whole time." She placed her palm against Caitlyn's collarbones, gently dragging it down the center of Caitlyn's abdomen and then back up to cup her breast, grazing a thumb over her nipple. Caitlyn bit her lip, beginning to squirm underneath Vi as she lit the sparks of arousal once more. "Three ducks in a trench coat my ass."

Caitlyn giggled shyly, reaching up to brush her fingertips along Vi's cheek. Vi grabbed Caitlyn's hand and brought it to her lips, pressing a kiss to her palm and then once more to the pulse point on Caitlyn's wrist. There was something so intimate in the action, like Vi was placing a vow onto Caitlyn's skin. She ached to do the same in return.

Caitlyn's free hand gripped at the fabric of Vi's shirt at her waist, tugging twice. "Off." She pouted. She couldn't believe Vi was still fully clothed. A downright crime.

Vi chuckled and sat back on her heels, gripping the bottom of her shirt but pausing momentarily to glance around the room. Caitlyn frowned.

"Sorry, just checking to make sure there's no flower vases at risk."

Caitlyn groaned and smacked her palms over her face. "Oh my god *please*."

Vi chuckled, finally pulling her tank top up and away to then follow it up with her sports bra. Caitlyn's breath caught, her brain short circuiting while trying to process the stunning expanse of Vi's muscular torso. She reached her fingers out and brushed the tips of them down Vi's abs, marveling at the way they flexed as she did so.

"Beautiful…" Caitlyn murmured, completely in awe.

Vi's ears reddened slightly, her brow furrowing as she sat back and allowed Caitlyn to just *feel* her. After a moment of quiet filled only with their awestruck breath, Caitlyn found Vi's gaze once more. Vi was concentrating hard on something, Caitlyn could practically see the gears turning in her mind.

"Tell me what you're thinking?" She asked softly.

Vi took the hand Caitlyn had been brushing across her stomach, bringing it up to place a delicate kiss on her knuckles before falling forward to cage Caitlyn beneath her once more.

"I'm thinking that with a view like this, I'll never need to go into space again."

It was just talk. It had to be. Just romantic jargon in the heat of the moment. Caitlyn wouldn't allow herself to believe Vi would give up her dreams for something as silly as… well, her.

She wouldn't acknowledge it now. She'd chalk it up to the heat of the moment and brush past it.

Caitlyn twisted her arms around Vi's neck to pull her down for another heated kiss. God, she could get lost in the way Vi's lips moved against hers. Spend hours twirling her tongue around Vi's and swallowing her moans.

An idea suddenly came to Caitlyn, a downright bratty one but amusing to her nonetheless. She reached back to graze her fingertips along Vi's forearm where it was braced against the bed by Caitlyn's head, stroking downward until she reached the monitor on her astronaut's wrist. She pressed the button on the side, a devastatingly frantic beeping resounding through the air.

Vi tensed, pulling back from Caitlyn slightly to glare at where Caitlyn's fingers were wrapped around the monitor. "You little brat."

Caitlyn giggled and pressed the button once more to stop the beeping. "I just wanted to hear it again is all."

Vi sighed, lifting a palm off the bed to brush her thumb against Caitlyn's cheekbone. "It's all for you."

The butterflies in Caitlyn's gut had returned, fluttering softly around with a gentle feeling of love. It was incredible how affected she could be by Vi's words of devotion, how much she ached to speak her feelings in return.

Vi bent down to press soft kisses down the side of Caitlyn's neck. Where earlier it had been frantic and starved, it was now soft and unbelievably tender, but riling Caitlyn up just the same.

"Shit." Vi suddenly cursed, her arms shaking slightly with the effort of holding herself up.

"What's wrong?" Caitlyn grasped Vi's face in her palms, searching her suddenly paled expression.

“I just- I might have overdone it a bit.” Vi breathed out.

Caitlyn panicked slightly, shimmying underneath Vi and pushing lightly on her shoulder. “Come on, lay down. You shouldn’t push yourself.”

Vi groaned and flopped unceremoniously over onto her back. “Fuck. This vertigo shit is so annoying.”

“You were in space for a year without gravity. Of course you’re going to be off kilter for a while.”

“Still annoying.” Vi turned to look at where Caitlyn had propped herself up next to her. She lifted her arm to stroke the back of her fingers up Caitlyn’s side. “I wasn’t done with you.”

Caitlyn bit her lip, eyeing the expanse of Vi’s bare torso. She gingerly returned her palm to Vi’s abs, not missing the way the muscles clenched under her touch. She slowly dragged her fingers up, ghosting them over Vi’s breast with a tantalizingly light touch. Vi let out a shuddering breath and Caitlyn took it as an invitation, slowly grazing over Vi’s nipple and pinching down to roll it between her fingers.

“Fuck, Cait-“ Vi breathed out,

“I’ll take care of it now.” Caitlyn leaned in to press a kiss to Vi’s collarbone. “Just relax.”

Vi did as she was told, letting her eyes fall shut as Caitlyn’s fingertips traced into the divots and curves of her muscles. Caitlyn felt as though she was tracing the lines of a sculpture, firm and yet so soft all at once. It was as if she was carved especially for Caitlyn, embodying everything she had dreamed Vi would be.

Caitlyn took her time to graze over the expanse of Vi’s body, something she had ached to do for countless months. She traced her collarbones, across her shoulders and down her arms, up Vi’s sides and across her breasts to offer more soft pinches and pulls at her astronaut’s nipples. Vi was a shuddering mess throughout it all, her breath laced with a shaky desperation.

Caitlyn sat up and decided she’d had enough of Vi not being fully nude. She popped open the buttons of Vi’s jeans and tugged them downward along with her briefs, the astronaut lifting her hips for a moment to allow Caitlyn to rid the material. Caitlyn then slid her own undergarments down and tossed them aside, leaving both of them completely exposed for one another.

Their encounter in the kitchen had been downright feverish, the culmination of months of pining exploding out of them like a shaken bottle of soda finally releasing its cap. Now it was slow, methodical and intimate. Both lost in a state of awe as they took the time to take each other in completely. They were in their own world, locked into a bubble of desire that had Caitlyn in a bit of a trance.

She braced herself over Vi, her back arching like a cat in a sinful manner as she hovered over her astronaut. Her hair fell in such a way that created a dark curtain around them before Vi

reached up to tuck one side behind Caitlyn's ear, letting her palm linger there and stroking against Caitlyn's jawline.

Every touch lit a fire under Caitlyn's flesh and a spark in her gut. She had never felt such a pull towards someone before. It was as if gravity itself had created taught strings that bound them together.

Caitlyn very slowly placed her lips against Vi's, focusing on the feeling of them shaping around one another. She flicked her tongue against the small scar that slashed through Vi's upper lip and Vi's grip tightened against her neck, hot breath puffing out in the miniscule space between them.

Her fingertips returned to Vi's flesh, starting at the center of her chest and sliding down, over the ridges of Vi's abdomen, through the soft patch of dark pink curls and down between her legs.

"Caitlyn…" Vi broke their silence with a broken whisper, her legs parting to give Caitlyn access to what she wanted.

Caitlyn shushed Vi gently, her fingers parting to trace the outer edges of Vi's cunt and spreading the slick moisture that had gathered there. She teased at Vi's entrance for a bit, watching her astronaut's expression morph into something intense, almost anguished in her desire.

They weren't kissing, but their lips were ghosting against one another, bated breath mingling in the intensity of the moment. Caitlyn's fingers slipped between Vi's wet folds, tracing up and down for a moment until dipping down into the opening and slipping two fingers inside, knowing Vi could take it.

Vi's lips parted on a shuttered gasp against Caitlyn's. It sparked something new in Caitlyn, an overwhelming desire to pleasure another person that she had never felt in such magnitude. She twisted her wrist with the motion of dragging her fingers in and out, her breath quickening in pace with the intense focus of making this good for Vi.

Her astronaut's arm flexed as she pulled Caitlyn in to connect their lips together one more. Caitlyn angled her head, allowing Vi to simply devour her lips as her hips flexed up into Caitlyn's touch. The dance of their tongues became messier and messier in time with the increasing pace of Caitlyn's movements. She angled her palm down, pressing it against Vi's clit and allowing her astronaut to grind up into it.

"*Fuck.*" Vi whimpered against Caitlyn's mouth, followed by a low moan as Caitlyn sucked her bottom lip between her teeth. "Shit- Wait, Caitlyn-"

Caitlyn's motions slowed, her eyelashes fluttering as she blinked at Vi. "Yes?"

Vi wordlessly reached between them, bringing her fingers down the center of Caitlyn's drenched pussy and languidly dragging them along. Caitlyn moaned softly, her limbs trembling slightly as her body shook with anticipation.

“Wanna feel you against me.” Vi whispered as she stroked her fingers in between Caitlyn’s folds. “Wanna cum like that, please.”

Caitlyn swallowed, a spark of nerves and excitement lighting her up below. “Yes, okay.”

She retracted her fingers from between Vi’s legs, parting her own to straddle one over Vi’s hips and line their centers against one another. Vi bent one of her legs, spreading it further to the side so that Caitlyn could easily fit herself between them.

Caitlyn wasn’t sure why her heart was pounding at that moment as she ground her hips down, their wet cunts gliding against one another in a molten heat that shot a jolt straight up Caitlyn’s body.

“Oh my god-” Caitlyn cried out. She hadn’t expected it to feel this *good.* The pace of her hips picked up speed and became frantic, needy whimpers and whines slipping past her throat and mixing with Vi’s own moans of pleasure.

“Yeah, just like that.” Vi reached down to grip Caitlyn’s hips, tracing her hipbones and encouraging the gyration of their hips. “You’re so damn good, Cait.”

Caitlyn pushed herself upright, arching backwards and gripping onto Vi’s thighs as she ground them together. She clenched at the slick feeling, angling her head to the side as she became completely lost in the spine tingling sensation.

Vi’s eyes blew wide as they took Caitlyn in while she rode out the high. She cursed under her breath, one rough palm sliding up to grasp at Caitlyn’s breast as her own hips lifted to move in tandem with Caitlyn’s. The hunger in Vi’s eyes, the twitch of her lips and the sheen of sweat on her skin sent a shiver up Caitlyn’s spine, mixing with that climbing white hot feeling below that put a stutter in her hip’s movement.

“I’m so close, Vi.” Caitlyn breathed out, her voice absolutely wrecked.

“Yeah.” Vi groaned, her breath laboured and body trembling below. “Me too.”

“It- it feels so good.” Caitlyn threw her head back, unable to keep the symphony of moans at bay as she got closer to the edge. “God, Violet, I love feeling how wet you are against me-”

“Shit.” Vi seemed to have found a newfound sense of vigor. She shot up and in an instant their positions were switched, Caitlyn now on her back with her hair splayed out against the sheets. Vi ground her hips down hard and Caitlyn could see those familiar stars once more.

“*Yes*-” She cried out, reaching up to claw at Vi’s shoulder blades. “Vi-Violet, I can’t hold-”

“I know, I’m there with you.” Vi ghosted her lips along Caitlyn’s, her body beginning to tremble above. “Cum with me, baby.”

Caitlyn cried out against Vi’s lips, hot tears of overstimulation gathering in her waterline as she shook with a climax somehow much more intense than the first. Vi’s body also trembled with the intensity of her own orgasm. There was something so intense and special about them

reaching that point in unison. It left a fluttery feeling in Caitlyn's heart, an overjoyed sense of euphoria unparalleled by anything she had felt before.

They stayed like that for a moment, shaking and breathing heavily in one another's arms until Vi's limbs gave out on her and she collapsed at Caitlyn's side, remaining close. She kept her grip on Caitlyn's hip although it had softened significantly, her thumb stroking in soothing circles against where Caitlyn's hip bone stuck out.

As Caitlyn regained her sense of surrounding, she felt a new sort of neediness, a desperation for proximity. She pulled herself toward Vi, uncaring of the sweat coating both of their skin or the slick drying on their fingers. She buried herself in Vi's neck, nuzzling against the warm expanse of it while Vi tugged at her hip to pull them closer together. Caitlyn became wrapped in a deep understanding of just how much she had needed this, the aching hole in her heart she had yearned to fill for all of those long months finally filling up and overflowing with the warmth of their bodies pressed together.

Vi pressed a kiss to Caitlyn's forehead, her fingers stroking through the now tangled mess of Caityn's hair as the two let themselves be lost in the comfort and euphoria of their love making.

Caitlyn thought back to that first night of pleasure they had over the comm system, the drop and cold feeling she had felt afterward having not been able to hold her astronaut after. She couldn't help the joyful tear that streaked down her face, pooling against where her cheek met Vi's skin. She could finally feel her, feel the thrum of her heart and the warmth of her breath.

She could feel that Vi was *real.*

Their blissful silence was suddenly interrupted with the rumble of Vi's stomach.

Caitlyn snorted, turning further into Vi's neck to muffle her laughter as Vi groaned.

"Sorry." Caitlyn spoke softly, still afraid to break the bubble of ecstasy they had created. "We probably shouldn't have skipped dinner."

"Well I don't know about you but I had a wonderful meal in your kitchen already."

"Oh my god." Caitlyn giggled, stroking her palm up Vi's side. "Well if you'd like some actual food, it should still be warm on the stove."

"Mm. What's on the menu? Burnt instant mac n' cheese?"

"On second thought, starve."

Vi's laugh was absolutely beautiful, like the soft sound of wind chimes on a summer breeze. "I'll happily eat whatever you make me, cupcake."

"Oh good, because I have a pint of mint chocolate chip ice cream in the freezer-"

"Nevermind, starvation sounds divine."

The two lost themselves in a fit of laughter, neither wanting to make the first move to actually get out of bed and part from each other's touch. Vi's stomach grumbled again and Caitlyn rolled her eyes, being the first to break contact and sliding off the bed to retrieve some clothes from her dresser.

She could feel Vi's gaze on her as she pulled out a simple grey NASA t-shirt and some sweats, no longer feeling the need to bother with the theatrics of a sexy silk dress. She slipped the t-shirt over her head and turned to look at Vi, who was indeed propped up on her elbows simply watching Caitlyn with an awed reverence.

Caitlyn quirked a curious brow at Vi. "Do you intend to eat naked?"

"That is my favorite pastime." She winked at Caitlyn, who rolled her eyes fondly in reply. She scooped up Vi's clothes off the floor and tossed them at her astronaut. Vi feigned like she had been hit with a bullet and fell back dramatically.

"You really are a drama queen." Caitlyn chuckled as she finished dressing. She found herself smiling like a fool as she walked out into the kitchen, giving her hands a good wash before pulling out two bowls to scoop the pasta into.

Vi emerged from her bedroom a few minutes later and Caitlyn had to admit, she did miss the view of Vi being naked. Caitlyn was grating some parmesan over their bowls as Vi came up behind her, holding onto her hips and brushing Caitlyn's hair aside to place a tender kiss to the back of her neck.

Caitlyn had to suppress an aroused tremor. She had just climaxed twice and yet she was certain if Vi kept this up she would be built back up again. She turned her head to the side, their eyes meeting before Vi reached around to cup Caitlyn's cheek and press a drawn out kiss to her lips.

Caitlyn sighed, gaining a sudden understanding that if she didn't put her foot down Vi would most likely spend the rest of her life touching Caitlyn. "Go wash your hands so you can eat."

"Why? That's just extra flavor."

Caitlyn made a face. "God you are so *crass*."

Vi chuckled but turned to wash her hands in the sink, accepting her meal from Caitlyn afterward with a kiss to her cheek and a soft thank you. Caitlyn's butterflies were practically singing at this point.

The two sat on the couch to eat, Caitlyn with her legs spread across Vi's lap. It felt startlingly domestic and cozy, the two chatting pleasantly as they ate. Vi insisted the meal was actually delicious and as much as Caitlyn wanted to believe her, she was sure Vi was most likely exaggerating a bit.

"You up for a little trip?" Vi asked, massaging Caitlyn's calves after she had put aside her bowl that Chowder was now sticking his curious nose in.

Caitlyn blinked. “A trip?”

“Yeah, I want to take you somewhere.”

“Right now?” Vi nodded. Caitlyn pursed her lips. “Are *you*?”

She chuckled softly. “Yeah, I’m good, Cait. Honest.”

“Well, I don’t see why not.”

The two tidied up their dishes, Caitlyn packing two of the cupcakes she made into a tupperware container to bring along at Vi’s request before they made their way out to the building’s parking lot. Vi led them to where her car was parked, a simple red SUV that somehow suited her. She held the passenger door open for Caitlyn. “Sorry it’s a little dusty in there, hasn’t been driven in a while.”

“That’s alright, a little dust never killed anyone.”

Vi turned on the radio to emit a soft indie playlist as she drove with one hand on the wheel. Her other was comfortably laid in Caitlyn’s lap, intertwined with Caitlyn’s fingers as she traced the veins on the back of Vi’s hand.

After about ten minutes, they pulled into the parking lot of a rather retro looking diner, the lights were off and there were no cars in the parking lot so Caitlyn could only assume it was closed.

“Is this Jericho’s?”

“Yeah, you still haven’t been?”

Caitlyn shook her head. “No, I know it’s your favorite so… I was waiting for you.”

Vi chuckled softly. “Always waiting for me.” She popped open her car door, shaking her head at Caitlyn when she made to do the same. Caitlyn frowned for a second before she noticed Vi walking around the front of the car toward her side.

“My lady.” Vi grinned, holding the passenger door open for Caitlyn and extending her palm.

Caitlyn rolled her eyes with a smile and took Vi’s outstretched hand. “How very butch of you.”

“Why thank you. I try my best.”

The two walked hand in hand around toward the back of the building. They stopped at an old looking blue metal door, Vi releasing Caitlyn’s hand for a moment to squat down and retrieve a key from under the doormat.

“Are we allowed to be doing this?” Caitlyn asked, eyeing Vi suspiciously as she turned the key in the lock.

“Of course. We used to hang out here all the time. Jericho doesn’t mind.” She retrieved Caitlyn's hand once more, tugging her inside and up a rickety staircase toward a second door that led to the roof.

Vi brought Caitlyn past several large fans and steam chutes, around a brick maintenance shed to the back corner. A smile lit up Caitlyn’s face at the scene spread out before her. There were several old ornate rugs laid out atop each other in a rustic sort of collage, a worn leather couch against the brick wall of the maintenance room and various chairs and pillows. Vi walked over to the couch to flick a switch that lit up several rows of dim patio lights strung above. It was the most cozy space Caitlyn had ever seen.

“This is wonderful.” She walked around the space, placing the cupcake container down on a small side table as she observed the random collection of furniture and stopping at the telescope angled up toward the edge of the roof.

“My siblings and I would come here a lot to stargaze and study.” Vi began fidgeting with a record player she’d pulled out of a chest near the couch. “It’s a pretty special place for us.”

Caitlyn grazed her fingers along the expanse of the telescope, glancing up to the vast view of the stars stretching above her. She couldn’t help but think back on all the times she had gazed up at the sky longing for Vi, a pleasant warmth blooming in her chest knowing that she would no longer feel such a devastating loneliness in the vast darkness.

A soft tune began to play from the record player Vi had set up. Caitlyn turned her attention back to her astronaut, who was watching her with a soft smile. She extended her arm out, palm up toward Caitlyn. “Dance with me?”

Caitlyn’s heart fluttered in her chest.

She bit her lip shyly and approached Vi, slipping her palm in Vi’s outstretched hand. Vi immediately lifted her arm up to twirl Caitlyn in a circle before pulling her flush against the astronaut’s chest. They swayed softly to the tune of the music, Caitlyn’s cheeks practically aching from the brilliant smile on her lips.

“Are you sure you’re okay to be doing this?”

Vi chuckled, her gaze flickering down to Caitlyn’s lips and back up. “I’m fine, Cait. Really. I just get a little dizzy from time to time.”

Caitlyn pouted. “You know you didn’t have to push yourself through recovery for me.”

“Yeah, I did.” There was a firm resolve to Vi’s voice. “I couldn’t wait any longer to see you, it was driving me mad.”

Caitlyn hummed, her fingers lacing into the hair at the base of Vi’s neck. The two became lost in each other, wrapped in a bubble of bliss under the stars as they swayed. Caitlyn wasn’t sure if she had ever been as happy for a moment in her life as she was then.

“Oh, I brought you something.”

Vi stopped to reach into her jacket pocket, pulling out a small silver chain bracelet with alternating star and moon charms dangling off of it. She took Caitlyn's wrist and secured the chain around it, leaving Caitlyn stunned beyond words.

She inspected the small charms and the unusual link of the chain. “Did you… make this?”

“I did, yeah. Up on the space station.”

Caitlyn’s heart jumped into her throat.

“How?”

Vi quirked a brow at her. “Remember that goo you forced me to make?”

Caitlyn blushed at the memory, she still felt a bit guilty about that. Then again, it did finally get Vi to confess to her feelings. “Yes.”

“Well the ratio was way off. Way too much water. It turned more into clay than it did cement so I was able to mold a couple of little charms out of it. The chain was from some supplies we had on the station.” She scratched at the shaved side of her head, an action Caitlyn had heard a few times over the communications line but never seen in person until now. “Do you like it?”

“It’s perfect.” Vi always left Caitlyn completely bewildered and breathless. Speaking with this woman had quite literally been her job for over half a year and yet now she was rendered speechless. “I love it so much. I can’t believe you made this for me.”

“I told you I’d whip something up.” She retrieved Caitlyn’s palm, her free hand coming to rest against Caitlyn’s hip as they began to sway to the music once more.

Caitlyn suddenly became overwhelmed with emotion, the events of the day finally crashing down on her like a tidal wave. Much as she tried, she couldn’t help the tears that gathered quietly in her waterline, spilling down her cheeks in thin streaks. Vi’s brow furrowed, concern painting her features. She cupped Caitlyn’s cheek ever so delicately, like she was worried Caitlyn would break at any moment.

“Hey, what’s wrong?” Her voice was so soft, like it had been when she first greeted Caitlyn that morning. It only spurred on Caitlyn’s overflow of emotion.

“I’ve just… I’ve missed you.” Caitlyn whispered, a gentle smile forming on her tear streaked cheeks. “Before I even knew you… I missed you.”

Vi’s shoulders lost their tension, her features relaxing into one of understanding and empathy.

“I’m here now.” She said, leaning forward to rest her forehead against Caitlyn’s.

Caitlyn closed her eyes, allowing herself to take in this moment, to allow herself to go through the motions of how she had been feeling throughout the day. The cumulation of her anxiety, relief, desire, and love all swirling together in a perfect storm that drove her thunderous heartbeat alight within her chest.

She looked into Vi's eyes for a moment, finding herself unable to say the words she desperately wanted to convey to her astronaut but hoping, praying that Vi could see it in her gaze.

The fact that Caitlyn was so desperately, hopelessly in love with her.

Vi could see it. Caitlyn could tell by the way her gaze smoldered and her thumb brushed against Caitlyn's lower lip.

They weren't ready to speak it into existence yet, not with the swirling array of emotions their day had brought forth, but Caitlyn knew Vi wouldn't keep her waiting long. Not again.

And as they swayed to the soft tune upon that rooftop, Caitlyn came to a realization.

It didn't matter that Vi couldn't bring her the stars and the moon. It would pale in comparison to this moment.

For there was nothing in the universe more valuable than the astronaut she finally held in her arms.

Chapter End Notes

Yell at me on twitter here.

Comments and kudos much obliged. <3

Whiplash

Chapter Summary

> “Can’t I convince you to stay?”

Chapter Notes

> Heya. Just wanted to say thank you for your patience with this chapter and to anyone who supports my work, it means more to me than you know and I appreciate your kind words so deeply.
>
> This is a very special chapter. One that was tricky to write as it’s more emotionally dense as opposed to the dialogue heavy style I’m known for. I’ve been eager to bring you this one from the beginning as it’s very near and dear to my heart so I hope you enjoy it.
>
> Playlist for this fic here.
>
> See ya. <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Violet was in awe.

She’d been in a perpetual state of it, actually, for the two months since she’d come back to Houston. Unable to fully root herself in the reality of what her life had become, how she had gotten so lucky.

She was currently propped up on her elbow, taking in every breathtaking feature of the woman lain sleeping in bed next to her. Caitlyn’s stunning cobalt hair was spread across the pillow, a few stray pieces drifting along her face and fluttering over her parted lips where small puffs of breath escaped in her sleep. Vi could see that adorable gap in Caitlyn’s teeth peeking out from between the soft lips that she constantly ached to kiss.

It was early morning, the sun having barely risen and casting golden streaks through the curtains, onto the bed, and across the bare top half of Caitlyn’s body. Dark blue silk sheets draped across her waist, a slender leg peaking out to the side slightly, it all made for the most beautiful sight Vi could imagine.

A fucking goddess.

Vi thought Caitlyn looked beautiful in everything, but the gold of the sun especially suited her. Vi would absolutely drench Caitlyn in gold if she was able. She'd spoil Caitlyn worth her weight in the most valuable riches the world had to offer and yet it still wouldn't be enough.

She couldn't believe she spent eight months speaking with this ethereal woman having not known what was on the other side. It was torturous at the time but thinking back it was probably for the best. Vi had already spent all those months teasing and riling Caitlyn up but she quite frankly would have acted up far worse had she known just how breathtaking Caitlyn was.

Vi couldn't suppress the urge to reach out, her fingers gently brushing aside the few locks of hair fallen across Caitlyn's face and palm finding its way to cup her warm cheek. Caitlyn's brow furrowed slightly as she stirred in her sleep, her eyes softly fluttering open to find Vi's. She sighed with a soft quirk of her lips and turned into Vi's touch, pressing her lips to the edge of the astronaut's palm with a delicate kiss.

God, what had Vi done to deserve this?

"Good morning, beautiful." She whispered softly, her thumb stroking against Caitlyn's sharp cheekbone.

"Mm' morning." Caitlyn grumbled, her voice scratching slightly with the remnants of her slumber. Cute. So goddamn cute.

"I gotta go into work, dad wants to talk to me."

Caitlyn's eyes had fallen shut once more, an adorable pout overtaking her features. She reached out and slid her arms around Vi's waist, pulling their naked bodies flush against one another and intertwining their legs. Vi held her breath as Caitlyn dragged the tip of her nose and the ghost of her lips up the column of Vi's throat. She pressed her lips softly under the astronaut's jaw, moving up to her ear to speak in the most sinful voice imaginable.

"Can't I convince you to stay?"

Yeah, she could. Vi was weak, so absolutely weak when it came to this woman.

Vi groaned and gripped at Caitlyn's hip, her body betraying her resolve as her head tilted back to allow Caitlyn free range to kiss tantalizingly down her neck.

"Fuck." Vi whispered. She pulled back slightly to meet Caitlyn's sultry gaze, their lips now barely a breath apart from one another. "You're not playing fair, cupcake."

Caitlyn hummed, her fingers now skimming up and down Vi's muscular tattooed back, sending chills down her spine. She grinned wickedly, her voice a sultry whisper on Vi's lips. "Never was fond of playing fair. It's much more fun to break the rules."

Her thigh slipped in between Vi's, very slowly sliding up and up to where Vi was growing needier by the second. She stopped just short of the warmth between Vi's legs, chuckling softly at the sharp intake of her breath.

“You’re such a tease.” Vi whispered, a strained sort of desperation laced within her tone.

“You’re one to talk.” Caitlyn shot back, her fingernails digging gently into Vi’s back as she dragged them down, making the astronaut arch against her touch with a shuddering breath. “Wasn’t it you who edged me in front of the mirror last night?” Caitlyn’s voice hinted at something dark and seductive, a rare side to her that never failed to completely shut down Vi’s defenses. “You who made me watch as you slid your fingers inside me, who reduced me to a tearful mess with your touch?”

A shiver ran its way up through Vi’s body. “Cait…”

Caitlyn closed the distance between her thigh and the slick warmth between Vi’s legs. “What happened to all that bravado, hm?”

Vi could feel herself slipping into a very rare headspace for her, one that completely softened her demeanor into something delicate, needy. She was at a loss for words, completely enraptured by the way Caitlyn dominated her senses.

Caitlyn hummed as she returned to Vi’s neck, her lips leaving a trail of fire in their wake where they dragged along the soft flesh. Vi closed her eyes, allowing her head to crane to the side once more with a low groan and completely submitting to Caitlyn’s ministrations.

Vi used to think she couldn’t climax just from friction alone, but this was so much more than that. It wasn’t just the drag of Caitlyn’s thigh between her legs that was pushing Vi closer to the edge, it was Caitlyn herself.

Vi loved having Caitlyn beneath her, reducing her to a whimpering mess with the sweet whisper of Vi’s name on her lips. But this, when Caitlyn found her voice, when she broke down Vi’s walls and took charge-

Yeah, Vi liked her like this. Found herself intoxicated on it, really.

“That’s it, good.” Caitlyn murmured, sucking blooming dark spots into Vi’s neck as the astronaut shifted her hips against Caitlyn’s thigh. The low timbre of her voice had already reduced Vi to a shuddering mess, practically whimpering as she slowly ground her hips to relieve the desperate ache her lover had brought forth.

Caitlyn persisted in breathing out words of encouragement, kept that featherlight teasing touch against Vi’s back and the ghost of her lips on the astronaut’s neck. She knew exactly how to rile Vi up, precise in the teasing lilt to her tone. If there was one thing in particular about Caitlyn that Vi was weak to, it was her voice. She’d always been powerless to it, since the very beginning. But god, when Vi heard it like this, laced with a tempting poison of enchanting lust, it awakened something primal within her.

“Caitlyn-” Vi gasped, her hips twitching and tightening as she felt that familiar molten heat building rapidly below.

“I know.” Caitlyn whispered, reaching up to grasp Vi’s chin between her thumb and forefinger tugging gently so that their expressions could meet once more. Vi gasped against

Caitlyn's lips, trembling under intensity in her hooded cerulean gaze. "You're going to cum for me, yes? Go ahead, sweet girl. You deserve it. Been so good for me, Violet-"

Vi hadn't realized how tight her grip had been on Caitlyn's hip until she found herself digging her nails in, leaving tiny crescents in Caitlyn's flawless skin as she held on for dear life while the force of her orgasm slammed into her. She clenched down desperately around her lover's thigh, allowing the shivers to wrack her body and the sparks to squeeze her inner walls together. Caitlyn didn't seem to mind, in fact, she smiled and pressed a light kiss to the corner of Vi's mouth, gently stroking her skin and encouraging her through the all-consuming high.

As the alluring spike of Vi's ecstasy declined, she found herself hungry with a new renowned sense of desire. One that was screaming at her, begging her to please.

Vi surged forward to devour Caitlyn's lips with a hungry groan, morning breath be damned as she gently encouraged Caitlyn onto her back and licked into her mouth. Caitlyn let out soft, almost lazy moans. It was as if she was still sleepy, so pliant and soft under the astronaut's touch. She relaxed back into the silk of her bedspread, her arms falling bent at her head to completely submit to the promise of what Vi was going to do to her.

Vi took ample time pressing her scarred lips down the expanse of Caitlyn's body, dragging her tongue across her collarbones, sucking at Caitlyn's nipples, her rough hands softly stroking along Caitlyn's sinful curves, kissing down and down to that beautiful warmth between her long legs.

Caitlyn's eyes remained closed through it all, her soft whimpers of pleasure increasing in intensity as Vi licked and sucked at where she found Caitlyn to be her neediest. Vi took her time appreciating the sweet taste on her tongue, a soft tanginess that she could swear was laced with something floral. Caitlyn thought she was insane for believing such, but Vi couldn't help it. There was something so completely delectable, so utterly delicious about the way Caitlyn tasted on her tongue. Vi found herself completely enraptured in her addiction to it.

Vi pushed and pulled Caitlyn to the edge until her body shook with her own climax, the astronaut's name a soft whisper on Caitlyn's beautiful lips while she slowly writhed against the deep blue of her bed sheets. Vi wished she could start every morning this way, with this stunning view. No view in the universe could compare to something like this. She would know.

Caitlyn breathed in deeply, humming appreciatively as Vi pressed a kiss to her hip bone and moved upward to meet Caitlyn's lips once more. Their mouths moved slowly, languidly against one another while lost in the golden bubble of bliss the morning sun had blanketed them in.

"I really do need to go to work." Vi murmured after breaking their kiss, brushing the tip of her nose against the soft expanse of her lover's cheek.

Caitlyn sighed. "Well I suppose you've paid the orgasm toll, so you may go."

Vi chuckled softly. “Is this a permanent exit fee? Will I need to pay it every time I leave?”

She thought for a moment. “Hm, no. Toll is free on Tuesdays and Sundays.”

Vi nearly collapsed into a fit of restrained laughter, her forehead falling against Caitlyn’s chest as she shook with it. She sighed once the giggles died down and pressed a soft kiss to each of Caitlyn’s collarbones, dragging her lips as she went with an unspoken vow on them.

A vow of how deeply and desperately she loved Caitlyn.

Vi hadn’t said it directly to her yet. She’d felt it for months, long before she even knew just how stunning Caitlyn was, but there was something keeping her from speaking the words aloud.

No, not *something.* Vi knew what it was. She had promised Caitlyn she wouldn’t hold back due to her self-sacrificing nature, but how could she *not* feel so utterly selfish when holding this beautiful woman in her arms? How could she possibly claim something as precious as Caitlyn’s love?

It terrified her, the notion of taking something so grand for herself. Taking Caitlyn for herself. She was working on expressing her wants, as they had talked about, but she just wasn’t ready to be that selfish. Not when Caitlyn had already given her so much. She knew Caitlyn was waiting for her to say it first and god did she want to, desperately.

She just couldn’t. Not yet.

Vi reluctantly tore herself away from her girlfriend, stepping out of bed in favor of walking over to the dresser and pulling open the drawer Caitlyn had cleared out for her. She retrieved a comfortable outfit for the day, dressing herself with a sigh starting with the sports bra stretching over her head.

She chanced a glance to the side upon catching movement in her peripheral. Caitlyn was now flipped onto her stomach at the end of the bed, her bare back exposed and arms crossed over a pillow where her head rested, simply watching Vi with a sort of awe and reverence in her sharp gaze.

Vi’s voice was soft, almost pleading. “Don’t look at me like that.”

Caitlyn tilted her head to the side, her cheek smushing against where her arms were folded atop the pillow. “Like what?”

Like you’re in love with me.

Vi didn’t answer. She pulled her muscle tee over her head and slipped into her briefs followed by a pair of sweatshorts, trying and failing not to ogle the stunning woman watching her with bedroom eyes.

Caitlyn sighed in contentment as Vi dropped a kiss between her shoulder blades, unable to resist dragging her lips further down the dip of Caitlyn’s spine and pressing more into the soft expanse of skin as she went.

Caitlyn giggled. “I thought you needed to leave.”

Vi chuckled in reply, her warm breath puffing against the dimples at Caitlyn’s lower back. “You make it too hard for me to leave.”

“That’s my job.” Caitlyn smiled, stealing Vi’s breath away. She reached back to cup the astronaut's cheek, stroking against the small tattoo embedded there. “See you later for the party?”

“Yeah, I’ll be there.” She bent down for one last, slow kiss against Caitlyn’s lips. Vi really would have stayed there all damn day if she could, laying in bed with Caitlyn and worshiping every inch of her body. Thankfully, she somehow managed to find the strength to pull away after a moment, brushing her fingers through Caitlyn’s hair lightly before turning to head out the bedroom door.

After reluctantly brushing away the taste of Caitlyn from her mouth and a quick comb to the mess of magenta on her head, Vi headed into the kitchen. She sat at a chair at the dining table to pull on her sneakers, struggling suddenly with a soft laugh as her vision became obstructed by a wall of fluff.

“Sorry, CC. I gotta head out.” She scratched at the back of Chowder’s neck, dragging her nails down to the base of his tail. “Take care of mom while I’m gone, yeah?”

After a glass of water accompanying the medication she was required to take and swiping a protein shake from the fridge thereafter, Vi begrudgingly left Caitlyn’s apartment. The place she had felt more at home than anywhere in a very long time.

Vi drove to the control center with an eager elation in her heart. It was amazing how love could do that to you, break down your walls and wipe the tension from your body. She’d never felt so at peace before, so content with her surroundings down on Earth. After Vi’s first expedition, she found herself staring up at the stars, craving to be back amongst them. This time, she felt an astounding sense of comfort in Caitlyn’s arms. It was as if Caitlyn was the embodiment of gravity itself, rooting Vi to the very Earth beneath her feet.

She parked swiftly and strolled into the comm center, chugging down the remainder of her protein shake and tossing it in a nearby trash can before knocking twice on her father’s office door, not waiting for an answer to enter.

“Hey Dad.”

Vander glanced up from his morning newspaper, offering Vi a smile and a raised brow before nodding his head toward the clock on the wall. “Was expecting you about a half hour ago.”

“Yeah, well.” Vi scratched at the side of her head. “I got… distracted. Sorry.”

The man hummed, a small smirk present on his face which Vi blatantly ignored in favor of slumping into one of the old leather chairs in front of her father’s desk.

“So what’s up? What did you need me for?”

Vander's posture stiffened. He let out a deep sigh before folding up his newspaper and setting it aside. He clasped his palms together on the desk in front of him, an almost apologetic smile touching his features.

And that's when Vi knew what he was going to say.

"They've asked for you back for the next expedition."

Vi's fists clenched where they lay rested atop her thighs. She glared down at them for a moment, processing. She knew this was coming at some point, but she had hoped that it wouldn't be nearly this soon. Of course there was a part of her that was itching to go back, to return amongst the stars where she felt at peace, at home.

But she had also found a new home down there on Earth.

"How long?"

"Six months. Starting in January."

Fuck that was too soon, and too damn long.

Vi sighed, her voice strained with indecision. "I don't know, Dad."

"You don't have to go, Vi."

"I know that." She did, but the thought of not going made her stomach churn uncomfortably. Being an astronaut was everything Vi had wanted in life. It was something that lit a passionate fire in her veins, a desperate desire for discovery that she ached to see through.

But then Vi thought about Caitlyn, softly sprawled out in bed with the glow of the morning sun kissing her flesh. She thought about what it felt like to hold that beautiful woman in her arms, to feel the warmth of their bodies pressed against one another and the soft touch of her lips. Vi was sure that was as close as she'd ever get to paradise. She had a hard enough time leaving just that morning. How the fuck would she leave for another six months now that she knew just how perfect it felt to be held by Caitlyn?

Vander seemed to recognize Vi's train of thought. "It's serious, then?" Vi's brow furrowed at the man's words. "You and her?"

Oh. "Yes." Vi didn't really need to think about it, she'd known for a while. "She's… she's it for me, Dad."

Vander smiled with a knowing nod. "I can tell. Could tell back then, too. When you were up there. Never seen you so motivated, but I could tell it was eating at you, not being able to see her."

Vi scoffed. That was the understatement of the century right there. "I spent so many days just… staring down at the Earth. Long distance is one thing but when you're above everything? When you can physically *see* the distance and *feel* how stuck you are?" She

shook her head, her nose scrunching with the painful memories of frustration she felt. “I’m surprised I didn’t go insane.”

She looked down at her fist, unclenching it to stare at an open palm. It’s like she could feel the remnants of Caitlyn’s touch there, soft and warm and encouraging. “And now I know just how good it feels to have her. I’m- shit, Dad I don’t think I’ve ever been this happy in my entire life. I didn’t think a love like this was out there for me.” She chuckled humorlessly for a moment. “Figures I had to leave the fucking planet to find it.”

They were quiet for a moment, both taking in Vi’s confession. She hadn’t said any of this out loud before, too afraid to speak it into existence, but now she was backed into a corner. Completely lost in the war raging between her wants and desires.

“You know she’d be here when you got back.” Vander said, harboring all the sympathy and compassion in the world. “I’ve seen the way she looks at you. I saw how her smile lit up every time she spoke to you over comms, the relief and realization in her eyes on that day we nearly lost you. She’d wait for you, Vi.”

Yeah, Vi knew that more than anyone. “But she deserves better than that.”

“So that’s a no, then?”

Vi gave him a strained look.

“I… don’t know.” She glanced at the photo on Vander’s desk. The image of her mother, pregnant with Powder and an enthusiastic Vi hugging her belly. Suddenly there was a tightness in her chest, a feeling of shame brewing at the prospect of giving up. “How do you choose between an old dream and a new one? How do you move past your heart's deepest desire when it comes to fulfilling a promise you made to yourself?”

Vander sighed. “I’m afraid I don’t have the answer. It’s something you need to figure out how to prioritize for yourself. Find a common ground.”

“And how the hell do I do that?”

“Talk to her about it.” Vander drummed his fingers against the desk, thinking deeply. “I’m sure there’s… some sort of solution for the two of you.”

Vi shook her head. “I doubt it’ll be that easy.”

“Hmm.” Vander hummed, staring down at the surface of his desk in concentration. Vi was beginning to get the feeling he was holding something back. “Well the decision is yours alone to make.”

Vi ran her fingers through her hair, glaring at the edge of the wooden desk in front of her. “I wish someone would just… tell me what the right choice is.”

“No one can choose your path for you, Vi. I know you’ve always struggled with finding your way, but it’s important for you to do what *you* think is best.”

She met her father's consoling gaze with her own look of frustrated concern. "What if I get it wrong?"

"Then you trust in those you love to support you through it."

Vi let some of the tension out of her shoulders. She knew he was right, she'd always have her family and she had faith in the strength of her and Caitlyn's relationship, but it didn't make the decision any easier.

"I'll… think about it."

Vander nodded. "Take your time. There's no rush. Enjoy the party tonight… and enjoy your time with her."

Vi sighed, a soft smile curving up the corners of her lips despite the new ache of indecision in her heart. "Thanks, dad."

He leaned back into his chair with a supportive smile. "Not that you need it, by the way, but you have my approval. She's perfect for you, Vi. I've always thought so."

She let out a soft laugh, a slight shake to her head as she once again fondly recalled the breathtaking sight of Caitlyn sleeping in the sunlight that morning, how Caitlyn looked at her as Vi made to leave. "She's too good for me."

Vander sighed, a deep care and consideration in his tone. "You deserve happiness, Vi."

Vi wanted to believe him. She wanted to believe that the pure euphoria she had felt lately was earned, that she deserved it. That she deserved Caitlyn. But it was hard knowing what she had gotten herself into. That she had taken something for herself knowing it could potentially hurt the woman she loved more than anything.

"Yeah… okay." She offered a weak smile, one that Vander didn't seem to buy, but he always knew when Vi needed a push and when she needed him to back off.

Vi stood and shoved her fists into the pockets of her shorts. "See you tonight."

She didn't look at her father's face as she left, couldn't bring herself to face the overwhelming sympathy she knew she'd find in his gaze. Vi needed to think, to clear her mind and consider her options. She needed space, pun not fucking intended.

Once back in the sanctity of her car, Vi cursed under her breath as reality crashed down on her, a sudden all encompassing feeling of whiplash pulsing behind her temples. This was not how she thought her morning would go. Of course it would start so damn perfect only to leave her with a piercing ache in her heart and a cold feeling in her gut.

Vi couldn't help but think about just how difficult it had been to tear herself away from Caitlyn that morning, the loss of the warmth she felt as she pulled away, the look in Caitlyn's eyes when Vi left. She found herself already itching to have it back, to hold the woman of her dreams and become lost in the small universe they created together, just for one another.

How would she be able to leave that behind for six months? Now that she knew how good it was, Vi wasn't sure she could. She didn't know the first time. Already stuck in space with no inkling of just how breathtaking Caitlyn's smile was, how soft her touch could be. It was probably the only reason she *did* make it through that expedition.

She closed her eyes, her head falling back against the headrest of the driver's seat.

In truth, Vi hadn't spent any real time reflecting on the year she had spent aboard the space station. She had been so caught up in her time with Caitlyn, so blinded by her state of lovesick bliss that she hadn't given much thought to processing everything.

Could Vi really handle that distance again? To be so far away, so out of reach from the one you crave to touch, to love…

How had she even done it the first time?

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ISS Expedition number 59
Personal Logs: Astronaut No. 516: Violet Wick

"New capcom, aye?"

Vander hummed in affirmation from the other end of the communication line. "She'll be coming in today. Quite an impressive record. She's an expert in mathematics and physics. Also has extensive knowledge of the station. I think she's only about your age as well."

Vi gripped the various hand rails as she floated through the station modules, stopping in front of a blue velcro pouch stuck to the wall and tearing it open to retrieve her toothbrush. "She hot?"

He sighed. "Be on your best behavior, Violet."

"Awe you know me, Dad. I'm always on my best behavior"

"Hm. She'll be here in about an hour. Pop back on then to introduce yourself and try not to scare the poor girl off, aye?"

"Copy that." Vi grumbled around a mouthful of foaming toothpaste as she brushed. A beep sounded in her compact headset, indicating Vander had gone offline for now. Vi had to admit, she was happy at the prospect of getting a new capcom. Someone her age sounded nice as well. Maybe they could even be friends, so long as she didn't have a stick up her ass like the old guy.

Vi typically liked to start her mornings with a workout, but given that her new communicator would be in soon, she elected to spend the spare time fiddling with one of the egregiously large cameras on board to take some photographs of the Earth. Vi really never got tired of this view, there was simply nothing that compared to such a breathtaking sight. It made her heart thrum with excitement every time she looked out the window. Oftentimes she'd even lose herself there, allowing herself to float weightless and carefree above it all, just like her mother had wanted.

About a hundred or so photos later, Vi stashed the camera on the wall of the Russian module and made her way to retrieve a protein bar from the makeshift kitchen on board. Calling it a kitchen was actually a bit laughable. Really it was just a wall of various compressed plastic food pouches to either be rehydrated or warmed up and a fold-down table with velcro strips lining the surface. It certainly wasn't homey like a real kitchen, but they managed.

Vi held her snack of choice and looped the headset back over her ear, rotating upside-down as she pressed the button on the side.

"Houston, do you copy?"

There was no answer. Vi frowned and eyed the central time clock on the wall. It had been a little over an hour since she'd talked to Vander. The new capcom should be in by now and set up. Was she shy?

Vi pushed herself off the ceiling, moving through the station as she spoke into the headset once more. "Hellooo? I said Houston, do you copy?"

"Um, yes. Hello? This is Houston. I copy."

Vi stopped short in the doorway connecting two of the modules together, her grip tight against the walls and eyes blown wide.

That… was a sexy voice. Vi had never heard anything like it before. It was deep, but not in a masculine way. More sultry, tantalizingly so and especially with that British accent. Vi was a sucker for accents.

Well, so much for being on her best behavior.

"Damn, Houston. I didn't expect you to sound so sexy."

Vi could hear a shocked scoff through the line. She couldn't help but grin wickedly. "I- I beg your pardon?"

"You can beg for whatever you want, sweetheart."

It was probably a smidge too far but fuck, with a voice like that when you're stranded in space without any beautiful women to flirt with, Vi was going to take the opportunity she had been given. The question now was if this woman would take the bait.

"Sorry. But I'm a sophisticated woman. You would need to wine and dine me before I'd entertain such notions."

Oh. Violet thought she was in love.

Not actually, at least, not at that point. But the more she spoke with Caitlyn and the longer the days stretched filled with that tempting voice, the more Vi was becoming enthralled, enchanted almost. No one had ever matched her banter so perfectly before. The conversations flowed almost like a warm tide, a gentle push and pull that left a soothing calm in its wake. Vi found herself thoroughly enjoying Caitlyn's company, even looking forward to when they would next speak. It motivated her, gave her a new sense of eagerness to do her job well.

She had been hoping she and her new capcom could be friends, but she hadn't expected Caitlyn to be so addicting to speak to… and so much fun to rile up.

"ISS, do you copy?"

"For you, angel? Always."

Vi grinned at the annoyed groan sounding from the other end of the line. "You know one of these days I might just go to HR."

"Well I do enjoy being punished."

"Oh for god's- is there no end to your proverbial spank bank?"

Vi rotated backward with the force of her laugh, because that was another thing. Caitlyn was *funny.* Not the usual kind of funny, she didn't crack jokes or puns, didn't force humor in a way that one may try to get a laugh out of someone. She just had this way with words, so posh and proper yet strung together with the most random modern slang in such a way that left Vi gasping for air.

Never had Vi's cheeks ached from smiling so much, her heart full from such humor, genuine care, and empathy she found in her capcom. Vi loved being an astronaut, she felt at home among the stars, but even she had to admit the days would often drag.

With Caitlyn, however, they began to get brighter. Brighter than the sun that shone through the space station windows, than even the light of the largest star in the galaxy could possibly emit. Vi felt such a newfound sensation of irreverent joy through just… simple conversation. It was fun, intoxicating, addicting. Like the all-encompassing joys and jitters of interacting with a high school crush.

She found herself rising from her sleep cabin each day with a newfound eagerness and determination, excited at the prospect of starting her work day and speaking with her capcom.

It had only been a couple weeks at that point, but each day the two learned something new about one another, slowly closing a metaphorical gap between them. It was incredible how Vi could grow so close to someone so quick, someone who seemed to just… get her. In every aspect. Vi may have been a flirt, but she was also extraordinarily sentimental. Caitlyn matched her flirtatious banter in the best way, but the heartfelt moments were just as impactful.

“Do you have any siblings?” Vi asked one day as she was disinfecting experimental lab equipment. She hated the housekeeping duties but hey, someone had to do them.

“No, I’m an only child. Although, my best friend is sort of like a brother to me.”

“Oh yeah? What’s he like?”

Caitlyn paused. “He’s an arrogant, rich playboy.” Vi snorted at the bluntness. “But he’s also incredibly sentimental. He’d be there for me at the drop of a hat should I need him.”

Vi found herself smiling, feeling glad that Caitlyn had someone like this in her life. She tended to harbor a very protective nature over the people she cared for. As Caitlyn grew to be one of them but maintained out of Vi’s reach, it was nice to know she had a safety net. “I’m glad you have him, then.”

“I didn’t always.” There was something somber in Caitlyn’s voice. “I’m afraid I had quite the lonely upbringing.”

Vi felt an unpleasant ache in her chest. Caitlyn shouldn’t be lonely, she deserved better than that. “You didn’t have any friends?”

“Hm, not really, no.” There was a sad sort of acceptance in Caitlyn’s voice. Vi began to wonder, definitely not for the first time, what sort of face Caitlyn was making as she recalled something so heartbreaking. “Most of my ‘friendships’ were for diplomatic purposes. None of them harbored any sense of genuine companionship.”

Vi didn’t know much about Caitlyn’s family at that point, or the sort of life she had lived, but she didn’t want to pry unless Caitlyn offered up the information willingly. “Well, we’re friends now, aren’t we?”

Vi thought she could hear a smile in Caitlyn’s voice as she replied in earnest. “Yes, we are.” She paused for a moment, but it seemed as though she had more to say so Vi waited, wishing she could see the heartfelt emotions in Caitlyn’s eyes for a conversation like this, maybe even brush her fingers over the back of Caitlyn’s hand in a show of comfort. “I’m glad I have you to talk to now. It’s almost like- like a hole I’ve felt all my life is slowly closing the more we speak. Is that strange to say?”

“No.” Vi understood all too well, because she too could feel it. Heck, she could from the first time she heard Caitlyn’s voice. “No, it’s not.”

Thinking back, this was probably when things shifted between them. Sure they had been a little flirty, but this was different. It was raw, honest. It opened the doors for something deeper between them, a trickling of sincerity that would build and build into a typhoon of deep rooted trust.

Vi liked Caitlyn, that much she knew, but there was something more there. A warmth in her chest that she hadn’t yet found the words to describe.

And Vi didn’t need to see Caitlyn to understand that she was just so damn *cute.*

The adorable flustered state she had been in after finding Vi's fitness interview had the astronaut practically swooning, aching to see the blush that most likely colored her capcom's flesh. Vi couldn't help but wonder if Caitlyn's cheeks filled out in a rosy glow or more of a light pink dust. How did Caitlyn act when she was embarrassed? Did she fidget during their conversations or have any unique habits? Did she fiddle with her hair, bite at her fingernails? Vi was beginning to feel an itch beneath her skin, one that she couldn't scratch with all these questions buzzing around in her mind.

"What's my type?"

Vi grunted around the screwdriver in her mouth, currently in the middle of replacing filters for the HEPA air filtration system on board.

"I don't know if I have a type."

Vi opened her mouth and let the screwdriver float into the air. "Sure you do, everyone's got a type."

She let Caitlyn mull it over for a bit, only feeling slightly anxious as she awaited the reply.

"I guess… just someone with a good heart."

Vi halted in the middle of her task, staring blankly at the wall in front of her. Her heartbeat picked up to a sprinting tempo and suddenly the words Vander had spoken to her the day she decided to leave for the first expedition rang true at the back of her mind.

"You've got a good heart, Vi. One that transcends the boundaries of time and space. Even when you're up there, we can feel it down here. We always will."

It was a coincidence. It had to be, but it didn't fail to make Vi's heart leap into her throat.

"I like that." She managed to get out, trying and miserably failing to force down the throb in her chest. She began to really feel it then, a strange pull in her body, like gravity was tugging her heart back down toward the Earth. It was unsettling… but also oddly comforting.

An understanding washed over Vi that night as she hovered overtop her sleeping bag, arms crossed behind her head and a thoughtful furrow to her brow. This ache in her chest and itch beneath her skin could only be described as yearning. A deep longing accompanied by a sudden desperate desire for more. More of Caitlyn's voice, of her laugh, their playful banter, the soft smile present in her voice…

Vi found that no matter how many countless hours she spent speaking to Caitlyn, getting to know about her life, sharing details of Vi's own upbringing and laughing with her, it was never enough. She craved more, like a hyperfixation that was all consuming and debilitating.

"I got a problem."

Ekko quirked a brow at her from where he was currently rehydrating a dried milk and cereal packet. "One? Singular? Wow, that's an all time low for you."

Vi reached out and flicked him in the forehead. “Don’t be a dick, I’m serious.”

“Ow, jeez. Okay, what’s your problem?”

“I think I have a crush on my capcom.”

Ekko’s eyes rolled. “Well I could have told you that.”

Vi blinked. “What are you-”

“You’ve been smiling and giggling like a damn schoolgirl for weeks. I’m amazed you get any of your tasks done with how often I hear you shamelessly flirting with her.”

Vi groaned. Yeah, now that he mentioned it she was probably being way too damn obvious. “So what do I do?”

Ekko placed his meal on the velcro strips along the table, eyeing Vi as she floated overhead. “What do you mean? There’s nothing really you can do from up here, is there?”

Yeah, she definitely knew that. It bothered the shit out of her. “Well should I… I don’t know, reel it back a little?”

He shrugged. “Why not just lean into it? You’re happy, you’re having fun. What’s the worst that could happen? I mean, it is a harmless crush, right?”

Yeah, it was a harmless crush.

But then Vi told Caitlyn about her mother, and Caitlyn opened up about her upbringing. Then Vi’s walls became smaller and smaller until they crumbled completely. It was harmless until she often found herself awake in her cabin, going over their conversations on loop within her mind. Harmless until Vi grew increasingly more desperate to know what Caitlyn looked like, the expressions she made as they spoke and if she maybe felt that same itch that Vi did.

At that point Vi still hadn’t a clue toward her capcom’s appearance. She had asked a few times, begged even for a few details, but Caitlyn was always too shy to give up anything meaningful. It was becoming maddening. The more Vi spoke with Caitlyn and filled her days with pure unadulterated joy, the more desperate she became for a glimpse. To know how Caitlyn’s eyes lit up when she laughed or how they rolled when Vi pushed her buttons. To know what color Caitlyn’s hair was, how it flowed, how plush her lips were…

Then came the day of the first space walk, and Vi had never been more relieved to hear her sister's voice as it came through Caitlyn’s headset that morning.

“Oh she’s smoking hot dude. I haven’t met her personally but I’ve seen her around. Definitely your type.”

“Can you describe her to me the best you can?” Vi was gripping onto one of the metal rails by a round window, almost glaring at the distance between her and the Earth. “It’s- fuck- it’s driving me crazy that I don’t know what she looks like, Pow. Please.”

“Yeah yeah, I got you.” Powder cleared her throat dramatically and that’s when Vi knew she was in for a lengthy description. “Okay so first she’s like crazy tall, probably six feet or so. She’s real slender but you can tell she has some toned muscles in there, she probably does pilates or some shit. She’s half Asian. She’s got a gap in her front teeth but not like a big one it’s more of a cute bunny kind. She has perfect fucking skin. I’m gonna need to get her skin care routine because damn she doesn’t have a blemish in sight. Oh, and her hair is straight, little lower than shoulder length and blue but not like my blue. It’s more like a deep cobalt and in the light of the comms room it actually looks more black. What else is there- oh she’s at least a D-cup.”

Vi groaned. “Jesus Pow, did you really need to add that?”

“I know what details are important to you!”

Well, she had a point. Vi sighed, feeling a tiny bit of relief as she put the pieces together. She had deduced a few things, of course. Caitlyn had already admitted to her height and Vi could tell she was more on the femme side. She also seemed quite put together based on the posh and proper verbiage so Vi always envisioned someone relatively elegant.

“What does she dress like?”

“Oh she’s always in these expensive looking pant suits with her hair in a ponytail, usually with a couple wavy strands framing her face.” Bless Powder and her artistic descriptions.

“What… what color are her eyes.”

Powder paused. “Blue. Like, crazy gorgeous blue. Like the ocean in Hawaii or a glowing gemstone sort of cerulean. They’re kind of striking and intimidating, to be honest.”

Fuck, Vi thought this would help. She really did, but it only made the longing, the desperation, so much worse.

“I just wish I could see her.” Vi whispered, closing her eyes in a pathetic attempt to envision the woman her sister had described. “Just once.”

There was a tense silence for a bit. Vi felt immense guilt in dumping out her stress onto Powder, but if she didn’t then it was possible her emotions may burst out of her like a bottle of champagne any day now.

“Ekko said it was just a crush but… you really like her, huh?”

Vi sighed, pressing her forehead against the cold glass window that overlooked the Earth. “I don’t know what’s come over me. I’ve never felt so at peace than I do when I speak with her. When we’re not talking she’s all I think about. I find myself awake at night going over our conversations, counting down the hours when I can contact her again.”

“Hm, you make it sound like you’re falling for her.”

Vi scoffed. No, it couldn’t possibly be that extreme. “Is it even possible to fall for someone you’ve never actually seen?”

“Of course it is, sis. It happens all the time.”

Vi thought hard for a moment. Could she be falling for Caitlyn? It seemed a little intense for where her feelings currently sat, but not implausible. “What if I’m just a job to her? What if she doesn’t feel the same?”

“Ain’t no way you’re just a job to her. Dad says she blushes whenever he mentions you.”

So Caitlyn did blush. Vi smiled at the thought. “Well, I guess that makes me feel good.”

“Want me to test out the waters a bit? See if I can gauge how she feels?”

Vi thought about it for a second. “Sure but… don’t be too obvious. Nothing extreme.”

Powder mock gasped and Vi cracked a smile. “Me? Extreme? I would never do that to you sis.”

Vi let out a lighthearted laugh. She truly missed her sister so much. “So how’s work going?”

“Oh my *god* don’t even get me started. My boss is such a fucking-”

Vi laughed as her sister droned on in her work related frustrations. The truth of it was that Caitlyn wasn’t the only weight pressing down on Vi’s chest. It was difficult for her to be away from Powder, from everyone in her family. She had long since come to terms with the distance, they all had adapted well, but this new desire for proximity brought forth by her capcom ushered in an ache to be surrounded in the warmth of her loved ones once more.

Despite Powder’s promise and her extreme nature, Vi trusted her to deliver on her word. What she hadn’t anticipated, however, was such a firm kick off the edge she had been precariously perched on in regards to her feelings.

The song choice, the view, Caitlyn’s soft voice laced with so much tenderness in her ear…

“It’s like we’re dancing.”

That was the moment Vi knew. Floating out there among infinite stars, her heart full with the euphoria brought on by the breathtaking sight in front of her. That’s when she knew for sure that she’d fallen for Caitlyn.

And that’s when the realization slammed into her that Caitlyn was too fucking far away.

Vi extended her arm toward the Earth, feeling absolutely haunted by the emptiness that filled the space between them. The void felt infinite, endless. Vi was in zero gravity, she couldn’t physically fall, but in that moment she wished she could. She wished she could feel the adrenaline of it, the pounding rush of her heart plummeting into her gut. She wished she could fall all the way down to Earth for Caitlyn.

But she couldn’t. Still, she had a sudden urge to take some sort of action. To do something with this heart-pounding discovery.

As Vi tucked herself back into the airlock after one of the longest and most emotionally rich days of her life, an idea sprang into her mind. One that she would come to regret.

She wasn't sure what she was expecting, letting Caitlyn see her through the suit camera. It wasn't possible for her to see Caitlyn in return, so why did she do it? Maybe it was that spark of hope, a small ember she had been praying would become a flame in her desperate search for the confirmation that Caitlyn felt the same.

"You know, when you get back… I'll be here."

Vi had to look away from the camera for a moment. It was as though she could feel Caitlyn's eyes on her, peeling away her very flesh and exposing the raw devotion that Vi now knew lived within her heart.

"You promise?" She had to ask. She needed to know, to have hope that Caitlyn really would be there.

"Yes, of course." Vi could feel the care, the pure empathy and commitment in the smile present in Caitlyn's voice. "I'll wait for you."

No.

No, that was something else. That isn't what Vi wanted… Was it?

A typhoon of conflicting emotions emerged and swirled violently around in Vi's heart. Caitlyn said she would wait for her. There was a pure sense of overwhelming ecstasy in that knowledge, but also a deep cut of guilt. Vi knew she couldn't ask that of Caitlyn. She deserved better than that. So much better than sitting around waiting for Vi.

She had fallen for Caitlyn, but Ekko was right. There was nothing she could do about it from up there.

"What's wrong?"

Shit, Vi had almost forgotten Caitlyn could see the torn expression on her face. "It's nothing."

It was nothing. Really it was. At least, Vi would pretend it was for the time being. She'd douse that spark of hope, lock it away until she figured out what it is she wanted, how to navigate these tumultuous and conflicting feelings. She couldn't let herself lean into the idea of Caitlyn waiting for her. It was too much for her to take for herself.

But something deeper had been ushered forth between them that day, and much as Vi tried to reign in her selfish desires, the two began to creep closer and closer toward dangerous territory. Something that brooched the line of the emotional, into the tempting territory of the physical.

"You have perfectly functioning fingers don't you?"

Yeah, Vi did, and she suddenly found herself burning with the urge to use them.

For months Vi had been enthralled, smitten with the sound of Caitlyn's voice alone but now, she could feel herself inching into something tantalizingly sinful. A new sort of fire spread beneath Vi's skin, an ache somewhere below in which she found herself borderline debilitated by. Vi had never been so out of her mind with pure want before. She was consumed by it, inching so fucking close to giving in.

Repressing the desires of love in your heart was difficult enough without also feeling insatiably horny to boot. She just couldn't help it, the alluring nature of Caitlyn's voice simply made her too weak to her urges.

She had been doing so well, holding back just enough to keep Caitlyn close but her feelings at bay. There had to be something to close this door that Vi had been creeping open, something to block the path she had found herself more and more enticed to traverse.

And then, Caitlyn gave her that opening.

"You told her to go out with someone else?" Vi flinched at the shocked, disapproving tone of her sister's voice. "Vi, why the hell would you do that? You're not this dense, you know she likes you."

"Yeah I know but-" Vi groaned because yeah, she knew. She had been avoiding admitting it to herself, but it had become pretty obvious that Caitlyn reciprocated at least some of what Vi felt. "I wanted to give her a chance to find something else. Something that's down there and not up here."

"Mhm, and how do you feel now?"

"Like shit."

Powder sighed. "She's probably thinking you don't want her now, dummy."

"I know, I regret it so much." Vi glared down at the packet of strawberries she had rehydrated from where she sat strapped to a chair at the kitchen table. "Why do I always screw everything up? Why do I always choose wrong?"

"You don't, Vi. I understand why you feel that way, but I think it's your intentions that matter most. You always do what you think will make others happy, it's not a bad trait to have but you gotta make decisions for yourself once in a while."

She sighed, fisting at the long pink strands at the base of her neck. "I just don't know what to do anymore, Pow."

"Well, what is it that you want?"

Vi thought for a moment, her voice timid and unconvincing. "I don't know what I want."

"Yes you do." Vi could hear the eye roll in Powder's voice. There was simply no one else as capable of calling Vi on her shit more than her sister. Well, maybe also Ekko. "You just don't want to admit it to yourself. You're self-sacrificing again because you think you're being selfish and in doing so, shoving away your own happiness."

Vi unstrapped herself from her seat, forgetting her meal in favor of pushing off toward one of the many windows she occupied constantly to stare at the Earth. As much as Vi hated to admit it, Powder was right. In her heart she did know what she wanted.

“She… she said she’d wait for me.”

“How did that make you feel? And don’t say selfish or shitty or any of that bullshit. How did it *really* make you feel?”

“Amazing.” Vi smiled at the memory. At the time she could only think for Caitlyn, how it wouldn’t be fair to her, how Vi wasn’t worth sitting around waiting for and how she deserved better than that sort of life.

But yeah, that’s what she wanted, craved more than anything. The thought of Caitlyn waiting back home, finally seeing just how beautiful Vi knew she was and feeling her warmth in Vi’s arms. She’d never wanted something more in all her life. It lit a warm glow in Vi’s chest, a bubble of pure euphoria that enveloped her so completely. An excited but nervous spark in her veins, desperate for the culmination of feelings poured into when they would finally embrace.

Yet, she just wasn’t sure if she could do that to Caitlyn. It was what she wanted, and she felt she could admit to that now, but she had a long way to go to get around those steel bars she had imprisoned her heart within.

Powder was very intuitive when it came to Vi, she seemed to understand Vi’s desperation, but also her reluctance. “So just accept it. Let her wait for you.”

If only it were that easy. “I can’t. I … I need some time to think.”

Her sister sighed. “Alright, but stop completely shutting her out. Try to talk about your feelings with her, even a little bit.”

“Yeah.” Vi wasn’t ready to confess the magnitude of her feelings yet, but she wasn’t sure how much longer she could keep lying to herself, and to Caitlyn. So maybe a little give would be fine. “Thank you, Powder. You don’t know how much I appreciate you listening and talking to me about this.”

There was a clear, sympathetic smile in Powder’s voice. “You know I’m always with you, sis. Even when we’re worlds apart.”

“Yeah.” Vi’s own lips stretched into a relaxed grin. “I know.”

As it turned out, a little give became a big one.

Vi felt as though she was losing her mind as she lay awake in her cabin, trying desperately to focus on the systems rebooting on the monitor in front of her but she just couldn’t keep her mind from wandering. Honestly, who could blame her? It was about as visually stimulating as watching paint dry. So yeah, she couldn’t help but think back again to the conversation she and Caitlyn had two weeks ago that lit this flame beneath her skin.

Caitlyn owned sexy lingerie. Vi could picture exactly what it is she had described and fuck, it had been doing things to her ever since. She couldn't stop thinking about it, the timid and yet intrigued arousal she could hear in Caitlyn's voice, how desperately Vi ached to be between her legs, what Caitlyn would taste like on her tongue, the sweet moans of pleasure she would make as Vi took her apart, devoured her even.

"Fuck." Vi fisted at her pink hair. This was getting absurd. She had never felt so horny in all of her damn life. Never ached to feel the touch of a woman this *badly.* It was consuming her thoughts on the daily. A constant dampness in her pants, the occasional shudder wracking her muscular body, a static twitch between her legs. She tried so hard, so incredibly hard to sweat it out. Pushed her body with multiple workouts a day, distracted herself with whatever she could. It was never enough.

She couldn't take it anymore.

She wasn't thinking when she donned her headset once more to contact Caitlyn. Her thoughts were consumed by the buzz of arousal, just a glimpse at what it could be like between the two of them. God did she want it so badly…

So she gave in.

Caitlyn sounded heavenly as she got herself off over the line. Vi ached to see it, to be the one who's touch had brought Caitlyn to that point. She felt possessive, desperate at that moment to feel her capcom's touch. She glared down at where her own fingers twisted and pulled at her slick warmth, wishing once more she could see exactly what Caitlyn looked like, to picture the pleasured twisting of her features, to imagine it was her fingers driving Vi closer to the edge.

There was an overwhelming ecstasy, a wave of deep relief once Vi had finally let the culmination of weeks worth of tension release. A weight had been lifted off her chest, lungs and heart full for only a fleeting moment until the inevitable crash. The realization that she was stuck in a metal box the size of a phone booth, lacking the warmth of the woman she ached to feel in her arms.

Caitlyn could feel it too, Vi could hear it in her voice. It broke her, to know they had shared such an intimate moment and yet she couldn't hold Caitlyn through the drop of endorphins, couldn't yet express to Caitlyn how she felt.

The most she could do was assure Caitlyn that given the chance, she would give this up in a heartbeat to be there for her. She had meant it at the time, she really had.

And she was getting closer, so damn close to finally throwing caution to the wind and laying her heart out on a platter for Caitlyn.

Turns out, the universe had a truly heinous and unpredictable nature.

Vi will never forget the fear that coursed thickly through her veins as she suited up to enter the debris field. She'll never unhear the absolute terror in Caitlyn's voice or unsee the paled expression on Ekko's face as the two exited the airlock.

They could hardly see a damn thing, the ISS currently orbiting within the window of the Earth's shadow and countless pieces of scrapped debris surrounding them. Vi had swallowed her nerves and bottled her personal feelings at that moment, putting an intense focus on her duties, on protecting Ekko and the crew. It pained her to know her family was watching, no doubt riddled with anxiety and terror. Vi needed to stay strong for them, and Caitlyn's determined voice in her ear pushed her to do just that.

The absolute fierceness and dedication of her capcom pushed each of Vi's feet forward, kept her steady and alert in a way she wasn't sure she'd have been able to accomplish on her own. There was an undeniable and deep intrinsic trust she had instilled on Caitlyn at that moment, one that gave her a strength unlike any other. She trusted Caitlyn with her life.

But there was nothing Caitlyn could do once Ekko's tether was severed. That was on Vi.

She didn't think as she firmly planted her feet against the hull of the station and pushed off, her body moving on its own into the throws of danger to save someone she loved dearly. It was pure instinct and love that drove her forward, toward the infinite darkness knowing what she could lose, what she could potentially never hold in her arms.

"Vi… come ba- plea-"

Caitlyn's voice cut out, and Vi suddenly panicked. She couldn't go now. She had promised Caitlyn she would come back.

And Caitlyn promised she'd be there when Vi got back.

She needed to tell her, needed her to know-

"Caitlyn, I love you."

It was the only time she had spoken the words aloud, there in the all consuming terror and void that awaited her. A place beyond Caitlyn's reach, where she couldn't hear Vi's heartfelt whisper.

The words sparked a blaze of determination in Vi. She refused to let that be the only time she said those words. Refused to continue on until she had a chance to let Caitlyn hear them.

So she drove her body forward, through the terror and the adrenaline, past the pieces of debris and persevering in the face of her malfunctioning equipment.

I need to make it back.

I promised her I would.

I promised Powder I would protect Ekko.

I love them all so much.

She pushed forward with the weight of her loved ones on her shoulders, knowing what it would do to them if she didn't return. It was the only thing that mattered. There was no limit

to what she would do for them, not even the furthest reaches of the galaxies could compare in magnitude to the things she'd do for love.

As she firmly planted herself in the airlock, grasping onto her best friend for dear life and finally allowing the tremors to wrack her body, all Vi could feel was elation. A thrill that she had done what she promised, that she fulfilled the role she had designated herself to play.

She'd made it out of the most terrifying encounter any astronaut could experience, and yet it meant little to nothing next to the pit in her stomach at the broken sound of Caitlyn's voice.

Vi believed in that moment that she would throw all of it down the drain. Her ambitions, her dreams, every achievement and medal she had earned, she'd give it all up to hold Caitlyn in her arms. To comfort the woman who had unknowingly saved Vi in countless ways.

It was cruel, knowing what she had put Caitlyn through and that she was unable to soothe the shakiness in Caitlyn's voice or brush the tears from her cheeks. It ate at Vi even after she had sent Caitlyn home to rest. Tormented her all through the next day and brought about a new nervous twitch in her fingers on the day Caitlyn was set to come back into work.

"Houston, do you copy?"

"Hey there, Vi. I copy."

Vi blinked, her anxieties replaced with utter befuddlement by this voice that was definitely not Caitlyn's. "Uh, no offense, but I was expecting someone who sounds a lot sexier."

The man on the other end laughed softly. "Hate to disagree with you, but I've been assured many times by many partners that my voice is quite sexy."

Arrogant, rich playboy. "Jayce then, yeah?"

Jayce hummed. "I guess my reputation precedes me."

"Painfully so." Vi shook her head, tucking her palms under her biceps with an intrigued quirk to her brow. "To what do I owe the pleasure?"

"Flew into Houston yesterday, thought I'd stop by Cait's work and meet the infamous astronaut she's been going on about for months."

Vi's heart did a flip. "Months, huh?"

"Oops, I've said too much." Vi smirked at the obvious air of teasing in Jayce's tone. "Heard you had quite a scare."

She shrugged, feigning nonchalance. "Wasn't that big a deal."

Jayce hummed in thought. "Putting up a strong front?"

Vi really didn't need this man clocking her shit right now. "Well, somebody has to."

“Now *that* we can agree on.”

Vi got the feeling Jayce was often put in similar circumstances when it came to Caitlyn. She may even be able to sympathize with him, given that the two were older siblings in their own regards. Vi then remembered what Caitlyn had told her months ago, that Jayce would be there for her at the drop of a hat. “Did you fly into Houston because of this? To be there for Caitlyn?”

“I did, yes.”

Suddenly Vi had a new level of respect for this man. “Thank you. It… it kills me that I can’t be there for her right now given how freaked she was. I owe you, pretty boy.”

“You don’t owe me a thing, Vi. I’d do anything for Caitlyn. No questions asked.”

Yeah, Vi liked him. “My gratitude still stands.” She stuck her tongue in her cheek for a moment, staring at where her feet were hooked into a metal rail. “She doing alright?”

“She’s better.” Jayce supplied, Vi felt a tiny bit of relief. “She slept and we had a nice day out. I won’t go into too much detail but… she spent a long time staring up at the stars last night.”

This was a genuine surprise to Vi, but not an unwelcome one. It was comforting to know that she wasn’t the only one hopelessly gazing across the vast distance between them.

“So tell me about yourself, Vi.”

Vi scoffed. “What do you wanna know?”

“Hm, what are your intentions with my little sister?”

Oh fucking hell. “I don’t have… intentions. I care about her.”

“That really all there is?”

“Damn, you’re nosy as hell.”

Jayce laughed heartily. “Well someone’s gotta shove you lesbians out the door or you’d never get anywhere.”

Well, he wasn’t wrong. Vi sighed. “We’re… figuring things out. It’s not exactly easy considering the distance.”

“You mean… the space?”

Nevermind. Vi was gonna eject him out the airlock.

“Yeah. That.” She gritted out, blatantly ignoring the man’s arrogant chuckles over the line.

“Sorry, couldn’t resist. I understand, and I trust you guys to figure it out. Just, please take care of her. She’s special.”

Vi’s demeanor softened at that. “Yeah, she is.” It was an understatement in Vi’s eyes, but she wasn’t about to rattle off the intricacies of her love to someone she’d just met. “I’ll do my best. Better than that, even.”

“I believe you.” Vi could see why Caitlyn and Jayce were friends. He definitely held an air of overconfidence, but also one of deep compassion. “So, want to hear some of Cait’s embarrassing college stories?”

Vi grinned. “Now you’re speaking my language.”

She felt herself relaxing into the conversation as Jayce went on, going down a literal tier list of Caitlyn’s wild adventures. Vi laughed along, feeling a bit guilty at having found such entertainment in what Caitlyn would certainly be mortified to have shared with her. She couldn’t help it, though. Everything Caitlyn did was endearing to Vi, and it was nice getting to know someone who she held so close.

The nerves from that morning had been tampered significantly by such lighthearted memories. Vi was beginning to feel hopeful for a good day, encouraged to do as she promised Jayce she would and stop beating around the bush with Caitlyn.

That was, until she overheard the two in their discussion.

“You didn’t- You didn’t tell her anything about our conversation yesterday, did you?’

“No! No, of course not. I wouldn’t do that.” Fuck, Vi shouldn’t be hearing this. She should turn her headset off, give them privacy. “But I still think you should tell her.”

“I- I thought about it a lot.”

Vi really needed to tune out, this was wrong and she knew it.

“And?”

She just couldn’t, she needed to know.

“I don’t know, Jayce. There’s no telling if she feels the same and we still have four months left of working together on this expedition. I would be putting her in a very uncomfortable spot and… and she already misses her family so much. I can’t add myself to that stress. I care about her too much to do that to her.”

A freezing chill ran through Vi’s body, reality dousing the flames of her desires like a cold shower. How could she possibly have been so damn self-centered? Caitlyn was willing to push aside her own happiness, her own desires for Vi’s wellbeing and yet Vi hadn’t done the same. Not by a long shot. She had selfishly grasped for more and more, greedy in her desires to have Caitlyn for herself without stopping to think of how it would affect the woman’s happiness.

She had been a complete fool to push for more, to take Caitlyn's love and lust for herself and hold it hostage two hundred miles above the Earth. She promised Jayce she would do right by Caitlyn, and now she understood what that entailed. To lock away her feelings.

So Vi did what she always did best, she ran away.

She put up a wall with Caitlyn, a wall with the damn psychiatrist they had brought in who pried about Vi's wellbeing and seemed skeptical of her holding back her true feelings. Vi wouldn't let anyone in anymore, dedicating herself completely to sealing it all away.

It ripped her apart, the guilt coursing through her veins like a toxic poison. It felt fucking wrong to avoid Caitlyn. A fierce rumble of something rotten filling her gut. She just wasn't sure what to do anymore. Unable to face the consequences of that night of passion, unable to voice the emotions swirling around like a treacherous storm within her heart. It built into something all consuming, something Vi wasn't sure she could contain for much longer.

Until she was backed into a corner. Or in her case, a thick puddle of wet cement.

The fear, the adrenaline, the desperate plea of her aching heart all roared in Vi's ears once she realized she had been stuck, that Caitlyn wouldn't let her flee any longer. Vi couldn't even tighten her fists where they lay in the thick mixture, forced to keep her palms spread, vulnerable.

So she snapped.

Her confession poured out of her like a dam bursting, raw, honest and unabashed. She couldn't hold it in anymore. Months of build up, of that fire in her veins and temptation in her heart. It finally flooded out of her. It was terrifying, but freeing. She wasn't sure what she expected to come out of it, and she tried so desperately to convince Caitlyn that she deserved better, but Caitlyn was having none of it.

And then she said it.

"The only thing that can transcend the magnitude of our universe for me is how I feel about you."

Those words would forever linger in Vi's heart. She realized it then, the pure scope of Caitlyn's devotion. Suddenly, there was no fight left in her. The iron bars around her heart had been reduced to a pile of rust and nothing she could say or do would build them back up again.

She loved Caitlyn. Longed for her like the moon's pull of the tides. The acceptance of it lifted a weight from her chest that went far beyond the effects of zero gravity. Vi let it envelop her completely, allowing for the beat of her heart to succumb to what it had truly desired all this time.

"So you'll really do it then?"

She had to ask. It was the final step forward off the edge for her, a nail in the coffin of which she would use to bury her insecurities.

“Do what?”

Vi took a deep breath, steadying herself and finally submitting to what she had craved all this time.

“You’ll wait for me?”

Vi thought she could hear the soft rasp of tears in Caitlyn’s voice, but she knew. She knew they came from a place of heartfelt joy. She could feel it herself in the salty streaks that fell down her own freckled cheeks.

“Yes, Violet.” Her name sounded holy on Caitlyn’s lips, softly spoken like a vow to the very universe itself. “I’ll wait for you.”

And that’s what Caitlyn did.

Through months of soft whispers of fidelity, shy giggles and virtual intimacy that never failed to send Vi’s body alight with desire. They cherished every moment through it all, each counting down the days in which they could finally see one another, to pair a physical reaction with the longing they had shared.

“What do you think it will be like when the two of us meet for the first time?” Caitlyn mused, the two of them having completed their tasks and simply enjoying the company one evening. Vi was in the cupola looking down at the Earth, as she often did when the two conversed. The station was passing over the Sahara Desert, bathing the entirety of it in a breathtaking orange glow.

Vi thought for a moment. In truth, she really wasn’t sure what to expect, but she did know one thing. “Honestly I don’t think I’ll be able to keep my hands off you.”

Caitlyn giggled shyly, pulling the corners of Vi’s own lips into a fond smile. “I suppose I don’t have a problem with that.”

“Well that’s good because I’m afraid this transaction is non-refundable.”

Caitlyn scoffed playfully. “But I kept my receipt.”

“Tough shit, cupcake.”

Her capcom sighed. “Then I guess I’ll just have to keep you.”

The two of them laughed softly. Shit, Vi never thought she’d enjoy this kind of corny talk but Caitlyn continued to draw the best out of her. She couldn’t help the fuzziness, the tough butch demeanor she’d spend her life building crumbling to pieces in this woman’s hands.

“Do you think it will be different?” Caitlyn asked suddenly, wary.

“Well, yeah. It will be different.” Vi knew what Caitlyn meant. She also knew that change was a part of growth, and that she was anything but scared to grow with Caitlyn. “But not in a bad way.”

Caitlyn hummed, Vi could tell she was nibbling on her lower lip, a trait the astronaut couldn’t wait to witness in person. “It might feel like we’re starting over.”

Vi smiled at the thought. “Well then that just means I get to fall for you all over again.”

“And… you’re okay with that?”

Vi pressed her temple against the glass window. It was cold, and yet she felt so unbearably warm in the sunlit glow of the Earth. “I would happily spend the rest of my life falling for you over and over again, Caitlyn.”

Caitlyn hummed and Vi practically melted into the soft sound of her voice. “As would I for you, Vi.”

Then came the day that Vi finally, literally, fell back down to Earth.

Much as she tried to keep a stoic façade, she was unbearably nervous. Not for the trip itself, but for seeing Caitlyn for the first time. Vi knew she had to get through recovery, that it would still take some time to see her capcom, but the sudden anticipation of a dramatic shift in their dynamic flooded her veins like a drug.

Vi was fiercely determined, desperate to be freed from the metal capsule and breathe in the Earth’s atmosphere for the first time in twelve months. She was going to be strong, breeze through recovery, stand on two solid feet once she exited the craft and be ready to see her capcom.

At least, that’s what she had hoped, but reality was a bitch and its name was gravity.

Vi had never felt so damn weak. A tremble in her legs, a heaviness in her limbs and vertigo like she had been on a perpetual roller coaster for hours had her nearly collapsing into the gurney waiting for her once she exited the capsule. She hated the hands of the NASA employees gripping at her arms, supporting her back and ushering her to lay down. She hated the bile that rose in her throat, spilling into a bucket provided for her and leaving her with a hollow feeling in her gut. She spent the better part of her journey to the hospital stretching out her shaking, heavy arms, flexing her fingers and remembering just what it felt like to have bones and muscles.

“I need a phone.”

The nurse who had just finished setting up Vi’s heart monitor blinked, astounded. “Um, you should be resting-”

“Please.” Vi begged, a trembling desperation to her tone. “Please, there’s someone I need to talk to.”

The nurse eyed her for a minute, but relented with a soft nod and pulled out a small flip phone from her scrub pocket.

“Thank you.” Vi breathed out, ignoring the numbness in her fingers as she flipped open the device and punched in the number Caitlyn had given her. Her thumb hovered over the green call button, seconds away from pressing it down, from hearing Caitlyn’s voice again.

But she just… couldn’t.

Ekko gave her a confused look from his adjacent hospital bed. “So are you gonna call her or did you suddenly lose function of your fingers? Cause for a lesbian that would be unfortunate as shit.”

Vi didn’t even have the energy to make a return retort. She swallowed hard, staring at the number on the screen. “I can’t.”

“You can’t?”

“I- shit. I can’t do it, Ekko.” There was a quickening of Vi’s heart that set the monitor off, anxiety flowing fiercely through her veins and a weight in her chest not unlike the one she felt in her limbs. “I- I don’t know why, I just feel so fucking heavy-”

“That’s called gravity.”

“Shut the fuck up. That’s not what I mean.” She clapped the phone shut, her nose scrunching with irritation and confusion. “This just doesn’t feel right. I’m here. I’m on Earth, I don’t want to just fucking hear her through a line anymore, I want to see her. I need to feel her. If I- if I hear her voice right now I think I’ll cave. I’ll drag myself out of this hospital if I fucking have to. I don’t give a shit about recovery. I just need to-”

“Okay, okay. Calm down, Vi.” Ekko tried his best to sit up, to offer Vi a consoling expression past the pale dizziness he most likely also felt. “You’re still fucked up on the adrenaline of coming back. Take some time to relax. Your brain is all scrambled trying to remember how to be a human again so don’t push yourself. Take it slow, alright?”

Vi collapsed back into her hospital bed, stubbornly clenching and unclenching her fingers into fists until she could feel them again. Ekko was right, she just needed time to process everything, to understand how it felt to move and function in this environment once more. She was impatient, and it would be grueling, but she’d do it, and she’d do it double time.

For Caitlyn.

Vi tried. She tried every damn day to call, but she never could. Her mind gradually cleared, the feeling in her limbs returning to normal the more she trained, but this one thing remained constant. She couldn’t bring herself to hear Caitlyn’s voice again, couldn’t accept the fact that she was being prevented from getting to her, finally closing the torturous distance after all this time.

So she focused on recovery. She pushed herself to a breaking point, ignoring the disapproving brow raises from her doctors and physical therapists. Vi wasn't stupid, she knew her body's limits and she would respect them, but she'd be damned if she didn't go as far as she could.

And when she could finally jog a mile, once the puffiness in her face from fluid shifting had subsided and she could lift a sandbag without a single tremor to her limbs, Vi was ready to return to Houston.

Vi laid awake that night, unable to quell the anxious fluttering in her gut and the rampant thoughts of what it might be like when she sees Caitlyn for the first time. She ran through countless scenarios, each one setting her heart alight with excitement. She finally managed to close her eyes for a bit and just a few hours later she was on an early flight, finally headed home.

"Here we are." Vander led her down the familiar rows of desks, stopping in front of a cubicle at the back of the comms room. He leaned casually against the wall, waiting for Vi to enter.

Vi didn't pass the threshold of the space. She didn't want to pry, not without Caitlyn's permission. She could see a few framed photos sitting on the desk and made sure to look away, not wanting that to be her first view of the woman she'd fallen for. She clenched her fists at her sides, catching a glimpse of the frantic rhythm the heart rate monitor strapped to her wrist was displaying with a frown.

"Something wrong?"

Vi let out a huff, her gaze fixated on the ground below her feet and voice an anxious whisper. "I'm so fucking nervous, Dad."

Vander's voice was patient, deeply rooted in a sense of compassion. "I'd be surprised if you weren't."

"Shit, it feels like my heart is gonna explode."

"Vi, look at me." She did, and what she found was a soft sort of understanding and empathy only her father was capable of. "Trust in the path your heart has chosen. Love comes wrapped in all sorts of emotions. Let yourself feel them, and know that there's beauty in all of it. That's what makes it real."

The tension in Vi's shoulder's released, a sting behind her eyes that she was too stubborn to let fall. Instead she reached out and pulled herself into her father's arms, basking in the immense relief and comfort his presence brought forth. "Thanks, Dad."

Vander's strong arms wrapped tightly around Vi's shoulders, grounding her in the moment. "Always, kiddo."

He left Vi to wait by Caitlyn's cubicle and Vi let herself be blanketed by the warm excitement flowing through her body. Vander was right, these feelings shouldn't be suppressed. There

really was something beautiful about it, knowing that she felt this way at the prospect of finally seeing the woman she'd fallen in love with.

Vi took her time glancing around the comms room and breathing in deeply to accompany the frantic beat of her heart. She busied herself by staring at the various photographs hung along the walls. Beautiful, vast images of stars and planets. The most stunning sights known to mankind. She truly never tired of looking at these photos, believing there to not be a sight nearly as impactful or stunning anywhere on Earth.

Vi always loved this room. She loved the soft blue ambient lighting, the warm mahogany of the desks, the smell of coffee and printer ink-

The sound of paper scattering to the ground.

Vi turned before she had time to think.

And suddenly felt as though she had been punched in the gut.

Vi knew the woman standing in front of her. She could have not known a single detail about what Caitlyn looked like and still, she would have known this was her. She could feel it under her skin, a static charge that lit her nerves on fire, setting a deafening pace to her heartbeat.

She knew, and yet she still couldn't believe it.

Vi had convinced herself that it didn't matter what Caitlyn looked like, believing that no matter what she was faced with, it wouldn't affect her feelings in the slightest. She would love Caitlyn regardless, and there was no possible way her feelings could extend past the peak they had already ascended too. No possible way that just the sight of her capcom could send Vi spiraling upward to new heights of irreverent love.

God, she had been so fucking wrong.

The woman who stood before her was nothing short of breathtaking, even in her clearly shocked and flustered state. The cosmic photographs that Vi had spent the better part of the morning admiring seemed like mere scraps of paper compared to the work of art that was her capcom. Vi took in every detail, dragging her wide eyes down the expanse of Caitlyn's body and drinking her in like she was parched and only Caitlyn could quell the aching thirst.

How many times had she tried to envision Caitlyn? To put the pieces together in her mind? The silk cobalt of her hair, the smooth expanse of her blush-tinted skin, and the striking depth to her cerulean hues. Vi didn't know why she even bothered trying. Nothing her feeble mind could have concocted would have held a candle to the shining ray of light that Caitlyn was.

Vi had seen many wonders of the universe, felt the psychological effects brought on by such sights that human minds often couldn't comprehend and suddenly it all felt like nothing. A whisper compared to the crescendo of this woman's all consuming presence.

Vi found herself rendered weak once more, immobile. All of the training and recovery be damned to how frail she felt in that moment. This was certainly not what she had anticipated

happening. Every scenario she had gone over in her restless night prior couldn't dream of coming close to this. She planned to sweep Caitlyn off her feet, to kiss her breathless as she promised she would on the night they confessed to one another. Yet all she could do was stare, the magnitude of her awe rendering her body completely useless.

That was, until Caitlyn finally came to her senses, attempting to brush a stray lock of hair behind her ear as she fell to the ground to collect the scattered papers she had dropped in her shock.

Vi moved without thinking once again, lost in a trance of awestruck wonder. She found it easy to fall on her knee in front of Caitlyn, feeling as though that's where she belonged. On her knees, begging for this woman's love. The familiar numbness in her fingers went ignored while she swept up the documents, her eyes glued to the ethereal beauty in front of her.

Caitlyn stood, and Vi still couldn't bring herself to move.

It's like she could feel the fresh effects of gravity once again. The same heaviness to her limbs that accompanied her after her return journey. It was suddenly so clear to Vi that this beautiful woman, Caitlyn, was the new tether that bound her to the Earth.

Caitlyn was her gravity, holding Vi firm and breathing new life into her very being.

She found the strength to stand, swooning at the adorable way in which Caitlyn awkwardly shuffled the papers together in her arms. Their eyes met.

And Vi fell in love with Caitlyn all over again, just as they had predicted.

Of all the things Vi wanted to do, she found herself restrained by the uncertain anxiety in Caitlyn's eyes. This was new for both of them, but also terrifyingly exciting. How could Vi justify touching this woman, someone who looked as though she belonged on display amongst the finest works of art the world had seen?

Vi could only ghost her fingers across Caitlyn's gossamer flesh, feeling unworthy of caressing such an ephemeral beauty. She touched Caitlyn as if grazing the wings of a butterfly, afraid that she would break apart under the astronaut's rough fingers.

There were countless things Vi wanted to say at that moment. Pages of poetry and limericks, endless novels, the most beautiful romances the world had come to know. She would recite them all to Caitlyn, and yet it wouldn't be enough.

So instead, she settled for what was familiar. What she knew was so intrinsically and truly *them.*

"Hey, cupcake." She spoke with the utmost care she could possibly muster, almost afraid of scaring Caitlyn off. "You copy?"

If Vi thought Caitlyn shone brighter than the stars before, she was absolutely blinded by the stretch of Caitlyn's lips into an elated smile. Vi could feel her own cheeks aching as she

returned the expression, her gaze prickling with unshed tears as she *finally* took in the beauty of her capcom.

“Yes.” Caitlyn whispered, the familiar voice Vi had hopelessly fallen for sending shivers down her spine. “I copy.”

Vi wasn’t sure just how many times she felt she had fallen for Caitlyn after that. The two months they had spent together felt harmonious, carefree and wrapped in a sense of peace that warmed Vi’s heart from the inside out. She cherished every second, every touch of Caitlyn’s lips and whisper of her breath. Caitlyn was everything to Vi, her new beginning, her future. Vi was certain this was it for her, that there was no other love in the universe that could compare.

And as Vi opened her eyes from where she sat reminiscing in her car, she realized something.

She realized it had all been worth it. Every second of emotional torment, every aching beat of her heart and itch beneath her flesh. It was all worth it to now be able to hold Caitlyn in her arms. She’d do it all over again, the highs of sharing intimacy, their confession, the laughter and the banter. The fear of the unknown, of losing herself into the vast darkness, the long drawn out days filled with the melodious sound of Caitlyn’s voice.

It was the most difficult thing she had ever done, but had brought about something so incredibly beautiful.

Could she do it again?

She had meant it when she said no view of space could compare to Caitlyn’s beauty. She had meant it when she declared she would give it all up for Caitlyn. She meant every word, and yet that ache, that hollowness in her gut at the prospect of giving up was consuming her.

Vi had never felt so lost.

Caitlyn's words from that morning ran circles in her head like a broken record.

“Can’t I convince you to stay?”

She could, and Vi would.

But Vi knew that Caitlyn wouldn’t even try.

Chapter End Notes

I promised you all a happy ending, so trust me, yeah?

Sorry for the heavy recap but I tried to balance it with some new stuff and I thought Vi's POV was essential to the story, hope you didn't mind too much.

Yell at me on X here.

Comments and kudos much obliged. <3

Liftoff

Chapter Summary

> “You deserve happiness, Vi.”

Chapter Notes

> Heya. Well, here it is. I must admit it’s very bitter sweet to post this final chapter. I'm so happy to have finally completed this work, but sad of course to see it end. Thank you so much for your patience and I hope you find it’s all been worth it.
>
> So without further ado.
>
> Playlist for this fic here.
>
> See ya. <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“If you keep staring at her like that, you may burn a hole through her head.”

Vi tore her gaze away from where Caitlyn was standing across the yard to glare at Ekko as he lifted a beer to his lips with a smug grin. She nudged him with her elbow, taking a swig from her own bottle with a shake of her head. Vi was well aware she had a habit of dissociating when staring at Caitlyn. Really though, who could blame her? They had already spent the majority of their relationship out of sight from one another. So yeah, she’d take every opportunity she could to stare. Ekko and his arrogant mug could get fucked.

The entire back yard of the Wick family home had been strung up in patio lights with varying sizes of paper star lanterns hanging from the strands. Several picnic tables with space themed vinyl tablecloths were scattered throughout, covered in various snacks and beverages. It was truly a sight to behold, the perfect combination of cozy and fun. There really was no one who could put together a party like Powder could.

Everyone had already arrived, all scattered throughout the grassy terrain and entranced in their own conversations while a soft playlist echoed across the space from the speakers on the back porch. The Eta Aquarids meteor shower wasn’t to start for a few hours, but Mylo and Claggor were already creating a practical minefield of blanket nests and pillow forts. It was as comfortable a setting as Vi could imagine, surrounded by soft music, good booze, the stars, and her loved ones.

Yet she simply couldn't relax with the hollowness of indecisive angst swirling around in her gut.

"How do you do it?"

Ekko paused in his motion to take another sip from his drink. He quirked a brow at Vi. "Do what?"

Vi nodded toward where Powder was enthusiastically discussing an idea for another ridiculous invention with Jayce near the porch, a vibrant smile on her lips and bright red liquid sloshing out of her cup as she gesticulated. "Leave her."

Ekko looked at Powder and sighed, his eyes softening with a gentle sense of devotion. "It's not easy but… when you love someone that much, it transcends non-tangible things like time and space. It kills me to be away from her, but we learned how to make it work."

Vi glanced back over to where Caitlyn was eagerly chatting with Vander. She caught Vi's eye for a moment, a brilliant smile overtaking her features accompanied by the small wave of her hand. Vi couldn't help but smile back despite the deep ache in her chest.

Her expression dropped slowly once Caitlyn looked away, replaced with a frustrated furrow to her brow. "What if I can't make it work?"

"You can. I mean, you did once before, right?"

"That was before I saw her, Ekko. Before I held her in my arms. Now that I know what she looks like, and how fucking perfect she feels against me… I don't think I could let that go for anything."

Ekko hummed in thought for a moment. "Not even your dream?"

Vi inhaled deeply, her mother's gentle smile appearing at the forefront of her mind accompanied by the soft whisper of her voice reading to Vi about the vastness of the universe, telling Vi that's where she belonged.

She found herself releasing all that was left unspoken in her conversation with Vander that morning, letting it flow completely unabashed. "I don't know. I mean, fuck, I love being up there. I find myself aching for it, like it's where I belong. I think about my mother, how she wanted so much for me, how much work I put in to achieve the dream we shared for me." She took a deep, steadying breath, unable to bring herself to look back down toward the woman she loved. The only one who could keep her drawn to the Earth. "But then I think about the way I feel in Caitlyn's arms, and it feels as though I've found a new dream in her. Like there isn't a force in the universe that could tear me away from her."

Ekko sighed and Vi shifted her gaze to him. It felt good to open up to Ekko about this. Heck, he was probably the only person in the world who could understand exactly how Vi was feeling.

“Time is a funny thing.” He mused, twisting the amber bottle in his grasp. “Feels endless when you’re in it, and then, in what feels like a blink, it’s over.” He looked at Powder once more and Vi understood. She could see it in his eyes, the type of love that was nearly impossible to put words to. The feeling was all too familiar to her. “It’s torturous, but it passes, and you might not know what’s waiting for you at the end of it, but if you trust in the people you love then you know it’ll turn out okay.”

Yeah, Ekko was the right person to talk to about this. He was right, and deep down Vi knew that. She knew she could make it work with Caitlyn, the time, the distance. Sure, it would be torturous, but it wouldn’t be forever. Time would pass, and she’d find her way back into Caitlyn’s embrace. Caitlyn said she would wait, and Vi trusted her to do that.

Still, it felt wrong to put Caitlyn through that when she deserved to be worshipped every morning in the warmth of the sun.

“What about her? What if I can’t do that to her?”

Ekko flicked Vi on the temple. She flinched back, rubbing at the side of her head and offering him a dumbfounded, slightly offended glare.

“You’re doing that thing again where you think you’re making the people you love suffer by choosing what you want. She knew what she was getting into, Vi. I mean, shit, how many times did she say she’d wait for you?”

“A couple.” Vi grumbled.

“Mhm. Caitlyn’s tough as shit, I’m sure she can handle waiting a few months for your dramatic, gay ass.”

Why the fuck do people always call her dramatic? “Okay well what if-”

He rolled his eyes and Vi feared she was in for another flick. “You’re overthinking it, Vi.” She opened her mouth to retort but Ekko beat her to it. “Look, humor me. I’m gonna ask you some questions, and I want you to answer them quickly without thinking. Got it?”

Vi’s brow furrowed in confusion, not really sure where her friend was going with this but willing to give him the benefit of the doubt. She offered Ekko a curt nod and the man cleared his throat to fire off.

“What are you?”

She blinked. “What-”

“Answer quickly.”

“An astronaut?”

“How many times have you been to space?”

“Twice.”

He tilted his head in Caitlyn's direction. "You see the two of you together long term?"

"Yes."

"You trust her?"

"With my life."

"How many fingers am I holding up?"

"Three."

"Do you want to go?"

"Yes."

Vi gasped. Ekko leveled her with a look. "Well then, you have your answer."

She glared down at the ground for a moment unblinkingly, unable to wrap her mind around the simplicity of it. "That easy, huh?"

"Fuck no, it's not that easy, but if it's what your heart is telling you on instinct then maybe you shouldn't fight it." He nudged her arm with his elbow, offering a kind smile. "Does it feel right?"

Vi finally looked back toward Caitlyn, staring across the physical distance between them and feeling that all too familiar pull in her chest. Caitlyn was everything Vi could have dreamt up, more so even. There wasn't any room left in Vi's heart for doubt in the strength of their relationship or the magnitude of their shared devotion. They fell in love separated by over two hundred miles, something so unique and transcendent couldn't be shattered so easily.

She fell in love with Caitlyn among the stars, and she could do it all over again.

"Yeah." She whispered, unsure but uncaring if Ekko could even hear her. "It does."

They fell into silence for a moment, Ekko seemingly allowing the reality of Vi's decision to sink in. Vi suddenly felt surrounded and smothered, unable to truly process everything with so many people around that depended on her.

"I need a minute." She set her drink down on a nearby picnic table and headed across the yard toward the house, avoiding eye contact with anyone as she went. She just couldn't look yet, couldn't face the gazes of her loved ones knowing that she had once again chosen selfishly, even if she knew they would be nothing but supportive.

She couldn't look, and yet she could feel Caitlyn's eyes on her as she went.

Vi stood in a sort of trance-like state as she stared at the display set upon the dresser in her old bedroom. Countless medals and awards, framed degrees and certificates, a practical road map of all of her achievements. Those tacky, plastic glow-in-the-dark stars trailed up the wall at a diagonal, scattering in between the array of framed photographs throughout the years and extending toward the ceiling. Vi's graduation photo, receiving her medals, some training stills, her and Ekko up at the space station with their arms around each other's shoulders, and of course, her NASA profile photo.

A photo of her and her mother at the Air and Space Museum together, hand in hand gazing at the various spacecraft models with wonder.

It was quite a collection, one that felt too magnanimous for Vi to comprehend and yet she felt greedy in the way she wanted more. There simply was no limit to her desires for exploration and discovery, her ambition extending across the vast expanse of the universe itself. Vi wasn't sure it would ever be enough, not when there was so much more to see out there.

A soft knock against the doorframe pulled Vi from her musings. She looked back over her shoulder, unable to keep the flutter from her heart at the sight of Caitlyn casually leaning against the old wood with a red solo cup in her hand.

"Had a feeling I might find you here." She said softly, coming to stand at Vi's side. The two stood in silence for a moment, both looking over the variety of Vi's accomplishments over the years. Vi felt sick to her stomach as the realization hit that her choice was quite literally right in front of her.

Caitlyn, and her ambitions as an astronaut.

"I don't think I've ever told you this…" Caitlyn murmured. Vi looked to her and saw a deep sense of care, but also pride swimming in her cerulean hues. She reached out with her free hand, grazing her fingertips over Vi's Congressional Space Medal of Honor. "But I am so incredibly proud of you, Violet."

Vi's heart sputtered. She blinked at Caitlyn, completely taken aback by such a sentiment. "What?"

Caitlyn's lips quirked into a soft smile as she turned to meet Vi's gaze. "You've accomplished so much, persevered when the odds were against you but always managed to stay strong in the face of uncertainty for the sake of your family. I've never met anyone quite like you, Vi. You're amazing and I am so proud of you." She nodded toward the museum photo. "And I know your mother would be proud as well."

There was a push behind Vi's eyes, an intense ache and a burning at the corners where tears threatened to spill over. She tore her eyes away from Caitlyn's, her brow furrowing deeply where she glared down at the space between them.

Vi didn't know what to say. What could she say in the face of such a raw confession of unconditional support? It was as if Caitlyn wiped the slate of Vi's guilt clean, instilling in her

a sense of pride and solidifying her in her desires for further pursuit of discovery.

Yet that burning nature of self deprecation still singed the edges of her heart. She didn't feel as though she deserved this, that she deserved Caitlyn's love.

As if sensing the negative spiral of Vi's thoughts, Caitlyn reached out to gently cup her cheek, encouraging the astronaut's gaze back up. Caitlyn's thumb gently stroked Vi's freckles, her eyes softening into deep pools of sympathy.

"You're holding something in again, I can tell."

Fuck, Vi wasn't ready for this. A sentiment that Caitlyn, of course, picked up on.

"I won't push you if you're not ready to talk about it-"

"No." Vi retrieved Caitlyn's palm from her cheek, holding it gingerly in both her hands with an intense look of focus as she studied the lines on her lover's palm. "I kind of *have* to talk to you about it, so…"

"Okay." There was a tentative angst present in Caitlyn's tone, but she seemed calm. She waited patiently for Vi to force the words stuck in her throat. Unmoving and patient with the most considerate gleam to her stunning hues.

Because that's what Caitlyn did. She always waited for Vi.

"They want me back. For the six month expedition in January."

"Oh." Caitlyn didn't seem necessarily shocked by this news. Instead she looked more like she was internally debating something, her brow furrowing in concentration and consideration. Vi knew Caitlyn wouldn't react with any particular sense of aversion, but this look of pondering wasn't necessarily on her bingo card. It was a surprising reaction, to say the least.

"You don't- um, you don't seem very surprised."

Caitlyn shrugged, completely unperturbed. "I'm not. You're their best astronaut, it would be ludicrous of them not to ask for you back. Besides, we knew this was coming eventually."

It seemed Caitlyn had given this far more thought than Vi had over the months. It made sense, Caitlyn always stared down the barrel of her issues whereas Vi tended to let them boil below the surface like a geyser until they eventually burst free. That's just how they were. "So… what do you think?"

"It doesn't really matter what I think, it matters what *you* want."

Yeah, Vi figured it would go something like this.

"It *does* matter what you think." Vi stepped forward, looping an arm around Caitlyn's waist and stroking a soothing palm against her lower back. Caitlyn angled the cup in her hand away from where their bodies were joined, sighing fondly in response to what Vi knew was her stubborn nature. "We're a team, Cait. So if you want me to stay-"

Caitlyn shook her head. “I want what I’ve always wanted, Vi. For you to do what makes you happy.”

“*You* make me happy.” Vi pushed, gripping at Caitlyn’s lower back as if frightened she would pull away. Terrified of losing the most valuable thing in this room, far more than any medal or certificate. “Being here with you is the happiest I’ve ever been-”

“And I’ll be here regardless of what it is you choose.” Caitlyn flattened her free hand over Vi’s chest in reassurance, grounding her. “It’s your decision, *your* dream. If staying is what you want then I’ll support you… but if I know you as well as I believe I do, then I know what it is you truly desire.”

There really was no hiding from Caitlyn. She had peeled back every one the layers of Vi’s heart, stared at her so openly with a deep understanding that simply no one else could. Vi wasn’t even sure why she was pushing back when she had already made up her mind. It was as if she was looking for an out, for Caitlyn to be the one to take the decision from her and decide what was best for both of them.

Of course, Caitlyn wouldn’t ever do something like that. Vi knew that.

“Do you want to go?” Caitlyn whispered, tentative and yet so, *so* supportive.

“I think…” Vi swallowed, steadying herself with the comfort in her lover’s grasp as she spoke aloud the words she had feared all this time. “I think I do. Yeah.”

Vi couldn’t bring herself to look at Caitlyn anymore, but she refused to pull away. Instead she let her eyes fall shut, a light press of their foreheads spreading warmth all throughout the astronaut’s body. “I don’t want to leave you and, shit, it’s been fucking tearing me apart but… I think I’d regret it if I didn’t go.” There was a tremble to her voice, a vulnerability in finally admitting to the quandaries of her heart. “You’re everything to me, Caitlyn, and if you asked then I know I would give all of this up for you but… I know you’ll never do that and if it’s truly up to me then I just don’t think I can give up on my dreams.”

The words sat heavy around them, blanketing Vi in a strange swirl of relief, but also uncertainty. Was this really the right choice? She had chosen wrong so often before, made so many wrong turns and it ended up biting everyone in the ass. It was no wonder she struggled to trust her instincts, the confidence in her decision making held by a delicate thread.

Powder was right, Vi always made her decisions based on what she felt other’s would want. Choosing for herself this time was such unfamiliar territory, especially when she could risk hurting Caitlyn because of it.

She finally pried her eyes open, terrified of what she may find. Vi had stared into an infinite void of space countless times, nearly lost herself to it. But this, the unknown of how Caitlyn would take Vi’s decision, the anxiety of having once again done wrong by the woman she loved, was so much more terrifying.

But Caitlyn was smiling softly, reaching up to brush her thumb across Vi’s flesh to drag the moisture trailing down her tattoo’d cheek away that Vi hadn’t even registered falling there.

There was no room for uncertainty in Caitlyn's eyes, none of the same anxiety that Vi was so haunted by. Caitlyn looked… she looked proud, elated even.

"Why are you smiling?" Vi whispered, dumbfounded and awed.

Caitlyn's voice was unbelievably tender, laced with raw honesty. "Because I'm *happy.* I'm happy that you finally chose what you wanted for yourself." She laughed softly to herself. "I was worried I would need to send you up there kicking and screaming."

Vi wondered if there would ever be a time when this woman didn't steal the very breath from her lungs. "You're really okay with this? You think this is the right choice?"

"It's the right choice because it's what you want, and I'll support you in it. Unconditionally."

How many times was it now that Vi had fallen for Caitlyn? She'd lost count.

"Thank you." There was still a light tremble to Vi's lips as she pressed them to Caitlyn's forehead. She needed to stand on her toes a bit to do so, but she could care fucking less. "You have no idea how much this means to me, Caitlyn."

"You don't need to thank me for this."

"No. I kinda do." Vi retrieved Caitlyn's palm from her cheek, cradling it against her chest as she reconnected their foreheads together, no longer fearful of looking her lover in the eyes. "I'm just so grateful for you. You never let any sort of doubt linger in me and I-" Caitlyn sucked in a breath. Vi sighed. "I wish you could come with me."

Caitlyn tensed suddenly in Vi's grasp, nibbling at her lower lip anxiously. "Is that… is that something you would want?"

Vi couldn't help but laugh somewhat incredulously. "Yes. *God,* yes. I would move heaven and Earth itself for it."

"You're-" Caitlyn swallowed and Vi had to admit, she was beginning to feel that same doubt creeping in again at Caitlyn's sudden wavering. "You're just saying that."

Vi pulled back, her brow furrowing. "Caitlyn, you're kidding right? You? Up there with me? The two of us drifting together among the stars? I'd give up a lifetime of expeditions just to have that even for just a second's time."

Caitlyn wasn't looking at her anymore, her gaze averted to Vi's NASA profile photo once more. Vi found herself plagued by what Caitlyn could possibly be pondering. What was she thinking about now? What had she been thinking at the start of this conversation, when Vi had initially told her about the recruitment?

There was something left unsaid, something Vi needed to know.

"Caitlyn?"

"What if… what if I did come with you?"

Vi chuckled. “Well that would be a dream come true, but you’re not an astronaut, baby.”

Caitlyn shifted from foot to foot for a second, suddenly interested in staring at where she was swirling the nightmare of a mixed drink Powder had made in her cup. “Well not… not yet but…”

Vi’s heart jumped into her throat. “But what…?”

Caitlyn bit her lip shyly, retrieving her hand from Vi’s grasp to rub against her forearm, a cute habit of hers whenever she felt conflicted or dismayed. “I… I was in Vander’s office a few days ago-”

Vi couldn’t breathe.

“With Loris’ retirement there’s a position open and, well, apparently the higher ups were quite impressed with my knowledge of the space station and, in particular, how I handled the emergency situation with the satellite.”

There was nothing but static in Vi’s mind, a numbing sort of hollowness as she struggled to process the words slowly slipping from Caitlyn’s beautiful lips.

Caitlyn finally looked back up to her, swallowing thickly with what Vi assumed were nerves. “They… they’ve asked me if I wanted to begin training for the next expedition.”

Suddenly Vi was thrown back into how she felt upon arriving back to Earth, the weight of gravity pushing down on her, rooting her to the ground and shocking her to the core. Her chest felt tight, words impossible and breathing a forgotten skill.

This couldn’t be reality. It had to have been a dream.

Caitlyn was staring at Vi, anxiety swimming in her gaze. Fuck, Vi needed to say something but out of the three languages she knew not a single word nor coherent thought would come together.

“I’m so sorry.” Caitlyn suddenly rushed to say, searching Vi’s shocked face with a nervous tremor to her lower lip. “I was going to tell you sooner but- I wasn’t sure if you wanted that. It’s a lot to commit to and… I wanted you to make the decision for yourself first. I didn’t want you to make it because of me. This was- it was about what *you* wanted, and Vander agreed with me. I needed to let you choose for yourself first… it was important to me that you did.”

The gears slowly began turning in Vi’s head, processing everything as she stood there in open-mouthed awed. As much as this decision had torn Vi apart all day, she understood Caitlyn at that moment. If Caitlyn had outright told Vi about the offer, then Vi would have been deprived of the opportunity to do something she never did, to choose for herself.

Caitlyn wasn’t lying, she only wanted Vi to do what made her happy. Vi had never doubted that fact but this… it meant more to her than she could find the words for.

“And I haven’t given them my answer yet.” Caitlyn was rambling anxiously, fidgeting with that loose strand of hair she could never get to stay put in her ponytail. “Of course I want to go, it’s the opportunity of a lifetime but it- it was never my dream. It was yours. So if you don’t want me to go, if it was all talk in the heat of the moment and if you’d rather not spend six months stuck in a metal tube with me in space, then I understand and I-”

The words had been stolen from Caitlyn’s lips as Vi firmly wrapped both strong arms around her waist, lifting her off the ground and spinning with the overwhelming sense of Euphoria that had completely enraptured her. She had nothing to say, nothing to do but squeeze the ever living daylights out of Caitlyn and suppress the bubble of emotions threatening to gasp free from her lips.

Caitlyn floundered in Vi’s arms, gripping her shoulder in vice with one free hand while trying and failing to keep the sloshing cup steady in the other. “Violet! You’re going to spill everywhere-”

“I don’t care. God, I don’t fucking *care,* Cait.” The tremble now present in Vi’s voice was one of unabashed glee, incredulous, breathy laughs fanning out against where her face was pressed to Caitlyn’s chest. She stopped spinning to pull back and stare upward, a brilliant smile soliciting an ache from her cheeks as she gazed up toward her lover. “You’re going into space with me?”

Caitlyn relaxed into Vi’s arms, smiling softly and trusting in the astronaut’s grip on her waist enough to return her palm to Vi’s cheek. “If that’s alright with you then… yes.”

“Of course that’s alright, are you fucking kidding?” She slowly lowered Caitlyn to the ground, releasing her waist to instead grip either side of Caitlyn’s neck and rain kisses down against her lips. “ I want to show you the stars, stare down at the Earth with you-” Caitlyn giggled in between the slew of kisses and confessions Vi was pouring into her. Vi couldn’t bring herself to stop. “Want to dance with you up there, see the warmth of the sun glow on your skin when it shines through the windows. I want to do everything with you. Fuck, I can’t believe this. I love you so much, Caitlyn.”

Caitlyn gasped against Vi’s lips and it was only then in the sudden silence, with the high of euphoric adrenaline still loud within the astronaut’s ears, that it dawned on her what had been uttered.

“You… you love me.” Caitlyn whispered. Vi pulled back an inch to see dampness threatening at Caitlyn’s waterline.

Vi hadn’t thought before saying it. Didn’t have time to process, to overthink, to talk herself out of it. It just happened. Spilled so naturally from her lips like the words belonged there. It was then, staring at the drop trailing down Caitlyn’s cheek, that she realized how completely foolish she had been to keep it in all this time when it was just so *right.*

“Yeah.” Vi whispered, swiping her thumb along Caitlyn’s jaw to steal the salty drop away before it could fall from her chin. “I love you. I’ve loved you all this time. Even when I was up there.” There was no use holding any of it back anymore, not when Vi had been completely freed of her guilt, of her insecurities in what she desired. “You’re my gravity,

Caitlyn. You pulled me in and grounded me in a way I never thought possible. I could feel it for months, this pull toward you. I've stared into infinity and still felt as though it wasn't enough to contain the magnitude of my feelings for you. How could I possibly do anything but love you?"

Caitlyn's stunned expression broke, too many tears slipping over her cheeks for Vi to catch despite how she craved to kiss each of them away.

"I love you, too." She whispered brokenly, gripping at the back of Vi's neck and offering a brilliant smile that Vi was sure could light up the cosmos. "I've loved you for so long, Violet. I wanted to say it but-"

"I know." Vi whispered, placing a delicate kiss to Caitlyn's lower lip. "You waited for me. Like you always do."

"Not anymore." Her palm slid down to cover Vi's heart, gaze softening there. "Now you'll have to wait for me, I'm afraid."

Vi frowned. "What-"

"Well I'm sure you know the training typically takes around two years to complete. I've already completed the basics and my knowledge of the station, its functionality, and my experience as a capcom will make the process easier, but it's going to be quite a challenge to complete everything in just seven months."

"Oh." Vi scoffed. "Trust me, cupcake. You'll breeze through it. It's not all that bad."

Caitlyn quirked a brow. "Well not everyone has the benefit of rippling muscles and rock hard abs you know."

Vi leaned in to smirk against Caitlyn's lips, shifting her hands down to grip at that tantalizing waist. "I'm sure you can take it, baby."

There was an unmistakable heat in Caitlyn's cheeks that only served to encourage Vi further. "Are we still talking about astronaut training?"

"No." Vi whispered, relishing in the shiver that shot up Caitlyn's spine. "We're not."

She pushed and pushed until Caitlyn's back hit the wall, several of the plastic stars coming loose and clattering to the ground below. The two pressed tightly into one another, needing the proximity, the desperate clash of their hips and mouths. Caitlyn's lips somehow tasted even sweeter after their shared confession, leaving Vi nearly drunk in a desire for more-

"Vi! You guys are gonna miss the meteor shower!" Vi groaned against Caitlyn's lips as she giggled while Powder continued to echo her raspy voice up the stairwell. "You know the rules, Vi. No boning in the family home."

"If I had a quarter for every time Powder interrupted us then I wouldn't be very rich, but it's fucking annoying that it happened twice." Vi grumbled.

“Come on.” Caitlyn gave Vi’s shoulder a gentle nudge, slipping out from the space between her and the wall. “Let’s go before she comes barreling in here with a paintball gun.”

“Oh she knows better than to do that with me. Mylo on the other hand, there’s a reason half of his paycheck goes toward a new wardrobe every month.”

Caitlyn laughed as the two made their way down the creaky, old stairs and back out to where everyone had begun settling down into their pillow nests in the backyard. Vi cocked a curious eyebrow at Jayce, who had a firm grip on Viktor’s elbow as he assisted in helping the man to the ground. The two made eye contact and Jayce shot her a wink. Mildly impressive. Pretty boy must have some good dick game to bag a workaholic like Viktor.

She then caught Ekkos eye where he lay propped up on his palms with Powder’s head in his lap. He gave Vi a questioning look and she smiled, wordlessly communicating the depth of her gratitude and relief. She’d known Ekko since they were children, he knew how to read her by then and the brilliant grin he flashed in reply was evident of that. Vi was immensely grateful for him and glad that he and Powder had such a strong foundation in their relationship, that they found what worked for them. They truly deserved one another.

Caitlyn ditched her drink in a nearby trash can, tugging Vi along to an encircled collection of various pillows laid out over a blanket covered in mini stars and astronauts. They fell on their backs in the middle of the circle, shoulders touching and fingers intertwined, staring up above to where Vi now felt an eager surge of emotion knowing they would end up together in just a few months.

With the warm night and comfort of her loved ones blanketing them, Vi found herself in a state of elated bliss. She truly wasn’t sure how she had gotten to this point, so fortunate in opportunities and love.

“You deserve happiness, Vi.”

Maybe Vander was right, and maybe Vi could finally accept that.

Powder gasped, her arm shooting up to point toward where a quick streak of light had blipped in and out of view. A smile stretched Vi’s lips as more and more quick flashes swirled in front of them, one of the many stunning sights of the universe on display for them to behold.

“I used to stare up at the stars every night while you were up there.” Vi turned to watch Caitlyn’s expression, meteor shower be damned when she had a woman like this to view instead.

“Yeah. I did the same.” Vi whispered. “Stared down at the Earth constantly, desperate to close the distance between us.” She gave Caitlyn’s hand a reassuring squeeze, finding it difficult to look away.

“You’re missing it.” Caitlyn murmured, her cheeks tinged with red and gaze fixated on the streaks of light painting the sky above.

Vi grinned, flat-out refusing to tear her eyes away despite Caitlyn's protest. "Nothing I haven't seen before. Besides, there are more beautiful sights to behold right here."

Caitlyn turned to meet Vi's expression, her lips parting around a stunned exhale. "How can you say things like that so easily?"

"Because I love you."

God, it really was that simple. Vi had been utterly silly to have waited so long to say it when it was so obvious and true.

There was a vulnerability in the way Caitlyn looked at Vi, almost as if she felt exposed by the unwavering devotion in the astronaut's words.

"Take me home?" She asked quietly, expectantly.

Vi didn't have it in her to argue, didn't give a shit about the meteor shower anymore when she knew what the both of them needed.

"Yeah. Let's go home."

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The door to Caitlyn's apartment banged open with a desperate and uncoordinated tangle of limbs. It was a miracle, really, that the two made it across town and up the elevator without ripping each other's clothes off. The static tension, the urgent need for touch, was so thick between them that it made the hairs on the back of Vi's tattoo'd arms stand up.

She simply couldn't get enough. The weight she had been carrying for months had finally lifted, allowing her to melt completely into the woman she so desperately loved. Their lips moved together as if trying to consume one another, moans that Vi hadn't thought possible pulled from her throat with the simple but messy glide of their lips. She couldn't even bring herself to be fucking embarassed by them, too lost in the molten heat setting her alight with a craving for more.

The door clicked shut and Caitlyn's back hit the surface, Vi's grip firm on her waist where they were pressed together. Her thigh slipped between Caitlyn's own and immediately pressed upward, soliciting a sharp gasp and aroused shudder from Caitlyn who ripped their mouth's apart to let her head fall back in surrender. Vi immediately dove for her neck, trailing kisses and harsh sucks down the soft flesh as Caitlyn ground down against her thigh.

Vi found herself completely lost in her primal need to have Caitlyn, to please her, to take every inch of this woman's body and worship her like she deserved. There were no negative thoughts swirling around in her mind, no poison of guilt in her veins nor plague of indecision in her chest. There was only Caitlyn now, filling her heart and shaking beneath her rough palms.

“What do you want?” She murmured against the smooth expanse of Caitlyn’s neck, savoring the shivers that traversed her lover’s body at the soft spoken words. “Tell me. Whatever it is, I’ll do it.”

“Oh- well…” Vi pulled back to look upon hearing the anxious tremble in Caitlyn’s voice. There was a hesitancy in the woman’s gaze where she averted it to stare down the space between them, bunny teeth sunken into her lower lip anxiously. It was an adorable habit honestly. One of Vi’s favorites to behold, but she’d be damned if she let Caitlyn feel any sort of uncertainty in her wants and desires.

Vi gently grasped Caitlyn’s chin between her fingers, encouraging eye contact once more. Pulling at where Caitlyn’s lower lip had been bitten into and stroking at it gently with her thumb, Vi’s voice remained a delicate and encouraging whisper. “What is it? What do you need?”

Caitlyn took a moment to search Vi’s gaze, her voice timid but eager as she found it once more. “Could we… could we try again? Tonight?”

Vi blinked, excitement suddenly coursing hotly through her veins in stark contrast to the tentativeness threatening her conscience. Her palm moved to the edge of Caitlyn’s jaw, soft eyes searching her lover’s expression for any true signs of hesitancy.

“Are you sure? It was a lot for you last time…”

“Yes.” Caitlyn whispered, her palms sliding up and fingers dragging through the longer hairs at the base of Vi’s neck. “I think I need it. I want to feel you deeply… it feels right.”

Vi swallowed past the nervous lump in her throat, her grasp firm on Caitlyn’s jawline in an attempt to ground them in the raw honesty behind her words. “I’ll make it good for you. I promise.”

“I know.” She offered a small smile and Vi was relieved to see some excitement in her eyes. “I trust you.”

Caitlyn tugged Vi forward to reconnect their lips. She groaned into the kiss, unable to do anything but simply fall completely into it once more. Vi had kissed women before, but she’d never come to think of it as so utterly addicting until she had tasted the sweetness of Caitlyn’s lips. It dragged her down into a depth of desire she’d hadn’t known was possible, wrapping her limbs in a tantalizing warmth that Vi didn’t mind in the slightest. She’d happily breathe it all in, let it fill her lungs and soothe her soul. She’d willingly drown in Caitlyn’s love a million times over and still feel it wasn’t enough.

Their kiss was uncoordinated, sloppy, much like their movements to finally pull away from the damned entrance to Caitlyn’s apartment and toward the bedroom. In a surprising show of force, Caitlyn shoved at Vi’s shoulders and the astronaut folded like a deck of cards, falling back onto the edge of the bed and staring up in wonder whilst Caitlyn pulled the elastic from her hair and the cotton of her dress up and over.

“Holy shit.” Vi murmured, trembling palms finding their way to Caitlyn’s impossibly toned waist while she parted her legs to straddle Vi’s lap. If there’s one thing that never failed to take the astronaut’s breath away, it was Caitlyn’s collection of lingerie. The set she currently wore was all black lace in floral patterns, just barely cupping her stunning breasts while the dip of her panties hung impossibly low, thin strings sitting high on her hips. Vi suddenly felt deprived of oxygen in such a way that she was sure not even outer space could accomplish.

Caitlyn giggled and it was only then that Vi had noticed her jaw had gone slack, mouth hanging open embarrassingly and yet she couldn’t find the strength to shut it. Caitlyn dragged a finger from the dip in Vi’s collarbone up the column of her throat, pushing her chin lightly to close her gaping mouth.

“Sorry.” Vi grumbled, burying her face in Caitlyn’s chest. “I just can’t believe I get to have you like this.”

Caitlyn dropped a delicate kiss to the top of Vi’s mess of magenta hair. “You can have me any way you’d like.”

“Yeah?” Vi smirked and pressed a kiss to the center of Caitlyn’s chest, dragging her lips sidelong and a palm up to graze her thumb over a lace-covered nipple. Caitlyn arched into the touch, gripping at Vi’s shoulders as she let out laboured puffs of breath into the air.

“Yes, please Vi-”

“I think I like you like this for now.” She pinched at Caitlyn’s nipple over the lace, grinning wickedly in response to the impatient twitch of Caitlyn’s hips. “Needy is a good look on you, baby.”

Caitlyn cupped Vi’s chin, angling her smug face up to meet the pout decorating her gorgeous features. “As much as I loathe to admit that I usually love your teasing… I think I’m a little too impatient for that right now.”

Vi’s brow lifted. “What happened to ‘any way I like.’”

“I reserve the right to change my mind.”

She didn’t wait for a response from Vi, releasing her jaw to instead pull at Vi’s muscle tee, yanking it over the astronaut’s head, followed by her sports bra, and tossing them aside with little care. Vi made to make a witty retort, and yet found herself unable to with Caitlyn’s tongue suddenly pressed between her lips, Caitlyn’s moans filling her mouth and practically choking her with lust.

“Fuck.” Vi growled in between the smack of their lips, an itch creeping below her flesh that lit the flame of her desires tenfold. If Vi was being honest with herself, she didn’t have the patience for much foreplay either. She needed Caitlyn in a way that felt unholy. Needed their bodies connected, their souls laid bare. Wanted to take it all for herself and finally submit to her own greediness.

The thin fabric of Caitlyn's lingerie set nearly tore as Vi pulled it from her body. She made a mental note to buy some new ones as she gripped Caitlyn's hips hard and flipped them over, littering her neck with a stunning array of blossoming bruises once her back hit the sheets. Caitlyn groaned and squirmed, her arm stretching to the side toward the nightstand.

"Vi-" Caitlyn pressed impatiently.

"Okay, yeah." She reluctantly tore herself away to fish out the tangled harness and attachment from the wooden drawer, nearly falling over in her uncoordinated attempt to simultaneously pull down her shorts and underwear. Caitlyn snorted softly and Vi cursed under her breath, feeling like a fucking virgin with how sloppy and desperate she was growing by the minute.

She just couldn't fucking help it, the jitters that had sat under her skin all day buzzing in anticipation and need. Caitlyn loved her, Caitlyn was going into space with her, and now Vi was going to fuck her so deeply in a way that would leave her shaking.

Thankfully, she managed to slip the harness up her hips without falling flat on her face. The strap was a relatively simple black design, tightening firmly around each of her thighs and laced up at her lower back. She couldn't help but notice the hungry look in Caitlyn's eyes as she shimmied the dark blue silicone through the ring at the front, settling it into place and giving an experimental tug to ensure its security.

Caitlyn's chest was practically heaving where she was now propped up on her elbows, pupils dilating with her tongue peeking out to lick at her lips. Vi hadn't expected such a wanton look of lust to overtake Caitlyn. They had tried using a strap only once before, and it had overwhelmed Caitlyn to the point of needing to stop. She hadn't much experience with any sort of deep penetration and it had been too much, something she wasn't physically or mentally prepared for, but this time it looked as though she really needed it.

It sent a familiar jolt down Vi's spine, all too similar to the one she had felt that first night in Caitlyn's apartment. This was technically something new for them, an intimacy they hadn't yet been able to get lost in and with the confessions of their love taking up space in Vi's heart, she felt an astounding sense of deja vu.

Vi reached out to cup Caitlyn's cheek. "Hey."

Caitlyn blinked away from her dissociative state whilst staring down at Vi's hips. "Yes?"

Vi pursed her lips in thought for a moment before electing to maneuver up Caitlyn's body, her thighs settling on either side of Caitlyn's chest. Caitlyn looked up at her questioningly, eyelashes fluttering in a way that had the astronaut clenching below.

She leveled Caitlyn with a hooded gaze, gripping the length of silicone in her palm. "Get it wet for me?"

A shocked expression overtook Caitlyn before she quickly schooled it into one of fierce determination. She eyed the toy thoughtfully for a moment, Vi waiting and watching patiently with the thrum of her heart growing increasingly loud within her ears.

Caitlyn began with a soft kiss to the very tip, small tentative licks as she gained confidence in her efforts. Vi's throat went dry, a gasp lodged there once Caitlyn parted her lips wide to stretch them down the length of the toy and back again.

Oh. Holy shit. Vi didn't think she would enjoy the sight *this* much. She couldn't feel what Caitlyn was doing, but fuck, it didn't matter. The effect was significant regardless.

"Oh my god, Caitlyn." Calloused fingers threaded into the silk blue of her hair, scratching lightly at her scalp as Vi's grip tightened more and more. Caitlyn groaned around the silicone in her throat, her bedroom eyes glancing up toward Vi with unspoken permission. It was then that Vi gently tugged at Caitlyn's hair, shifting her hips back and forth slightly to fuck into her lover's mouth.

It was all too much of a sight to process. The way Caitlyn's cheeks hollowed as she sucked, the focused furrow in her brow, hungry groan caught in her throat, the way her stunning lips dragged back and forth, glistening with spit-

Vi thought she could cum from this sight alone.

Vi's grip softened and Caitlyn popped off to glance up, a string of saliva connecting her swollen lips to the tip. "Is that good?"

"Yeah." Vi's voice was hoarse and she hadn't even done anything yet. She quickly cleared it away, shifting downward to position herself between Caitlyn's legs and dropping a gentle kiss to her forehead. "You were so good, baby."

"Are you going to fuck me now?" There was a broken rasp to Caitlyn's voice, it sent a jolt of heat straight to Vi's groin.

"You need it that badly, huh?" Vi felt a bit mean in her teasing, but judging by the shudder that traversed Caitlyn's body, she liked the little bit of malice.

"Yes." It was incredible that this woman had been the one to shatter Vi to pieces that morning and yet now was reduced to a crumbling mess when Vi hardly even touched her yet. "I need you."

"You have me." Vi bent down and placed a kiss to the spot just above Caitlyn's navel, the sight before her truly something to behold. Vi didn't think she'd ever get tired of gazing across the smooth perfection of Caitlyn's body, feeling the soft expanse of her skin beneath the astronaut's palms. Her hands weren't meant to hold someone this precious and yet there she was, dragging her fingers down the inside of Caityn's bent leg and toward the twitching heat below.

"Oh, shit." Vi panted against Caitlyn's stomach, dragging her fingers up the center of Caitlyn's drenched cunt and pushing in slightly. Caitlyn keened at the intrusion, arching up against Vi's lips and biting her lip down hard to suppress whatever sounds Vi was threatening to pull from her throat. "You're fucking soaked, baby. You liked sucking it that much?"

“N-No I-” Caitlyn’s fingers twisted in the sheets by her waist. “I’m just eager. I’ve wanted to try this again for a while and… I don’t know. I just feel so wound up today…”

“I know.” Vi added a second finger and pushed inward, twisting and curling them into the wet heat in a way she knew Caitlyn would cum in response to if she kept it up for long. Based on the quickening of Caitlyn’s breath and the soft *“Oh”* that fell off her lips, she knew it too. “I feel the same. It’s like… shit, it almost feels like the first time. Doesn’t it?”

“Yes.” Caitlyn gasped, shaky fingers rising to brush at Vi’s choppy hair while the astronaut slipped down to kiss the inside of her shaking thigh.

“I’m gonna make you feel so good baby.”

“I know, but if- if you keep going like that I’m going to cum-”

“I fail to see the issue with that.”

Caitlyn groaned. “No. Want to cum on your strap.” The words had Vi clenching around her own dampness. “I want to be so full with you, feel you in the deepest parts of me. Please, Vi-”

“Okay… yeah, okay.” She brought herself up onto her knees, gently encouraging Caitlyn’s legs to part further and giving a few more curls to her fingers before slipping them away. She watched Caitlyn’s entrance twitch, licking her lips at the sight as she tentatively shifted her hips closer and closer.

Caitlyn sucked in a breath once the damp tip grazed her entrance. Vi gripped the shaft and took a moment to drag the silicone up and down, allowing it to dampen further before catching on Caitlyn’s opening and slowly, ever so slowly sliding inside.

“Oh my g-” Caitlyn threw her arms back over her head, gripping at the deep cobalt locks spread there while her lips parted on a broken whine. As absolutely ravishing as this sight was, Vi couldn’t help but worry.

“You good baby?” She was only about halfway in, soothingly stroking Caitlyn’s thighs and keeping her hips still until Caitlyn had the time to adjust.

“Yes.” Her voice was breathy, but firm. “More, please give me *more*-”

Shit, what was Vi going to do, say no? She pushed deeper inside, tentatively lowering herself to brace her arms on either side of Caitlyn’s torso for a better angle until she pressed nearly all the way to the hilt. Caitlyn was already trembling at this point, allowing herself several deep, steadying breaths before giving her hips an experimental wiggle.

“Yeah?”

Caitlyn nodded. Vi wanted to kiss her bite-swollen lips but wasn’t about to press while she was buried inside until Caitlyn was ready. “Give- give me a second.”

“Take all the time you need.”

It was only a minute of tense, laboured breathing. Only a minute of Vi growing increasingly eager the longer she stayed lodged within Caitlyn. In that time she watched Caitlyn's expression change as she processed the weight inside her, occasionally offering a twitch or shift to her hips as she adjusted to the feeling. Vi's eyes narrowed in on the way Caitlyn's teeth sunk into her lip, the way her head angled backward to put the tantalizing stretch of her neck on display. The hooded, sultry, and somewhat tearful gaze she leveled Vi with…

It was only a minute, and yet in that time something in Vi seemed to snap. A new wave of primal desire crashing into her like a tidal wave.

Vi wasn't the jealousy type, never saw the point in getting worked up over such things when she knew she'd be the only one to see Caitlyn's like this. Yet at that moment, with Caitlyn splayed out and needy, a whine stuck in her throat, tears prickling the corners of her stunning eyes and a tantalizing arch to her back, Vi felt overwhelmingly possessive.

The most stunning sight in the universe laid out for her, and Vi felt she could finally accept it. Her walls had been reduced to ruble, no longer caging Vi to what she had feared was too grand for her to take. Perhaps there was an inherent greediness in taking someone's time, their devotion, and compassion. Yet there was beauty in the reciprocation of it all, the fact that someone *wants* to give themselves to you in this way.

She flattened her palm against the toned expanse of Caitlyn's stomach, slowly sliding up to the center of her lover's heaving chest and diverting the path to palm at her breast. Caitlyn keened into it, fisting at the sheets above her head and shifting her hips down against where Vi was buried inside of her.

Vi bent forward, knowing that Caitlyn had well adjusted by then and bracing her palm by Caitlyn's head. She smirked at the way Caitlyn gasped with the deeper push of the length inside her. Caitlyn looked so *good* like this. Desperate, aching, whiny, just for Vi.

"Mine." Vi nearly growled against her lips, not connecting them, just allowing them to hover there teasingly.

"Yes." A drop of moisture slipped down Caitlyn's temple, a sort of haze falling over her eyes in her complete submission. "I'm yours. All of me."

"Yeah." Vi did press her lips to Caitlyn's this time. Just once, very lightly. "Gonna fuck you now."

Caitlyn didn't have much of an opportunity to respond. Her lips parting with a gasp once Vi pulled her hips back and pressed inside once more. Vi took it slow for the first few thrusts, knowing that Caitlyn needed the slow build, needed the tentative push and pull of a tide before the storm.

Her arm muscles flex with the effort of holding herself there, no longer shaky as they had once been after she returned to Earth. Vi was fully recovered now, and she could use that to give Caitlyn the pleasure she deserved.

“My- my god.” Caitlyn gasped against Vi’s lips, so broken, so perfect- “It feels so *good* Violet-”

“I know, baby.” Vi’s voice was impossibly low, a rumble against Caitlyn’s lips, drinking down the sound of her needy moans as she built up a faster pace. Jolts of electricity shot down her spine at the obscene squelch sounding out with each thrust. “Can hear how wet you are. Taking it so well. Such a good girl, letting me take you like this.”

Caitlyn reached up to claw at Vi’s shoulders, the back of her hair, anything she could use for purchase. Her mouth hung open with the symphony of labored breaths and groans she let out, hardly able to form words but trying so, so hard. Cute, Vi thought.

“You’re so deep-” Shit, Caitlyn’s voice was much more high-pitched than usual in contrast to Vi’s hungry growl. It spurred her on even more, forced the snap of her hips at a quick pace and her palm to slide from Caitlyn’s chest down to the space below her belly button.

“Yeah. Can feel it here.” She pressed down and sure enough, could feel the movement deep inside Caitlyn with each thrust. Caitlyn gasped and pressed up into Vi’s palm, her body trembling with the rapid approach of her climax.

Caitlyn had been right earlier, this did feel right. A deep connection between them that, despite Vi herself not feeling any physical pleasure from, shook her to her core. Caitlyn had given her everything, blessed her with a love not of this world and brought about happiness unparalleled by even the most stunning sights of the universe. So now she would give her this, an ecstasy that lit her body alight. A sensual gratification that she deserved.

“Vi- I’m-”

“I got you, baby.” She kissed the edge of Caitlyn’s lips, meeting the stunning blue of her eyes as she pushed Caitlyn full force into her orgasm. “Cum for me. Want you to fucking shake with it. I love you so much-”

Caitlyn fell apart beautifully, like she always did. Her brows twisting in pleasure, core muscles tightening and vocal chords flexing with the effort of restraining her cries, practically gushing around the hilt where Vi slowed her movements and then stilled. Vi peppered soft kisses against her tear stained cheeks, the sweat on her forehead, the tip of her nose, anywhere she could reach.

“That’s it, good. Did so well, so perfect-” Vi murmured softly, rolling out her shoulders a bit where Caitlyn’s vice grip had softened. She slowly pulled her hips back to slip out, ignoring the very slight ache in her joints in favor of lowering down onto her elbow and stroking soothing fingers through Caitlyn’s tangled locks.

Caitlyn's arms fell limp by her head, eyes closed and an adorable pout overtaking her features. Vi couldn’t help but laugh lightly. “What’s that face for?”

“Feel empty now.” Caitlyn grumbled. Vi swooned, truly enamoured by the display of frustration. Caitlyn peeked her eyes open and sighed, bringing a shaking palm up to cup Vi’s cheek. “I want to make you feel good too.”

“I feel fucking fantastic.” Vi supplied, shaking her head and falling to the side in favor of pulling Caitlyn against her chest for cuddles. “Don’t need to cum to feel good. Doing that for you was plenty for me, trust me.”

Caitlyn hummed and curled into Vi’s chest, seemingly having lost all the fight in her body. Vi couldn’t blame her, that was a lot for both of them but god, she’d do it again and again without complaint. She wasn’t kidding, seeing Caitlyn in such a state was a gift, one she would cherish and cling to for as long as they had together on this Earth or among the stars above.

“Stars…” Caitlyn murmured, completely lost in her fucked-out bliss.

Vi frowned, wondering for a short moment if Caitlyn was somehow able to read her mind. “Stars?”

“Mm. That’s what I always see when you make me feel good. Stars.”

Vi rolled her eyes fondly. “I’m going to ignore the fact that that’s basically a space pun because I love you.”

Caitlyn looked mildly offended. “You called me your *gravity* earlier.”

Oh, fuck. She did. “Shit. Oh my god. What have you done to me?”

A sly giggle and a smug grin spread Caitlyn’s lips wide. “Does this mean I can make space puns when we go up there?”

“Ordinarily, hell no.” Caitlyn chuckled and Vi found herself smiling in return, stroking her palm up the dip in Caitlyn’s spine. “But I’m so hopelessly in love with you that I don’t think I can say no.”

“I will try to restrain myself, because I love you too.”

“Yeah.” Vi didn’t think she’d ever get tired of hearing that. She placed a kiss to the tip of Caitlyn’s nose, suddenly overwhelmed with the knowledge that Caitlyn would be joining her sinking further in. “I can’t wait to show you the stars, the view of the Earth…”

“I can’t wait to see it.” Caitlyn murmured softly, tracing her fingertips down the expanse of Vi’s neck. “The other side of where we met, where you spent your days as we fell for one another.”

“Can’t wait to pull you into my sleeping cabin, pin you up against the windows looking down at the planet-”

“Oh my god *stop.* The other astronauts would eject us out of the airlock.”

She pulled Caitlyn in tighter, wiggling her eyebrows suggestively. “We’ll just have to be sneaky then.”

Caitlyn rolled her eyes, though she was still smiling. It was then that Chowder jumped onto their field of vision, giving the two of them a once over with a rather judgmental gaze before settling down to groom himself at the foot of the bed.

“What about Chowder? Who’s going to look after him while you’re away?”

Caitlyn thought for a moment. “I don’t suppose Powder would be willing to take him in?”

Vi snorted. “Well, sure. She’d love to, but you may not get him back.”

“Oh I’ve got at least a foot in height on her. I can take her.”

The two giggled together at the thought, Caitlyn then letting out a content sigh as she traced patterns on Vi's chest. “I think I might actually miss being your capcom a little.” She pursed her lips in thought, running her fingertips over Vi's collarbone. “The distance was excruciating, yes, but also fun.”

“Well this will be better, yeah?” Vi reached up to grasp Caitlyn’s hand in her own. “Now we don’t have to be apart. The routine will be familiar, but now I can see the blush in your cheeks when I tease you, the smile on your lips when I tell you I love you. Now we can do it together.”

Fresh tears threatened Caitlyn’s waterline. “I think-” She whispered, voice laced with a pure timbre of devotion. “I think I would quite like that.”

Vi grinned, lifting Caitlyn’s fingers to press a kiss on the back of her knuckles and allowing them to fall into the relaxed comfort and relief. There would always be trials and tribulations in life, Vi knew that. She knew Caitlyn’s training wouldn’t be easy, that life would continue to throw hurdles at them and that there would be more tough choices for Vi to make. They would tackle them all together, but for now it didn’t matter.

The hard work would begin tomorrow, for now they simply allowed themselves this. An astounding peace in their bubble of love.

A feeling that Vi couldn’t wait to experience among the stars.

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It had been greuling, exhaustive work, but Caitlyn did it all. Through the brutal physical and survival training, the countless medical tests, experiment training and long nights of procedural study, the decompression sickness that came along with days in the Neutral Buoyancy Laboratory. Caitlyn pushed through it all in record time, and looked damn hot while doing it all. She handled it with grace and precision that only served to heighten not only Vi’s love, but her respect in the dedication. It was a wonder Caitlyn hadn’t much considered pursuing this path before. She looked as though she belonged there, smart and

calculated with the stunning blue of NASA's training suits a flawless fit for her stunning body.

She managed it all perfectly, Just as Vi knew she would.

Then the day came for their departure, bringing very little with them but a few articles of clothing and personal effects. Vi had pouted when Caitlyn was firm on her stance that they could not, in fact, bring a strap into space but she would make do. She had perfectly functioning fingers, after all.

Vi stood in front of her duffle staring down at the necessities for her journey, going down the mental list to make sure she had everything. Her clothes, toiletries, a few things to stash in her personal preference kit, some polaroids Powder had taken over the last few months…

A small, dark blue, velvet box.

She zipped the duffle closed and slung it over her shoulder, ready to traverse a new horizon, to start a new expedition and a new journey with the woman she loved.

"Ready to go?" Caitlyn asked from where she was waiting by the door to their shared hotel room in Florida, nearly bouncing from foot to foot in anticipation.

"Yeah." Vi grinned, dropping a kiss to Caitlyn's cheek and adjusting the bag over her shoulder. "I'm ready."

So they arrived at the Kennedy Space Center's Launch Complex, did all their checks, donned their suits, said their goodbyes to their loved ones, and strapped in for the long journey.

"ISS crew, do you copy?" Vander's voice picked up through Vi's headset and she couldn't help but smile, adrenaline pumping steadily through her veins at the prospect of her return to the International Space Station.

She looked at Caitlyn sitting vertically next to her, finding that she was already gazing back at Vi with an eager, elated smile. The same thunderous excitement present in the wide expanse of her cerulean eyes.

The woman who had brought Vi back down to Earth, who had distorted her reality in the best way possible. Who helped Vi realize she was worthy of love, of pursuing her passion and discovering the importance of accepting your desires.

And now Vi was going to take her to the stars. To her home.

She reached out to the side, extending an open palm toward Caitlyn who slipped her own gloved hand into Vi's grasp and finally, after the push and pull of countless months of yearning, of sleepless nights and desperate longing. After hurtling back toward the Earth and falling even harder than that into Caitlyn's embrace, finally feeling her warmth and taking it into her heart. There they were. Together, in love, despite it all.

"Yes." Vi said, offering a gentle squeeze to Caitlyn's palm, a vow of forever that extended far beyond the cosmos themselves. "We copy."

ISS Expedition number 60
Time Elapsed: 1 Day
Time Remaining: 182 Days

Chapter End Notes

To be continued.

I cannot thank you all enough for the love on this work. It has been one of the most unique and thrilling experiences of my life, and I'm so proud of what it has become. I'm honored it brought so many people, and so many couples, joy and comfort. Words will never truly express the depth of my gratitude, but truly from the bottom of my heart. Thank you.

Yell at me on X here.

See ya next time. <3

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